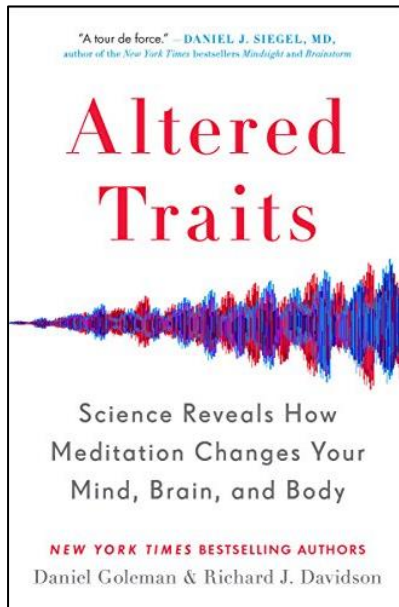




BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



Altered Traits: Science Reveals How Meditation Changes Your Mind, Brain, and Body

Daniel Goleman, Ph.D. & Richard Davidson, Ph.D.

411 Released: May 19, 2023

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. Altered Traits and the Real Goal of Meditation
2. The "State-by-Trait" Effect: Cautionary and Inspirational
3. Physical Health Effects: Lower Inflammation & Breathing Rates
4. The Biggest Benefits are Psychological

1 Life-Changing Idea

All Paths Are the Same



4 Thoughts

1. Altered Traits and the Real Goal of Meditation

“Historically, meditation was not meant to improve our health, relax us, or enhance work success. Although these are the kinds of appeal that has made meditation ubiquitous today, over the centuries such benefits were incidental, unnoted side effects. The true contemplative goal has always been altered traits.”

And what are altered traits? As the name suggests, they’re new characteristics you develop that persist even when you’re not meditating: **“Altered traits shape how we behave in our daily lives, not just during or immediately after we meditate.”** They include things like a calmer mind, better emotional regulation, and greater resilience to life’s stressors.

So essentially, the goal of meditation is to fundamentally change who we are for the better. As they say, to **“reach toward our better nature.”**

Importantly, however, these altered traits result from fundamental changes within our bodies, which we’ll discuss throughout the 411.

But keep in mind that all these changes are incidental. What we’re really after is being a better person, and meditation provides a means of getting there.

P.S. I view all breathing exercises, from slow breathing to alternate nostril breathing, from Wim Hof to Holotropic breathing, as subsets of meditation, just like loving-kindness or vipassana. Breathing exercises do have a more health-based motivation. But, ultimately, we’re focusing on the breath for an extended amount of time, just like we might focus on loving-kindness for an extended period.



2. The “State-by-Trait” Effect: Cautionary and Inspirational

“In contemplative science, an “altered state” refers to changes that occur only during meditation. An altered trait indicates that the practice of meditation transformed the brain and biology so that meditation-induced changes are seen before beginning to meditate.

So a “state-by-trait” effect refers to temporary state changes that are seen only in those who display enduring altered traits—the long-term meditators and the yogis.”

This book had so much goodness on contemplative science—this quote was only a minor section. But it conveys two important lessons, so I felt it was worth including in the 411.

The first is cautionary. As this passage states, they discovered that long-term meditators could reach states during meditation that only occur because they practice so much.

They practice a lot --> They alter their traits --> And this allows them to achieve profoundly altered states (like extreme bliss, compassion, or equanimity).

This is cautionary because teachers and people who write books are more likely-than-not very experienced. So, when they describe their experiences, we may feel like we’re doing something wrong if we don’t achieve those states. Or that they’re just lying to sound cool.

But, it may actually be that they have altered their brains and bodies so much that they can access states not physiologically open to us yet: **“Their remarkable meditation skills bespeak what’s technically known as a “state by trait interaction,” suggesting the brain changes that underlie the trait also give rise to special abilities that activate during meditative states.”**

Although cautionary, this is also very inspirational. These findings mean that, as we continue practicing regularly, these states will eventually become accessible to us. There’s nothing inherently special about long-term meditators (breathers, yogis, etc.). They just do it a lot. Those same blissed-out experiences will be available to us—we just have to practice 🙏



3. Physical Health Effects: Lower Inflammation & Breathing Rates

“Yet mindfulness training—even as short as three days—produces a short-term decrease in pro-inflammatory cytokines, the molecules responsible for inflammation. And the more you practice, the lower the level becomes of these pro-inflammatory cytokines. This seems to become a trait effect with extensive practice, with imaging studies finding in meditators at rest lower levels of pro-inflammatory cytokines.”

As we learned in Thought #1, meditation was never intended to treat or cure illnesses. But it turns out that it does have some powerful effects on our bodies and minds, one of which is decreasing inflammation.

And since inflammation negatively affects basically everything, this seems like a pretty nice unintended side-effect to have.

Another positive health effect of meditation is that it lowers our resting breathing rate:

“But consider what Richie’s lab found when they looked at long-term meditators (9,000 average lifetime hours of practice). Comparing each to a nonmeditator of the same age and sex, the meditators were breathing an average 1.6 breaths more slowly. And this was while they were just sitting still, waiting for a cognitive test to start.

Over the course of a single day that difference in breath rate translates to more than 2,000 extra breaths for the nonmeditators—and more than 800,000 extra breaths over the course of a year. These extra breaths are physiologically taxing, and can exact a health toll as time goes on.

As practice continues and breathing becomes progressively slower, the body adjusts its physiological set point for its respiratory rate accordingly. That’s a good thing. While chronic rapid breathing signifies ongoing anxiety, a slower breath rate indicates reduced autonomic activity, better mood, and salutary health.”

That’s amazing (and a perfect description of the power of breathing less) 🙌

Together, we see that regular meditation can lower inflammation and reduce our resting breathing rate, which will have positive downstream effects on virtually any health condition.



4. The Biggest Benefits are Psychological

“The sounder studies, we found, focus on lessening our psychological distress rather than on curing medical syndromes or looking for underlying biological mechanisms. So, when it comes to a better quality of life for those with chronic diseases, yes to meditation. Such palliative care gets ignored too often in medicine, but it matters enormously to patients.”

This was a major conclusion of the book: meditation can help some physical illnesses (see previous thought), but the primary benefit is psychological relief. Crucially though, this psychological relief stems from state and trait changes in the brain’s circuitry.

But from a practical perspective, these brain changes add up to things like better quality of life, better emotional health, and better resilience.

In my opinion, this is more critical than physical health in some cases. The authors address this wonderfully when discussing the viewpoints of doctors/researchers vs. patients:

“While doctors may want to see hard data showing medical improvements, patients just want to feel better, especially if there’s little to be done to relieve their clinical condition. From a patient’s viewpoint, then, mindfulness offers a path to relief—even as medical research tells doctors the evidence is not clear when it comes to reversing the biological cause of the pain.”

So, meditation may not cure you of anything, but it can help you feel better, which may be enough for you to continue doing it 🙏

P.S. To get a little nerdier, here are some of the brain changes that occur with meditation: **“The amygdala, a key node in the brain’s stress circuitry, shows dampened activity from a mere thirty or so hours of MBSR practice. Other mindfulness training shows a similar benefit, and there are hints in the research that these changes are traitlike: they appear not simply during the explicit instruction to perceive the stressful stimuli mindfully but even in the “baseline” state, with reductions in amygdala activation as great as 50 percent. ... A three-month meditation retreat brought indicators of better emotional regulation, and long-term practice was associated with greater functional connectivity between the prefrontal areas that manage emotion and the areas of the amygdala that react to stress, resulting in less reactivity.”**



1 Life-Changing Idea

All Paths Are the Same

"If someone was following a given inner path, Neem Karoli always encouraged it. From his perspective the main point was that you do your practice—not try to find the "very best."

Whenever Neem Karoli was asked about which path was best, his answer was "Sub ek!"—Hindi for 'They are all one.' Everyone has different preferences, needs, and the like. Just choose one and plunge in."

Amen to that 🙏

And although that just sounds awesome, it also has some sound logic to back it up:

"In that view contemplative paths are more or less the same, a doorway beyond ordinary experience. At a practical level, all forms of meditation share a common core of mind training—e.g., learning to let go of the myriad distractions that flow through the mind and to focus on one object of attention or stance of awareness."

Thus, I believe these wisdom nuggets are life-changing. We don't have to find "the best" breathing practice, or yoga practice, or meditation technique. We just have to find the one that resonates with us now (accepting it will change with time) and plunge in. They are all simply a doorway beyond ordinary experience.

1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

"Yet mindfulness, part of an ancient meditation tradition, was not intended to be such a cure; this method was only recently adapted as a balm for our modern forms of angst. The original aim, embraced in some circles to this day, focuses on a deep exploration of the mind toward a profound alteration of our very being."

"As we see it, the most compelling impacts of meditation are not better health or sharper business performance but, rather, a further reach toward our better nature."



“Meditation is a catch-all word for myriad varieties of contemplative practice, just as sports refers to a wide range of athletic activities. For both sports and meditation, the end results vary depending on what you actually do.”

““Each of you is perfect the way you are,” Zen master Suzuki Roshi told his students, adding, “and you can use a little improvement”—neatly reconciling acceptance with growth.”

“When these strands of change are twined together, there are two major ways anyone benefits from contemplative effort: having a healthy body and a healthy mind.”

“These various mind training methods drive the brain in different ways. During compassion practice, the amygdala is turned up in volume, while in focused attention on something like the breath, the amygdala is turned down. Meditators are learning how to change their relationship to their emotions with different practices.”

“Sharing another person’s feelings of distress need not be a downer. As Dr. Aaron Beck, who designed that depression test, has said, when you focus on someone else’s suffering, you forget your own troubles.”

“A universal goal in meditation of every kind comes down to sustaining attention in a chosen way or to a given target, such as the breath.”

“Mingyur had run smack into a paradox of today’s research on consciousness, the mind, and meditative training: those who do the research on meditation are too often in the dark about what they are actually studying.”

“This highlights a weakness in what otherwise might seem quite impressive findings on the yogis: these data points are but glimpses of the altered traits that intensive, prolonged meditation produces. We do not want to reduce this quality of being to what we happen to be able to measure.”



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3. Slow Breathing for Better Blood Flow
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Mindful low-and-slow breathing is “almost always helpful in reducing physiological arousal.” <— sounds good to me.

Use it anytime, anywhere for a quick reset and recovery.

P.S. The reduction in skin conductance is particularly important. As Dr. Khazan also tells us, “As your sympathetic nervous system (the one responsible for the stress response) is activated, sweat glands become more active and produce more sweat. ... the more moisture there is, the more conductive your skin is. **Higher skin conductance indicates increased stress activation.**” (my emphasis)

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“HRV is also strongly associated with our ability to perform at our best during times of increased stress or challenge. In fact, HRV is one of the best metrics of psychophysiological health and ability to perform we currently have.”

Dr. Khazan tells us that higher HRV is associated with better performance during stressful and challenging times <—sounds good to me 🦞

And fortunately, training our HRV is as simple as starting a consistent slow breathing practice. As she also tells us, “Regular practice is crucial to biofeedback success. Practicing a skill once or twice or every once in a while is unlikely to benefit you. Once your biofeedback practice is established, practicing your skills 7 days a week for 20 minutes a day is ideal.”

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“For the lobster, stress literally leads to growth—if the lobster did not feel stressed in the small shell, it would not know to get a bigger one and be able to continue growing. Stress provides you with the same opportunity to grow. If you don’t experience stress, you don’t move forward, you don’t challenge yourself, and you don’t get the opportunity to live a fulfilling, meaningful life.”

So, like lobsters, we need stress to grow, to “live a fulfilling, meaningful life.”

Stress—> Breathe—> Recover—> Grow—> Repeat Forever 🔄

3. Slow Breathing for Better Blood Flow

“Your fingers, toes, nose, and even ears may feel cold. The small blood vessels that constrict during the fight-or-flight activation have a large impact on your blood pressure. When these blood vessels are relaxed, more blood can flow freely through them. When they become constricted, the same amount of blood flows through a narrower space, increasing your blood pressure.”

This is one of the many things that happens when the sympathetic nervous system is activated. Slow breathing, on the other hand, activates the calming (rest-and-digest) parasympathetic nervous system. *This relaxes the small blood vessels, lowers blood pressure, and improves blood flow.*

This is a vital benefit of slow breathing because better blood flow is necessary for, well, just about everything (especially if you have a chronic disease).

Moreover, reducing blood pressure is also critical for just about everything, especially decreasing our risk of cardiovascular problems.

So, if you feel so inspired, give it a shot: sit and breathe at 5-6 breaths/min for 2 min. Feel for yourself the rapid boost in blood flow to your hands and/or feet.

P.S. I’ve had cold hands & feet for as long as I can remember (thanks, diabetes). Although it’s improved considerably, one of my favorite things about slow breathing is the warmth I feel in them during and after my practice.



4. Overbreathing, Electrolyte Imbalance, and Anxiety

“In addition, overbreathing and the resulting pH dysregulation also lead to electrolyte imbalances. Electrolytes, such as sodium (Na^+), calcium (Ca^+), and potassium (K^+), are responsible for communication between cells through electrical impulses. When your pH becomes too alkaline, electrolytes migrate into muscle and brain cells instead of staying in the fluid outside of those cells. As a result, you may experience muscle spasms, weakness, and fatigue.”

This one was news to me. Aside from just dehydrating us, overbreathing can also disrupt electrolyte balance.

The fix? Since it's hard to tell if you're “technically” overbreathing without a capnometer, I think the most practical safeguard here is to simply breathe nasally, even during exercise.

P.S. Here's another reason to stop overbreathing: it can cause or exacerbate anxiety and panic. Here's how Dr. Khazan puts it: *“All of these symptoms of overbreathing are also symptoms of a panic attack, and many of them are symptoms of anxiety in general. In fact, research shows that panic attacks almost always involve overbreathing. The tricky part about overbreathing is that, because it so closely resembles anxiety, its symptoms are often interpreted as anxiety, whether or not anxiety is actually present. Of course, once you think you are anxious, you become anxious. Sometimes anxiety does indeed provoke overbreathing.”*



1 STACK OF MEMORABLE QUOTES

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[...]

Allow your body to produce the physiological changes you are looking for rather than trying to make them happen.”

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“After controlling for possible confounding factors, the researchers concluded that HRV is a better predictor of future cardiac events than blood pressure, cholesterol levels, and resting heart rate.”



1 IDEA THAT WILL CHANGE YOUR LIFE

“On a physiological level, compassion requires the following elements:

- *Ability to orient and bring attention toward the person in need of compassion. [...]*
- *Ability to engage socially with others in times of stress. [...]*
- *Ability to feel safe while engaging with others. [...]*
- *Ability to regulate our own physiology. [...]*

[...] What all four of these points tell us is that HRV is central to the physiological foundations of compassion and self-compassion. HRV training improves your ability to pay attention, engage socially, feel safe, and regulate your own physiology and emotions in the presence of your own or others' suffering. [...]

But doing the structured, straightforward, and easily accessible HRV training will help you in developing and nurturing your ability to express and act with compassion toward others and self-compassion for yourself.”

Compassion is certainly something our world needs more of. And here, Dr. Khazan explains how HRV is essential to compassion and self-compassion. Thus, a simple slow breathing practice (see Thought #2 above) might be all we need to nurture compassion for ourselves and others. Life-changing, indeed.



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This is one of the many things that happens when the sympathetic nervous system is activated. Slow breathing, on the other hand, activates the calming (rest-and-digest) parasympathetic nervous system. *This relaxes the small blood vessels, lowers blood pressure, and improves blood flow.*

This is a vital benefit of slow breathing because better blood flow is necessary for, well, just about everything (especially if you have a chronic disease).

Moreover, reducing blood pressure is also critical for just about everything, especially decreasing our risk of cardiovascular problems.

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1 LIFE-CHANGING IDEA

How to Be Warm-Hearted: Slow Breathing and The 4 Elements of Compassion



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This is a vital benefit of slow breathing because better blood flow is necessary for, well, just about everything (especially if you have a chronic disease).

Moreover, reducing blood pressure is also critical for just about everything, especially decreasing our risk of cardiovascular problems.

So, if you feel so inspired, give it a shot: sit and breathe at 5-6 breaths/min for 2 min. Feel for yourself the rapid boost in blood flow to your hands and/or feet.

P.S. I’ve had cold hands & feet for as long as I can remember (thanks, diabetes). Although it’s improved considerably, one of my favorite things about slow breathing is the warmth I feel in them during and after my practice.



4. Overbreathing, Electrolyte Imbalance, and Anxiety

“In addition, overbreathing and the resulting pH dysregulation also lead to electrolyte imbalances. Electrolytes, such as sodium (Na⁺), calcium (Ca⁺), and potassium (K⁺), are responsible for communication between cells through electrical impulses. When your pH becomes too alkaline, electrolytes migrate into muscle and brain cells instead of staying in the fluid outside of those cells. As a result, you may experience muscle spasms, weakness, and fatigue.”

This one was news to me. Aside from just dehydrating us, overbreathing can also disrupt electrolyte balance.

The fix? Since it's hard to tell if you're "technically" overbreathing without a capnometer, I think the most practical safeguard here is to simply breathe nasally, even during exercise.

P.S. Here's another reason to stop overbreathing: it can cause or exacerbate anxiety and panic. Here's how Dr. Khazan puts it: *“All of these symptoms of overbreathing are also symptoms of a panic attack, and many of them are symptoms of anxiety in general. In fact, research shows that panic attacks almost always involve overbreathing. The tricky part about overbreathing is that, because it so closely resembles anxiety, its symptoms are often interpreted as anxiety, whether or not anxiety is actually present. Of course, once you think you are anxious, you become anxious. Sometimes anxiety does indeed provoke overbreathing.”*

1 LIFE-CHANGING IDEA

“On a physiological level, compassion requires the following elements:

- *Ability to orient and bring attention toward the person in need of compassion. [...]*
- *Ability to engage socially with others in times of stress. [...]*
- *Ability to feel safe while engaging with others. [...]*



- *Ability to regulate our own physiology. [...]*
[...]

What all four of these points tell us is that HRV is central to the physiological foundations of compassion and self-compassion. HRV training improves your ability to pay attention, engage socially, feel safe, and regulate your own physiology and emotions in the presence of your own or others' suffering.

[...]

But doing the structured, straightforward, and easily accessible HRV training will help you in developing and nurturing your ability to express and act with compassion toward others and self-compassion for yourself."

Compassion is certainly something our world needs more of. And here, Dr. Khazan explains how HRV is essential to compassion and self-compassion. Thus, a simple slow breathing practice (see Thought #2 above) might be all we need to nurture compassion for ourselves and others. Life-changing, indeed.

1 STACK OF MEMORABLE QUOTES

"Many people believe that biofeedback is a way to learn to relax. While it is true that you can learn to relax using biofeedback, relaxation is not the main goal. The main goal is self-regulation, which means being able to activate your nervous system most optimally for action and being able to relax and recover after the action is complete."

"You may use the principles of psychophysiology underlying biofeedback to strengthen your self-regulation and improve your health and performance without the use of biofeedback."

"Self-regulation, when applied to humans, refers to your ability to monitor your physiological and emotional states and alter them in accordance with the demand of the situation or the environment you are in."

"Use biofeedback skills as a way to respond to difficult experiences, not as a way to control them or make them go away."



[...]

Allow your body to produce the physiological changes you are looking for rather than trying to make them happen.”

“HRV reflects the parasympathetic nervous system’s ability to put on the brakes to sympathetic activation. Increasing HRV with training strengthens the parasympathetic brake.”

“After controlling for possible confounding factors, the researchers concluded that HRV is a better predictor of future cardiac events than blood pressure, cholesterol levels, and resting heart rate.”



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Book 411

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BY: WALLACE J NICHOLS

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1. What is Blue Mind and Blue Mindfulness?
2. Utilizing Blue Mind for Our Breathing Practice: More Benefits with No Added Effort
3. Natural Resistance Breathing: Aquatic Exercise Strengthens Breathing Muscles
4. For Breathing, We Need Emotion and Science, Head and Heart

4 THOUGHTS

1. What is Blue Mind and Blue Mindfulness?

"Several years ago I came up with a name for this human–water connection: Blue Mind, a mildly meditative state characterized by calm, peacefulness, unity, and a sense of general happiness and satisfaction with life in the moment. It is inspired by water and elements associated with water, from the



color blue to the words we use to describe the sensations associated with immersion.”

Based on that description, I think we’d all like a little more Blue Mind.

And its characteristics—“*calm, peacefulness, unity, and a sense of general happiness and satisfaction with life in the moment*”—sound a lot like what we get from our slow breathing, meditation, or basically any wellness practice we do.

In fact, Nichols tells us that we can “*think of it as Blue Mindfulness.*”

And the best part? This isn’t **another** wellness practice we need to include in our routines. Instead, think of it as an add-on. Back to Nichols for more: “*Water’s amazing influence does not mean that it displaces other concerted efforts to reach a mindful state; rather, it adds to, enhances, and expands.*”

Nichols also says, “*This is the huge advantage of water: you don’t need to meditate to take advantage of its healing effects because it meditates you.*”

I absolutely love that.

And in the following two thoughts, we’ll look at how we can take advantage of Blue Mind to enhance our wellness.

2. Utilizing Blue Mind for Our Breathing Practice: More Benefits with No Added Effort

“Petr Janata...is a cognitive neuroscientist and expert on music in the brain. He theorizes that the low frequency of the sound of water, coupled with its rhythmic nature, is similar to the frequency and rhythm of human breath. Sound, Janata contends, ‘affects our brain and influences our emotions. If I ask you to close your eyes and turn on a recording of the ocean, I can change your mood immediately.’”

Here’s the easiest way to get the benefits of Blue Mind: add the sound of water. For example, sit outside near a body of water or just use headphones with some relaxing ocean or river sounds.

As Janata says, the rhythmic nature is similar to breathing—seems like the perfect complement to our practice, huh?

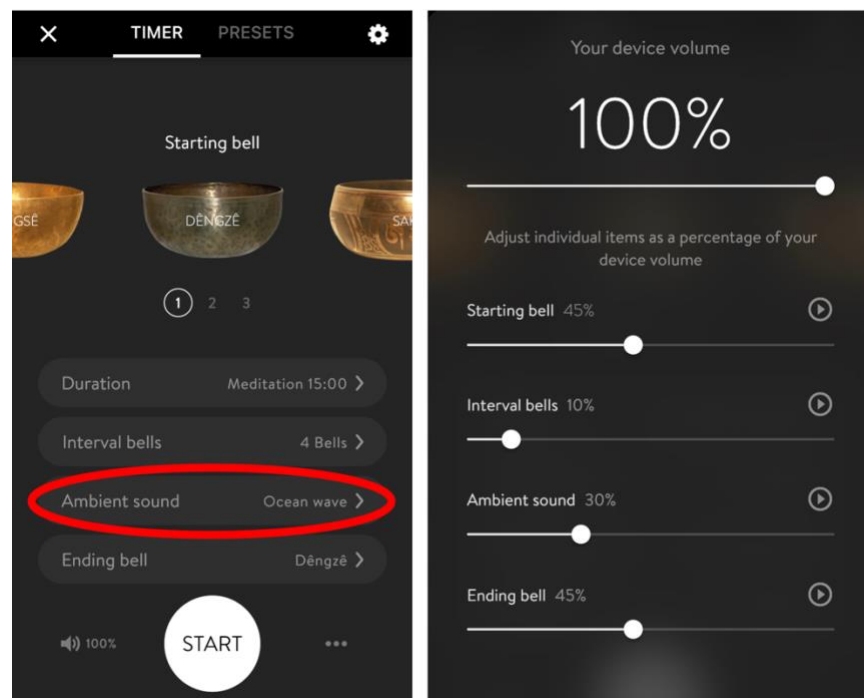
But the soothing sounds of water have even deeper roots:

"As a Harvard Medical School Senior Research Fellow specializing in the effects of sound, Shelley Batts is supremely qualified to speak about sound and water. "We spend our first nine months underwater, hearing sound through water in the womb," she comments. "We hear the whooshing of our mother's heart, her breath going in and out, the gurgle of her digestion.... These fluid, rhythmic sounds are very much like the ocean. Perhaps that's why the ocean often brings up feelings of relaxation and tranquility.""

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Below are my settings on Insight Timer for my morning 15-minute slow breathing practice. (Note: I modify the sounds [see right panel] so I can still use breathing apps that play over the ocean sound).

Give it a try, and enjoy the soothing sounds of water a little more in your life.





3. Natural Resistance Breathing: Aquatic Exercise Strengthens Breathing Muscles

“The lungs are receiving a greater volume of blood as well, which, combined with the pressure that water exerts on the chest wall, makes them work harder to breathe—approximately 60% harder than on land. This means that aquatic exercise can strengthen the respiratory muscles and improve their efficiency.”

Resistance breathing has countless benefits, including better cardiovascular health, stronger respiratory muscles, and less oxidative stress and inflammation.

But if you have no interest in buying a device for resistance breathing, here’s a free alternative: aquatic exercise. In fact, this might be an even better option.

As Bruce E. Becker, director of the National Aquatics and Sports Medicine Institute at Washington State University, says, *“During immersion, the body sends out a signal to alter the balance of catecholamines in a manner that is similar to the balance found during relaxation or meditation.”*

What does this mean practically? Back to Nichols: *“just being in the water can create a feeling of relaxation and a decrease in stress.”*

Thus, you get the calming effects of the water while also strengthening your breathing muscles.

A natural and soothing win-win 🏊‍♂️

4. For Breathing, We Need Emotion and Science, Head and Heart

“It’s time to drop the old notions of separation between emotion and science—for ourselves and our future. Just as rivers join on their way to the ocean, to understand Blue Mind we need to draw together separate streams: analysis and affection; elations and experimentation; head and heart.”

This is a beautiful passage, and it couldn’t be any truer for breathing, too: we need *“analysis and affection; elations and experimentation; head and heart.”*



Breathing is where all these rivers join and flow into the ocean of life.

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The Best Benefit of Water (and breathing) is Emotional

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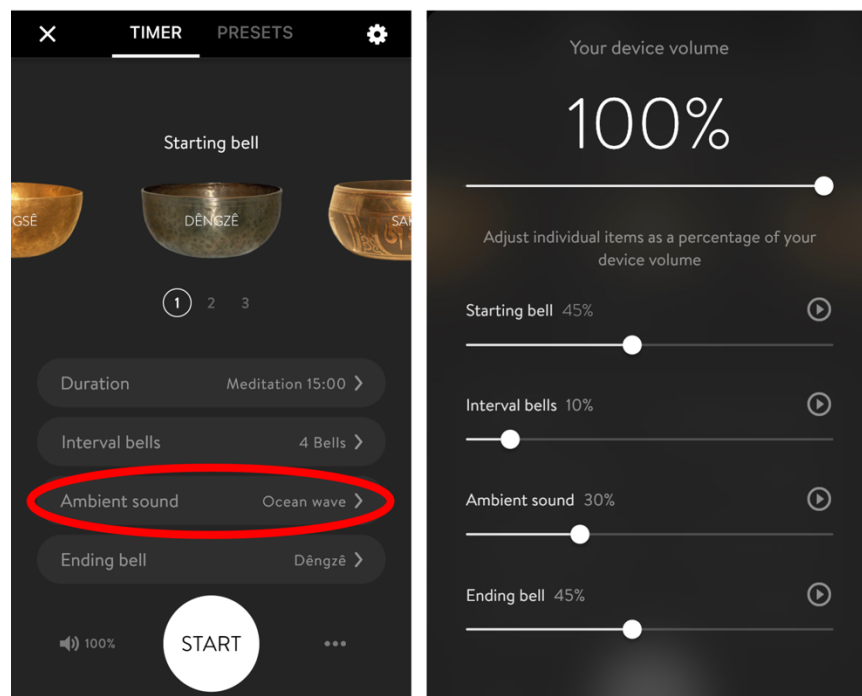
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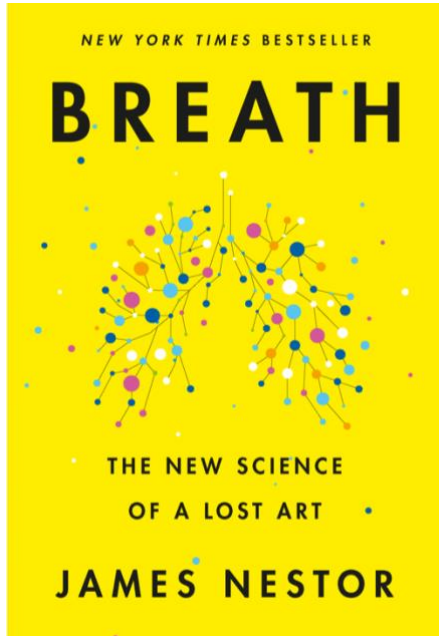
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BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



Breath: The New Science of a Lost Art

BY: JAMES NESTOR

411 Released: February 24, 2023

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. Breathe Through Your Nose
2. Exhale to Increase Lung Capacity?
3. Slow, Less, and the Perfect Breath
4. Breathing+: Sometimes Fast, Sometimes Not at All

1 Life-Changing Idea

Chew



4 Thoughts

1. Breathe Through Your Nose

"The readouts reveal what the previous days have revealed: mouthbreathing is destroying our health. [...] My blood pressure has spiked by an average of 13 points from where it was before the test, which puts me deep into stage 1 hypertension. ... Meanwhile, my heart rate variability, a measure of nervous system balance, has plummeted, suggesting that my body is in a state of stress. Then there's my pulse, which has increased, and my body temperature, which has decreased, and my mental clarity, which has hit rock bottom. Olsson's data mirror mine."

The craziest part of this book was the experiment Nestor and breathing expert Anders Olsson did. They plugged their noses for 10 days and then shut their mouths for 10 days. As stated above, the first 10 days of mouth breathing destroyed their health.

When they switched to nose breathing, everything improved: their blood pressure returned to near normal, HRV increased by as much as 150%, and their energy levels skyrocketed.

This set the stage for Nestor to explore all the benefits of nasal breathing. He goes through the standard benefits, things like warming and humidification, nitric oxide, better oxygenation, nasal cycles, and the differences between left and right nostril breathing.

But one thing that really stood out was his discussion on nasal breathing and nighttime bathroom breaks. One of the most consistent things I hear from people who start taping their mouths for sleep is that they don't get up to use the restroom as much. Nestor explained that this is related to a hormone called vasopressin:

"But if the body has inadequate time in deep sleep, ... vasopressin won't be secreted normally. The kidneys will release water, which triggers the need to urinate and signals to our brains that we should consume more liquid. We get thirsty, and we need to pee more."

Truly mind-blowing. We could go on and on about the nose. But, I think this quote perfectly summarizes everything he presented: **"the nose is the silent warrior: the gatekeeper of our bodies, pharmacist to our minds, and weather vane to our emotions."**



2. Exhale to Increase Lung Capacity?

“They gathered two decades of data from 5,200 subjects, crunched the numbers, and discovered that the greatest indicator of life span wasn’t genetics, diet, or the amount of daily exercise, as many had suspected. It was lung capacity. ... larger lungs equaled longer lives.”

The next thing Nestor discovered was that nasal breathing wasn’t enough for optimal breathing. We also need bigger lungs.

And fortunately, expanding our lung capacity is pretty straightforward. Something simple like stretching and breathing will do. Nestor specifically mentions the [5 Tibetan Rites](#) here, but it seems like almost any form of yoga would work. Additionally, he found that moderate exercises, such as walking or cycling, could increase lung capacity by 15%.

But the most paradoxical way to expand lung capacity was to exhale fully, which Nestor introduced in his phenomenal section on Carl Stough:

“What Stough had discovered, and what Martin had learned, was that the most important aspect of breathing wasn’t just to take in air through the nose. Inhaling was the easy part. The key to breathing, lung expansion, and the long life that came with it was on the other end of respiration. It was in the transformative power of a full exhalation.”

By exhaling fully, we can get more air in during our next breath. Over time, this can expand lung capacity and have life-changing effects (Stough used this approach to help people with emphysema, asthma, pneumonia, and more—the book is worth reading for this chapter alone).

Putting it together, we have learned that to optimize our breathing, we should (1) breathe nasally and (2) expand our lungs via stretching and breathing, exercise, and/or full exhalations. The next step is to slow our breathing down and breathe less.

3. Slow, Less, and the Perfect Breath

“One thing that every medical or freelance pulmonaut I’ve talked to over the past several years has agreed on is that, just as we’ve become a culture of overeaters, we’ve also become a culture of overbreathers. Most of us breathe too much, and up to a quarter of the modern population suffers from more serious chronic overbreathing.

The fix is easy: breathe less. But that’s harder than it sounds.”



Chronic overbreathing has many harmful effects because, when we do it, we offload too much carbon dioxide (CO₂). As you know, CO₂ is critical to all aspects of health. It loosens the bond between oxygen and hemoglobin, releasing more oxygen into the tissues and cells. It's also a vasodilator, improving blood flow and enhancing oxygen delivery.

But an even more detrimental effect—one that I hadn't learned until this book—is buffering. It was complicated, but Nestor explained that overbreathing causes kidney buffering, which depletes mineral stores. This can cause nerves to malfunction, muscles to spasm, poor energy production, and even contribute to osteoporosis—that last one is pretty mind-blowing.

Learning to breathe less can counteract these damaging consequences.

Nestor presents two ways to do this. The first is simply taking fewer breaths per minute (aka slow breathing). He discusses many benefits of slow breathing, which include calming the nervous system, stimulating the vagus nerve, improving blood flow, and eliciting a state of coherence in which our body's peak efficiency is achieved.

But breathing slowly isn't enough. We also need to breathe less air, which is where the real health benefits occur:

“To be clear, breathing less is not the same as breathing slowly. [...] The key to optimum breathing, and all the health, endurance, and longevity benefits that come with it, is to practice fewer inhales and exhales in a smaller volume. To breathe, but to breathe less.”

And when we combine nasal breathing, slow breathing, and breathing less, we get “the perfect breath,” something you can start practicing today:

“By various means, in various ways, in various eras of human history, all these pulmonauts discovered the same thing. They discovered that the optimum amount of air we should take in at rest per minute is 5.5 liters. The optimum breathing rate is about 5.5 breaths per minute. That's 5.5-second inhales and 5.5-second exhales. This is the perfect breath.”

4. Breathing+: Sometimes Fast, Sometimes Not at All

“Collectively, I'm calling these potent techniques Breathing+, because they build on the foundation of practices I described earlier in this book, and because many require extra focus and offer extra rewards. Some involve breathing really fast for a very long time; others require breathing very slow for even longer. A few entail not breathing at all for a few minutes. These



methods, too, date back thousands of years, vanished, then were rediscovered again at a different time in a different culture, renamed and redeployed.”

Breathing+ is not only the coolest name, but it covers all the paradoxes of breathing. The things we “shouldn’t do” yet have been used for millennia to enhance wellness. The methods that should cause harm based on medical knowledge, but instead seem to promote health.

Let’s start with fast breathing—the opposite of everything discussed so far—as Nestor has a perfect description of its benefits:

“Breathing really fast and heavy on purpose flips the vagal response the other way, shoving us into a stressed state. It teaches us to consciously access the autonomic nervous system and control it, to turn on heavy stress specifically so that we can turn it off and spend the rest of our days and nights relaxing and restoring, feeding and breeding.”

On the flip side, super slow breathing and breath holds cause intense stress due to the build-up of CO2 and drop in oxygen saturation. Although it seems dangerous at first, they can build mental and physical resiliency when done safely and in a controlled manner.

This brings us to the vital point about Breathing+. *It’s about conscious control:*

“Under normal circumstances, these conditions are considered damaging and would require medical care. (//) But something else happens when we practice these techniques willingly, when we consciously push our bodies into these states for a few minutes, or hours, a day. In some cases, they can radically transform lives.”

So, the take-home is that if things like fast breathing and breath holds occur unconsciously, they have terrible effects. But when done consciously, these Breathing+ techniques “**can radically transform lives.**”

1 Life-Changing Idea

Chew

“When mouths don’t grow wide enough, the roof of the mouth tends to rise up instead of out ... The upward growth impedes the development of the nasal cavity, shrinking it and disrupting the delicate structures in the nose. The reduced nasal space leads to obstruction and inhibits airflow. Overall, humans have the sad distinction of being the most plugged-up species on Earth.”



The most incredible (yet disheartening) thing Nestor discovered was that the human face and airways have been shrinking. That we have become “the most plugged-up species on Earth.” The natural question was, why? Why are we like this? *The answer was chewing.*

It turns out our ancestors used to spend a lot of time chewing...like hours and hours a day. This came to a somewhat abrupt end when we began processing food. But our faces and airways still desperately need this simple act to grow to their full potential.

Nestor outlines all kinds of ways in which chewing positively impacts facial growth and airway expansion. As one neat example, chewing releases stem cells that help the bones in our face grow at any age. Check out the book for tons of information on chewing.

From a practical perspective, it's difficult to fix our chewing deficiency unless we go back to eating like cave people. However, here are a few of things you can do to help:

1. Chew more. As much as you can. Liquify the food before you swallow. (NOTE: I am terrible with this, so I'm putting it here for me.)
2. Use proper oral posture: mouth closed, top and bottom teeth slightly touching, and tongue resting on the roof of the mouth.
3. Consider trying [Mewing](#), chewing gum (he suggests Falim or mastic), or even [a device](#) to expand your airways (the links come from the book).

Let's wrap up by putting everything we've learned together: Chew, breathe through your nose, mostly less but sometimes more, and enjoy the healing powers of the breath.

1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

“No matter what we eat, how much we exercise, how resilient our genes are, how skinny or young or wise we are—none of it will matter unless we're breathing correctly. That's what these researchers discovered. The missing pillar in health is breath. It all starts there.”

“In a single breath, more molecules of air will pass through your nose than all the grains of sand on all the world's beaches—trillions and trillions of them.”



"I foolishly had assumed that everyone had at least a rudimentary knowledge of physiology,' Stough wrote in his autobiography, Dr. Breath. 'Even more foolishly I had assumed that a universal awareness of the importance of breathing existed. Nothing could have been farther from the truth.'"

"What our bodies really want, what they require to function properly, isn't faster or deeper breaths. It's not more air. What we need is more carbon dioxide."

"Carbon dioxide is, in fact, a more fundamental component of living matter than is oxygen." – Yandell Henderson

"In many ways, this resonant breathing offered the same benefits as meditation for people who didn't want to meditate. Or yoga for people who didn't like to get off the couch. It offered the healing touch of prayer for people who weren't religious."

"The less one breathes, the more one absorbs the warming touch of respiratory efficiency—and the further a body can go."

"The earliest yoga was a science of holding still and building prana through breathing."

"Like all Eastern medicines, breathing techniques are best suited to serve as preventative maintenance, a way to retain balance in the body so that milder problems don't blossom into more serious health issues. Should we lose that balance from time to time, breathing can often bring it back."

"From what I've learned in the past decade, that 30 pounds of air that passes through our lungs every day and that 1.7 pounds of oxygen our cells consume is as important as what we eat or how much we exercise. Breathing is a missing pillar of health."

My favorite quote from the book:

"To breathe is to absorb ourselves in what surrounds us, to take in little bits of life, understand them, and give pieces of ourselves back out. Respiration is, at its core, reciprocation."



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on Amazon](#)

Citation

Stephen, M. J. (2021).
Breath Taking: The
Power, Fragility, and
Future of Our
Extraordinary Lungs.
Atlantic Monthly Press.

Version Read

Audible & Hardcover

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July 22, 2022

Book 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes

Breath Taking: The Power, Fragility, and Future of Our Extraordinary Lungs BY: MICHAEL J STEPHEN, MD

THE 4 THOUGHTS

1. Breathing Makes Everything Possible: Life & Breath Are Synonymous
2. The “Feynman of Breathing” and 4 Quotes on Our Beautiful Lungs
3. The Lungs Lead. The Heart and Mind Follow
4. Yoga and Breathing Exercises, or Prozac and Zoloft?

4 THOUGHTS

1. Breathing Makes Everything Possible: Life & Breath Are Synonymous

“That oxygen, life, and lungs all came into our world in relatively close succession is no coincidence. Only with oxygen and some means of extracting it are all things possible—thinking, moving, eating, speaking, and loving. Life and the breath are synonymous.”

I often feel crazy because the more I learn about breathing, the more I feel like all of life’s problems come back to it. It just seems too simple to be true.



Then, I read a beautiful quote like this. One that succinctly states how breathing, quite literally, **makes everything possible**. And it reminds me that it is, in fact, the opposite: It's not crazy that all of life's problems come back to the breath. It would be crazy if they didn't.

Remember: *"Life and the breath are synonymous."*

2. The "Feynman of Breathing" and 4 Quotes on Our Beautiful Lungs

Dr. Stephen is the closest thing we have to a "Feynman" of breathing. He's an expert on the lungs and uses that understanding to describe them beautifully.

So, for this thought, I just want to share a few of the elegant passages on the lungs so we can appreciate just how special they are.

"While the heart has dense striated muscle, and the brain its conglomerated networks of communicating neurons, the lung is a thin, graceful structure of interconnecting fibrous tissue that is beautifully held together with a foamy substance that lubricates its functions in a quiet and effortless manner. It is an organ of elegance, not brute strength."

"Our lungs developed to utilize oxygen and efficiently drive our metabolic reactions. We are aerobic creatures, and if the lungs are our most important organ, then oxygen is the most important gas in the atmosphere. [...] With oxygen, the possibilities of the world opened up."

"The lungs are a mysterious and even mystical organ. They are our connection to the atmosphere, the organ that extracts the life force we need to exist."



"The lungs tap into something universal in their structure, maximizing uptake of the life force that surrounds all of us."

3. The Lungs Lead. The Heart and Mind Follow

*"This knowledge is spreading back to the West through disciplines such as yoga and mindfulness, but also through techniques aimed at improving endurance, and even intimacy. **These practices demonstrate that the mind and the heart follow the lungs, not the other way around.**" (my emphasis)*

Study after study has shown that breathing gives you access and control over your heart and mind, for example, by increasing heart rate variability and synchronizing brain waves. The lungs lead; the heart and mind follow.

But even with all this research, sometimes it takes an eloquent quote like this to make it seem so obvious.

So, do you want to change how you think or feel? It all starts with the breath. Everything else follows.

4. Yoga and Breathing Exercises, or Prozac and Zoloft?

"Deep breathing is a potent inducer of the parasympathetic nervous system. The release of acetylcholine not only calms our organs, it also stimulates the release of serotonin, dopamine, and prolactin, the feel-good hormones targeted by medicines like Prozac and Zoloft. But yoga and breathing exercises produce this effect naturally and without side effects."

I found it fascinating to learn that breathing and yoga exercises target the same hormones as Prozac and Zoloft. This helps explain why they're such a potent therapy for stress and depression.



This might also be why in *Mind Over Meds*, Dr. Andrew Weil says, “*Learning to regulate the breath is a more effective anti-anxiety measure than benzodiazepines, without any of the cognitive impairment and addictive potential of those drugs.*”

Of course, we can’t just “breathe” our way off our medications. But, adding it into our daily routines seems like a no-brainer since it’s cheap, easy, and there are no adverse side effects.

1 LIFE-CHANGING IDEA

Breathing Exercises Lower Inflammation and Change Gene Expression

“In those who practice breathing exercises, levels of inflammatory proteins in the blood are significantly lower, especially under certain types of stress. Mobilizing the power of the breath has also been shown to turn on anti-inflammatory genes and turn off pro-inflammatory ones, including genes that regulate energy metabolism, insulin secretion, and even the part of our DNA that controls longevity.⁷ Looking down the generations, those of us who practice breathing exercises today may well pass on more disease-resistant genes to our descendants tomorrow.”

Here's a life-changing idea: How we breathe can reduce inflammation, change our gene expression, and maybe even allow us to pass down better genes to our kids.

How do we get these benefits? Well, the study Dr. Stephen is referencing (the ⁷ superscript) was on “the relaxation response,” which Dr. Herbert Benson (who discovered the response) describes as:

“Briefly stated, the relaxation response is defined as the response that is the opposite of the “fight-or-flight” or stress response. It is characterized by the following: decreased metabolism, heart rate, blood pressure, and rate of breathing; a decrease or “calming” in brain activity; an increase in attention and decision-making functions of the brain; and changes in gene activity that are the opposite of those associated with stress.”



A simple way to trigger this state is slow breathing with extended exhalations. Something as easy as a 4-second inhale and a 6-second exhale will do.

Another approach Dr. Benson recommends is a mantra-based meditation. Pick a word or phrase that's meaningful to you (I use "be the change"). Then inhale, and say your mantra silently in your head during the exhale.

Do either method for at least 10 minutes to trigger the relaxation response, change your gene expression, and maybe even change the future generations.

1 STACK OF MEMORABLE QUOTES

"Oxygen is the life force, the source of life's infinite possibilities."

"Ancient Egyptian cultures also recognized the importance of the breath, the evidence of which we see today in the many ancient statues that had their noses broken off but otherwise were left untouched. This defacement was no accident, but a deliberate act by conquering groups to take the life, in this case the breath of life, away from these icons."

"Science is beginning to investigate in a serious manner something humanity has known for centuries—that the breath can be used to heal the body."

"In the beginning was the voice. Voice is sounding breath, the audible sign of life." - Otto Jespersen

"Buddhism and Hinduism were based on an understanding of the potency of the breath. According to these disciplines, studying and harnessing the breath was the only recognized way to nirvana."

"It is a beautiful circle of reuse and recycle, appropriately termed circulation, with the lungs as the centerpiece, the lynchpin connecting the body and the outside world."

"Each time we check on each other, we are validating the words of the Roman philosopher Cicero, dum spiro, spero, 'As I breathe, I hope.'"



“The lung changes the breath, as the liver changes the chyle, into food for the vital spirit.” – Alessandro Benedetti

“Another crucial aspect of the breath, and one that is rarely discussed, is that it gives us our voice.”

“Life and respiration are complementary. There is nothing living which does not breathe nor anything breathing which does not live.” – William Harvey, 1653



[Get This Book
on Amazon](#)

Citation

Rosenberg, L. (2004, November 9). *Breath by Breath: The Liberating Practice of Insight Meditation* (Shambhala Classics) (0 ed.). Shambhala.

Version Read

Audible & Kindle

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Additional Note:

This book is a discourse on the Anapanasati Sutra. This sutra *“constitutes the basic meditative instructions of the Buddha, and so serves as a fundamental vehicle for gaining insight into the core teachings of Buddhism.”* – Jon Kabat-Zinn

Book 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes

Breath by Breath: The Liberating Practice of Insight Meditation BY: LARRY ROSENBERG

THE 4 THOUGHTS

1. To Contemplate Breathing is to Contemplate Life Itself
2. Where You Should Follow Your Breathing
3. How to Get from Point A to Point B: Be Fully at A
4. My Favorite Breathing Parable Ever

4 THOUGHTS

1. To Contemplate Breathing is to Contemplate Life Itself

“This quality of mindfulness, of just being with an experience, is what the meditator arouses when assuming the seated posture. At first the meditator brings his or her awareness to an extremely simple process.”

“Always mindful, the meditator breathes in; mindful, the meditator breathes out.”

It sounds simple, of course, but it’s actually—as anyone knows who has tried it—a profound and difficult



practice. The fact is that when we focus on the breath, we are focusing on the life force. Life begins with our first breath and will end after our last. To contemplate breathing is to contemplate life itself."

This insightful passage is essentially the premise of the whole book: *When we focus on our breath, we focus on our life force.* It's extremely practical yet deeply spiritual. Mundane yet enlightening.

It's also essential to note that this doesn't require altering the breath, just watching it. It's mindful breathing, not "breathwork." (We'll cover this more in Thought 3 and the Life-Changing Idea.)

And as simple as "following the breath" sounds, it's actually quite challenging.

Perhaps this is why the Buddha was still meditating twenty years after reaching enlightenment. And when asked what type of meditation he practiced, he replied, *"Mindfulness of breathing."*

2. Where You Should Follow Your Breathing

"A number of beginning students ask where in the body they should follow the breath. I've read widely in the Buddha's teachings and consulted a number of scholars, and nowhere does he give a precise answer to this question. Nevertheless, a number of traditional teachers are very specific. Some say the place to follow it is the abdomen, others say the nostrils or chest region. As far as I'm concerned, they are all right. It is really just a matter of individual preference.

Having worked with any number of students through the years, I feel that meditators should follow the breathing where it seems most vivid and comfortable to them, where it is most likely to hold their attention. None of these places will always, in every sitting, remain the most vivid. But it is important not to keep jumping from one to another, feeding an already restless mind. Station your attention at the nose, chest, or abdomen, and remain there with some consistency."

If you want to get started with mindfulness of breathing, this is about as practical as it gets.



Where we focus on the breath is not as important as being *consistent*.

So, we should pick the place that is most vivid and comfortable (that's the abdomen for me) "*and remain there with some consistency.*"

P.S. If you get started, don't forget from Thought #1 that, although it seems simple enough, it is actually "*a profound and difficult practice.*"

3. How to Get from Point A to Point B: Be Fully at A

*"This is the deepest paradox in all of meditation: we want to get somewhere—we wouldn't have taken up the practice if we didn't—but the way to get there is just to be fully here. **The way to get from point A to point B is really to be at A.** When we follow the breathing in the hope of becoming something better, we are compromising our connection to the present, which is all we ever have. If your breathing is shallow, your mind and body restless, let them be that way, for as long as they need to. Just watch them."* (my emphasis)

This is the paradigm shift I love about this book. Instead of using our breath "*in the hope of becoming something better,*" we just use it to be here with how things are. **Then, paradoxically, we will get better.**

To get from point A to point B, we just have to be fully at point A.

And point A is the breath. We don't have to change it, just watch it.

4. My Favorite Breathing Parable Ever

"An ancient teaching from India points to this truth. There was a conference of all the human faculties, all the senses, which in the Indian tradition are six: the five senses plus the mind. As at many meetings, they first had to decide who would be in charge. Sight popped up



and put in its bid, creating beautiful images that had everyone enraptured. Smell arose and created powerful and haunting aromas that left everyone tingling with anticipation. But taste could top that, with astounding and delectable flavors from all the world's cuisines. Hearing created exquisite harmonies that brought everyone to tears, and the body brought on physical sensations that had everyone in ecstasy, and the mind spun out intellectual theories that took on beauty by the depths of the truths they expressed.

*Along came the breath—not even one of the senses!—and said it wanted to be in charge. All it could present was the simple in-and-out breath, not terribly impressive in the face of everything else. No one even noticed it. The other senses got into a tremendous argument about which one of them would be chosen. The breath in its disappointment began walking away. And the images began to fade, the tastes lost their savor, the sounds diminished. . . . “Wait,” the senses called out. “Come back. You can lead. We need you.” **And the breath came back and took its proper place.***
(my emphasis)

That is all 🙏

1 LIFE-CHANGING IDEA

How it Should Be, and Letting Breath (and life) Unfold Naturally

“Our tendency is to ride the breath, push it along, help it out, especially when we hear that the breath is part of this marvelous sutra, that it is the life force itself and can lead us to enlightenment. ... We hear that a deep breath relaxes the body and figure that an accomplished meditator will be breathing deeply all the time, so—sometimes very subtly—we try to make the breath a little deeper.



That isn't the instruction. The instruction is to let it be, to surrender to the breathing."

I felt like Larry was looking right at me with this passage 😊 I definitely find myself trying to breathe certain ways, because that's how I "should be breathing."

But the instruction is to just let the breath be, to surrender to it.

And more generally, I think we can interpret breathing in this passage as a metaphor for all aspects of life.

We might ask: ***In what ways am I trying to make something "the way I think it should be" rather than accepting it how it is?*** (I have about a million.)

Then, we can use Larry's advice, literally or metaphorically:

"If we can learn to allow the breath to unfold naturally without tampering with it, then in time we may be able to do that with other aspects of our experience: we might learn to let the feelings be, let the mind be."

Life-changing, indeed.

1 STACK OF MEMORABLE QUOTES

"The fact is that when we focus on the breath, we are focusing on the life force. Life begins with our first breath and will end after our last. To contemplate breathing is to contemplate life itself."

"But when you learn to stay with the breathing, to sink deep within your consciousness, you find that there is an intrinsic happiness there that has nothing to do with sensual pleasures, and it gives your life a whole new balance."

"Practice should open us to a fuller life, not cut us off from it altogether."

"The breath is a gateway into the present moment, making our attention to it greater, not less."

"Zen Master Hogen said that the whole universe is in the breath. If you really pay attention to it, it takes you to its immaculate source."



"The act of breathing begins our life as we come out of the womb; in our last moment, when we cease breathing, our life is over. It only makes sense that the breath should also have a profound influence on all the moments in between."

"Thich Nhat Hanh says he has been watching the breath for fifty years and it only grows in interest."

"He let me see that because the breath is so unassuming, I had been undervaluing it. I was looking for a complicated path to enlightenment, when this simple one was right before me."

"We might say (every pun intended) that the richness lies right beneath our noses in any and every moment." – Jon Kabat-Zinn

"When you're feeling confusion, don't see it as interfering with your practice. It is your practice; it is your life in that moment."

"We're all breathing. The instruction is just to know that we are, not in an intellectual sense, but to be aware of the simple sensation, the in-breath and the out-breath."

"Something happens when mindfulness touches breathing. Its quality changes for the better. [...] The breath becomes pleasant; it is enjoyable just to sit and breathe. [...] The body, the mind, and the breath begin to coalesce. They each partake of the other, so that it is difficult to distinguish among them."

"This is the deepest paradox in all of meditation: we want to get somewhere—we wouldn't have taken up the practice if we didn't—but the way to get there is just to be fully here."

"Saint Francis of Assisi had a simpler way of putting it: 'It is no use walking anywhere to preach unless our walking is our preaching.'"

"As the breath goes, so goes the body."



[Get This Book
on Amazon](#)

Citation

Weil, A., MD, & True, S.
(2001, January 2).
Breathing: The Master
Key to Self Healing.
Sounds True.

Version Read

Audio Recording

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October 21, 2022

Additional Note:

This is an audio tape,
not a book. So, all the
quotes are punctuated
using my best guess
based on Dr. Weil's
dictation. Moreover,
this tape (released
more than 20 years
ago!) will now be my #1
recommendation for
anyone beginning with
breathing.

It's not "perfect," but
it's less than 2 hrs and
has basically everything
we need to start a
breath practice. It was
one of my favorite
listens in a really long
time.

Book 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes

Breathing: The Master Key to Self Healing BY: ANDREW WEIL, MD

THE 4 THOUGHTS

1. Why Breathwork Works for Everyone
2. How Long Should We Practice Breathwork Each Day?
3. How to Make Spiritual Progress using the Breath
4. Two Core Breathing Exercises + Dr. Weil's Routine

4 THOUGHTS

1. Why Breathwork Works for Everyone

"I recommend breathwork to almost all patients that I see because, in my experience, stress is a primary cause (or an aggravating cause) of most cases of illness. And even if people have diseases that clearly have organic physical causes, relaxation can nonetheless benefit them and help their body's healing system work better."

This is a perfect description of why breathwork works for basically anyone. Regardless of what condition you suffer from (even if none), relaxation is still valuable in our modern stress-filled world.

And physiologically, breathwork works for everyone because the *"breath is the only function through which you can influence the involuntary nervous system."*



That is, you can establish rhythms of breathing with your voluntary nerves and muscles that will affect the involuntary nervous system.”

Thus, we can use our breath to influence the involuntary (autonomic) nervous system and, subsequently, all the body’s major systems.

All of this is why Dr. Weil says, *“If I had to limit my advice on healthier living to just one tip, it would be simply to learn how to breathe correctly.”* 🙌

2. How Long Should We Practice Breathwork Each Day?

“I think the amount of time that you spend on this work is not that important. The basic exercise that I'll be teaching you, you can do in a few minutes, and if you do this twice a day, that's more than adequate. But again, I'd like to remind you that what is important here is the regularity of doing this work. You want to do this every day without fail because you are attempting to change rhythms in your nervous system, and it's the constancy of the input, it's the regularity of the input, that is going to produce these changes over time.”

Of course, we can use scientific findings to find a reasonable dose for our practice ([which is about 10 min/day for slow breathing](#)).

But an even better approach is what Dr. Weil says here: **Simply focus on consistency.**

We’re trying to rewire our nervous systems, and *“it’s the regularity of the input that is going to produce these changes over time.”* ←
Amen to that 🙏

3. How to Make Spiritual Progress using the Breath

“[B]reath is the animated, nonphysical aspect of your being. So that when you look in the direction of breath, when you focus your attention on your breath, you are really looking at your spiritual self.”

This is why Dr. Weil also says that *“if you do nothing other than pay attention to your breath today, for a few seconds more than you did yesterday, you have increased your spiritual awareness. You have made spiritual progress.”*



Sounds good (and easy enough) to me 🙏

P.S. Dr. Weil also has a great discussion on why liquor is referred to as “spirits.” Then somehow, he relates that back to the breath [*standing applause*, lol]. It’s too long to include, but here’s a quote that captures the essence of it: *“That’s a very interesting clue as to the meaning of spirit, and I think that it’s possible to look at breath in relation to body in the same way that we could look at Brandy in relation to wine. **That breath represents the concentrated, distilled essence of being. And that it is nonphysical, it is invisible, it does not have substance, but it’s where the power is.**”* (my emphasis)

4. Two Core Breathing Exercises + Dr. Weil’s Routine

“Let me give you one suggestion that I do myself that I find very useful, and that’s to experiment with combining the stimulating and the relaxing breath. So that you will do the stimulating breath, the bellows breath, for a minute if you can, and immediately go into the relaxing breath. I find this a very powerful combination, and I do this as a prelude to meditation. So I’ll do the stimulating breath for a minute; I do 8 cycles of the relaxing breath; and then I immediately go into my sitting meditation. And I find that that’s an excellent preparation for the experience of meditation.”

The two core exercises Dr. Weil teaches in this audio tape are a relaxing breath (4-7-8 breathing) and a stimulating breath (bellows’ breath):

1. **The 4-7-8 Breath:** Inhale quietly through your nose for 4 seconds, hold for 7, and exhale audibly through pursed lips for 8 seconds. [Here’s a video demonstrating it.](#)
2. **The Bellows Breath:** Inhale and exhale quickly and forcibly through your nose. Your pace should be 60+ breaths per minute (Dr. Weil suggests upwards of 180 breaths/min). [Here’s a video demonstration.](#)

At the very least, Dr. Weil recommends performing the 4-7-8 breath for four repetitions twice daily (that’s less than 5 minutes a day).

But this combination of the stimulating breath followed by the relaxing breath is particularly enjoyable. Start with 10-30 seconds of bellows breath followed by 4



reps of the 4-7-8 breath. After a few weeks, build it up to Dr. Weil's routine (one minute of bellows breath followed by 8 repetitions of the 4-7-8 breath).

P.S. If neither of those techniques sound appealing, you can also try Dr. Weil's simplest form of breathwork: *"The very simplest form of breathwork is doing nothing other than paying attention to your breath. That is, not trying to influence it, not trying to speed it up or slow it down, not trying to change the rhythm—simply looking at it, observing the breath."*

1 LIFE-CHANGING IDEA

The Four Qualities of Breath We Want to Develop to Feel Better

"One of the essential techniques that I distill from this body of knowledge about pranayama is that the qualities of breath that you want to develop are to make it deeper, slower, quieter, and more regular."

This has become my new mantra.

- **Waiting in line:** deeper, slower, quieter, & more regular.
- **At the park with my daughter:** deeper, slower, quieter, & more regular.
- **Anywhere we find ourselves:** deeper, slower, quieter, & more regular.

I love these qualities because they're concrete. Instead of just "coming back to our breath," we can come back to deeper, slower, quieter, and more regular.

And what makes this so powerful?

"When your breathing is deeper, slower, quieter, and more regular, you are feeling better, in both mind and body. Your nervous system is functioning more smoothly, and all your organs are operating more harmoniously as a result."

It has certainly been life-changing for me. I hope it is for you, too. 🙏

1 STACK OF MEMORABLE QUOTES



"Of all the techniques that I have investigated for reducing stress and increasing relaxation, it is breathwork that I have found to be the most time-efficient, the most cost-efficient, and the one that most promotes increased wellness and optimal health."

"In the four years I spent at Harvard Medical School and a year of internship in San Francisco, I learned nothing about the healing power of breath."

"Over the years, I would say that of all the techniques that I recommended to people for improving health, the single technique that I get most feedback about in a positive way is the breathwork that I'm going to teach you in this program."

"I feel very strongly, as a result of these experiences, that proper breathing is a master key to good health."

"In addition, the mental component of breath is a sense of rhythmic expansion and contraction. And I think that connects us to every other living thing because all living organisms breathe. So that same rhythm is at the center of the heart of all life."

"Somehow in ancient India, people discovered the power of breath as a technique for affecting the nervous system, for changing consciousness, and for changing physiology. And I think it's fair to say that that knowledge that came to ancient India has diffused all over the world and taken many different forms."

"I think it is also fair to say that when you turn your attention in the direction of breath, you are really looking at the spiritual pole of your existence."

"I'm also very impressed with the fact that breathwork is free, it requires no equipment, it's simple, and it's working with something that literally you have right under your nose and many of us never think to make use of."

"In a nutshell, I think it's fair to say that when you have your attention on your breath, it's in a safe place. It's like putting your consciousness in neutral."



[Get This Book
on Amazon](#)

Citation

Hanson, R., & Mendius, R. (2009). Buddha's Brain: The Practical Neuroscience of Happiness, Love, and Wisdom (1st ed.). New Harbinger Publications.

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Additional Note

This book has tons of deep neuroscience paired with practical application. As always, I'm pulling the most relevant parts for us and breathing, but if you're into the brain, go read the whole thing.

Book 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes

**Buddha's Brain: The Practical Neuroscience
of Happiness, Love & Wisdom**
BY: RICK HANSON, Ph.D, with RICHARD
MENDIUS, MD

THE 4 THOUGHTS

1. The Power of the PNS and How to Utilize It
2. Finding the Optimal Balance for an Optimal Life
3. Why Breathing Seems Like a Panacea
4. The Perfect Word to Describe Why We Practice

4 THOUGHTS

1. The Power of the PNS and How to Utilize It

"Parasympathetic activation is the normal resting state of your body, brain, and mind. If your SNS were surgically disconnected, you'd stay alive (though you wouldn't be very useful in an emergency). If your PNS were disconnected, however, you'd stop breathing and soon die. ... The cooling, steadying influence of the PNS helps you think clearly and avoid hot-headed actions that would harm you or others. The PNS also quiets the mind and fosters tranquility, which supports contemplative insight."



We frequently discuss the sympathetic and parasympathetic nervous systems (SNS & PNS). But that's crazy to learn that we could live with our SNS surgically disconnected. **Not the PNS, though.**

PNS activation is *“the normal resting state of your body, brain, and mind.”* If that's not enough, it also helps us think clearer and have contemplative insight (among many other things).

So how do we use it and nourish it?

Here are two (of several) exercises Dr. Hanson suggests:

Diaphragmatic Breathing: *“Place your hand on your stomach a couple of inches beneath the upside-down V at the center of your rib cage. Look down, breathe normally, and watch your hand. You'll probably see it move only a little bit, and sort of up and down. ... Leaving your hand in place, now breathe in such a way that your hand moves out and back, perpendicular to your chest. Try to breathe into your hand with real oomph, so that it travels back and forth half an inch or more with each breath.”*

Big Exhales: *“Inhale as much as you can, hold that inhalation for a few seconds, and then exhale slowly while relaxing. A big inhalation really expands your lungs, requiring a big exhalation to bring the lungs back to their resting size. This stimulates the PNS, which is in charge of exhaling.”*

Or better yet, combine both of those. Just a few minutes is all you need to feel it.

While you're doing that, let's move on to the next thought, where we learn that we still need the SNS for an optimal life.

2. Finding the Optimal Balance for an Optimal Life

“Happiness, love, and wisdom aren't furthered by shutting down the SNS, but rather by keeping the autonomic nervous system as a whole in an optimal state of balance.”

And how do we do that? Back to Dr. Hanson: *“The best-odds prescription for a long, good life is a baseline of mainly PNS arousal with mild SNS activation for vitality, combined with occasional SNS spikes for major opportunities or threats.”*



So, there's an excellent "prescription" for a long, good life.

But here's a crucial point: Our modern world does not set us up for this balance. In fact, it's kind of the opposite. We are constantly barraged by unnatural stressors (like phones, email, etc.).

This is a problem. As Dr. Hanson says, *"your brain preferentially scans for, registers, stores, recalls, and reacts to unpleasant experiences; as we've said, it's like Velcro for negative experiences and Teflon for positive ones."* So, in our minds, all those negative stressors severely outweigh the positive, putting us in an SNS-dominated state.

Meaning to find balance, we need to focus mainly on PNS-activating practices.

This is why we primarily discuss slow-breathing exercises here. They ramp up PNS activity and help offset those modern stressors.

So here's to using our breath to regularly activate the PNS, find an optimal state of balance, and ultimately an optimal state of life.

P.S. We could also apply Dr. Hanson's "prescription" to our breathing practice itself. It might look like this:

- **Baseline PNS Arousal:** Mainly slow breathing practices + nasal breathing 24/7
- **Mild SNS Activation:** Occasional fast-breathing and/or breath-hold practices
- **Occasional SNS spikes:** Wim Hof or similar

3. Why Breathing Seems Like a Panacea

"Your body has numerous major systems, including the endocrine (hormone), cardiovascular, immune, gastrointestinal, and nervous systems. If you want to use the mind-body connection to lower your stress, cool the fires, and improve your long-term health, what's the optimal point of entry into all these systems? It's the autonomic nervous system (ANS)."

And what's the optimal point of entry into the ANS? The breath.



As [Deb Dana](#) says, “Breath is a direct, easily accessible, and rapid way to shape the state of the nervous system.”

And when we combine that with Thoughts 1 and 2, we see why breathing often seems like a panacea: When we change the breath, we change the nervous system, and we change all the major systems of the body.

4. The Perfect Word to Describe Why We Practice

“Equanimity is neither apathy nor indifference: you are warmly engaged with the world but not troubled by it. Through its nonreactivity, it creates a great space for compassion, loving kindness, and joy at the good fortune of others.”

Equanimity. That’s the perfect word to describe what you get from a breathing practice. It’s both what you feel immediately after a session, and it’s a state that gradually becomes part of who you are.

So here’s to experiencing a little more of it, today.

P.S. Here’s the etymology of equanimity from Dr. Hanson: “The word equanimity comes from Latin roots meaning “even” and “mind.” With equanimity, what passes through your mind is held with spaciousness so you stay even-keeled and aren’t thrown off balance.” Sounds good to me.

P.P.S. Of course, I’m nowhere near a permanent state of equanimity (just ask my wife 😊), but it has certainly become more a part of me than it was before.

1 LIFE-CHANGING IDEA

Our Breath Moves Spirit Around Like Our Hearts Move Blood Around

“Each neural signal is a bit of information; your nervous system moves information around like your heart



moves blood around. All that information is what we define broadly as the mind, most of which is forever outside your awareness."

After reading that, I thought this analogy was fitting:

Our breath moves spirit around like our hearts move blood around.

Putting our breath in this perspective is, indeed, life-changing. Each breath we take feeds and moves our spirit—it nourishes our souls.

Of course, the words for breath and spirit (or soul, life force, etc.) [were the same](#) in ancient civilizations. We've forgotten this link, but it's always there. We only have to breathe mindfully to re-establish the connection.

As Thich Nhat Hanh said, *"It takes only two seconds, three seconds, to breathe in, to bring mind home to your body. And there, mind and body together, we are established in the here and the now, and you get in touch with the wonders of life, the Kingdom of God."*

So here's to using our breath to move our spirit and get in touch with the Kingdom of God, today.

1 STACK OF MEMORABLE QUOTES

"With Buddha's Brain, we are invited to take a deep breath and consider the neural reasons why we should slow ourselves down, balance our brain, and improve our connections with one another, and with our self." - Daniel J. Siegel, MD

"We're simplifying things when we refer to the brain as the basis of the mind. ... The mind and brain interact with each other so profoundly that they're best understood as a single, co-dependent, mind/brain system."

"Paradoxically, it takes time to become what we already are."

"The best-odds prescription for a long, good life is a baseline of mainly PNS arousal with mild SNS activation for vitality, combined with occasional SNS spikes for major opportunities or threats."



“Every time you take in the good, you build a little bit of neural structure. Doing this a few times a day—for months and even years—will gradually change your brain, and how you feel and act, in far-reaching ways.”

“Abide as equanimity. Breath after breath. At ease. Settle into deeper and deeper layers of equanimity. As you can, sense a sublime freedom, contentment, and peace.”

“With equanimity, you can deal with situations with calm and reason while keeping your inner happiness.” - The Dalai Lama

“Virtue sounds lofty, but it’s actually down to earth. It simply means living from your innate goodness, guided by principle. When you are virtuous no matter what other people do, their behavior is not controlling you.”

“Inner strength comes in many forms, including quiet perseverance. Get familiar with what strength feels like in your body so you can call it up again. Deliberately stimulate feelings of strength to deepen their neural pathways.”

“We hear the word “mindful” more and more these days, but what does it actually mean? Being mindful simply means having good control over your attention: you can place your attention wherever you want and it stays there; when you want to shift it to something else, you can.”

“When your attention is steady, so is your mind: not rattled or hijacked by whatever pops into awareness, but stably present, grounded, and unshakeable.”

“Oxygen is to the nervous system what gasoline is to your car. Although just 2 percent of body weight, your brain uses roughly 20 percent of your oxygen. By taking several deep breaths, you increase oxygen saturation in your blood and thus rev up your brain.”

“Integrate rapture and joy with the sensations of the breath. Let bliss breathe you, let the breath be tranquil.”

BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes



Fabi The Heart Warrior

BY: Fabiana González Aristizabal & José Paulino G.

411 Released: February 20, 2025

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. Meet Fabi, the Heart Warrior
2. Three Superpowers: Breathing, Prayer, and Meditation
3. A Successful Surgery
4. The Three Pillars and a Beautiful Message to Parents

1 Life-Changing Idea

1. I Believe in the Power of Conscious Breathing
-



4 Thoughts

1. Meet Fabi, the Heart Warrior

"Over time, I learned many new things, like reading and skateboarding. My adventures were filled with laughter, games, and discoveries. A few times I got into trouble, but always found a way to have fun and make everyone laugh!"

Fabi is a now 7-year-old girl, the daughter of a Learning Center member. She was a normal child who loved to laugh, explore, and even skateboard. (As an aside, I spent my entire youth, from age 8 to about 18, obsessed with skateboarding. So, seeing the cartoon drawing of Fabi holding a skateboard on the cover brought a special joy to my heart).

When Fabi was just a few months old, doctors noticed something unusual in her heart. At first, it wasn't a major concern, but as she got older, her mother noticed she would run out of breath and get tired easier than usual. That's when Fabi learned the seriousness of her heart problem:

"When I turned six, the doctor heard a slightly murmur in my heart again, and after many medical tests, my mom told me that it was congenital malformation and that I would need surgery to fix it."

As a parent, I can't even begin to imagine how her parents must have felt getting this news. But as we'll see next, they went above and beyond, giving Fabi tools that would help her face her surgery with strength and confidence.



2. Three Superpowers: Breathing, Prayer, and Meditation

"At first, I was scared, but my parents' hugs and love made me feel better. They also taught me the superpower of breathing, prayer, and meditation to stay calm and brave when anxiety and fear were knocking the door."

And this is where I may have started tearing up reading this book.

Here is this incredible young girl—just six years old at the time—practicing breathing, meditation, and prayer to prepare for heart surgery. To think of all the times I've used these practices for the "stressors" in my life...it suddenly makes you realize how insignificant most of our problems are. It's humbling and inspiring, to say the least.

And if you want even more inspiration for just how powerful these tools can be, here is what her dad, José, told me via email:

"I want to share with you that my 7-year-old daughter got open heart surgery in June 2024 and breathing practice was an EXCELLENT and INCREDIBLE useful tool to get her mind ready (avoid anxiety, stress, etc) and also was a key part of the recovery (Pain management, calm, etc)."

Next, let's hear the happy ending of Fabi's story.



3. A Successful Surgery

"My mom and dad were with me the whole time, along with my grandparents, uncles, godparents, friends, and lots of people who love me. The doctors and nurses were fantastic! After the surgery, I spent a few days with wires and machines attached to my body, but there was always someone there to help me when I was in pain or needed something."

And here is the best part of the story: Fabi had a successful surgery. As she puts it:

"I went back to my normal life with a healthy heart and more energy than ever."

And in true heart warrior fashion, she turns this experience into a source of support for others:

"Today, I have a special scar from my surgery that reminds me of how brave I can be. This experience will allow me to support others who have heart problems as I had."

That is wisdom beyond belief. Seeing her transform this challenge into something greater is a powerful reminder of just how strong, wise, and compassionate children can be.

And we'd all be wiser if we followed Fabi's lead, imprinting the final words of her story on our hearts:

"And so, with laughter and fun, I keep growing, ready for every new adventure life brings."

Amen to that 🙏



4. The Three Pillars and a Beautiful Message to Parents

"We believe that there are no magic tricks to support children through difficult health situations; each family has its own codes, beliefs, and traditions. However, we want to share with you, from parents to parents, three pillars that helped us stay calm during our Heart Warrior's battle: mindful breathing, meditation/prayer/faith, and the support from those around us. These helped us build emotional resilience and inner peace."

Fabi's parents leave us with an inspiring, heartfelt message at the back of the book. It's perfect as it is—none of my reflections are needed. Instead, I'll leave you with the final paragraph of their note, which is an incredible embodiment of mindfulness, humility, and pure love:

"We learned a lot during this journey. Understanding that miracles manifest in unexpected ways, letting go of things we cannot control, and trusting the processes of life—even when we don't understand why things happen this way—are undoubtedly three of the most important lessons."



1 Life-Changing Idea

I Believe in the Power of Conscious Breathing

"After the surgery, my daughter spent a few days in the intensive care unit. On the first night, after the anesthesia wore off, she woke up crying in a lot of pain. I asked her, 'On a scale from 1 to 10, how much does it hurt?' She replied, '12.'

We immediately alerted the nurse. At the same time, my wife told my daughter, 'The nurse is on her way, but in the meantime, breathe like your dad taught you.' At that moment, I looked at the monitor showing her breaths per minute, and it was over 50. Slowly, it started decreasing until it reached 18. I asked her again, 'On a scale from 1 to 10, how much does it hurt?' She answered, '6.'

Shortly after, the nurse arrived and gave her some pain medication.

This wasn't something subjective or something someone told me—I experienced it personally and confirmed it by watching the monitors she was connected to.

So yes, I believe more than ever in the power of breathing, consciously."

- José

That was an incredible story José shared with me. It wasn't included in the book, but it absolutely qualifies as life-changing.

José got to watch his daughter's numbers change while her pain eased. He got to actually see these tools work in real life, in the most trying of circumstances.

I hope this inspires you as much as it does me 🙏



1 (Special) Stack of Memorable Quotes

These quotes from the book were hand-picked my Fabi and José:

"At first, I was scared, but my parents' hugs and love made me feel better."

"They also taught me the superpower of breathing, praying, and meditation to stay calm and brave when anxiety and fear were knocking the door."

"Even though sometimes I did not want to, I knew I would have a stronger heart and more energy after this."

"I went back to my normal life with a healthy heart and more energy than ever."

"Today, I have a special scar from my surgery that reminds me of how brave I can be."

"Three pillars that helped us stay calm during our Heart Warrior's battle: mindful breathing, meditation/prayer/faith, and the support from those around us. These helped us build emotional resilience and inner peace."

My Favorite: "And so, with laughter and fun, I keep growing, ready for every new adventure life brings."

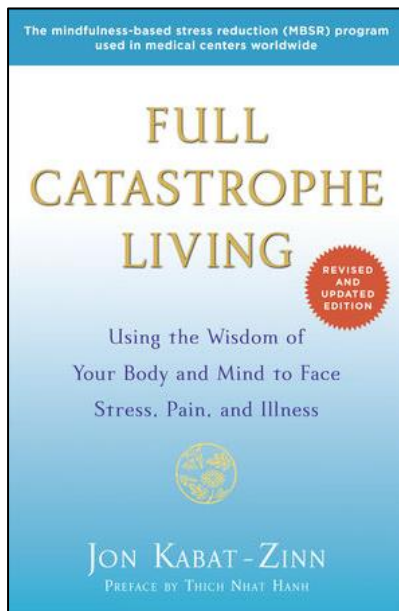
José's Favorite: "We learned a lot during this journey. Understanding that miracles manifest in unexpected ways, letting go of things we cannot control, and trusting the processes of life — even when we don't understand why things happen this way— are undoubtedly three of the most important lessons."

Fabi's Favorite: "My mom and dad were with me the whole time, along with my grandparents, uncles, godparents, friends, and lots of people who love me."



BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



Full Catastrophe Living: Using the Wisdom of Your Body and Mind to Face Stress, Pain, and Illness

BY: Jon Kabat-Zinn, Ph.D.

411 Released: May 5, 2023

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. What is Full Catastrophe Living?
2. Why Breathing is the Fundamental Anchor for Mindfulness
3. The Metaphorical Benefits of Belly Breathing for Stability
4. Why It Works: Breathing is No Longer Just Breathing

1 Life-Changing Idea

Remembered Wholeness



4 Thoughts

1. What is Full Catastrophe Living?

"Yet ever since I first heard it, I have felt that the phrase "the full catastrophe" captures something positive about the human spirit's ability to come to grips with what is most difficult in life and to find within it room to grow in strength and wisdom. For me, facing the full catastrophe means finding and coming to terms with what is deepest and best and ultimately, what is most human within ourselves."

I have avoided reading this book for a long time simply because of the title. But that passage on "the full catastrophe" is truly inspiring, and now I love the phrase :)

And really, the book is about using mindfulness to build our inner resources so we can accept this "full catastrophe" of living and still thrive. As Kabat-Zinn goes on to say:

"In this book, we will be learning and practicing the art of embracing the full catastrophe. We will be doing this so that rather than destroying us or robbing us of our power and our hope, the storms of life will strengthen us as they teach us about living, growing, and healing in a world of flux, change, and sometimes great pain."

That is inspiring and beautiful. So how do we embrace the full catastrophe? No surprise here: It all starts with the breath.

P.S. The philosophy and practices described in the book are the foundation of Kabat-Zinn's famous Mindfulness-Based Stress Reduction (MBSR) program. I'm focusing on breathing here, but the book/program includes other practices, such as yoga and body scans.

2. Why Breathing is the Fundamental Anchor for Mindfulness

"Probably the best place to start is with your breathing. If you can manage to bring your attention to your breathing for even the briefest of moments, it will



set the stage for facing that moment and the next one with greater clarity. As we have seen, the breath itself is calming...it anchors us, gives us stability, like the bridge piling anchored in bedrock as the river flows around it. ... What is more, we carry it everywhere, so it is always here, no matter what the circumstances, and thus exquisitely convenient for us to call upon—a true ally in the cultivation of emotional balance.”

I’m obviously biased 😊, but a lot of the book is about the breath. Kabat-Zinn does an incredible job articulating why our breath is so powerful for cultivating mindfulness, balancing our emotions, and embracing the full catastrophe of life.

As he points out, breathing brings us into the present, allowing us to face our next moment with more clarity. Moreover, it’s always there, so we can use it anytime, anywhere—**“a true ally in the cultivation of emotional balance.”**

But ultimately, the breath brings us back to life. Because it is life. As he says, the breath **“immediately anchors our awareness in the body, in a fundamental, rhythmic, flowing life process.”**

So how do we do it? He suggests you pay attention to the sensations of your belly rising and falling with each breath (we’ll see why in the next thought). When your mind wanders, you bring it back to these breath sensations. This can be done sitting or lying down. Start with three minutes, with the goal of reaching fifteen minutes daily.

3. The Metaphorical Benefits of Belly Breathing for Stability

“Focusing on the breath at your belly can be calming. ... when we focus on our breathing down in the belly, we are tuning in to a region of the body that is far from the head and thus far below the agitations of our thinking mind. It is intrinsically calmer. So tuning in to the breath at the belly is a valuable way of reestablishing inner calmness and balance in the face of emotional upset or when you have a lot on your mind.”

Although this analogy isn’t valid for everyone, I think it’s a neat way of framing the psychological benefits of belly breathing. We focus on the abdomen area because it’s **“far from the head and thus far below the agitations of our thinking mind.”**

It’s also helpful because it’s centering, both literally and figuratively:



“Your belly is literally the center of gravity of your body, far below the head and the turmoil of your thinking mind. For this reason we “befriend” the belly right from the beginning as an ally in establishing calmness and awareness.”

As an aside, tons of research shows that “belly breathing” is calming for most people. In the breathing community, however, there is a stigma about “belly breathing” because we really want diaphragmatic breathing, which doesn’t necessarily occur with belly breathing.

But perhaps this is why it works, even if technically incorrect... Maybe it’s so relaxing and beneficial for so many people, not just for physiological reasons, but because it gets them away from the agitations of their thinking mind...just a thought...

Either way, consider using the abdomen as your anchor for breath awareness to bring you back to the present and away from the turmoil of your thinking mind anytime, anyplace.

4. Why It Works: Breathing is No Longer Just Breathing

“When we surveyed several hundred patients who had been out of the stress reduction program for a number of years and asked them what the single most important thing they got out of the program was, the majority said, “The breathing.” ... Why would breathing, which they were doing before anyway, be so important and so valuable all of a sudden?

The answer is that once you start meditating, breathing is no longer just breathing. When we start paying attention to our breathing on a regular basis, our relationship to it changes dramatically. As we have already seen, tuning in to it helps us to gather our often unfocused energies and center ourselves. The breath reminds us to tune in to our body and to encounter the rest of our experience with mindfulness, in this very moment.

When we are mindful of our breathing, it automatically helps us to establish greater calmness in both the body and the mind. Then we are better able to be aware of our thoughts and feelings...And with this awareness comes a feeling of having more room to move, of having more options, of being free to choose effective and appropriate responses in stressful situations rather than losing our equilibrium and sense of self as a result of feeling overwhelmed, thrown off balance by our own knee-jerk reactions.”

Beautifully said. I have nothing to add, except a few of these 🙌🙌🙌



1 Life-Changing Idea

Remembered Wholeness

"Perhaps more than anything else, the work of MBSR involves helping people to see and feel and believe in their wholeness, helping them to tend, befriend, and mend the wounds of disconnectedness and the pain of feeling isolated, fragmented, and separate, and helping them to discover an underlying fabric of wholeness and connectedness within themselves."

Here is the overarching benefit of the practice: remembered wholeness. When we take time to sit or lie in stillness and breathe consciously, we reconnect with our true selves. We remember that we're already whole. It happens naturally.

As Kabat-Zinn also says, **"We remember wholeness so readily because we don't have far to look for it. It is always within us."**

Explaining why this is life-changing is difficult. It's more of a feeling than anything that can be described in words. But to link it back to embracing the "full catastrophe" of living, here's the power of remembered wholeness: **"You feel like you are at home no matter where you are and what problems you face."**

Putting it all together: We practice mindfulness—through breath awareness—so we can access the present moment and feel whole & at home wherever we are. Sounds worth it to me 🙏

1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

"There is not one person on the planet who does not have his or her own version of the full catastrophe."

"One way to think of this process of transformation is to think of mindfulness as a lens, taking the scattered and reactive energies of your mind and focusing them into a coherent source of energy for living, for problem solving, and for healing."



“The breath plays an extremely important role in meditation and in healing. Breathing is an incredibly powerful ally and teacher in the work of meditation, although people who have no training in meditation think nothing of it and find it uninteresting.”

“Our breathing has the added virtue of being a very convenient process to support ongoing awareness in our daily lives. As long as we are alive, it is always with us. We can’t leave home without it.”

“Right in the simple old breath (I won’t say “right beneath our noses”) lies a completely overlooked source of power to transform our lives. All we need to do to make use of it is to deepen our attentional skills and our patience.”

“After all, the breath sensations are themselves an intimate part of the sensory field of the body and can put you back in touch with the whole of it.”

“While it may not be possible for us to cure ourselves or to find someone who can, it is possible for us to heal ourselves—to learn to live with and work with the conditions that present themselves in the present moment.”

“Healing implies the possibility that we can relate differently to illness, disability, even death, as we learn to see with eyes of wholeness.”

“[A]s long as you are breathing, there is more right with you than there is wrong, no matter how ill or how hopeless you may feel.”

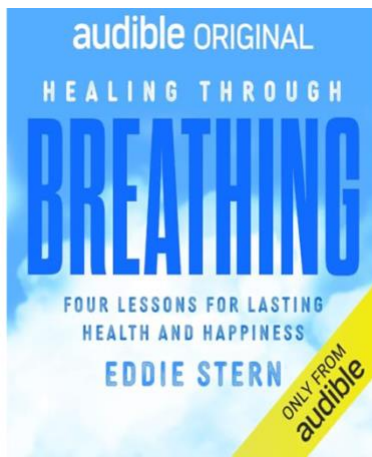
“It is impossible to become like somebody else. Your only hope is to become more fully yourself. That is the reason for practicing meditation in the first place.”

“As it turns out, we don’t have to look very far to reconnect with our deepest selves on this quest. At any moment, we are very close to home, much closer than we think. If we can simply realize the fullness of this moment, of this breath, we can find stillness and peace right here.”



BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



Healing Through Breathing: Four Lessons for Lasting Health and Happiness

BY: Eddie Stern

411 Released: April 21, 2024

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. How Conscious Breathing Heals
2. Practice When You're Not Stressed
3. Breathe Slow to Live Slow (our pace of breath is our pace of life)
4. The Power of Humming

1 Life-Changing Idea

1. Breathing as a Reminder of Connection, Surrender, and Trust

Reading Time: 5 min 36 sec

I hope the next 84'ish breaths are the most nourishing of your day.



4 Thoughts

1. How Conscious Breathing Heals

“What conscious breathing can do is...help shift our nervous system into what is called the healing response...Conscious breathing can enhance levels of sensitivity in our nervous system to handle and manage stress, and to support the restoration of balance. Conscious breathing can create enduring states of focus, presence, and mindful observation, so that life’s challenging situations do not completely highjack us, allowing a greater degree of control. While we cannot control life, we can learn to shape our response to it; conscious breathing is a valuable tool to support that.”

That nicely sums up how we heal through breathing 😊

Eddie provides several guided practices to elicit these healing benefits (which you can perform as you listen). But overall, they can be grouped into three broad categories:

1. Breath Awareness
2. Slow Resonant Breathing
3. Humming

We cover these regularly, so I won’t dwell on them here. Instead, I’ll leave you with one more insightful gem to contemplate on how breathing heals:

“When we breathe slow and steady, with the abdomen rising and falling with the breath, the messages that get sent to the brain through the vagus nerve are messages of steadiness, evenness, rhythmicity, safety, and control. The brain will receive these messages, and then respond in kind, sending messages back down to the body and releasing hormones and neurotransmitters that are a response to safety.” 🙌



2. Practice When You're Not Stressed

"It's important to have tools when it comes to dealing with stressful situations. If we haven't practiced them, absorbed them, and made them work for us outside of a crisis situation, they might be harder to draw on when we need them in real time. That's why it's important to practice them at times of the day when you are not in a crisis-situation. That way when you need to manage a stressful situation, your nervous system will already be attuned to what it feels like to be safe."

Take-home: Practice when you're not stressed so it works when you are. That's so good.

But, if we are to heal through breathing, this is even more critical because our bodies and minds need adequate time and space to mend. Therefore, practicing consistently, in a stress-free environment, is paramount to restoring health in our bodies and minds.

As Eddie puts it, **"Try to practice a little every day and see the effects that begin to emerge. As I'm fond of saying, small tweaks lead to big changes, and a little attention goes a long way. A few minutes of slow breathing is a small tweak—perhaps just one percent of our day—and that little bit of attention to the very thing that sustains our life is bound to have wonderful outcomes."** 🙏 Amen to that



3. Breathe Slow to Live Slow (our pace of breath is our pace of life)

"It has been said that if we breathe fast, we live fast. If we breathe slow, we can live slow. And remember, things that go fast are often over quicker, so when it comes to longevity, slow and steady wins the race. When we can control and steady our breath, we can also begin to embody steadiness in our day-to-day life. The pace of our breathing influences many aspects of our lives including our bodily rhythms, emotions, and mood, and so a slow and deliberate breathing pattern can allow for a slower-paced and more aware lifestyle."

I love this so much, and it's why slow breathing is fundamental to all meditative practices: It helps us live slower, allowing us to **"embody steadiness in our day-to-day life."**

And I'll note that this doesn't mean we have to lower our aspirations or do less. Instead, it means we can be busy doing things we love without feeling rushed. We can slow down the pace of our minds even when we have a million things to do.

And since Eddie and I have become close friends, I can attest that he lives this message. Between teaching yoga, writing books, traveling to speak, and running The Breathing App, he does more than anyone I know. Yet, he never seems rushed or overwhelmed, I'm guessing partly due to his regular breathing, meditation, and yoga practices.

So, let's use this passage (and Eddie's example) to breathe slowly so we can live a slower and more aware life.



4. The Power of Humming

“Humming induces brainwave entrainment, and since the sound of a hum is long and sustained, it has a calming effect on the brain. It also helps us to naturally extend our exhalation without making much of an effort to do so...With just a few minutes of humming, people often feel calmer. Humming is also a spontaneous sound of joy...We hum in agreement with people, or things we read, and children naturally hum when they are happy. Humming is both good for you and we vocalize a hum when we experience good things.”

Humming is one of the core healing practices of the book, and this passage explains why perfectly.

To practice formally, you can inhale fully, then exhale, making a high-pitched hum for as long as you comfortably can. Just a few of these will leave you calm and refreshed.

More informally, to induce feelings of happiness, use this as a reminder to hum your favorite songs while showering or walking around (when it's socially acceptable, lol).

So here's to using humming to create a little more joy and happiness, starting today 🙏



1 Life-Changing Idea

Breathing as a Reminder of Connection, Surrender, and Trust

"We are literally being breathed by the atmosphere all through the day, all through our lives. To acknowledge that is an interesting prospect, which can actually allow us to practice surrender and trust. It's reflective of a much larger principle in our lives, and that is the ability or willingness to let go of control, to accept the unknown, and allow nature to hold us. In that trust, in that acceptance, there can be found great peace and relaxation that we are ok."

Contemplating the idea that we are being breathed by the atmosphere is genuinely profound.

It reminds us that (as Emily Hightower says) rather than "taking" a breath, we can receive one. That we are connected to the ecosystem of this world, not separate from it.

So, if you feel so inspired, I invite you to reflect on this idea and see if you can occasionally "receive" a breath or two and let it bring you **"great peace and relaxation that we are ok."**



1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

“What if we consider breath not only as a biological marker of being alive but also as a reflector of what it truly means to be alive, encompassing the entire spectrum of the human experiences and emotions?”

“As we delve into specific breathing patterns, we can begin to discern that our breath has the power to influence how we experience life, and even transform the course of our existence, and our experience of everything that life is made of. Because indeed, breath is life. As we breathe, so we live.”

“Conscious breathing is the one automatic function of our nervous system that we have a measure of control over, and therefore, is useful for maintaining and restoring balance to our mental, emotional, and physical health.”

“When we begin to take up breathing practices, we temporarily make an involuntary, life-sustaining function voluntary, and in that can make dramatic shifts to our state of mind and the state of our nervous system.”

“There’s the saying that sometimes when we go looking all over the world for answers to our life questions, that the answers were there, right under our nose, the whole time. In the case of breathing, it’s literally true.”

“The mind and the breath are two sides of the same coin, what we do to one, we do to the other. By slowing the breath, we slow the speed of the mind.”

“A few minutes of slow breathing is a small tweak—perhaps just one percent of our day—and that little bit of attention to the very thing that sustains our life is bound to have wonderful outcomes.”

“We can form an intimate relationship with our breath, our nervous system, and thus understand on a deep level the way our mind works. Ultimately, this is not about simply breathing; it is about finding a deep connection to our inner life.”



[Get This Book
on Amazon](#)

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July 27, 2022

Book 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes

Heart Breath Mind: Conquer Stress, Build Resilience, and Perform at your Peak

BY: LEAH LAGOS, Psy.D.

THE 4 THOUGHTS

1. Something Amazing Happens: Baroreflexes and Why Slow Breathing is So Powerful
2. Breathing for Focus & the Noradrenaline Sweet Spot
3. Strengthening Your Heart May Have Antidepressive Effects
4. Exhale Fully (unless you enjoy anxiety and tension)

4 THOUGHTS

1. Something Amazing Happens: Baroreflexes and Why Slow Breathing is So Powerful

"The baroreflex is one of the body's mechanisms for maintaining blood pressure. ... Every time you inhale, your heart rate increases, followed by a rise in blood pressure approximately 4 or 5 seconds later. When you exhale, your heart rate slows, this time followed by a drop in blood pressure approximately 4 or 5 seconds later. This cycle is mediated by specialized receptors in the walls of your aorta and carotid arteries called baroreceptors."



The baroreflex is fixed and almost entirely mediated by unconscious mechanisms, but we do have control over our breathing rate. Most of us breathe at a faster frequency than our baroreflex, but when we purposefully slow our breathing to match the frequency of our baroreflex, we strengthen our control over it.

It turns out there is a particular rate of breathing, called resonance frequency, that maximizes the amplitudes of heart rate oscillations. For some people, it's 6 breaths a minute; for others it might be 5 or 7. Regardless of the specific number, when you breathe at this rate, something amazing happens: it strengthens the baroreflex, creating even greater overall increases in HRV."

This is one of the best descriptions I've read of the relationship between slow breathing, the baroreceptors, and HRV. And it sets the stage for the entire premise of the book: When we breathe slowly, we maximize HRV, improving our physical and mental health.

Heart. Breath. Mind.

And the real magic happens when we have a consistent slow breathing practice: *"As you train your heart by breathing at your personal resonance frequency, you are exercising your baroreflex, making it stronger and more efficient so that your HRV remains high even when you resume normal breathing."*

So breathe slowly, maximize HRV, and exercise those baroreflexes. This will translate into higher baseline HRV and thus a lower baseline stress level.

2. Breathing for Focus & the Noradrenaline Sweet Spot

"During times of stress, our brains secrete noradrenaline, a hormone that quickens heart rate and ramps up blood pressure because the body thinks it needs to prepare for a battle or escape. Noradrenaline is also released, though in different amounts, during times of intense focus, curiosity, or passion, promoting



the growth of new connections in the brain. Researchers at the Trinity College Institute of Neuroscience and the Global Brain Health Institute in Dublin, Ireland, found that slow, controlled, deep breathing helps the brain nail the noradrenaline “sweet spot,” heightening attention and getting people laser focused.”

A little more on the “Mind” in Heart Breath Mind. Dr. Lagos shares this fascinating research showing that slow breathing puts us into the “noradrenaline sweet spot,” which heightens our attention and gets us “laser focused.”

Of course, we all want more focus. (See the [Book 411 on Stolen Focus](#) for more on that.) Slow deep breathing is the simplest and most effective tool for getting it.

To summarize so far, when we breathe slowly, we maximize HRV and improve the functioning of our baroreceptors. This also enhances mental focus by optimizing noradrenaline.

It sounds pretty incredible, but it gets even better when we look at another aspect of the heart: feel-good chemicals.

3. Strengthening Your Heart May Have Antidepressive Effects

“Additionally, recent neurocardiology studies have revealed that the heart is capable of secreting feel-good chemicals like dopamine, oxytocin, and norepinephrine, all of which help to counteract feelings of depression. For years, the prevailing consensus has been that these powerful compounds were released only by the brain; the notion that the heart can produce these neurochemicals is exciting on many levels. This suggests that strengthening the heart through HRV-strengthening practices could possibly yield mild antidepressive effects.”

By strengthening our hearts, we may improve our ability to release feel-good chemicals like dopamine and oxytocin. ← Sounds good to me.



It reminds me of some wisdom from Michael J Stephen, MD, in [Breath Taking](#):
“Deep breathing is a potent inducer of the parasympathetic nervous system. The release of acetylcholine not only calms our organs, it also stimulates the release of serotonin, dopamine, and prolactin, the feel-good hormones targeted by medicines like Prozac and Zoloft. But yoga and breathing exercises produce this effect naturally and without side effects.”

Together, we see that slow breathing uses several pathways to release feel-good chemicals that may help with depression.

Of course, we can’t just “breathe our way off of medications.” But, adding slow breathing to our daily routines seems like a no-brainer since it’s cheap, easy, and has basically no adverse side effects.

P.S. I purposefully haven’t included specific breathing exercises yet...but they’re coming in the life-changing thought.

4. Exhale Fully (unless you enjoy anxiety and tension)

“Dr. Peper and another researcher trained 35 volunteers in slow belly breathing. The volunteers were then instructed to rein in their breathing, exhaling only about 70 percent of the air in their lungs with every exhale. After just 30 seconds of this subpar breathing, almost every subject reported a climb in unpleasant symptoms, including anxiety, dizziness, light-headedness, and neck and shoulder tension. Bringing themselves back to the slow belly breathing counteracted those symptoms, and stress levels returned to normal.”

Just 30 seconds of short exhales leads to anxiety, dizziness, and tension.

Luckily, there’s an easy fix: Slow belly breathing with a longer exhale than inhale.

The life-changing idea will provide Dr. Lagos’s precise formula for doing this.



1 LIFE-CHANGING IDEA

Slow Breathing and the 60/40 Rule

"The standard rate that works for most individuals is to inhale for 4 seconds and exhale for 6 seconds with no pause in between. This is a 10-second breath, or, technically speaking, a frequency of 0.1 Hz. Breathing at this rate will result in 6 breaths per minute. For context, most adults breathe at a rate of 12 breaths per minute."

"The magic ratio here is 40:60—you spend 40 percent of each breath inhaling and 60 percent exhaling."

This passage was life-changing in its simplicity. I've used this concept basically every day in my life since learning of it. Thus, I can attest that it lives up to this "life-changing" title.

And although I'm not a fan of breathing "rules," this is about as useful as it gets.

Want to breathe at 5 breaths per minute? Start with the 60/40 approach (which comes out to a 4.8 sec inhale and 7.2 sec exhale). What about 4 breaths per minute? Same thing, 60/40.

And even more life-changing is the first sentence in that passage: *"The standard rate that works for most individuals is to inhale for 4 seconds and exhale for 6 seconds with no pause in between."*

So, if you don't know where to start or are working with a new client, this is it. Four seconds in, six seconds out. It's safe, easy, and effective.

1 STACK OF MEMORABLE QUOTES

"There is, however, a scientifically proven, safe, natural way to rewire your body's baseline stress response and optimize your health and performance. The breathing exercises and peak performance strategies described in Heart Breath Mind will take you on a journey from merely surviving stress to thriving despite it."



“We’ll start by using technology to help you find your ideal breathing rate, but with dedicated practice, you’ll be able to breathe without the technology, accessing your best self on demand and linking together your heart, breath, and mind in the way nature intended.”

“Most people are under the impression that their heart beats with the monotony and repetitiveness of a metronome. On the contrary, when you inhale, your heart rate (the number of times your heart beats per minute) naturally rises; when you exhale, it slows down again. This is true for everyone.”

“But when you breathe at your resonance frequency, your heart rate oscillations become perfectly in phase with your breath. You enter a state called resonance, or flow.”

“Subjects with a higher daytime HRV took less time to fall asleep, woke up fewer times during the night, and rated their sleep as feeling more restful than those with lower daytime HRVs.”

“University of North Carolina psychologists Barbara Frederickson, PhD, and Bethany Kok, PhD, demonstrated this beautifully when they asked 52 adults to track their positive emotions—awe, gratitude, joy—for 9 weeks. They found that the higher a subject’s HRV was at the beginning, the easier and more quickly he or she could experience positive feelings over the next 9 weeks.”

“Recent research found that baseline HRV level predicted working memory performance under high-pressure circumstances, suggesting that HRV training can be used to prevent the choking-under-pressure phenomenon.”

“All these physiological improvements have their roots in the body’s relaxation response, but there’s also special magic in the act of counting. Counting is handled by the same area of the brain that’s responsible for worrying. It’s difficult to do both at the same time, so counting is exceptionally effective at crowding out stress, calming a busy brain, and enhancing focus.”

“The average person takes about 20,000 breaths a day. You’d think we would be pros at it by now. We’re not.”



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on Amazon](#)

Citation

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Nick's Disclaimer

I am not a Holotropic Breathwork® coach or practitioner. Thus, I read the book from a pure breath-enthusiast perspective. I usually only discuss things I practice myself, but I loved this book and wanted to share it.

Book 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes

Holotropic Breathwork: A New Approach to Self-Exploration and Therapy BY: STANISLAV GROF & CHRISTINA GROF

THE 4 THOUGHTS

1. What Are Holotropic States and Why Are they Therapeutic?
2. The Components and Safety Concerns of Holotropic Breathing
3. Is Hyperventilation Syndrome Obsolete (or maybe not applicable here)?
4. The Physiological Response to Holotropic Breathing

General Disclaimer

Anyone interested in Holotropic Breathwork® should do it in a workshop offered by a trained facilitator. This Book 411 provides general information on the method but is not a substitute for a trained professional. To learn more, the authors say the *"necessary information can be found on our websites holotropic.com or stanislavgrof.com."*

4 THOUGHTS

1. What Are Holotropic States and Why Are they Therapeutic?



“When we recognized the unique nature of this category of non-ordinary states of consciousness, we found it difficult to believe that contemporary psychiatry does not have a specific category and term for these theoretically and practically important experiences. Because we felt strongly that they deserve to be distinguished from altered states of consciousness and not be seen as manifestations of serious mental diseases, we started referring to them as holotropic (Grof 1992). This composite word means literally ‘oriented toward wholeness’ or ‘moving toward wholeness’ (from the Greek holos = whole and trepein = moving toward or in the direction of something).”

A holotropic state is a special category of non-ordinary states of consciousness. As the authors tell us, these states provide “access to biographical, perinatal, and transpersonal domains of the unconscious and thus to deep psychospiritual roots of emotional and psychosomatic disorders.”

And because of this, the therapeutic benefits of holotropic breathing are wide-ranging, and the healing will look different for each person. In general, it may help with emotional and physical problems, life outlook, and healing of cultural wounds. See the book for more details and lots of personal healing stories.

In any case, the simplified big-picture idea is that by entering a holotropic state (see next thought), we gain unique access to the unconscious, providing an enormous healing opportunity.

It’s powerful stuff. So let’s look at how we access it.

P.S. I’m avoiding the word psychedelic here because (unfortunately) I have never had a psychedelic experience (lol), nor have I experienced a *proper* holotropic breathing session. But my interpretation is that psychedelics put us into a holotropic state. So, the two are related, but for healing, it’s the holotropic state we’re ultimately after, regardless of how we get there.

2. The Components and Safety Concerns of Holotropic Breathing

“Holotropic Breathwork is a powerful method of self-exploration and therapy that uses a combination of



seemingly simple means—accelerated breathing, evocative music, and a type of bodywork that helps to release residual bioenergetic and emotional blocks. The sessions are usually conducted in groups; participants work in pairs and alternate in the roles of breathers and “sitters.” The process is supervised by trained facilitators, who assist participants whenever special intervention is necessary. Following the breathing sessions, participants express their experiences by painting mandalas and share accounts of their inner journeys in small groups.”

Holotropic breathing sessions are about 2-3+ hours of (1) faster breathing, (2) evocative music, and (3) bodywork, followed by self-expression and sharing.

(Although seemingly simple, the specific details are intricate. *We can't just turn on loud music and hyperventilate.* These holotropic states are powerful, so working with a trained facilitator who can get the details right is imperative.)

For our purposes, an interesting question is: how fast do people breathe during the sessions? In general, they say people begin breathing with the music and let their bodies decide what works best for them: *“The quality of attention and the attitude toward the experience seems to be more important than the speed and intensity of the breathing.”* So, there's no set or ideal breathing rate.

But since it does involve hyperventilation and profound inner experiences, it's critical to examine any safety considerations with the method. The authors have a very detailed medical screening process. The main concern is cardiovascular disorders, which may disqualify a person depending on their severity.

Seizures, pregnancy, and some psychiatric and emotional disorders also require special attention (but are not immediate disqualifiers).

Thus, if you're considering a holotropic breathing session, prioritize safety and use a certified instructor who will keep the entire process safe.

3. Is Hyperventilation Syndrome Obsolete (or maybe not applicable here)?

“In summary, the experiences and observations from Holotropic Breathwork show that the traditional concept of the hyperventilation syndrome is obsolete and has to be revised.”



That's a bold statement, and it's a major theme throughout the book.

As they say, *"We have now conducted over thirty-five thousand holotropic breathing sessions and have found the current medical understanding of the effects of faster breathing to be incorrect."* ← **How's that for controversy :**)

What is the current understanding? Here's a super quick summary: *"According to medical handbooks of respiratory physiology, faster breathing tends to result in the 'hyperventilation syndrome' characterized by tetany of hands and feet (carpopedal spasms), anxiety, and various forms of physical discomfort."*

What's their take? Their 35,000 sessions provide evidence that *"the reaction to faster breathing reflects the psychosomatic history of the breather and covers a very wide spectrum of manifestations—including occasional complete absence of physical symptoms—rather than being a rigid stereotype."* Some people even experience progressive relaxation the more they hyperventilate (🧘).

Thus, their observations suggest that the classical definition of hyperventilation syndrome might need revision or may not apply when *hyperventilation is done consciously over several hours*. Pretty interesting stuff.

But if hyperventilation syndrome doesn't apply, is there a better description of what might be going on physiologically? That's what we'll cover next.

4. The Physiological Response to Holotropic Breathing

*"As we have seen, the physiological mechanisms activated by faster breathing are quite complex ... However, if we take all the aforementioned physiological mechanisms into consideration, **the situation of people during Holotropic Breathwork very likely resembles that of being in high mountains, where there is less oxygen and the CO2 level is decreased by compensatory faster breathing.** ... This situation would thus cause inhibition of the cortical functions and intensified activity in the archaic parts of the brain, **making the unconscious processes more available.**"* (my bold)

Would you have guessed that breathing more air for several hours would mimic being at altitude? Well, maybe if you're into respiratory physiology :)



In any case, they did an excellent job describing the physiological processes that might occur during a holotropic breathing session. They don't make any "super oxygenation" claims you might see online. In fact, it's quite the opposite.

They say it leads to less oxygen delivery to the cells, vasoconstriction, and less brain blood flow, all due to hypocapnia (low CO₂ levels in the blood). Together, they hypothesize that this situation somewhat mimics being at altitude.

However, it's not like *living* at altitude. It's the acuteness that makes it powerful:

"While short-term exposure to high altitude might be comparable to Holotropic Breathwork, an extended stay in high elevations triggers physiological adaptations, such as increased production of red blood cells. The acute situation during Holotropic Breathwork might, therefore, not be directly comparable to an extended stay in high mountains."

So, holotropic breathing might be like a quick trip to the mountains. That's a pretty neat way to look at the physiological effects of prolonged hyperventilation.

1 LIFE-CHANGING IDEA

We Should Support (not suppress) Hyperventilation Symptoms

*"Research of holotropic states of consciousness has revealed an important alternative. It has shown that symptoms are more than just a major inconvenience in the patient's life. **They represent the manifestation of a self-healing impulse of the organism** that is trying to free itself from traumatic memories and other disturbing material from the biographical, perinatal, and transpersonal domains of the unconscious. **Once we realize that, it becomes clear that symptoms should be encouraged to emerge and brought to full expression rather than suppressed.**" (my bold)*

A central theme of the book is that symptoms should be supported, not suppressed.



They hypothesize (based on tons of theory, research, and observations) that when we hyperventilate, and harmful symptoms emerge, **we're actually seeing an attempt of our body to heal itself.**

I think this is life-changing in the context of symptoms in general, not just hyperventilation. (It's probably not true in all cases, but still a paradigm shift.)

But sticking to hyperventilation, they argue that, in some cases, supporting the symptoms will allow them to intensify and then resolve.

They go as far as to say: *“In the light of the observations from Holotropic Breathwork, spontaneous episodes of hyperventilation occurring in psychiatric patients and the normal population are **attempts of the organism to heal itself and should be supported rather than suppressed.**”*

I often think the opposite—that hyperventilation is the problem. They argue it might be the solution in some instances.

In any case, almost all mind-body practices share this sentiment of supporting the self-healing process rather than suppressing it. The difference here is that the healing modality (hyperventilation) causes or exacerbates the symptoms. Maybe they're onto something; maybe they're crazy. I'll let you decide :)

1 STACK OF MEMORABLE QUOTES

“In time, I believe their contributions will be seen as a major gift to the field of psychology and to the healing of the world.” - Jack Kornfield

“The name holotropic suggests something that might come as a surprise to an average Westerner—that in our everyday state of consciousness we identify with only a small fraction of who we really are and do not experience the full extent of our being.”

“However, the unique feature of Holotropic Breathwork is that it utilizes the intrinsic healing potential of non-ordinary states of consciousness.”

“The ideal attitude of the breather to the experience is to focus his or her full attention on the process as it unfolds from one moment to another, rather than on any specific goal or outcome.”



“Our primary interest in this book is to explore the healing, transformative, and evolutionary potential of non-ordinary states of consciousness and their great value as a source of new revolutionary data about consciousness, the human psyche, and the nature of reality.”

“The importance of non-ordinary states of consciousness for ancient and aboriginal cultures is reflected in the amount of time and energy that the members of these human groups dedicated to the development of technologies of the sacred, various procedures capable of inducing them for ritual and spiritual purposes.”

“Since earliest history, virtually every major psychospiritual system seeking to comprehend human nature has viewed breath as a crucial link between the material world, the human body, the psyche, and the spirit.”

“In materialistic science, breathing lost its sacred meaning and was stripped of its connection to the psyche and spirit. Western medicine reduced it to an important physiological function. The physical and psychological manifestations that accompany various respiratory maneuvers have all been pathologized.”

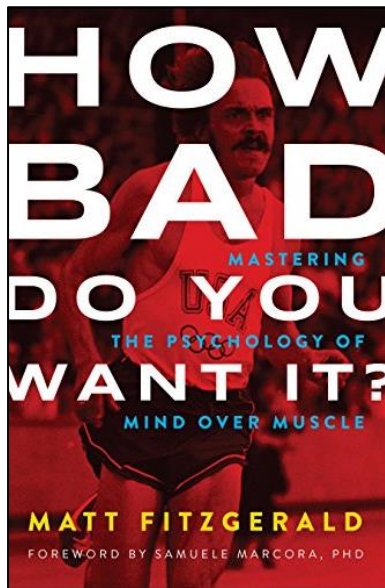
“The psychosomatic response to faster breathing, the so-called hyperventilation syndrome, is considered a pathological condition, rather than what it really is, a process that has an enormous healing potential.”

“A surprising but consistent observation from Holotropic Breathwork is that the symptoms induced by hyperventilation initially increase in intensity, but continued breathing brings about their resolution and permanent disappearance. This fact is in direct conflict with the assumption that the psychosomatic symptoms are a mandatory physiochemical response to hyperventilation.”



BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



How Bad Do You Want It?: Mastering the Psychology of Mind over Muscle

BY: Matt Fitzgerald

411 Released: August 11, 2023

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. Perceived Effort and the Psychobiological Model
2. Coping Mechanisms for Life (they are uniquely yours)
3. What Do You Expect? Mindfulness and the Audience Effect
4. The Workaround Effect and Setbacks as Blessings

1 Life-Changing Idea

1. Letting Go and the Self-Belief Paradox
-
-



4 Thoughts

1. Perceived Effort and the Psychobiological Model

“This alternative model of how the brain regulates endurance performance is called the Psychobiological Model. Its core principles are that decisions about pacing or quitting during endurance competitions are taken by the conscious brain and that these decisions are primarily based on the conscious sensation of how hard, heavy, and strenuous exercise is, a feeling we call perception of effort.”

This is the central theory behind the book: People give up during endurance events not due to hard physical limits, but due to perceived effort (how hard something feels).

If we consider life one big endurance event, under this theory, anything we can do to lower our perceived effort will allow us to go farther (literally and metaphorically).

Thus, we can analogously say that whether we quit or keep going during a project, chasing a dream, building a new habit, etc. will largely be based on our perceived effort of that task, not that we’ve actually hit our mental or physical limit.

This begs the question: How do we decrease our perceived effort? And what does any of this have to do with breathing and mindfulness?

The answer to both questions comes down to *coping mechanisms*, which we’ll cover next.



2. Coping Mechanisms for Life (they are uniquely yours)

"Psychologists use the term coping to refer to a person's behavioral, emotional, and cognitive responses to discomfort and stress. ... (//) In endurance sports, successful coping is any behavior, emotion, thought, or combination thereof that yields better performance. Phrased another way, successful coping in endurance sports is any response to discomfort and stress that favorably changes an athlete's relationship to perception of effort, either by increasing the amount of effort the athlete is able to give or by enhancing what the athlete gets out of her best effort."

"Coping mechanisms" was actually my favorite idea from the book. A positive coping mechanism is anything we can do to reduce our perceived effort.

We could consider breathing, meditation, mindfulness, walking, yoga, etc., as coping mechanisms for life. We apply these coping mechanisms, and they lower our perceived effort for the rest of life, making everything else feel easier.

Perhaps this is why most "successful" people use some of these practices. These coping mechanisms make their high performance feel easier by lowering their perception of effort.

But the most critical aspect of coping mechanisms is that we must figure out which ones work for us through real-life practice. As Fitzgerald says, **"No type of mental training or therapy that is conducted in street clothes can match the power of lived experience to spur the development of effective coping skills."**

Fortunately, however, there are coping mechanisms that work for most people (like mindfulness & breathing). We just have to be intentional with adapting them to our unique circumstances.

Let's look at some coping mechanisms we can apply to life and our contemplative practice.



3. What Do You Expect? Mindfulness and the Audience Effect

"All in all, high expectations for improvement and success are among the more powerful coping skills an endurance athlete can possess. As the saying goes, if you think you can, you're right. And if you think you can't (even if you say you can), you're also right."

If having high expectations is *"among the more powerful coping skills,"* how do we get them? There are many ways, but one powerful one is via audience effect:

"The online Psychology Dictionary defines it as "the influence of the presence of other people on an individual's behavior." ... (//) In essence, the audience effect coaxes people into holding themselves to higher standards."

What does the audience effect have to do with breathing and mindfulness? These practices cultivate meta-awareness, creating an audience effect of one.

Essentially, you begin coaxing yourself into higher standards because you bring awareness to everything you do. When your highest self is always watching you, you start having higher expectations for your actions, and you begin believing you can live up to them.

This may be one of the most potent ways mindfulness practices help our daily living: by cultivating an audience effect of one, we generate higher expectations for ourselves, and this helps us cope better with daily living 🍊



4. The Workaround Effect and Setbacks as Blessings

“Some athletes gain not only mental fitness but also physical fitness—after first losing it—through an injury or some other setback. It happens by way of a process I call the “workaround effect.” When the body loses the ability to achieve a desired level of performance in the accustomed way, the brain responds by seeking out new ways to get the same level of performance out of the body, ways the athlete might never have discovered otherwise. That’s the workaround effect.”

Are you dealing with any setbacks in your life? Of course you are, you’re human 😊 But have you considered that they could help you improve through the workaround effect?

If not, check out the book because Fitzgerald provides several case studies of people who suffered an injury and returned stronger or better than before through the workaround effect.

This effect works (regardless of the type of setback) via the same process, neuroplasticity: **“Unable to stimulate bodily movement in the way it did previously, the brain explores alternatives, eventually settling on the most effective of these.”**

And fortunately, we can deliberately stimulate this coping mechanism by trying new ways to do the things we used to do (in fact, Fitzgerald says that *trial and error* is one of the best ways to stimulate neuroplasticity and the workaround effect).

But, in my opinion, just shifting your mindset to realize that a setback can be a blessing in disguise is the first and most crucial step in making this coping mechanism work for you. So, keep this gem close by the next time you’re hit with a setback in life:

“Collectively, these examples prove that setbacks resulting in the loss of physical capacity, be it temporary or permanent, present an opportunity to make compensatory physical gains through the workaround effect and to become mentally fitter. Major injuries, minor injuries, sickness, starting over after time away from training, getting older—these hated setbacks and others are all potential blessings in disguise.”



1 Life-Changing Idea

Letting Go and the Self-Belief Paradox

"Many of the negative thoughts that such athletes experience issue from excessive focus on the desired outcome...They feel that if only they can achieve their goal, then they will have self-belief to carry into the next race. But it doesn't work like that. The self-belief has to come first.

So where does it come from? It comes from letting go...Counterintuitive though it may be, caring a little less about the result of a race produces better results."

This is the self-belief paradox: We think we need self-belief to succeed, but we think we need to succeed to get self-belief.

However, as Fitzgerald tells us here, the way to actually get self-belief is by letting go of succeeding: Caring less about the results produces better results (and more self-belief).

So, the life-changing idea is cliché but powerful: Let go of outcomes and focus on the process. That's easier said than done. How do we actually "let go?"

Of all the stories Fitzgerald shared, the common thread was gratitude. When athletes were simply grateful for the ability to perform their chosen sport, they could let go of outcomes and experience true success.

So, if you feel so inspired, try it out in any activity you do:

1. Let go of winning or any desired outcome you have.
2. Cultivate gratitude that you're able to perform the action.



1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

"Sure, it was just a race, but sports are not really separate from life, nor is the athlete distinct from the person. In mastering my fear of suffering in races, I acquired a greater level of respect for myself, a sense of inner strength that has helped me tackle other challenges, both inside and outside sports."

"Mind is everything. Muscle—pieces of rubber. All that I am, I am because of my mind." - Finnish runner Paavo Nurmi

"The most important discovery of the brain revolution in endurance sports, and the most important truth you can know as an endurance athlete, is this: One cannot improve as an endurance athlete except by changing one's relationship with perception of effort."

"In a race, the job of the muscles is to perform. The job of the mind is to cope. But here's the hitch: The muscles can only perform to the degree that the mind is able to cope. Endurance sports are therefore a game of 'mind over muscle.'"

"In every race, something within each athlete (something we may now specify as perception of effort) poses a simple question: How bad do you want it? To realize your potential as an athlete, you must respond with some version of this answer: More. And then you have to prove it."

"Any behavior, thought, or emotion that enables an athlete to perform better qualifies as an effective coping skill."

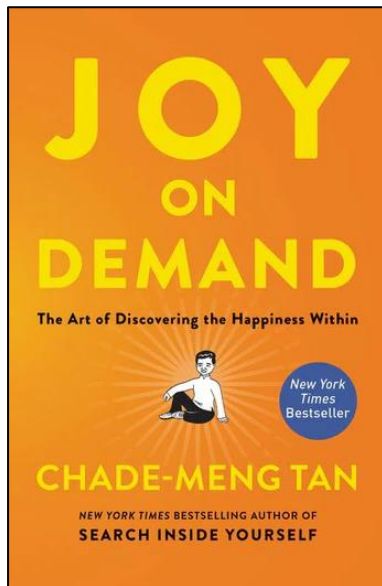
"The truth of the matter is that the stronger or more capable the body is, the weaker or lazier the mind can afford to be."

"If you ask me what is the most important key to longevity, I would have to say it is avoiding worry, stress, and tension. And if you didn't ask me, I'd still have to say it." – Comedian George Burns



BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



Joy On Demand: The Art of Discovering the Happiness Within

BY: Chade-Meng Tan

411 Released: August 25, 2023

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. How to Access Joy on Demand: One Mindful Breath
2. Adding Gentleness & Intensity for More Joy
3. Inclining the Mind Toward Joy (and the power of morning practice)
4. Slow Breathing is to Mindfulness what Smiling is to Facial Expressions

1 Life-Changing Idea

1. Take One Breath, Ten Times
-
-



4 Thoughts

1. How to Access Joy on Demand: One Mindful Breath

“Some believe you need a lot of money to experience joy, while others believe you can only find happiness if you give up everything and live in a hut in the woods. You might think you need to meditate for many years to access joy, but as you will see..., you can begin to experience benefits in one breath.”

The overarching premise of this book is that joy is a necessary building block of happiness and, fortunately, is easily accessible. Although Tan presents several practices and mindset shifts for joy, the ultimate goal is to experience it with just one mindful breath.

Here's how you do it: **“Take one slow, deep breath. For the duration of that one breath, give your full attention to your breath in a gentle way. Total and gentle attention on feeling your breath, that is all.”**

We'll cover the “gentle attention” part next, but for now, let's quickly discuss why it works.

One reason is physiological. As you know by now, a slow, deep breath will trigger the parasympathetic nervous system, which will induce relaxation, setting the stage for joy.

Another reason is psychological. Tan says, **“when you put your attention intensely on the breath, you are fully in the present for the duration of the breath. To feel regretful, you need to be in the past, and to worry, you need to be in the future. Hence, when you are fully in the present, you are temporarily free from regret and worry.”**

So, there you have it; that's how we get joy on demand. We give our full attention to one slow, deep breath. One mindful breath, many times throughout the day, adds up to a happy life 🙏



2. Adding Gentleness & Intensity for More Joy

“Simply taking one mindful breath under any circumstances is beneficial. However, for those wishing to optimize its benefits, for that one breath to work very well, it is good to have generous helpings of two key ingredients: gentleness in attitude, and intensity of attention.”

To get more joy from that one mindful breath, add two more things: gentleness and intensity.

To do that, Tan provides a helpful metaphor: **“Attending with intensity and gentleness is like gazing at your baby or the way your puppy looks at you. The attention is intense but also gentle and effortless. The idea is to bring the same intensity and gentleness to the object of meditation, in this case, the breath.”**

We talk a lot about mindfulness (which cultivates gentleness and an accepting, nonjudgmental attitude), so let’s look at intensity.

Tan tells us it’s critical **“because the more intensely you are attending to the present moment, the more temporary freedom you gain from regrets about the past and worries about the future. Furthermore, the more intensely you practice, the longer the benefits linger after the practice.”**

Practically, one way of doing this is through what we might jokingly call “High-Intensity Interval Mindfulness.” Instead of a continuous 20-minute meditation session, break it into four “intense” 4-minute sessions, with a 1-minute break between each.

Give it a try and see if you like it 🙏

P.S. If you’re new to this practice, always start with gentleness, as this sets the stage for intensity. As Tan says, **“Here is an important general rule: if, for whatever reason, you can only choose one, always choose gentleness over intensity. In this case, attend very gently to the breath, and over time, as you become accustomed to gentleness and get comfortably relaxed with the breath, then increase intensity.”**



3. Inclining the Mind Toward Joy (and the power of morning practice)

“There is a beautiful description of mental inclination in some ancient texts. They compare it to mountain slopes. When the ground is sloped in a certain way, water flows effortlessly according to the direction of inclination. Similarly, when the mind is inclined in a certain way, thoughts and emotions happen effortlessly according to the nature of its inclination. If the mind is inclined toward joy, for example, then joyful thoughts and feelings tend to occur effortlessly.”

Another way of accessing joy on demand is to incline your mind toward joy, sloping it into more joyous thoughts. Importantly, though, this must be done gently without force:

“the skillful way to train the mind is not to exert forceful control over the mind itself, but to change its inclination so that thoughts and emotions occur effortlessly in the direction one intends.”

So how do we do this? An easy way is to simply notice joy every time it pops up. It’s like when you get a new car and, all of a sudden, you see them everywhere. Once you start looking for joy, you’ll start finding it more.

Another way is with breathing itself. We’ve covered the science behind breathing for joy before (and Tan’s instructions match it wonderfully). We simply breathe deeply and slowly, adding in gentleness and intensity.

But if we want to use this practice to incline our minds toward joy, consider doing it first thing in the morning, which will set us up for a more joyous day 🙌



4. Slow Breathing is to Mindfulness what Smiling is to Facial Expressions

“Our facial expressions reflect our emotional state. It turns out, however, that the causation flows both ways. Facial expressions reflect emotional states, and they can also affect emotional states. (...) Given this insight, we can effectively invite joy just by smiling a genuine smile. Smile as if you are really happy. When you do this, you may create changes in the autonomic nervous system relating to happiness, and from these changes, you may experience joy. This works for me almost every time. It doesn’t even need to be a full smile—a half smile works as well.”

Here's another way to experience joy on demand: smile more. You may even put a smile (or half-smile) on your face during your one mindful breath practice.

This idea is powerful on its own, but it also made me think of just how similar breathing and facial expressions are.

Facial expressions are reactive or voluntary, immediately changing our nervous system and emotional state. Breathing is just like that, too. And specifically, if we breathe slowly and deeply through our noses, we can elicit joy just like a smile can.

So, we might say: *Slow breathing is to mindfulness what smiling is to facial expressions.*

Be sure to take advantage of this relationship today 🙏



1 Life-Changing Idea

Take One Breath, Ten Times

Tan tells a story of his friend Gopi who wanted to meditate. His advice to Gopi: just take one mindful breath. That's it. (See Thought #1.)

Gopi decided to aim for ten and, over time, he gradually (and effortlessly) increased how long he meditated. This led Gopi to a life-changing revelation:

"He realized that one hour of sitting is simply a lot of one breaths stringed next to each other—that's all. Over time, his daily sits got longer and longer, and within a few months, he succeeded in his goal of meditating for one hour a day."

This idea has probably been the single-most helpful thing I've discovered in all my time breathing: All our sessions are just **"a lot of one breaths stringed next to each other."**

Now, when I sit down to focus on my breath (even when I'm using a pacer for slow breathing), I simply take one breath, giving it my gentle yet intense attention, over and over.

It inspired me to come up with this quip: Don't take ten breaths, take one breath, ten times.

I hope this mindset shift will be life-changing for you, too 🙏



1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

"This leads us to a question only a shamelessly lazy engineer would ask: what is the absolute minimum amount of meditation practice before there is any sort of benefit? My answer: one breath."

"One of the best things about the One Mindful Breath practice is that since it is so easy and takes so little time, you can practice anytime and anywhere. In geek speak, I say it is highly portable."

"Remember, my friends, never underestimate the power of one breath. Mental fitness and joy on demand both start here, with one breath."

"The preceding paragraph leads us to a mind-shattering, life-altering conclusion, which is that with sufficient proficiency in nothing more than the most basic meditative state, one may gain the ability to reliably access a highly sustainable source of gentle joy, joy that is deep enough to appear to fill one's entire being."

"It is imperative that we apply gentleness at the same time as intensity. In other words, if intensity comes at the cost of gentleness, then it is not a price worth paying."

"Physiologically, attending to the breath makes it slower and deeper and thereby stimulates the vagus nerve, which then launches the relaxation response. Psychologically, attending to the breath intensely brings the mind to the present, away from past and future, and so temporarily frees the mind from regret (about the past) and worry (about the future)."

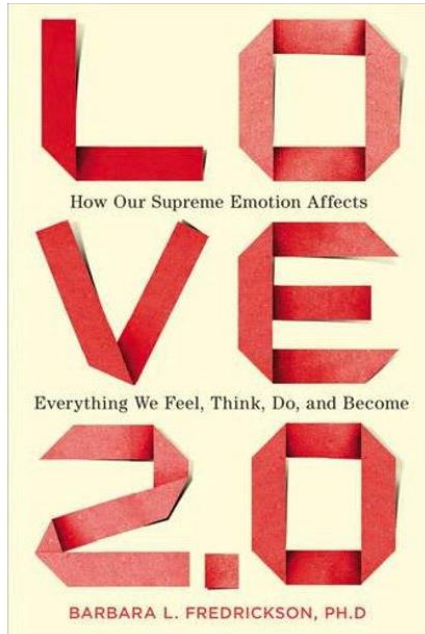
"Under normal conditions, it is easy to calm the mind by attending to the breath, but it is harder to do so under stressful conditions, precisely when you need it the most. Fortunately, if you practice it a lot under normal conditions, then in times of need, in the midst of emotional pain, you will be able to activate it instinctively."

"Sometimes, you get lucky in life, when the most important thing you need to do turns out to also be the simplest. One example is breathing. Breathing is the most important thing we need to do in our lives, and for most of us, it is also the easiest thing we ever do. If you belong to the population of people who can breathe effortlessly, you are so lucky!"



BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



Love 2.0: How Our Supreme Emotion Affects Everything We Feel, Think, Do, and Become

BY: BARBARA FREDRICKSON, PH.D.

411 Released: February 10, 2023

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. What is Love 2.0?
2. The Breath-Love Connection: Vagal Tone = Loving Potential
3. Breathing is Also Self-Love, a Precursor to Loving Others
4. Your Upward Spiral of Love & Breathing

1 Life-Changing Idea

Becoming Breathing Wise



4 Thoughts

1. What is Love 2.0?

Before we get into the surprisingly straightforward breath-love connection, let's answer the obvious question: What is "Love 2.0"?

Dr. Fredrickson defines love as a micro-moment of "positivity resonance" between you and another person. To experience it requires three things:

"[L]ove is the momentary upwelling of three tightly interwoven events: first, a sharing of one or more positive emotions between you and another; second, a synchrony between your and the other person's biochemistry and behaviors; and third, a reflected motive to invest in each other's well-being that brings mutual care. My shorthand for this trio is positivity resonance."

What's unique about this idea of love as positivity resonance is that it's based on the science of mind and body. It's psychological, like most ideas of love. But it's also physiological—it's rooted in what our bodies are doing, not just how we feel at any given moment. This is love 2.0

Although this outlook has some downfalls—for example, it technically means you can't experience love with someone unless they're physically close to you—it's actually a neat perspective for experiencing more love in our day-to-day lives. It means we can share positivity resonance (and thus love) with anyone, even complete strangers:

"At the level of positivity resonance, micro-moments of love are virtually identical regardless of whether they bloom between you and a stranger or you and a soul mate; between you and an infant or you and your lifelong best friend. The clearest difference between the love you feel with intimates and the love you feel with anyone with whom you share a connection is its sheer frequency."

Thus, checking out at the grocery store, crossing paths on a walk, or waiting in line for a coffee. These are all opportunities to create a micro-moment of positivity resonance, experience love, and, as we will see, improve our physical, mental, and spiritual health.



2. The Breath-Love Connection: Vagal Tone = Loving Potential

“Keeping in mind that love is connection, you should know that your vagus nerve is a biological asset that supports and coordinates your experiences of love. Completely outside of your awareness, your vagus nerve stimulates tiny facial muscles that better enable you to make eye contact and synchronize your facial expressions with another person. It even adjusts the minuscule muscles of your middle ear so you can better track the other person’s voice against any background noise. In these exquisitely subtle yet consequential ways, your vagus nerve increases the odds that the two of you will connect, upping your chances for positivity resonance.”

The breath-love connection is the same connection linking our hearts to our brains and our guts to our lungs. It’s our vagus nerve.

As Dr. Fredrickson points out above, **“your vagus nerve is a biological asset that supports and coordinates your experiences of love.”**

She even goes as far as to say:

“High vagal tone, then, can be taken as high loving potential. ... Compared to people with lower vagal tone, those with higher vagal tone experience more love in their daily lives, more moments of positivity resonance.”

This is where breathing comes in. [Research shows us](#) that we can immediately increase our vagal tone with just five minutes of slow breathing. We can also improve our baseline vagal tone (and thus baseline loving potential) with [just 10-20 minutes of slow breathing](#) daily.

Thus, slow breathing literally increases our physiological ability to love.

So breathe less to love more.

P.S. Increasing vagal tone does a lot more than just increase loving potential. Here’s how Dr. Fredrickson describes people with higher vagal tone: **“Physically, they regulate their internal bodily processes more efficiently, like their glucose levels and inflammation. Mentally, they’re better able to regulate their attention and emotions, even their behavior. Socially, they’re especially skillful in navigating interpersonal interactions and in forging positive connections with others.”** Sounds good to me 🙏



3. Breathing is Also Self-Love, a Precursor to Loving Others

As Dr. Fredrickson described love (or positivity resonance) throughout the book, it sounded identical to the feelings slow breathing elicits. In fact, there were many places I felt like we could just replace “love” with “breathing” and not change the meaning of the sentence.

Here’s one of my favorites:

“As for all positive emotions, the inner feeling [breathing] brings you is inherently and exquisitely pleasant—it feels extraordinarily good, the way a long, cool drink of water feels when you're parched on a hot day. Yet far beyond feeling good, a micro-moment of [breathing], like other positive emotions, literally changes your mind. It expands your awareness of your surroundings, even your sense of self. The boundaries between you and not-you—what lies beyond your skin—relax and become more permeable.”

But technically, our breathing practice cannot be considered “love” because it lacks connection with another person (see Thought #1). What it can be considered, however, is self-love, a precursor to love:

“The old saying tells us that we can’t love others unless we first love ourselves. It’s true.”

I actually can’t think of a better description of breathing than “self-love” since it nourishes us physically, mentally, and spiritually. But Dr. Fredrickson would likely group it into a broader category she calls “preparatory” practices for love:

“While these activities do not directly create positivity resonance, they can set the table for an eventual feast of love. ... They condition your mind, heart, eyes, and ears to be more prepared for positivity resonance when true connections become possible.”

Thus, we might say that breathing is a self-love practice that increases our vagal tone and prepares our hearts and minds to feast on more love-love throughout our day.

And this daily feast of love will compound into a happy and healthier life, as we’ll cover next.



4. Your Upward Spiral of Love & Breathing

“With this momentarily broadened, more encompassing mind-set, you become more flexible, attuned to others, creative, and wise. Over time, you also become more resourceful. This is because, little by little, these mind-expanding moments of positive emotions add up to reshape your life for the better, making you more knowledgeable, more resilient, more socially integrated, and healthier. In fact, science documents that positive emotions can set off upward spirals in your life, self-sustaining trajectories of growth that lift you up to become a better version of yourself.”

That description of love is, in a nutshell, how I feel about breathing. Breathing helps you become more flexible, attuned to others, creative, and wise. More knowledgeable and resilient, healthier and more resourceful.

And that last sentence perfectly summarizes the goal of the Learning Center and The Breathing 1%, in particular. By consistently expanding your brain and body through reading and daily breath practice, you start **“upward spirals in your life, self-sustaining trajectories of growth that lift you up to become a better version of yourself.”**

But perhaps a big part of this all comes back to love. We’ve now learned that breathing is self-love; it increases our vagal tone and allows us to experience more love-love (more positivity resonance). Experiencing more love, then, will reshape our lives for the better, triggering an upward spiral that lifts us to become the best versions of ourselves we can become.

That sounds amazing to me 🙏

1 Life-Changing Idea

Becoming Breathing Wise

“We call people that meet these ideals wise. They have what scientists call ‘expertise in the fundamental pragmatics of life.’ They judiciously draw on their past experiences and values to arrive at practical and fitting courses of action for themselves and others in nearly any situation. They not only grasp the human condition and the meaning of life but are also able to translate these lofty philosophical insights into down-to-earth plans and advice. Wise



people, studies show, are especially discerning because they are able to see holistically and integrate seemingly contradictory perspectives to achieve balance and well-being in everyday life.”

Based on that passage, being wise sounds pretty darn appealing. And that’s precisely what we’re doing together in the Learning Center. We’re learning to draw on our knowledge and past experiences to **“arrive at practical and fitting courses of action for [ourselves] and others in nearly any situation.”**

And with all the conflicting (yet equally correct) viewpoints on breathing, we’re doing our best to **“see holistically and integrate seemingly contradictory perspectives to achieve balance and well-being in everyday life.”**

Simply stated: *We’re on a path to becoming breathing-wise.*

But from an even broader perspective, since breath is life, we might even say: *Breathing wiser is being wiser.*

So here’s to integrating these ideas, stacking them with skills you already have, and sharing them with the world to become wiser and better, starting today.

1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

“The new take on love that I want to share with you is this: Love blossoms virtually anytime two or more people—even strangers—connect over a shared positive emotion, be it mild or strong.”

“What you long for is love. Whether you’re single or not, whether you spend your days largely in isolation or steadily surrounded by the buzz of conversation, love is the essential nutrient that your cells crave: true positivity-charged connection with other living beings.”

“Just as your body was designed to extract oxygen from the earth’s atmosphere, and nutrients from the foods you ingest, your body was designed to love.”

“Love—like taking a deep breath or eating an orange when you’re depleted and thirsty—not only feels great but is also life-giving, an indispensable source of energy, sustenance, and health.”



“When you experience love—true heart/mind/soul-expanding love—you not only become better able to see the larger tapestry of life and better able to breathe life into the connections that matter to you, but you also set yourself on a pathway that leads to more health, happiness, and wisdom.”

“Put succinctly, smiles may well have evolved to make love, to create positivity resonance.”

“Keeping in mind that love is connection, you should know that your vagus nerve is a biological asset that supports and coordinates your experiences of love.”

“Scientists can measure the strength of your vagus nerve—your biological aptitude for love—simply by tracking your heart rate in conjunction with your breathing rate.”

Talking about Harvard psychiatrist George Vaillant: *“Succinctly, he concludes, “Love is the shortest definition of spirituality I know.” I see no need to improve upon this definition.”*

“[L]ove and health cocreate each other in your life.”

“Each new breath creates a unity of life as all people share the nourishment that the earth’s atmosphere freely offers.”



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on Amazon](#)

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Book 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes

Mind Over Meds: Know When Drugs Are Necessary, When Alternatives Are Better and When to Let Your Body Heal on Its Own

BY: Andrew Weil, MD

THE 4 THOUGHTS

1. Breath is (quite literally) Medicine
2. Why Slow Breathing Helps Reduce Blood Pressure
3. Breath Work and the Power of the 4-7-8 Breath
4. The Anti-anxiety and Anti-depressive Effects of Breathing

4 THOUGHTS

1. Breath is (quite literally) Medicine

"One question I always ask is "How did we come to believe that medication is the only or the most effective way to treat disease?" Medicine and medication both derive from an ancient Indo-Iranian root meaning something like "thoughtful action to establish order"; the same root gives us the words measure and meditate. How curious that "thoughtful action" has become synonymous with the giving and taking of chemical substances."

If "medicine" literally means something like "thoughtful action," then mindful breathing is (in every sense of the word) medicine.



Let's not forget to take our dose, today.

2. Why Slow Breathing Helps Reduce Blood Pressure

"The connection between stress and blood pressure is the autonomic nervous system, which regulates the tone of the smooth (involuntary) muscle that lines the walls of arteries. The sympathetic branch of that system constricts arteries, increasing blood pressure, while the parasympathetic branch relaxes them, lowering pressure."

Slow breathing activates the parasympathetic branch of our nervous system. As we learn here, this relaxes our arteries and lowers blood pressure.

And with regular practice, we increase the tone of the parasympathetic nervous system, leading to [long-term reductions in blood pressure](#).

As Dr. Weil succinctly puts it, "Relaxation training, such as breathing exercises, meditation, and biofeedback, lowers blood pressure by increasing activity of the parasympathetic nervous system. These approaches can drop the top blood pressure number by 10 and the bottom number by 7, if practiced regularly."

Sounds good to me 🙏

3. Breath Work and the Power of the 4-7-8 Breath

"Breath work offers a unique access to the involuntary nervous system and is a powerful method of relaxation. One very effective technique is the 4-7-8 breathing exercise: inhale for 4 counts, hold for 7 counts, then exhale for 8 counts. Repeat this sequence several times throughout the day. (A video showing the practice can be found at DrWeil.com.)"



We can't cover an Andrew Weil book without mentioning the 4-7-8 breathing technique he's made famous.

It's simple to perform: Inhale through your nose for 4 seconds, hold for 7, then exhale forcibly and audibly through pursed lips for 8 seconds. [Here's a link to the video demonstration.](#)

This exercise only needs to be performed around 4-8 times in a row (Dr. Weil recommends **not exceeding 8 reps** in [a podcast interview with Tim Ferriss](#), but he did not state why). People generally find this technique most helpful at bedtime.

Give it a try and enjoy the relaxing power of the 4-7-8 breath.

4. The Anti-anxiety and Anti-depressive Effects of Breathing

*"Many options are available for managing depression and anxiety without drugs. There is good scientific evidence, for example, for the antidepressant effects of exercise and supplemental fish oil (to provide the essential omega-3 fatty acids needed for optimal brain function). Talk therapy, especially CBT, often works as well as or better than medication to treat depression. Acupuncture can be useful as well. **Learning to regulate the breath is a more effective anti-anxiety measure than benzodiazepines, without any of the cognitive impairment and addictive potential of those drugs.**" (my emphasis)*

Of course, we probably can't just "breathe our way off medications." But, this is a powerful statement from Dr. Weil and reminiscent of a passage from another MD we've covered, Michael J Stephen.

[Here's how he puts it in Breath Taking](#): "Deep breathing is a potent inducer of the parasympathetic nervous system. The release of acetylcholine not only calms our organs, it also stimulates the release of serotonin, dopamine, and prolactin, the feel-good hormones targeted by medicines like Prozac and Zoloft. But yoga and breathing exercises produce this effect naturally and without side effects."

Let's also not forget how Leah Lagos, Psy.D., makes the connection in [Heart Breath Mind](#): "Additionally, recent neurocardiology studies have revealed that the heart is capable of secreting feel-good chemicals like dopamine, oxytocin, and



norepinephrine, all of which help to counteract feelings of depression. For years, the prevailing consensus has been that these powerful compounds were released only by the brain; the notion that the heart can produce these neurochemicals is exciting on many levels. This suggests that strengthening the heart through HRV-strengthening practices could possibly yield mild antidepressive effects.”

When three brilliant authors arrive at similar conclusions, I think there’s a good chance we might be able to use our breath to help reduce depression and anxiety without side effects. Sounds like a win-win to me 🙏.

1 LIFE-CHANGING IDEA

A Perfect Quote on the Extraordinary Power of Breathwork

*“Breath work—learning how to change breathing habits and practicing specific breathing techniques—has remarkable effects on physiology. **It cannot cause harm, requires no equipment, and costs nothing.** It can correct some cardiac arrhythmias and gastrointestinal problems, for example, **and is the most effective treatment I know for anxiety, as well as the simplest method of stress reduction.**” (my emphasis)*

I don’t have much to add, except that this is one of the best quotes I’ve ever read about breathwork. Life-changing, indeed.

1 STACK OF MEMORABLE QUOTES

“But because information on breath work is totally absent from conventional medical training, very few doctors can instruct patients about it. Instead they rely on drugs.”

“Optimal heart health depends upon balance of the mind-body connection. Stress, anger, anxiety, and depression accelerate coronary disease, while optimism and gratitude are balms for the heart. Fortunately, positive moods and emotions can be cultivated.”



“There are many practices to consider for neutralizing the harmful effects of stress on the body and mind: tai chi, yoga, meditation, hypnotherapy, breath work, and more.”

“Various mind-body techniques are available to help alleviate muscle tension: yoga, progressive muscular relaxation, breath work, self-hypnosis, transcranial stimulation, and neurofeedback.”

Discussing ADHD:

“Mind-body interventions like yoga and mindfulness training may help as well; ongoing studies are beginning to demonstrate their usefulness. And breath work can be an effective remedy for hyperactivity.”

“Apart from hypnosis, mind-body therapies useful in managing pain include visualization and guided imagery, biofeedback, breath work, meditation, and mindfulness training.”

“Therapies such as cognitive behavioral therapy (CBT), which can help a child or adolescent recognize and change unhelpful negative thought patterns, and techniques such as deep breathing to relax the mind and body can be as useful as antidepressant medications for some children.”

Discussing falling asleep:

“We need, instead, to practice letting go of wakefulness. Mastering relaxation techniques, such as breath control, can help greatly.”

And here are a few non-breathing ones I’ll leave:

“Keep in mind that doctors are frequently paid thousands of dollars to promote drugs to other doctors and allied health care professionals. The cozy (and lucrative) relationship between the pharmaceutical industry and physicians has become such a problem that the Affordable Care Act mandates public disclosure of these payments. There is now a website you can check to see if your doctor has taken money from the pharmaceutical industry: [cms.gov/openpayments](https://www.cms.gov/openpayments).”

“Although it’s not their primary function, sedating antidepressants, antipsychotics, and antihistamines are also used “off label” as sleep aids.



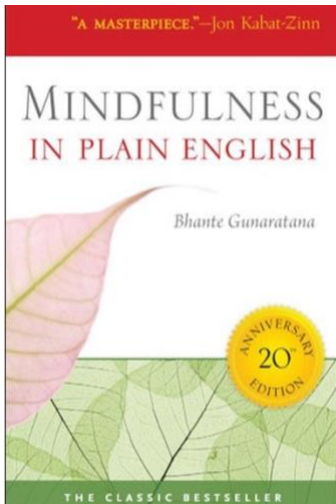
Consumer cost of these drugs ranges from less than \$1 to more than \$30 per dose. The pharmaceutical industry promotes their sale through extensive direct-to-consumer ads and through contributions that influence public sleep education. For example, the National Sleep Foundation, the leading nonprofit organization dedicated to improving sleep health, has received substantial funds from numerous pharmaceutical companies.”

“The information that doctors rely on when prescribing comes more often from industry sources than from objective ones. And despite attempts to curtail their influence, representatives of those companies are still very much present in medical offices, doing their best to persuade doctors to push their products. Pharmaceutical ads are the major revenue source for medical journals, compromising the objectivity of these journals in accepting or rejecting articles that report research findings with drugs and in deciding which to feature prominently.”



BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes



Mindfulness in Plain English

BY: Bhante Henepola Gunaratana

411 Released: December 8, 2024

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. Why We Meditate: It's a Simpler Reason than You May Think
2. The Three Activities of Mindfulness
3. The Nasal Nexus Point and Inherent Connectedness
4. The Third Level of Morality: What We're After

1 Life-Changing Idea

1. A Miniature Slice of Life (and all of life)
-
-



4 Thoughts

1. Why We Meditate: It's a Simpler Reason than You May Think

"Meditation takes gumption. It is certainly a great deal easier just to sit back and watch television. So why bother? Why waste all that time and energy when you could be out enjoying yourself? Why? Simple. Because you are human. Just because of the simple fact that you are human, you find yourself heir to an inherent unsatisfactoriness in life that simply will not go away. You can suppress it from your awareness for a time; you can distract yourself for hours on end, but it always comes back, and usually when you least expect it."

I love this. There are tons of reasons to meditate: to get healthier, achieve insight, or have better attention. But, there's an even simpler one: because we are human. Because of this, we all have a chronic, nagging sense of unhappiness, of always needing just a little bit more.

And while sometimes this unhappiness can spur creativity and resourcefulness, at some point, we realize it will never end. As Gunaratana says, **"You can't ever get everything you want. It is impossible. Luckily, there is another option. You can learn to control your mind."**

Through meditation, we learn to observe (and tame) our minds so that this condition of being human is less burdensome—and actually quite enjoyable. The result is self-transformation into your true nature:

"The purpose of meditation is personal transformation. The "you" that goes in one side of the meditation experience is not the same "you" that comes out the other side. Meditation changes your character by a process of sensitization, by making you deeply aware of your own thoughts, words, and deeds. Your arrogance evaporates, and your antagonism dries up. Your mind becomes still and calm. And your life smoothes out."

So, we meditate because we are human, and through meditation, we become more ourselves—and our lives smoothen out. That seems worth the "gumption" required, if you ask me 😊.



2. The Three Activities of Mindfulness

"There are three fundamental activities of mindfulness. We can use these activities as functional definitions of the term: (a) mindfulness reminds us of what we are supposed to be doing, (b) it sees things as they really are, and (c) it sees the true nature of all phenomena."

When we meditate, we develop mindfulness, a state of awareness associated with the three activities/principles listed above. Let's briefly look at each one, as they're critical to understanding what Gunaratana means by the word "mindfulness" in the book.

Mindfulness Reminds Us of What We Are Supposed to be Doing: "In meditation, you put your attention on one item. When your mind wanders from this focus, it is mindfulness that reminds you that your mind is wandering and what you are supposed to be doing. It is mindfulness that brings your mind back to the object of meditation."

To me, this is the most critical aspect of mindfulness: it's the "noticing" of when your mind has gotten off track. This principle can be applied to life in general: When we're not being the person we want to be or not focusing at work or looking at our phones instead of our kids, mindfulness is that "ah ha" moment when we realize we've gotten off track. This allows us to return to our intention and live how we hoped to be living. This is powerful.

Mindfulness Sees Things as They Really Are: "Mindfulness adds nothing to perception and it subtracts nothing. It distorts nothing. It is bare attention and just looks at whatever comes up."

With mindfulness, we don't label things—labeling is conscious thought. Mindfulness is a layer below that, the layer of awareness that notices without creating a story. It's bare attention.

Mindfulness See the True Nature of All Phenomena: "At this level of inspection, one sees the following: (a) all conditioned things are inherently transitory; (b) every worldly thing is, in the end, unsatisfying; and (c) there are really no entities that are unchanging or permanent, only processes."

This aspect of mindfulness is the insight when you "realize" or "understand" these three aspects of nature, but again, it comes as something beyond your ability to conceptualize it with language. The above words work, but remember that they might be different for you.

Alright, that's mindfulness in a nutshell. Let's next turn to a primary object of meditation and mindfulness: the breath.



3. The Nasal Nexus Point and Inherent Connectedness

"Then, too, that point at the tip of the nostril can be viewed as a sort of a window between the inner and outer worlds. It is a nexus point and energy transfer spot where stuff from the outside world moves in and becomes a part of what we call "me," and where a part of "me" flows forth to merge with the outside world. There are lessons to be learned here about self-identity and how we form it."

One of those lessons is that we are not separate from the world around us but are (quite literally) connected to it: "We" absorb pieces of "it," and "it" absorbs pieces of "us." The breath just reminds us that the boundary between "we" and "it" is somewhat of an illusion.

And in this way, breathing reminds us of our connection to all of life, making it a perfect object of meditation and mindfulness. As Gunaratana puts it:

"Breathing is a universal process. All vertebrates breathe in essentially the same manner. All living things exchange gases with their environment in some way or other. This is one of the reasons that breathing has been chosen as a focus of meditation. The meditator is advised to explore the process of his or her own breathing as a vehicle for realizing our inherent connectedness with the rest of life."

So, by focusing on our breath and observing it with mindfulness, we are reminded of our inherent connectedness with all of life. We are transformed from a "me" vs. "it" perspective to a knowing that, although we are each unique, we are all part of the same whole. This is why focusing on the breath is an underlying principle in essentially every contemplative tradition.



4. The Third Level of Morality: What We're After

"There is a third level of morality, which might better be termed as "ethics." This level is a quantum leap up the scale from the first two levels, a complete shift in orientation. At the level of ethics, a person does not follow hard and fast rules dictated by authority. A person chooses to follow a path dictated by mindfulness, wisdom, and compassion. This level requires real intelligence, and an ability to juggle all the factors in every situation to arrive at a unique, creative, and appropriate response each time."

I think this is a primary goal of all the mixed mindful arts. Yes, we want to develop mindfulness, and good attention, and, of course, better health and wellness. But it is this third level of morality that's critical:

When we arrive at a place where we instinctually choose a path guided by mindfulness, wisdom, and compassion—when we observe things as they are and respond appropriately by our own standards—then our practices will improve our daily living beyond measure.

And fortunately, this happens almost naturally when our intentions with our practice and life are clear and aligned with who we want to become 🙌

P.S. I have most certainly not fully achieved this yet 😊. But I continue to take baby steps, one daily morning practice at a time...



1 Life-Changing Idea

A Miniature Slice of Life (and all of life)

"We don't normally live in the present, of course. We spend most of our time caught up in memories of the past or looking ahead to the future, full of worries and plans. The breath has none of that "other-timeness." When we truly observe the breath, we are automatically placed in the present. We are pulled out of the morass of mental images and into a bare experience of the here and now. In this sense, breath is a living slice of reality. A mindful observation of such a miniature model of life itself leads to insights that are broadly applicable to the rest of our experience."

The breath is "a living slice of reality," a "miniature model of life itself." That basically sums up my entire life philosophy 😊

So, the life-changing idea here is remembering that when we observe the breath with mindfulness (see thought #2), it can lead to insights that apply to all of life. The breath is simply the best tool for these insights because it's always available, always reminding us of our interconnectedness with all of life.

Thus, we might say that breathing is both a miniature model of life and all of life itself.



1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

"There is only one way you will ever know if meditation is worth the effort: learn to do it right, and do it. See for yourself."

"Meditation is not a mindless formula that gives automatic and predictable results; you can never really predict exactly what will come up during any particular session. It is an investigation and an experiment, an adventure every time."

"It is true, of course, that most holy men meditate, but they don't meditate because they are holy men. That is backward. They are holy men because they meditate; meditation is how they got there. And they started meditating before they became holy, otherwise they would not be holy. This is an important point."

"Mindfulness practice is the practice of being 100 percent honest with ourselves."

"When the mind is united with the breath flowing all the time, we will naturally be able to focus the mind on the present moment."

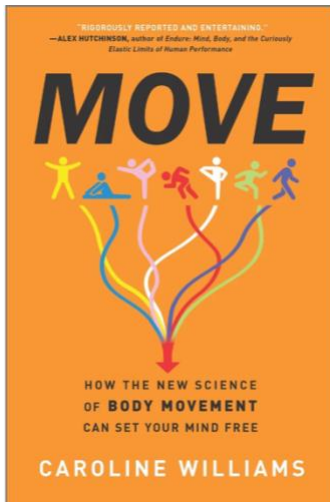
"There is another word for self-discipline. It is patience."

"Mindfulness is mirror-thought. It reflects only what is presently happening and in exactly the way it is happening. There are no biases."

"You can't develop mindfulness by force. Active teeth-gritting willpower won't do you any good at all. As a matter of fact, it will hinder progress. Mindfulness cannot be cultivated by struggle. It grows by realizing, by letting go, by just settling down in the moment and letting yourself get comfortable with whatever you are experiencing."

BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes



Move: How the New Science of Body Movement Can Set Your Mind Free

BY: Caroline Williams

411 Released: October 6, 2024

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. Movement Is Mindfulness: Moving Shapes Who We Are
2. Breathing is the Best Movement
3. Walking: Brain Blood Flow, Creativity, and Memories
4. Changing Our Soundtrack

1 Life-Changing Idea

1. Move to Be Still
-
-



4 Thoughts

1. Movement Is Mindfulness: Moving Shapes Who We Are

"It doesn't matter what you want to do with your mind. Whether you want to learn better, slow brain aging, spark new ideas or just feel more in control of your mental health, there is almost nothing that moving more—and in particular ways—can't help you to achieve. Body movements can serve as a short-cut to changing the ways we think and feel."

The way Williams speaks of movement is reminiscent of how many authors approach breathing and meditation (which is probably why I loved this book so much). And in this passage, we discover the basic premise of the whole book: Movement is a shortcut to changing how we think and feel.

As she explains, "By changing the chemical and physical basis of how we feel, movement allows us to change the inputs to the 'global emotional moment,' leaving us with a different sense of 'how I feel now.'"

And how about this gem: "It is entirely possible to use the way we move as a form of self-management for better physical and mental functioning."

Thus, beyond the body, movement becomes a powerful form of mind training and mindfulness, transforming how we feel and giving us a tool not just for better physical health but for better mental health, too.

With that in mind, let's begin with the most fundamental yet powerful body movement of all: Breathing.



2. Breathing is the Best Movement

"There is now enough robust science to show that mastering the simple movements needed to control the rate, depth and route by which you get air into your body can become a handy tool to steer thoughts and feelings in useful ways. Mastering this range of bodily movements can allow us to dial into the workings of the brain and the rest of the body, change the settings of both and get the very best out of the mind."

The chapter on breathing from this book is phenomenal. I can't recommend it enough. And from this quote, you can likely see why 😊

One primary topic Williams covers is the connection between breathing and brainwaves. As she says, **"There is also an ever-increasing pile of scientific research that demonstrates that, when you control your breath, what you are actually doing is taking your brainwaves in hand and tethering the rate of their fluctuations to your breathing rate."**

How awesome is that? (If you want more on this, check out two of the coolest studies on this topic, which we've reviewed [here](#) and [here](#).)

One practice where this breath-brainwave connection is particularly useful is in ultra-slow breathing. While we know slow breathing at ~6 breaths a minute is almost universally beneficial, Williams highlights the power of slowing it down to just 3 breaths a minute: **"The power of three breaths per minute could provide a much-needed holiday from thinking and a freeing sense of being part of something greater than ourselves."** This happens because ultra-slow breathing increases theta and delta brainwaves, facilitating deep relaxation and a focused inner state. That sounds good to me 🙌

And, of course, none of this is possible without nasal breathing, which she sums up perfectly:

"Whatever rate you breathe at, whether you focus on the breath for alertness, slow it down a bit for relaxation, or a lot to reach an altered state of consciousness, only nasal breathing allows your brainwaves to synchronize with the breath, offering a fast track to an alternative state of mind."

P.S. Williams also covers mindful breathing vs. controlled breathing, breathing at 6 breaths a minute, and a bunch of great quotes on the power of the breath.



3. Walking: Brain Blood Flow, Creativity, and Memories

By now, we all know walking is good for us, but let's explore three neat insights from this book that may inspire you to get on your feet even more:

1. Walking for Brain Blood Flow

"Crucially, though, [Greene] recently found that putting your full body weight on your feet while you are exercising provides an added boost...putting weight on your feet compresses the major arteries of the feet, increasing turbulence in the blood and increasing blood flow to the brain by a further 10–15 percent."

There you go: By simply putting weight on our feet, we increase brain blood flow by 10-15 more than with exercise that doesn't involve foot compression.

2. Walking for Creativity

"One thing that works in our favor here is that, whenever you're moving under your own steam at a pace that feels easy, the activity in the prefrontal cortex gets temporarily turned down...Reducing this filter allows access to a broader set of options—ideas that you might not otherwise consider ... Ideally this would be done alone somewhere familiar, so that your thinking mind can switch off, drift away and come back with a shiny new idea. It really is that simple."

When we feel stuck, a pleasant stroll might be all that's needed. We can find a leisurely pace, let our minds wander, and "come back with a shiny new idea. It really is that simple."

3. Walking for Mood

"In experiments when people walked with a high-energy, bouncing gait they were able to remember more happy words from a list of emotionally charged words, while those who were asked to walk slowly and with little bounce remembered more of the negative ones, even when they weren't aware that they were doing a "depressed"-or "happy"-style gait."

And how about this neat research? You likely won't catch me bouncing down the sidewalk anytime soon 😊, but it's great motivation to walk with a little more zest so we can potentially remember (or notice) more positive than negative.



4. Changing Our Soundtrack

"According to Damasio, the unconscious messages coming from the body provide not only the basis for the self but also a kind of undercurrent to our consciousness that sets the mood for everything else that happens. These "background feelings," as he calls them, act a bit like the soundtrack of a film: they have the power to make us feel happy, sad, hopeful or on edge, for reasons that we can't quite put our finger on."

This idea of "background feelings" subtly shaping the overall mood of our lives also perfectly illustrates the power of practices like breathing, meditation, and mindfulness. These rituals seem to influence our physiology in ways that change our "life's soundtrack," helping us feel happier and more hopeful "for reasons that we can't quite put our finger on."

So, here's to changing our life's soundtrack, one mindful session at a time 🙏

P.S. One way that slow breathing rewrites our soundtrack is by lowering our baseline stress levels. As Williams puts it, "Remarkably, it's possible to use your breath to train your body to react more healthily to stress, both in the moment and over the longer term, by virtue of the way that it changes the level of activity along the vagus nerve. Over time, practicing slow breathing can change your baseline level of stress reactivity to a point where you freak out less often and recover more quickly when you do." Being less stressed and freaking out less often sounds like a perfect new "soundtrack" to live to 🙌🎵



1 Life-Changing Idea

Move to Be Still

"All of this together suggests that the modern scourge of tiredness is partly explained by a lack of movement and partly by a lack of proper rest. Working on one without the other is only going to give you half the improvement in overall well-being. **We need to move to be still, and only from that place of stillness can we move well.**"

Here is a life-changing reminder that movement is an essential part of our breathing, meditation, and mindfulness practices. They are two sides of the same coin: **"We need to move to be still, and only from that place of stillness can we move well."** Amen to that.

P.S. This also echoes Eknath Easwaran's wisdom from Passage Meditation: **"Without a balance between physical activity and meditation, for instance, we may become irritable or restless. Exercise can help to solve some of the problems that come as you descend in consciousness."** In other words, we need to move to be still 😊

When teachers coming from diverse perspectives converge on the same idea, it's a good sign we've stumbled upon a universal principle 🙌



1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

"Moving in the world and interacting with it are the best way to make sense of what the brain thinks is true."

"Our biological baseline is to be on our feet, moving and thinking at the same time...when we get on our feet and move, it primes the brain to be alert and to learn."

"Despite centuries of reports from followers of Eastern traditions that slow breathing can improve focus, bring a sense of calm when we might otherwise lose it and even whisk us away to an altered state of consciousness, most of us still don't take time out from our busy lives to prioritize this simplest and most unobtrusive of body movements."

"If you are already breathing at a normal rate, slowing it down further still can change your state of mind to the point where you tune out from reality and skip happily away with the fairies."

"Breathing at six breaths per minute is, to all intents and purposes, a short-cut to a sense of calm and contentment."

"Becoming a master of your body, in other words, might help you become a master of your mind."

"Break into a full belly laugh and you hit two pillars of stress control in one go: a recent study found that laughing really hard provides a better core workout than crunches."

"Even if you've never given it a moment's thought, breath control is instinctively recognizable as not only a human-only skill but also as one that is intimately linked to our unique powers of mental and emotional self-regulation."

"Ultimately, whether you are looking for more brain power, to feel more connected to others or just more in control of your life, the message from all corners of science is coming through loud and clear: this is no time to be sitting around."



[Get This Book
on Amazon](#)

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Book 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes

Neurodharma: New Science, Ancient Wisdom, and Seven Practices of the Highest Happiness

BY: RICK HANSON, Ph.D.

THE 4 THOUGHTS

1. Beating Our Negative Biases with Slow Breathing
2. On Sailboats, HRV, and Developing Your Inner Resources
3. Delight in Practice: Finding Routines that Are Meaningful to You (it's ok to have fun with it)
4. Perfect Advice to Follow Today (and for the rest of our lives)

4 THOUGHTS

1. Beating Our Negative Biases with Slow Breathing

"We need to deal with real dangers, but much of the time we overestimate threats—an aspect of the negativity bias—and don't feel as safe as we actually are. This makes us feel bad, and it wears down physical and mental health over time. Plus when we feel at all anxious, attention understandably skitters around, scanning the world—including relationships—and body and mind for what might go wrong. Helping yourself to feel reasonably safe calms the stress response system



and helps you stay with the object of attention rather than look about for a tiger that might pounce.”

Evolution wired us to notice the negative about [9x more than the positive](#). Although that’s good for survival, it’s not so great for our everyday health.

Enter slow breathing exercises. By activating the calming parasympathetic nervous system, **they teach our bodies to feel safe**. This dampens the negativity bias, helping us engage fully in things that matter.

It reminds me of this wisdom from Russ Harris in [The Confidence Gap](#), “*Mindful Breathing is a useful practice in its own right. It allows us to take some time out from our busy daily routines, and often creates a restful state that allows us to recharge our batteries and find some inner peace.*”

So here’s to using our breath to feel safe, to find some inner peace, and to beat our negativity bias.

2. On Sailboats, HRV, and Developing Your Inner Resources

“Developing inner resources is like deepening the keel of a sailboat so that you’re more able to deal with the worldly winds—gain and loss, pleasure and pain, praise and blame, fame and slander—without getting tipped over into the reactive mode—or at least you can recover more quickly. With growing confidence in these capabilities, you become more comfortable raising your sights in life and sailing even farther into the deep, dark blue.”

Although Dr. Hanson is talking about inner resources in general, this is an excellent analogy for why [improving HRV via slow deep breathing](#) is so helpful: it’s like deepening the keel of our *physiological sailboats*.

Of course, we’ll always be hit by life’s storms, but with higher HRV, we’ll remain steadier and recover quicker. We could say, then, that deep breathing = deep keel.



3. Delight in Practice: Finding Routines that Are Meaningful to You (it's ok to have fun with it)

"Whatever your practices are, you're more likely to keep doing them if you enjoy them. So look for what feels good and meaningful in what you are already doing, and perhaps find additional things that are naturally pleasurable for you. Ask yourself if you've been doing some things by rote, or if they've gotten dry for you; see if there are ways to help them be more rewarding. It's all right to let go of some things to make room for others that would be more fruitful for you."

It's good to bring playfulness, even delight, to your practices. See if you can be amused sometimes by your own mind, its zigging and zagging, the tricks it can play, the surprising sudden openings. I've gotten way too serious about my own practice in the past. Practice is less effective if it's heavy and somber most of the time. It's okay to have fun with it!"

What a perfect attitude to take toward our breathing practice (or any practice we do for self-care).

If you want to start applying the new things you learn, start with what you already find meaningful and add or subtract from there.

For example, suppose you love Wim Hof breathing, but then you learn about the power of slow breathing for better health. In that case, you might try adding 5 minutes of slow breathing after your Wim Hof routine.

If you like it, you keep it. If not, you don't.

Lastly, let's remember not to take ourselves (or our practice) too seriously (guilty here). As Dr. Hanson also tells us, *"It's good to bring playfulness, even delight, to your practices."*

Here's to applying rigorous science in our lives in a delightful way, today.

Related Quote: "As long as you derive inner help and comfort from anything, keep it." - Gandhi.



4. Perfect Advice to Follow Today (and for the rest of our lives)

*"So look for those little ways in the flow of life to feel a bit more relaxed, protected, strong, and at ease...and a little more grateful, glad, and successful...and a little more cared about and caring, and a little more loved and loving. **One breath at a time, one synapse at a time, you can gradually develop an increasingly unshakable core inside yourself.** The more often and deeply you do this, the greater the results."*

That sounds like perfect advice to follow today, tomorrow, and for the rest of our lives 🙏

1 LIFE-CHANGING IDEA

You Can't Live There, but You're Changed Forever

"I was once talking with the teacher Steve Armstrong, who had trained as a monk in Asia. I asked him if he could tell me about nibbana. He looked at me intently and then got a faraway look and said something I've thought about many times since: 'It's as if you live in a deep valley surrounded by mountains. Then one day you're standing on top of the highest peak. The perspective is amazing. Still, you can't live there. And so you come back down to the valley. But what you've seen changes you forever.'"

What a fantastic story with such a practical, life-changing message.

We can have spiritual, even mystical experiences, whether through a 2-hour breathing session, a weekend retreat, or just 10 minutes of slow breathing on your couch.

But remember that we can't live up on the mountaintop they bring us to. If we chase that state forever, we'll always be unhappy. Instead, we have to integrate



the perspective they give us in our everyday lives while simultaneously doing the things that need to get done to live in our current reality.

1 STACK OF MEMORABLE QUOTES

“Train yourself in doing good that lasts and brings happiness. Cultivate generosity, the life of peace, and a mind of boundless love.” - Itivuttaka 1.22

“In a saying from the work of the psychologist Donald Hebb, neurons that fire together wire together. This means that you can use your mind to change your brain to change your mind for the better.”

“Be devoted to the breath and renounce everything else.” – Eugene Cash

“It’s helpful to extend your exhalations because the “rest-and-digest” parasympathetic nervous system (PNS) handles exhaling while also slowing your heart rate, so longer exhalations are naturally relaxing.”

“Just as a felled tree grows again if the roots are unharmed and strong, so suffering sprouts again and again until the tendency to crave is rooted out.” - Dhammapada 338

“For example, the classic Mindfulness of Breathing Sutta (Majjhima Nikaya 118) suggests that we “breathe in, tranquilizing the body; breathe out, tranquilizing the body...breathe in, tranquilizing the mind; breathe out, tranquilizing the mind...”

“One of the most remarkable facts of existence is under our noses all of the time. This is the Now of the present moment: endlessly ending, and endlessly renewed. Radically transient, yet always enduring.”

“Your experience of the present moment is based on the activity of your nervous system at that moment.”

“In truth we are always present. We only imagine ourselves to be in one place or another.” – Attributed to Howard Cohn



“Every atom in your body that is heavier than helium was made inside a star, usually as it was exploding. Carbon, oxygen, iron: all of it. Take a breath—and breathe stardust with stardust. This body is billions of years old.”

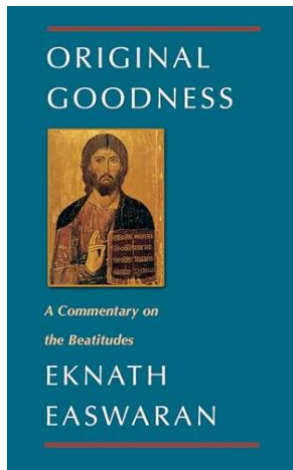
And I’ll just repeat this gem one more time to finish it off:

*“So look for those little ways in the flow of life to feel a bit more relaxed, protected, strong, and at ease...and a little more grateful, glad, and successful...and a little more cared about and caring, and a little more loved and loving. **One breath at a time, one synapse at a time, you can gradually develop an increasingly unshakable core inside yourself.** The more often and deeply you do this, the greater the results.”*



BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



Original Goodness: A Commentary on the Beatitudes

BY: Eknath Easwaran

411 Released: July 14, 2024

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. What is Original Goodness?
2. Why We Train the Mind: The Key to Unlocking Our Original Goodness
3. Love is the Most Valuable Resource
4. Breathing, Emotions, and Life Span

1 Life-Changing Idea

1. The Real Meaning of Simplicity (plus the whole naturally includes us)

Reading Time: ~ 7 min

I hope the next 100'ish breaths are the most nourishing of your day.



4 Thoughts

1. What is Original Goodness?

“When all hostility, all resentment, all greed and fear and insecurity are erased from your mind, the state that remains is pure joy. When we become established in that state, we live in joy always.

That state of joy, hidden at the very center of consciousness, is the Eden to which the long journey of spiritual seeking leads. There, the mystics of all religions agree, we uncover our original goodness. We don’t have to buy it; we don’t have to create it; we don’t have to pour it in; we don’t even have to be worthy of it. This native goodness is the essential core of human nature.”

That is the essence of Original Goodness: there is a hidden state of joy at the center of our consciousness. **“We don’t have to create it...We don’t even have to be worthy of it. This native goodness is the essential core of human nature.”**

Easwaran also tells us, **“Even if we try with all our might to douse or hide it, it is always ready to set our personality ablaze with light.”** <-- That’s so good.

There are many ways of uncovering it (some of which we’ll discuss next), but for our purposes, breathing, reading, and meditation are how we slowly reveal our own original goodness so we can set our personality ablaze with light 🙏

P.S. Of course, I haven’t fully uncovered this for myself (just ask my wife 😊). Perhaps I never will. But, the process still helps us become better people, which is something worth striving for.



2. Why We Train the Mind: The Key to Unlocking Our Original Goodness

“To begin with, it is our mental apparatus – our feelings, memories, and desires – that selects what we even perceive. Out of the vast confusion of data that our senses present, it is the mind that decides what registers. Anything that fails to fit our interests or understanding is not introduced to our attention. What we see – and therefore the world we live in, our world as opposed to others’ – is a function of our own thinking.”

This is precisely why training the mind is foundational to uncovering our original goodness: Our mind selects what we perceive (what we see **“is a function of our own thinking”**). So, it just makes sense for us to train it.

Thus, when we incline our minds toward goodness through contemplative practices, more goodness will be revealed. You’ll notice more beauty; your social media algorithms will show you more positive news; you’ll talk less negatively; you’ll express more love; and on and on.

It all starts with training our minds, which we do through our daily breathing, reading, and meditation.

P.S. Here’s a great quote to drive home the importance of this idea: **“...mental states are real – in fact, in some ways they are even more ‘thingy’ than things. If I were to throw this pen at you, you might get a little bruise. But if I said something unkind and you couldn’t stop thinking about it, your resentment might burn for years.”**

P.P.S. This also relates back to our stress levels: **“A person whose mind is well trained can manage in the midst of a stressful environment. Noise and pollution will take their toll on the body, but vitality and resistance will remain high. By contrast, a person whose mind is out of control can suffer from stress while lying on a quiet beach in Saint-Tropez.”**



3. Love is the Most Valuable Resource

“One simple proof of love’s unbelievable power is that it is still the most longed-for commodity on earth. In an age rich in technological toys, aren’t we still troubled if we have a losing record in love? ... The awful truth is that no one on earth is more severely handicapped than those who are unable to love. Without love we are desperately deprived – and that may prove to be our saving grace.”

In his typical manner, Easwaran uses simple yet profound logic to remind us that, of all the ways of unlocking our original goodness, love has the most power. Love **“is still the most longed-for commodity on earth.”**

Another of our favorite teachers, Gladys McGarey, MD, says something similar: **“It’s not hokey. It’s not overstated. Love truly is the greatest medicine the world has ever known.”**

The natural question, then, is how do we cultivate it? The best solution I’ve found is loving-kindness meditation (you can get a recorded one on the [practice page](#)). However, Easwaran provides another way, one which I found incredibly inspiring and insightful:

“Love means that whenever negative thoughts enter the mind, we can turn our attention to positive thoughts instead. This is all that is required to guard ourselves against lapses from love.

The key to this is giving – our time, our talents, our resources, our skills, our lives – to selfless work, some cause greater than our small personal interests. By working hard to give what we can, and by cultivating kindness and compassion under every provocation, we can escape destructive ways of thinking.”

So, here’s to giving ourselves to something bigger than ourselves so we can cultivate more love and become prosperous in this most longed-for commodity on Earth.

P.S. And if you don’t think that level of love lies within you, think again: **“The whole message of original goodness is that we do not have to work to draw this kind of love from some external source. A full reservoir of love is lying right inside us. In meditation we are digging deep into our own consciousness, tunneling toward this infinite reservoir that lies waiting to be discovered and manifested in our daily life.”**



4. Breathing, Emotions, and Life Span

“In Sanskrit, vital energy is called prana, which literally means “the energy of life.” Prana is the energy that drives the whole organism we call ourself: not only the physical body, but the mind as well. All creatures consume vital energy. In the ancient Hindu tradition, it is said that we come into life with a given supply of this energy, enough to power a certain number of breathing cycles. **Our natural human life span, according to this view, is allotted not in calendar years but in the number of breaths we take. ...**

If this theory is true, it may help to explain why these ancient sages claim a close connection between mental states and longevity. Our breathing rhythm, the measure of how fast our reserves of vital energy are being consumed, is regulated in part by our state of mind. **Security, compassion, patience, forgiveness – all these are accompanied, if you observe closely, by a relatively slow breathing rhythm and heart rate.** Positive states of mind like these conserve energy and lengthen the life span, leaving a reserve of resilience and resistance for facing challenges.” (my emphasis)

To bring it all together, this passage beautifully connects the breath back to original goodness. When we tap into positive attributes like patience and forgiveness, our breathing rate naturally slows, conserving vital energy.

But let’s not forget it’s a two-way street. By consciously slowing down our breathing, we can change our nervous system and brainwaves to support the cultivation of these qualities.

So here’s to choosing whichever route we enjoy most (or perhaps both, if you’re up for it) so we can conserve our vital energy and leave a **“reserve of resilience and resistance for facing challenges.” 🙏**



1 Life-Changing Idea

The Real Meaning of Simplicity (plus the whole naturally includes us)

"In the name of simplification today we are asked to take the most remarkable steps: to buy food processors and microwave ovens, open charge accounts, install a telephone in every room, pay a travel agent to plan our next vacation down to the last waiter's tip. It is exhilarating to be reminded here that the real meaning of simplicity is singling out what is worth living for, and then shaping our lives around what matters and letting go of everything else."

It bears repeating: **"The real meaning of simplicity is singling out what is worth living for, and then shaping our lives around what matters and letting go of everything else."** Living like that is not easy, but it's a North Star worth moving toward, one that our breathing, reading, and meditation can inch us toward each and every day 🙏

P.S. Here's another (perhaps even more eloquent) way Easwaran put it: **"To live simply is to live gently, keeping in mind always the needs of the planet, other creatures, and the generations to come. In doing this we lose nothing, because the interests of the whole naturally include our own."**



1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

“The soul is made of love and must ever strive to return to love. Therefore, it can never find rest nor happiness in other things. It must lose itself in love.” - Mechthild of Magdeburg

“Interestingly enough, it is just when we forget about the body that it functions at its best.”

“In fact, the mystics say, all the daring and aggressiveness in human nature is given to us for one supreme evolutionary purpose: to remove what covers our original goodness so that we can reveal more and more of God in our own lives.”

“What a man takes in by contemplation, that he pours out in love.” - Meister Eckhart

“Pilgrimage to the place of the wise is to find escape from the flame of separateness.” - Jalaluddin Rumi

“It is an astonishing truth: there is only one person in the world I can hope to control, and that is myself. I may learn to govern the way I think, but I can never govern the way you think. How much of our behavior reveals that we have not grasped this truth at all!”

“If you want a life full of vitality, the mystics say, don’t waste your energy in thinking about yourself. Think about others. You will find it not only conserves personal energy, it actually brings you to life.”

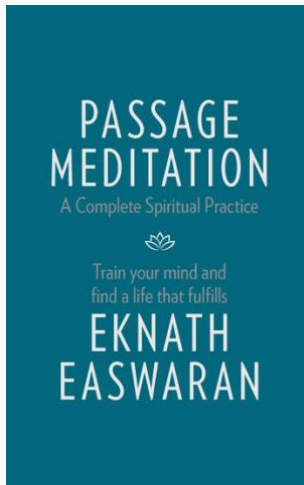
“When you develop this marvelous capacity to hold attention steady on the present, like the flame of a candle in a windless place, most anxieties evaporate. There is no reason to worry about what tomorrow may bring.”

“If you live today completely in love – hating no one, hurting no one, serving all – then tomorrow has to be good, whatever comes.”



BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes



Passage Meditation - A Complete Spiritual Practice: Train Your Mind and Find a Life That Fulfills

BY: Eknath Easwaran

411 Released: September 9, 2024

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. The Philosophy of Passage Meditation
2. How to Practice Passage Meditation
3. The Mantram (and the eight-point program)
4. Movement is Not a Luxury, but an Imperative

1 Life-Changing Idea

1. The True Signs of Progress in Meditation

Reading Time: ~ 6 min 44 sec

I hope the next 81'ish breaths are the most nourishing of your day.



4 Thoughts

1. The Philosophy of Passage Meditation

"Passage meditation can be followed equally well in any religion or in none. It belongs to no movement, asks for no change of beliefs; it simply allows you to take the ideals you respond to and gradually, gracefully, make them part of your life."

The name "passage meditation" stood out to me because, despite years of exploring meditation, I hadn't encountered it. Though it does involve meditating on a passage (as you might expect), its simplicity and depth make it worth exploring:

Key Point 1: You Become What You Meditate On

"In the simplest possible language, this is the secret of meditation: we become what we meditate on."

By meditating on inspirational wisdom that resonates with you, its qualities gradually shape you. The more you internalize the words, the more they become a part of who you are.

Key Point 2: Memorization and Mind Training

"Though our mind may be three-pointed or four-pointed or even a hundred-pointed now, we train it to be one-pointed in meditation. This remarkable discipline brings all the powers of the mind to an intense focus."

The second key point is that memorizing and mentally reciting passages (more on this next) strengthens attention and reduces distraction, improving focus throughout your day.

So, in a nutshell: You become what you meditate on, and through meditation, you train your mind to be less distractable, more focused, and more at peace. Sounds like a good philosophy to me 🧘.



2. How to Practice Passage Meditation

"I recommend beginning with the Prayer of Saint Francis of Assisi...over many years of teaching meditation, I have found that Saint Francis's words have an almost universal appeal. Through them pulses the spiritual wisdom this gentle friar drew upon when he undertook the most awesome task a human being is capable of: the total transformation of character, conduct, and consciousness."

Steps to Follow:

1. Choose and Memorize: The first step is to select a passage and commit it to memory. Easwaran suggests beginning with the Prayer of Saint Francis of Assisi, a passage with universal spiritual appeal (I've added it to the end of this 411). But you can, of course, choose any passage that resonates with you—just make sure it's easy to memorize at first.

2. Meditate:

- Sit comfortably with a straight back.
- Close your eyes and silently recite the passage in your mind.
- Focus only on reciting the words—don't visualize them.
- Recite at a slow pace, leaving comfortable space between words.
- If your mind wanders and you forget your place, start over from the beginning.
- Repeat the passage for about 30 minutes.

Additional Notes:

- When you finish the passage, instead of starting over, you can also mix it up and start a new passage once you have more memorized.
- Easwaran advises not exceeding 30 minutes.
- He also says less than 30 minutes is less effective. However, personally, I've found even 10 minutes rewarding.

If you feel inspired by this approach, give it a try and see how it feels 🙏



3. The Mantram (and the eight-point program)

"A mantram is a spiritual formula of enormous power that has been transmitted from age to age in a religious tradition. The users, wishing to draw upon this power that calms and heals, silently repeat the words as often as possible during the day, each repetition adding to their physical and spiritual well-being. In a sense, that is all there is to a mantram. In another sense, there is so much! Those who have tried it—saints, sages, and ordinary people too—know from their own experience its marvelous potency."

While Passage Meditation is the name of the book, it is just one component of a broader eight-point program Easwaran presents. The other seven points are: Repetition of a Mantram, Slowing Down, One-Pointed Attention, Training the Senses, Putting Others First, Spiritual Fellowship, and Spiritual Reading. Each of these practices is powerful on its own, but for now, let's dive into the second point: the mantram (or mantra).

The word mantra comes from the Sanskrit roots "man" meaning "mind" and "tra" meaning "tool" or "instrument." Thus, it's a "tool for the mind." Just as we use physical tools to build and repair, we use a mantram to build and repair our mental state.

In Easwaran's approach, you perform passage meditation for 30 minutes each morning and then recite the mantram throughout your day as much as possible. He says, **"The mantram works best when we repeat it silently in the mind with as much concentration as possible."** This repetition builds a protective mental habit that guards against worry and stress.

Easwaran also offers wise guidance for choosing a mantram: **"Please exercise some care in your choice of a mantram. After all, it will be with you for a long time. Deliberate for a while and take into account the practical significance of the words, your religious background, and your personal response. A bit of self-knowledge is required when it comes to making a selection."** (You can find his [recommended mantrams here.](#))

Lastly, if you're still hesitant about mantras in general, take his advice: **"If you have preconceptions about using a mantram, let me ask you to put them aside and give it a personal trial. Why take someone else's word for it? Enter the laboratory of your mind and perform the experiment. Then you will be in a position to judge for yourself, and nothing can be as persuasive as that."**

That sounds like perfect advice for any practice 🙏



4. Movement is Not a Luxury, but an Imperative

"Energetic movement is not an option, not a luxury, but an imperative on the spiritual path if we are to do the work that needs doing. Young people require strenuous activities, such as jogging, swimming, and hard work, that tax the heart and lungs. And nearly all of us, of course, can walk, as briskly as our condition permits. I say "briskly" because the body is designed for and thrives on vigorous motion, so give it a pace that will send the blood spinning through the veins and bring the cells to life."

Given his gentle and compassionate nature, I imagined Easwaran spending all his time sitting in meditation 😊. Yet, as we learn here, he is a huge supporter of vigorous activity. In fact, he says it's *necessary* to increase our ability to go deeper in consciousness:

"Without a balance between physical activity and meditation, for instance, we may become irritable or restless. Exercise can help to solve some of the problems that come as you descend in consciousness."

So, let's remember that a contemplative life doesn't require sitting around all day. Physical activity (somewhat paradoxically) helps calm the mind, creating the inner stillness needed for deeper meditation when we do sit to practice.

P.S. This brings to mind another great quote from Caroline Williams in [Move](#): "We need to move to be still, and only from that place of stillness can we move well."



1 Life-Changing Idea

The True Signs of Progress in Meditation

"One reason we may find lights and sounds and so on intriguing is that we take them for evidence of progress. Something is happening! Beneath my gentle ways, however, I am a very hard-nosed mystic. **I'm not impressed by supernatural experiences; I look for changes in character and conduct.** How selfless can you be? Can you restrain your senses when necessary? Can you go against your self-will when it benefits those around you? How long is your span of attention? These are the signs of progress in meditation."

How powerful is that? Of course, there are many different signs of progress in meditation (and breathing and mindfulness). However, these resonated deeply with me as I've gradually shifted toward "*improvements in my daily life*" as the true benchmark of growth.

So, let's use this passage as a life-changing reminder that true progress isn't found in chasing transient, supernatural experiences, but in how our character and conduct evolve for the better 🙏

P.S. Here are two quotes from the book that complement this idea nicely:

"Surprisingly, it is not during meditation that you make progress in meditation; it is during the rest of the day. What you do in meditation is get the power, install the dynamo; the actual work is done after you open your eyes, get up, and go out into the world."

"So try to remember every day that you are participating in meditation even at breakfast, at work, at school, in the garden, everywhere." 🙏



1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

"Let me just say here that in our behavior, we often defy an inescapable principle: if you let your mind be ruffled by what is pleasant, it is bound to be ruffled by what is unpleasant."

"Speed begets many physical disorders, often simply from stress. Digestive, breathing, and nervous problems may be cured when the pace of life slows down."

"As human beings, all of us have the capacity to take our evolution into our own hands and act not compulsively, but from free choice."

"Do you know the old proverb, 'You are what you eat'? We can ring a variation on it by saying, 'You see what you are.'"

"What motivates us receives our attention, and whatever has our attention is what we see."

"Often, physical problems constitute a clear call from the physical system that something in our daily life is destroying it. Pain, disease, loss of optimum health are meant by beneficent nature to be signals, very much like the signs on freeway ramps: 'Stop! You are going the wrong way!'"

"Repeating a mantram sounds so simple that most people cannot believe it works until they try it."

"In this sense, perhaps the simplest expression of our goal in meditation is that we are trying to make ourselves whole."

"Happiness comes when we forget ourselves, and misery when we can't think about anybody else."

And my favorite from the book:

"If you can laugh it off when things go against you while still giving your very best, you are mastering the art of living."



The Prayer of Saint Francis of Assisi

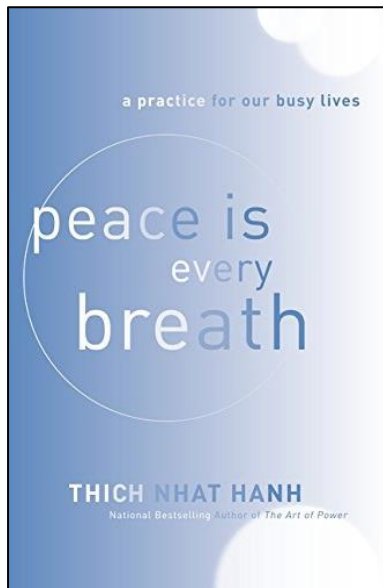
"Lord, make me an instrument of thy peace.
Where there is hatred, let me sow love;
Where there is injury, pardon;
Where there is doubt, faith;
Where there is despair, hope;
Where there is darkness, light;
Where there is sadness, joy.

O divine Master, grant that I may not so much seek
To be consoled as to console,
To be understood as to understand,
To be loved as to love;
For it is in giving that we receive;
It is in pardoning that we are pardoned;
It is in dying to self that we are born to eternal life."



BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



Peace Is Every Breath: A Practice for Our Busy Lives

BY: Thich Nhat Hanh

411 Released: July 28, 2023

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. Peace is Every Breath: The Power of Mindful Breathing
2. Belly Breathing, Treetops, and Life's Storms
3. Your Seatbelt in Everyday Life
4. How to Deal with Anger: A Burning House and Your Emotions

1 Life-Changing Idea

1. Joy is a Habit (and mindful breathing gets us there)
-
-



4 Thoughts

1. Peace is Every Breath: The Power of Mindful Breathing

"The practice of mindful breathing may be very simple, but the effect can be great. Focusing on our in-breath, we release the past, we release the future, we release our projects. We ride on that breath with all our being. Our mind comes back to our body, and we are truly there, alive, in the present moment. We are home. Just one breath, in and out, can make us fully present and fully alive again, and then the energy of mindfulness is there in us."

"Just one breath, in and out, can make us fully present and fully alive again." < -- That's how we achieve peace with every breath.

And fortunately, although it requires consistent practice, we're all capable of doing it. As Thich Nhat Hanh says, **"Every one of us is capable of breathing in mindfully. I breathe in, and I know I am breathing in—that's the practice of mindful breathing."**

But I believe the real power of this practice is that, as Hanh says, with just one conscious breath, we cultivate the energy of mindfulness within us. Thus, mindful breathing is just a tool for cultivating mindfulness in all aspects of life. And mindfulness in daily living is perhaps the most significant benefit of all because:

"Doing things with mindfulness means you perform each action with clear awareness of what's happening and of what you're doing in the present moment, and you feel happy as you do it."

Sounds good to me 🙌



2. Belly Breathing, Treetops, and Life's Storms

"When trees get hit by a storm, the treetops are thrashed around and run the highest risk of being damaged. The trunk of a tree is more stable and solid; it has many roots reaching deep into the Earth. The treetops are like your own head, your thinking mind."

When a storm comes up in you, get out of the treetop and go down to the trunk for safety. Your roots start down at your abdomen, slightly below the navel...Put all your attention on that part of your belly, and breathe deeply. Don't think about anything, and you'll be safe while the storm of emotions is blowing. Practice this every day for just five minutes, and after three weeks, you'll be able to handle your emotions successfully whenever they rise up."

We discuss using our practice to help us handle "life's storms" a lot. So naturally, I absolutely love this analogy. It also reminds me of Jon Kabat-Zinn's wisdom: **"Focusing on the breath at your belly can be calming. ... when we focus on our breathing down in the belly, we are tuning in to a region of the body that is far from the head and thus far below the agitations of our thinking mind. It is intrinsically calmer."**

Thus, with belly breathing, we get out of our treetops—out of our thinking mind—and find safety in our roots. And the best part: If we do this daily for five minutes, we'll make it through a few storms, realize this stuff actually works, and ultimately build confidence in ourselves:

"Seeing yourself pass through a storm unharmed, you gain more confidence. You can tell yourself, 'Next time, if the storm of emotions comes back, I won't be scared or shaken, because now I know the way to overcome it.'"

So remember, the next time you're dealing with an emotional storm, **"get out of the treetop and go down to the trunk for safety."**

3. Your Seatbelt in Everyday Life

"It's like when you're flying in an airplane. Whenever severe turbulence comes along, the seatbelt keeps you from getting thrown around the cabin. Mindful breathing is your seatbelt in everyday life—it keeps you safe here in the present moment. If you know how to breathe, how to sit calmly and quietly, how to do walking meditation, then you have your seatbelt and you're always safe."



“Mindful breathing is your seatbelt in everyday life—it keeps you safe here in the present moment.” < -- how perfect is that? (And it’s an excellent follow-up to the previous thought.)

But to me, the most critical part of that passage is: **“Whenever severe turbulence comes along...”** Not if turbulence comes along, but *when*.

Mindful breathing (or any contemplative practice, for that matter) won’t prevent all of life’s problems and help us live a perfect, stress-free life. Instead, it’s preparing us (and building an attitude of acceptance) so we can get through life’s turbulence without being tossed around the metaphorical cabin whenever something lousy happens.

So, we’ll be wise to remember: **“Mindful breathing is your seatbelt in everyday life—it keeps you safe here in the present moment.”**

4. How to Deal with Anger: A Burning House and Your Emotions

“Any time your anger rises up,...don't try to say or do anything about the situation yet. Imagine you've been away from your house, doing some errands, and now you've just come back and found your house on fire. The first thing you need to do is not to take off running through the neighborhood to find the arsonist, berate him, and bring him to justice. The first thing you need to do is deal with the burning fire in your house, so it doesn't go on to destroy everything. When anger is flashing up in you, don't give in to the urge to start speaking and acting it out. Come back to your breathing and take care of your emotions first.”

This is such a great analogy. You wouldn’t leave your burning house to catch the arsonist, so why would you immediately take out your anger on someone who has angered you? **“Come back to your breathing and take care of your emotions first.”** I am definitely going to heed this advice...I hope you will try it out, too 🙏

P.S. And, of course, this applies to any intense emotional state, not just anger 😊



1 Life-Changing Idea

Joy is a Habit (and mindful breathing gets us there)

"Dwelling happily in the present is another kind of habit—a good habit. It takes a little training to acquire a new, positive habit. While brushing your teeth, washing your hair, getting dressed, walking, driving, and so on, put your full attention into what you're doing, and find the peace and joy in that very moment. When you practice conscious breathing, you have a greater ability to recognize your habit, and every time you do, its power to pull you out of the moment diminishes. It's the beginning of your liberation, your true freedom, your real happiness."

There are really two incredible concepts in this passage.

The first is that being happy in the present is a *habit*. Framed that way, it actually becomes quite practical. It just takes practice—like building any habit.

The second is that building that "happiness habit" starts with mindful breathing. Mindful breathing is how we return to the present moment so we can dwell happily in it. And it also helps us recognize when bad habits are pulling us away from presence.

Together, the life-changing idea is to recognize that dwelling happily in the moment is a habit (like checking our phones) and to begin building that good habit with mindful breathing.

Then, with consistency, mindful breathing becomes **"the beginning of your liberation, your true freedom, your real happiness."** Sounds good to me 🙌



1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

"Meditation is offering your genuine presence to yourself in every moment. It's the capacity to recognize clearly that every moment is a gift of life, a gift from the Earth and sky."

"Breathing in, touching your full aliveness, is a spiritual practice."

"The moment you wake up, right away, you can smile. That's a smile of enlightenment. You are aware that a new day is beginning, that life is offering you twenty-four brand-new hours to live, and that that's the most precious of gifts."

One of my favorite definitions of mindfulness to date:

"Doing things with mindfulness means you perform each action with clear awareness of what's happening and of what you're doing in the present moment, and you feel happy as you do it."

"Practicing to walk and breathe mindfully helps you dwell more in the real world, so you can get in touch with the wonders of life in the present moment, and nourish and heal your body and mind."

"The absence of suffering is happiness, just as the absence of darkness is the presence of light."

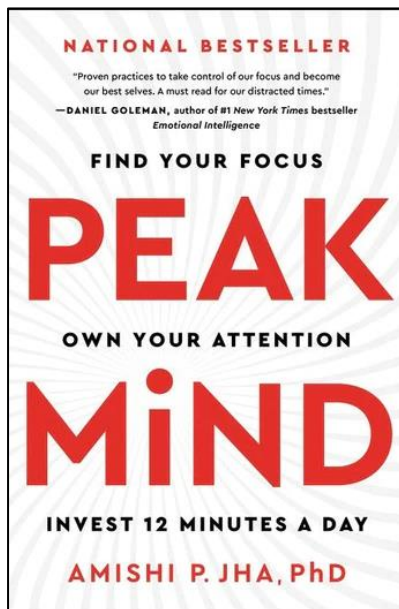
*"Earth brings us to life
and nourishes us.
Earth takes us back again.
We are born and we die with every breath."*

"Breathing and walking with awareness generates the energy of mindfulness. This energy brings our mind back to our body so that we're really here in the present moment, so we can be in touch with the wonders of life that are there inside us and around us. If we can recognize these wonders, we have happiness immediately."



BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



Peak Mind: Find Your Focus, Own Your Attention, Invest 12 Minutes a Day

BY: Amishi P. Jha, Ph.D.

411 Released: April 31, 2023

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. Attention is Everything (and yours is perfect)
2. The Only Thing That Works: Mindfulness
3. The Flashlight, Floodlight, and Juggler
4. You Actually Have to Train (but not long—the most important finding of the book)

1 Life-Changing Idea

Pre-silience: Maybe the Best Word and Concept Ever



4 Thoughts

1. Attention is Everything (and yours is perfect)

“You may be surprised to know that all of this ultimately comes down to one thing: your attention.

- **If you’re feeling that you’re in a cognitive fog: depleted attention.**
- **If you’re feeling anxious, worried, or overwhelmed by your emotions: hijacked attention.**
- **If you can’t seem to focus so you can take action or dive into urgent work: fragmented attention.**
- **If you feel out of step and detached from others: disconnected attention.”**

In other words, *attention is everything*. As Dr. Jha points out, basically any issue we’re facing, from anxiety to cognitive fog, comes back to an attentional problem.

And one of the most surprising points she makes is that our attention is actually perfect. Thus, if you’re feeling anything on that list—like you can never concentrate, are always overwhelmed, or feel detached—it’s likely because your attention is working perfectly. Wait, what!?

“I want to make one thing crystal clear: there is nothing wrong with your attention. In fact, it’s working so well, and so on cue, that computer programs can predict how it will respond. We’re in a crisis because our attention works so well. It’s doing exactly what it was designed to do: respond powerfully to certain stimuli. You can’t defeat algorithms on social media websites, the Pavlovian pull of your phone’s dings and bings, the blaring red notification bubble of your inbox, or the desire to complete one more quest so you can up-level. Yet, we aren’t helpless. We can solve this attention crisis.”

How’s that for a mind-blowing perspective shift? Everything we interpret as attentional problems is happening because our attention works so well. It’s just that our environment surrounds us with perfectly-designed ways to use our attention.

But we’re not hopeless. Let’s look at how we solve this attentional crisis: mindfulness.



P.S. Unfortunately, escaping society (my dream) isn't the answer. Dr. Jha says: **"But we don't need external stimuli to have a crisis of attention—this has always been a challenge for humans. We have records of medieval monks in the year 420 fretting that they could not keep their thoughts on God as they were supposed to...They felt overwhelmed with information, frustrated that the minute they sat down to read something, their restless minds wanted to read something else instead. ...They went so far as to cut off relationships with family and give up all their possessions—the idea being that if they had fewer earthly entanglements to think about, they'd be less distracted. Did it work? No."** Talk about disappointing...my entire life goal is now ruined 😂😂😂.

2. The Only Thing That Works: Mindfulness

"You cannot simply decide to pay attention 'better.' No matter how much I tell you about how attention works and why, and no matter how motivated you are, the way your brain pays attention cannot be fundamentally altered by sheer force of will. I don't care if you're the most disciplined person alive: it will not work. Instead, we need to train our brains to work differently. And the exciting news is: at long last, we've actually figured out how."

Dr. Jha studied a number of ways to improve attention in her lab at the University of Miami. As she points out here, sheer discipline doesn't work. Neither will a lot of brain-hack games you see advertised. The one thing that does: mindfulness.

"I'll skip to the end, to the zillion-dollar question: Did it work? Could mindfulness training protect and strengthen attention? [//] The answer was a resounding yes. In fact, mindfulness training was the only brain-training tool that consistently worked to strengthen attention across our studies."

This is great news. We've already learned that *attention is everything*. Now, we have an ancient tool in the form of mindfulness for training that attention and improving every aspect of our lives. It means that, through mindfulness, **"we can strengthen our capacity to fully experience and enjoy the moments we are in, to embark on new adventures, and to navigate life's challenges more effectively."**

Sounds good to me. Let's look at the basics of mindfulness training and how long we need to do it to get the benefits.



3. The Flashlight, Floodlight, and Juggler

Dr. Jha had an excellent analogy for our attentional systems that puts mindfulness training in perspective: the flashlight, floodlight, and juggler.

“The Flashlight Your attention can be like a flashlight. Where you point it becomes brighter, highlighted, more salient. Whatever’s not in the flashlight’s beam? That information remains suppressed—it stays dampened, dimmed, and blocked out. ... You can point that flashlight beam anywhere: outward at your external environment, or inward, to your own thoughts, memories, emotions, body sensations, and the like.”

“The Floodlight This is, in some ways, the opposite of the flashlight. Where the flashlight is narrow and focused, this subsystem, called the alerting system, is broad and open.”

“The Juggler To direct, oversee, and manage what we’re doing, moment to moment, as well as ensure that our actions are aligned with what we’re aiming to do: this is the job of the juggler. [...] The juggler’s job isn’t to do everything itself. It’s to make sure that the whole operation is fluidly ongoing. It’s to match up goals with behaviors to make sure those goals get accomplished.”

Training all three attentional systems is critical, but “finding our flashlight” is the most fundamental starting point for mindfulness training.

And, of course, this comes back to the breath: **“To find your flashlight, you’ll draw on a foundational mindfulness practice often called breath awareness.”** We point our flashlight at our breath, notice when it wanders away, and then bring it back to our breath. Simple enough.

However, this practice is actually even more potent because it simultaneously trains the floodlight and juggler, too:

“The breath awareness exercise targets all three systems of attention, because it allows you to practice focusing—as you orient attention to the breath; noticing—staying alert and monitoring ongoing mental activity to detect mind-wandering; and redirecting—executive management of cognitive processes to make sure we return and remain on-task.”

So, we focus on our breath to train our flashlight, floodlight, and juggler 🙌 And as we’re about to learn, we don’t even have to do it for that long.



4. You Actually Have to Train (but not long—the most important finding of the book)

“Imagine a moment that calls for physical strength. Say you’re about to help a friend move a piece of furniture. You approach the heavy couch, realize you’re not quite up to the task and . . . drop to the floor and begin to do push-ups in an effort to gain the strength you need.

If that sounds silly, consider that this is what so many of us do every day, constantly, when faced with cognitive challenges—instead of developing a training regimen, making it a habit, and doing a little bit each day to build up our capacities, we drop and try to eke out a “mental push-up” or two once we’re under stress or in crisis, the whole time believing that it will help and that we’ll be able to stand up and “lift that couch.” Instead, we’ll only be more depleted.”

That’s such a fantastic analogy. It gets a central theme of the book across perfectly: *We actually have to train regularly for this stuff to work.* Throughout the book, Dr. Jha likens mindfulness training to physical exercise because it’s so obvious that regular training is needed there. But for some reason, we think our brains should be able to magically focus when needed without training. It doesn’t work like that. We actually have to train. Consistently.

And the good news is that we don’t have to train too much. In fact, Dr. Jha and her students ran tons of experiments to find the minimum effective dose. Here’s what they discovered:

“The pieces were falling into place. We were homing in on a recipe that time-pressured people were actually willing to do. And, when they followed it, their attention benefited. It was, to the best of our knowledge up to that point, moving us to a practical prescription, the minimum required dosage for training your attention: Four weeks. Five days a week. Twelve minutes a day.”

Using science to arrive at practical solutions is about as good as it gets: Twelve minutes a day, five days a week, for four weeks. And if you need more motivation, here it is:

“[I]f you come away from this book with anything, I want it to be a clear sense of how important this is. We’re busy. We’re time-pressured. We are always under the gun. But twelve more minutes of work is simply not going to catch you up as much as sitting quietly, and on purpose, with your breath.”

Amen to that 🙏



1 Life-Changing Idea

Pre-silience: Maybe the Best Word and Concept Ever

"People talk a lot about resilience. What you'll learn in this book is really about what I call "pre-silience." Resilience means bouncing back from adversity. But what we want is to train our minds so that we maintain our capacities even as we are experiencing challenge."

I got a little too excited when I read this passage, saving it with "OMG lol." My mind was blown...

In any case, I just LOVE this word, pre-silience. It's perhaps the best word and concept ever:

"[I]t means that you can be in a difficult situation, fully, and know that you have the cognitive resources to get through it."

This is literally everything we're trying to do with wisdom in the Learning Center. It's not just "bouncing back better" (resilience); it's also being able to acknowledge when times are tough and moving forward anyways. In other words, developing pre-silience.

And the best part? Breathing and mindfulness practices already build this skill:

"Mindfulness practice guides us to be present through stressful, upsetting, demanding circumstances, and know that we have the mental capacities we need to handle it."

Just remember: **"It works only if you do the practice."** 🧘



1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

"Our basic definition of mindfulness was this: paying attention to present-moment experience without conceptual elaboration or emotional reactivity."

"What you focus on becomes most prominent in your present-moment reality: you feel the corresponding emotions; you view the world through that lens."

"What we've uncovered is new evidence that, with training, mindfulness can change the way the brain works by default so that our attention—that precious resource—is protected and readily available, even in the face of high stress and high demand."

"[O]ur breath is always with us. It's the most natural built-in target for our attention that we can always return to."

"Mindfulness practice as attention training allows us to notice when we are no longer in the moment we want to remember."

"It's simple: To know if you're getting grabbed by something and need to intervene, you have to be watching."

*"And attention is one of the fundamental building blocks for all social relationships: it's what shapes our moment-to-moment interactions with other people. In fact, the Latin root for the word "attention" is *attendere*, which means "to stretch toward." In this sense, attention is connection."*

"Attention, both its receptive and concentrative forms, is not only a precious brain resource—it's a currency, one of our most valuable currencies. The people in our lives notice what, where, and who we spend it on. Attention, in a lot of ways, is our highest form of love."

"We're busy. We're time-pressured. We are always under the gun. But twelve more minutes of work is simply not going to catch you up as much as sitting quietly, and on purpose, with your breath. For only a little effort and a small investment of time, you can reap an enormous reward."



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Book 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes

Relaxation Revolution: Enhancing Your Personal Health Through the Science and Genetics of Mind-Body Healing

BY: HERBERT BENSON, MD AND WILLIAM PROCTOR, JD

THE 4 THOUGHTS

1. What is the Relaxation Response and Why Is It So Powerful?
2. Phase One: Eliciting the RR (and the RR+ technique I use)
3. Phase Two: Visualization and the Power of the Mind
4. The Holistic Healing Power of the Relaxation Response

4 THOUGHTS

1. What is the Relaxation Response and Why Is It So Powerful?

"Briefly stated, the relaxation response is defined as the response that is the opposite of the 'fight-or-flight' or stress response. It is characterized by the following:

- decreased metabolism, heart rate, blood pressure, and rate of breathing;
- a decrease or "calming" in brain activity;
- an increase in attention and decision-making functions of the brain; and



- changes in gene activity that are the opposite of those associated with stress.”

That’s the relaxation response (RR) in a nutshell. *It’s the opposite of the stress response.* For our purposes, the RR is critical because it provides a framework for understanding all the benefits of slow breathing practices:

Slow breathing elicits the RR, which induces the physiological changes listed above.

What’s more, the RR also increases nitric oxide, which does many wonderful things: **“These actions include a healthful influence on the body’s antibacterial, antiviral, and stress responses. ... this release of NO can protect the body from microbes, cardiovascular disorders such as hypertension, and immune problems.”**

So, if the RR counteracts stress physiologically, mentally, and even genetically, it’s easy to understand why it’s so powerful in many health conditions (which we’ll cover more in Thought #4).

But for now, let’s look at how we can get these benefits using the two-phase approach described in the book: the Benson-Henry Protocol.

2. Phase One: Eliciting the Relaxation Response (and the RR+ technique I use)

“Your objective in Phase One is to create the distinctive physiologic and genetic conditions associated with the relaxation response. These include such anti-stress changes as a healthier metabolism, lower blood pressure, slower heart and breathing rates, an overall calming of the brain, and a sense of relaxation and well-being. When these changes occur, you can assume that the beneficial changes in gene expression are also taking place.”

Phase One of the Benson-Henry Protocol is the elicitation of the RR. There are two critical elements to this phase:

#1. A Focus Word or Phrase



“Pick a focus word, phrase, image, or short prayer for your relaxation response session. Or choose just to focus on your breathing.”

Any word or phrase with neutral or positive connotations—such as one or peace—will be fine for this purpose. ...

If possible, the word, phrase, or prayer you select should be emotionally soothing and should conform to your deepest beliefs or worldview. For example, a Christian might pick Lord Jesus; a Jew, Echod; a Hindu or Buddhist, Om; or a Muslim, Insha’Allah.”

Once you have your word or phrase, the second ingredient is letting go.

#2. A Passive “Oh Well” Attitude

This is critical. You do not want to judge yourself or have any kind of expectations for each RR session. Just let go and do it. As Dr. Benson says, **“Physiologically, ‘letting go’ breaks the connection of the body and mind with unproductive, stressful thought patterns and responses and opens the door to the relaxation response and all the healing potential that it can provide.”**

Now that you have your word/phrase and a passive attitude, here’s what to do:

1. Sit or lie down in a quiet place.
2. With each breath, silently say your focus word/phrase during exhalation. Extend the word/phrase to match the length of your exhale. For example, peace might become “peeeeeaaaccee.”
3. When thoughts intrude, say, “oh well,” and return to your word/phrase.
4. Continue for 12-15 minutes.

[Here’s a short YouTube clip](#) of Dr. Benson guiding you through this process.

P.S. A crucial aspect of the RR is that there is no one “right way” to do it. You can focus on your breath, do yoga, do Tai Chi, etc. Personally, I like combining it with slow breathing to create what I call the “relaxation response plus” (RR+).

Specifically, [I use an app](#) to pace my breathing at ~4 breaths/min with a slightly longer exhale (the exact rate will be unique for each person). This alone will trigger the RR. I add the focus word during exhalation to increase the benefits and allow deeper relaxation. I have been doing this for the first 12 minutes of my practice for several months and love it. Give it a try and see how you feel.



3. Phase Two: Visualization and the Power of the Mind

“Just as an antibiotic drug may stop an infection or surgery may eliminate a malignancy, so the mind—your mind—has the capacity to treat or even cure many of your serious physical and emotional complaints.”

Once we have spent 12-15 minutes eliciting the RR, our body is ready to harness the power of our minds. Dr. Benson provides an enormous amount of research on the power of our minds to heal our bodies. Rather than go through them all here, this statement (and the one highlighted above) summarizes it nicely:

“These well-designed scientific studies make it clear that it is at least as reasonable to believe in the healing power of the mind as it is to believe in the healing power of a given drug or surgical procedure.”

To harness the power of the mind, Phase Two of the Benson-Henry Protocol is visualization. We’re going to cover the “Why” in the 1 Life-Changing Idea, but for now, here is the “How:”

1. Sit quietly with your eyes closed.
2. Visualize what it was like when you didn’t have the disease or symptom(s) you’re currently experiencing.
3. Picture yourself engaging in a physical activity without pain/symptoms.
4. Alternatively, you can simply picture a peaceful scene (the beach, a river) where you are free of symptoms.
5. Play these images in your head for 8-10 minutes.

Putting Phase One and Two together, we see that the entire protocol takes 20-25 minutes. That’s not much to ask for, given the tremendous benefits we learned in Thought #1.

4. The Holistic Healing Power of the Relaxation Response

“A certain mind body treatment may help hypertension, depression, or insomnia. At the same time, this treatment will counter the overall physical and mental manifestations of stress through the calming of brain activity and altering hormones and gene expression. The mind body treatment performs particular, reductionistic functions on specific health



complaints and at the same time tends to the health of the entire biological system.”

This is a powerful statement on why the RR can help with basically every health condition. Because of the physiological changes listed in Thought #1, it will explicitly address many problems, like anxiety and depression, hypertension, some heart conditions, insomnia, hot flashes, and nausea.

But simultaneously, the RR will also tend **“to the health of the entire biological organism.”** So even if you don’t have a particular problem you’re trying to heal, the RR will still optimize your overall health and wellness.

And for this exact reason, you can also use the RR as a preventative measure: **“Every treatment suggested ... can be used as part of a prevention plan to head off diseases for which you feel you may be at risk, either because of your personal medical examinations or your family medical history.”**

And the absolute best part? Back to Dr. Benson: **“at the very least, this approach is safe and could make you feel better.”**

That sounds like a no-brainer to me 🙌 Here’s to using our bodies, minds, and breath to prevent, heal, and optimize all aspects of our health and well-being.

1 LIFE-CHANGING IDEA

Remembered Wellness for Visualization

“To help patients access their full potential to be healed through expectation and belief, I have developed a memory-related concept that encompasses, but also moves beyond, the healing power of the placebo effect. This concept, which I have introduced in the medical literature, is called ‘remembered wellness.’”

Remembered wellness. I love that term. And I love it more when it’s applied to visualization, as suggested for Phase Two of their protocol.

Before we get into why I love it so much, here’s Dr. Benson’s definition of remembered wellness:



“[T]his term refers to the utilization in the healing process of one or more memories of a past state of wellness. Typically, these memories can be accessed and employed for medical treatment through a process of visualization, or the use of mental images and pictures, which may be built around actual memories of being healthy, strong, and resilient.”

The part I underscored is so critical. The visualization Dr. Benson suggests isn't wishful thinking. You do not imagine you're a millionaire or magically healed. Instead, you remember a time you were healthy and vibrant, which puts your nervous system into that state:

“[R]emembered wellness is rooted in the patient's memories of good health. These recollections may arise from the patient's actual experiences of being symptom free, or they may be associated mainly with the patient's ideas of what complete good health and wellness might be like.”

So remembered wellness is how we truly utilize the power of the mind. Thus, when you practice phase-two visualization, don't use wishful thinking. Use remembered wellness. It's been life-changing for me; I hope it is for you too.

1 STACK OF MEMORABLE QUOTES

“In fact, we believe that mind body science has now reached a stage where it should be accepted as the third major treatment and prevention option, standing as an equal alongside drugs and surgery in the clinical medical pantheon.”

“You may not be able to change your genes per se, but you can use your mind to change your genetic activity. And with that altered activity, you can enhance your potential for healing and good health.”

“We now have scientific proof that the mind can heal the body. ... This means that you have the innate ability to self-heal diseases, prevent life-threatening conditions, and supplement established drug and surgical procedures with mind body techniques that can improve your physiology, biochemistry, brain functioning, and genetic activity.”

“An important lesson to take away from such differences is this: There is no single, correct approach for triggering the relaxation response or employing any other mind body technique.”



“We found that our minds and bodies, all the way down to the genetic level, are built to experience a common relaxation response state, regardless of the technique used to elicit it.”

“Your mind can actually alter your genetic activity—in ways that may significantly improve your health and heal you of a number of diseases.”

“Many ancient practices and rituals have been rejected by modern science, only to be resurrected from the grave by that same science!”

“Gradually, study after mind body study, carried out with the most careful scientific protocols, produced incontrovertible evidence that the mind can indeed influence—and heal—the body.”

“Science—the same reductionistic science that is used to evaluate various drugs and medical procedures—has proven that your mind can heal your body.”

“Another difference from the placebo effect is that remembered wellness is based on a positive, wellness-based medical model rather than on the typical disease-based model followed by most physicians and researchers.”

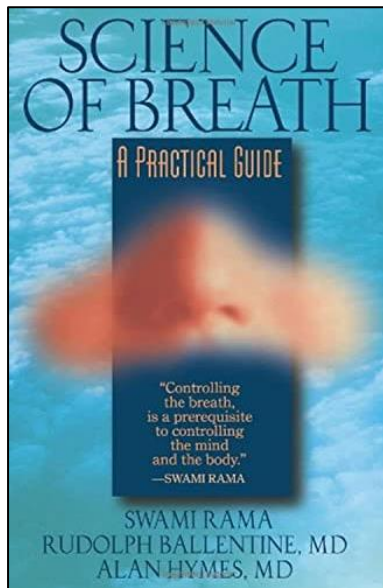
“In these ways, mind body healing can merge with—or be bolstered by—religious faith as the patient’s faith enhances the power of the patient’s expectation-belief.”

“As for you personally, you have the capacity to change your physiology, biochemistry, brain activity, and genetic expression for the better. Isn’t it time for you to invest a short period each day to capitalize on your innate and underutilized gifts of healing?”



BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



Science of Breath: A Practical Guide

BY: Swami Rama, Rudolph Ballentine MD, Alan Hymes MD

411 Released: September 8, 2023

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. Why Breathing? Energy, the Pranic Body, and Yogic Philosophy
2. "All Systems Are Voluntary": Where Yogic Philosophy Meets Modern Science
3. Picture a Cylinder, and the Mechanics of Optimal Breathing
4. Nostril Cycles & a Natural (but Sad) Neti Pot

1 Life-Changing Idea

1. Who You Are and Who You Become
-
-



4 Thoughts

1. Why Breathing? Energy, the Pranic Body, and Yogic Philosophy

The underlying theme of *Science of Breath* is understanding why breathing and pranayama are central to yogic philosophy, then showing how modern science backs up this ancient wisdom.

To understand why breathing is central to yoga, there are two critical concepts: (1) the pranic body and (2) energy. Let's start with a quick description of the pranic body:

"In the Upanishads, the pranic level is described as a second body within the physical body called the "vital sheath." The Upanishads say that it takes on the shape of the physical body. If we were able to look at one another, seeing past each other's physical body, we would perceive a subtle body instead, a body of energy."

So, we all have a subtle, pranic body through which prana (or life force) is received and distributed. Energizing and controlling this pranic body is where breathing comes in:

"Next arises the question of how this pranic body is regulated so that we might see whether there is some possibility of developing the ability to consciously control it. Many variables have an impact on the pattern of energy flow, yogis claim. ... The one function which has the most central and strategic impact on the flow, however, is that of respiration. Breathing brings in oxygen for fuel and energy exchange. Its rate and rhythm, its course and depth, all have an effect on the way the body is energized.

...

With each breath, energy flows through the body in waves, constantly shaping and restructuring the pattern of energy which comprises the pranic body."

With this knowledge, we can see why breathing is central to yoga practice and philosophy. We all have a pranic body that receives and distributes our life force, and breath control gives us access to that pranic body.

Let's next look at where modern science comes in.



2. “All Systems Are Voluntary”: Where Yogic Philosophy Meets Modern Science

“Then, by regulating the motion of the lungs, the heart and the vagus nerve are controlled. The autonomic nervous system regulates processes in our body which are not normally under our voluntary control, such as secretion by the digestive organs, the beating of the heart, and the movement of the lungs. The science of pranayama is thus intimately connected with the autonomic nervous system and brings its functions under conscious control through the functioning of the lungs.” – Swami Rama

The autonomic nervous system is where breathing, energy, and the pranic body meet modern science. The breath (or, more specifically, the movement of the lungs) gives us control of systems often thought to be involuntary.

Thus, from a scientific lens, the “Why Breathing?” question from Thought #1 is answered slightly differently. Of course, energy is still critical, but the breath’s direct tie to the nervous system is a primary reason it’s such a powerful tool for physical, mental, and spiritual health.

Thus, by controlling the breath, we gain access to “involuntary” processes via the autonomic nervous system:

As Swami Rama says, **“There is no such thing as an involuntary system if the student learns to regulate the motion of the lungs. For by doing so, a vast portion of that system is brought under his voluntary control.”**

Therefore, whether you look at it through the lens of (a) subtle energy and the pranic body or (b) lung movement and the autonomic nervous system, we see that the power of breathing can be explained and validated from both perspectives.

With its importance covered, let’s next look at optimal breathing mechanics.



3. Picture a Cylinder, and the Mechanics of Optimal Breathing

“Thinking of the chest cavity as a cylinder again, one can produce an increase in its volume, and consequently inhalation, by one of three means: extending the diaphragmatic floor of the cylinder downward, expanding the walls outward, or moving the top of the cylinder upward. These three phases will be termed diaphragmatic breathing, thoracic or chest breathing, and clavicular breathing.” – Alan Hymes, MD

I love this analogy. It makes it so easy to visualize how these three primary breathing styles all accomplish the goal of breathing (expanding the volume of the chest cavity) but in different ways. Of course, each serves a purpose, but is one method optimal? Yes:

“Of the three types of breathing mentioned, diaphragmatic breathing is physiologically the most efficient. A major portion of the blood circulating in the lungs goes to the lower portions, or gravity-dependent parts, and expansion occurs in these lower portions (although all of the lung expands to some degree). Since one of the purposes of breathing is to expose the blood in the capillaries to air, diaphragmatic breathing in the upright position is very efficient.” – Alan Hymes, MD

In addition to the improved efficiency, Dr. Hymes discusses research showing that diaphragmatic breathing can reduce blood pressure and anxiety.

Chest and clavicular breathing are less efficient, requiring more work and more breaths to get the same gas exchange (which puts more stress on the heart).

So, picture a cylinder, and as you breathe gently and deeply, visualize the bottom of that cylinder going down, improving gas exchange, lowering blood pressure, and reducing stress.

P.S. Dr. Hymes also says that when you perform the three phases in sequence, belly -- > chest -- > clavicular, it's termed the “complete yogic breath.” It's used to help you breathe at maximum capacity and stretch and utilize different areas of the lungs.



4. Nostril Cycles & a Natural (but Sad) Neti Pot

"We would be most embarrassed to admit that we didn't appreciate the difference between lifting the left arm and the right arm, but most people, when asked, cannot say which nostril they're breathing through at the moment. If it is true that the right side activates a whole set of psychological and physiological functions and the left side brings into play a different set, then it would certainly be valuable to have access to an awareness of which nostril is flowing at any given moment." – Rudolph Ballentine, MD (all below)

After covering breathing mechanics, they provide an excellent section on the nose. You know most of it by now, but one thing that really stood out was the discussion on nostril cycles.

Our nostrils have an ultradian rhythm, with one nostril periodically being more open than the other: **"The breath will be flowing predominantly through one nostril for about an hour and forty-five minutes to two hours, after which it becomes predominant in the other side, for flow increases in one side until it reaches a peak, and then it begins to decrease."**

Yogic wisdom says if your right nostril is dominant, you're more active, alert, and externally oriented. Conversely, if it's your left, you're calmer, more passive, and inner-oriented. Modern science has proven these claims to be mostly true.

But what's nice about these cycles is their practicality for understanding how you feel. For example, I've started checking first thing when I wake up, and I've discovered that my left side is open when I wake up tired. On days I wake up "ready to go," my right nostril is open. It's a neat way to incorporate more breath awareness into the day.

If you feel so inspired, try checking in on your nostril dominance periodically to see what you can learn 🙏

P.S. They had a fantastic section on neti pots, which flush the nose with warm salt water. But did you know there is a natural way to get a similar effect? It's through crying. Tears go through a duct that drains into the nose, which is why people often need a tissue when they're crying. It's even suggested that nasal washes should match the structure of tears: **"To capitalize on this fact, the nasal wash should be done with water that is of the same composition as tears. It should be exactly that salty, and it should be at body temperature."** Who knew?! So, next time you need a cry, let it out. Your breathing will thank you 😊



1 Life-Changing Idea

Who You Are and Who You Become

"Psychologists have shown that there is a correspondence between personality types and breathing patterns. Yoga science also recognizes such a correspondence, but according to yoga, the relationship between the breath and mind is reciprocal. If a certain state of mind results in a certain mode of breathing, then conversely, by consciously adopting that mode of breathing we can evoke the corresponding state of mind. If there is a correspondence between personality type and pattern of breathing, then the yogi states categorically that by changing the pattern of breathing we can transform the personality, for when the mind is disturbed, the breath is disturbed and becomes shallow, rapid, and uneven. By consciously making the breath deep, even, and regular, we will experience a noticeable release of tension and an increased sense of relaxation and tranquility." – Swami Rama

We know that breathing and emotions are reciprocal. But I had never made the personality connection. Thus, if personality types are associated with patterns of breathing, then we can fundamentally change who we are (or who we want to become) by changing our breathing. That's literally life-changing.



1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

"And the key to perfect self-mastery, these yogis maintain, is svarodaya, the science of breath."
– Linda Johnsen

"As the breath is the link between the body and mind, it can intervene in the activities of either level. With increased awareness and control of the subtle aspects of breathing, these interventions can affect deep physical and psychological changes." – John Clarke, MD

"This is an intriguing situation when we stop to think about it, for if it is true that breath influences both body and mind, then the rhythm and the rate of the breath would reflect not only one's physical condition, but would also help to create it."

"Hence it is that one can spend decades, or even a lifetime, delving into the subtleties and implications of the process of breathing."

"How much work the cardiovascular system must do, then, is directly related to how efficiently one breathes." – Alan Hymes, MD

"He who has controlled his breath and prana has also controlled his mind. He who has controlled his mind has also controlled his breath." – Swami Rama

"All techniques aimed at providing relaxation of the body, nerves, and mind will be ineffective unless chest breathing is replaced by deep, even, and steady diaphragmatic breathing." – Swami Rama

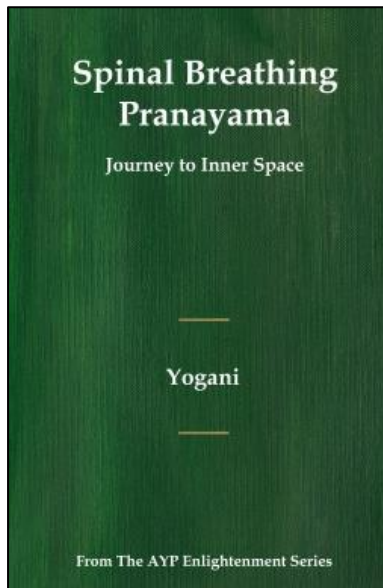
"Actually, pranayama in practice means "pause," though various authors have tried to explain it in other ways. All the breathing exercises are meant to control, eliminate, and expand that pause." – Swami Rama

"The flow of breath, then, is constantly helping to shape the pattern of energy flow that underlies and sustains the physical body. If we can grasp the significance of this, if we can understand the crucial way in which the energizing effects of the breath support the metabolic processes of different parts of the body, we can begin to understand how the physical aspects and activities of our body are created by and dependent on the process of breathing."



BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



Spinal Breathing Pranayama: Journey to Inner Space

BY: Yogani (although Yogani has written many books, his bio says: “He wishes to remain anonymous, preserving a quiet life in practices.” So, I immediately loved him, lol.)

411 Released: June 30, 2023

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. Why Do Spinal Breathing Pranayama?
2. How to Perform Spinal Breathing Pranayama
3. When, How Long, and Breath Rate for Spinal Breathing Pranayama
4. Scenery and Always Coming Back to Practice

1 Life-Changing Idea

Made Simple by Virtue of the Simplified Control



4 Thoughts

1. Why Do Spinal Breathing Pranayama?

"There are many methods of pranayama, many breathing techniques. But one stands out above all the rest. It is called spinal breathing pranayama. The reason it stands out is because of its effectiveness in stimulating and regulating prana within us in a way that covers the three primary objectives of all pranayama:

- 1. Culturing the nervous system to become a steadily improving vehicle for inner silence rising from deep meditation.**
- 2. Awakening the nervous system to a condition of permanent ecstatic conductivity.**
- 3. Increasing and balancing the flow of inner energy (prana) over the long term to facilitate a progressive and safe unfoldment of the individual toward enlightenment."**

Spinal breathing pranayama (SBP) is probably exactly what you'd expect: Breathing with a focus on the spine (it's super simple, and we'll cover how to do it in the next thought).

Yogani says it's potent because of the spine's power: **"The spinal nerve, which we are stimulating, is the central highway in the nervous system. By enlivening the spinal nerve with the combination of attention moving up and down, and the restraint of breath, we are stimulating the entire nervous system in a way that is both energizing and relaxing on a very deep level."**

Sounds good to me. And although I haven't tried to validate this approach in an ancient text, I do know that Richard Brown, MD, and Patricia Gerbarg, MD, teach a very similar method called Breath Moving: **"The Breath Moving methods...are derived from the study and practice of Japanese and Chinese martial arts, Hesychast monks, Russian fitness training, qigong, and written descriptions of Systema training."**

So, it seems like many ancient breathing techniques did something similar. With that in mind, let's look at exactly how we do spinal breathing pranayama.



2. How to Perform Spinal Breathing Pranayama

“First, we slow down our breathing in a comfortable way – no straining. We just take it to the slowest comfortable pace we can. As part of this we breathe deeper, drawing more air in and expelling more air out than we do in normal breathing. We just breathe slower and deeper, keeping comfort well in hand. No heroics are necessary.”

That’s the first step. We sit straight and slow down our breathing to a comfortable rate. Next, the spine comes in:

“Second, we imagine a tiny nerve, like a little tube the size of a thread running from our perineum all the way up to the center of our brow. The perineum is the place underneath, between the genitals and the anus – we also call it the root. The center of the brow is the point between the eyebrows – sometimes it is called the third eye. ... Between the root and the brow, the spinal nerve goes up the center of the spine to the center of the head and turns forward to the brow, like that.

What we do in spinal breathing is trace the spinal nerve with our attention as we breathe. We go up from the root to the brow on inhalation, and down from the brow to the root on exhalation. This we do over and over again for as long as we are practicing spinal breathing.”

That’s it. You just do that repeatedly, going up from root to brow during inhalation and down from the brow to the base of the spine during exhalation.

If your mind wanders, you return to this tracing: **“No strain and no fuss. Very simple, yes?”**

P.S. Listen to audio version of this 411 for my experience doing this and my take on it.

3. When, How Long, and Breath Rate for Spinal Breathing Pranayama

“The best benefits of spinal breathing will be found in keeping up a twice-daily practice session. The ideal time to do it is before the morning and evening meal. There is flexibility on this according to one’s schedule. Doing pranayama on an empty stomach is preferred. ... It is suggested to start with five minutes of spinal breathing at each sitting, followed by meditation.”



That's the when and how long: 5 minutes, twice daily (I love the practicality and flexibility of the instructions).

But what really stood out was the discussion of what breath rate should be used during the practice. I'm a HUGE fan of using apps to guide us, but Yogani made an excellent argument for letting your body set the pace. Here's what he said about breath rate:

"The time it takes will be different for each person. It can be different for the same person from day to day, depending on the course of purification occurring in the nervous system. It can even vary in a single spinal breathing session we are doing. Duration is a function of our inner neurobiological processes and our metabolism, which change as the processes of inner purification and opening are occurring. // In spinal breathing we comfortably favor slow deep breathing, whatever that is for us in the moment. That is what determines the duration."

But, of course, you can always pace yourself at your preferred rate :)

So that's it in a nutshell: Five minutes, twice daily, breathing at a slow, comfortable pace 🙏

P.S. Yogani says we can increase the duration to 10 minutes twice daily, but this should be done slowly: **"The important thing is to find a stable routine – a steady duration of our practice time that we can stick with over the long term. Upward adjustments in our practice time should be made carefully in small steps, and only after our practice has been smooth and stable for at least a few weeks. A few months is better."** <-- Amen to that.

4. Scenery and Always Coming Back to Practice

"Experiences are a by-product of our practice. We always favor our practice over the experiences. We don't try and push the experiences out. We can easily favor our spinal breathing practice with any kind of experience going on, even a glorious expansion inside. This is important."

This was one of my favorite ideas from the book.

When we have a great experience: we feel joy, we get a clear mind, we experience insightful breakthroughs, we feel just a sense of peace, whatever it might be, we don't really get too caught up in them. We simply remember that it was the practice that got us there:



“The practice of spinal breathing is what produces the results. Let’s always keep that in mind whenever we feel tempted to chase after the sirens of experience. Just easily come back to the simple procedure of spinal breathing, and all will be progressing fine.”

And this:

“The gorgeous scenery we encounter along the way is only that – scenery. We can enjoy it for a while. If we want to travel further, then we know it is our twice-daily spinal breathing that will carry us forward.”

1 Life-Changing Idea

Made Simple by Virtue of the Simplified Control

“For example, consider a car. We hardly give it a second thought when we climb into a car and drive off to an appointment. ... All we have to do is press on the gas pedal and hold the steering wheel, and away we go. Simple, yes? No, not simple at all, but it has been made simple by virtue of the simplified controls that enable us to effortlessly transform a volatile substance, gasoline, into a speedy and safe ride to our appointment.

Pranayama is like that. In fact, all effective spiritual practice is like that. We can take complex principles of transformation found in the human nervous system and, with a series of simple procedures, apply these for great spiritual benefit.”

That is so good. And it’s the perfect analogy for any breathing practice.

Breathing is the simplified lever, right? It’s the gas and the brake, allowing us to control the miraculous human body without understanding all its complicated inner workings (think of all the cardiovascular, nervous system, and muscular changes occurring with each breath we take).

However, we just have to breathe in specific patterns, and the outcomes we’re after will happen, even if we don’t understand everything happening under the hood.

I hope this inspires you to take advantage of the fact that it has all been made easy by the virtue of the simplified control, which is, of course, our breath 🙏



1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

"Breath is life. It sustains us and it is an expression of the life force within us. The fact that we are breathing is an affirmation of life. It means we want to be here. It means we want to be doing something here."

"From physiology and neurology we know that the spinal cord is the main highway of our functioning. From yoga, we know that the spinal cord is the main highway of the life force in our body."

"As the process refines, we find this remarkable development overflowing through our conduct in daily living and into our surroundings, gradually transforming us to become a channel of divine love flowing into the world."

"But none of this is the final destination of spinal breathing. We are going in so we can come back out and enjoy our inner qualities in the outside world of our everyday living. So spinal breathing is a practical technique. It is not something we do to escape. It is something we do to arrive completely in the presence of who and what we are. Then we are in a position to live life to the fullest."

"Spinal breathing, followed by deep meditation, will take us surely along the path toward inner peace, creativity, boundless energy and happiness in our daily life."

"In spinal breathing we are providing the body the opportunity to do what it would naturally like to do. As soon as we begin to force the issue we are putting an undue strain on the system which will not necessarily enhance the results."

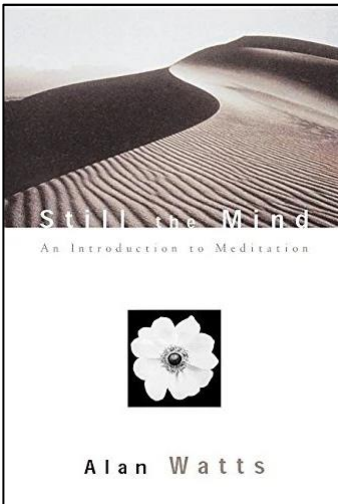
"Whatever our reason has been for starting spinal breathing, it is a good enough reason. It really does not matter why we have begun. The important thing is that we have!"

"If we commit to a twice-daily practice and give it some time to work, the benefits will be there. The beauty in this is that no matter which of the benefits we have come looking for, we will receive all of the benefits in due course – relaxation, good health and, eventually, enlightenment too."



BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes



Still the Mind: An Introduction to Meditation

BY: Alan Watts

411 Released: January 12, 2025

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. It's Okay to Be You
2. Meditation, Humor, and a Way of Being in the World
3. Breathing is the Unity of the Voluntary and Involuntary Systems
4. Meditation Instructions

1 Life-Changing Idea

1. The Universe Exploring Itself
-
-



4 Thoughts

1. It's Okay to Be You

"We wonder if we could somehow be made over so that we would not have to worry about our problems. But if you examine the desire to overcome this mess through a spiritual discipline, you will see that this wanting to overcome the mess and not to have it anymore is precisely the mess. **The thing that we object to about ourselves is precisely what we continue to do in our attempts to overcome it; in other words, the activity that we employ in overcoming the mess is the mess that we object to.** It is very important to realize this."

How's that for a head-spinning perspective? Anything we want to change about ourselves is a manifestation of that part of ourselves we want to change, ha! A philosophical tongue twister.

Watts gives this example: trying to be unselfish is actually selfish because you believe being unselfish will make you feel better. (I absolutely love philosophical arguments like this. Although somewhat pointless, they're fun to think about, lol.)

In the end, Watts says **"You are put in the position of feeling that it is absolutely necessary to be different from the way you are, but there is absolutely nothing you can do about it because being the way you are, you can't be different from your self."**

So, this is our permission slip to simply be ourselves. Whether it's in designing our breathing and meditation program, in how we live our daily life, in what we eat, and so on. We'd be wise to remember: **"you can't be different from your self."** So, we might as well enjoy it 😊



2. Meditation, Humor, and a Way of Being in the World

"What we call meditation or contemplation — for want of a better word — is really supposed to be fun. I have some difficulty in conveying this idea because most people take anything to do with religion seriously — and you must understand that I am not a serious person. **I may be sincere, but never serious, because I don't think the universe is serious.** And the trouble comes into the world largely because various beings take themselves seriously, instead of playfully."

"I may be sincere, but never serious, because I don't think the universe is serious."

That may be my new life motto.

And I love that this was said in the discussion about meditation, as it highlights a critical aspect of all contemplative practices: lightheartedness. Laughing at oneself is essential. As Watts says, **"Meditation is different from the sort of things that people are supposed to take seriously."**

So, if breathing, meditation, and mindfulness are not serious, how are we supposed to practice? Watts has some good advice here, too:

"The only way you can talk about practice in the context of meditation is to use the word practice in the same way as when somebody says that they practice medicine. That is their way of life, their vocation, and they do it nearly every day."

So, we treat our practice as just that: practice. Realizing there's no right or wrong way. We can't "be good at it" or "bad at it." We just practice; it's who we are. It reminds me of this gem from Rick Rubin, which I'll leave you with:

*"Living life as an artist is a practice.
You are either engaging in the practice or you're not."*

*It makes no sense to say you're not good at it.
It's like saying, "I'm not good at being a monk."
You are either living as a monk or you're not."*

We tend to think of the artist's work as the output.

The real work of the artist is a way of being in the world."



3. Breathing is the Unity of the Voluntary and Involuntary Systems

"Breath is a curious operation, because it can be experienced as both a voluntary doing and an involuntary happening. You can do a breathing exercise and feel that "I am breathing" in just the same way as you can feel "I am walking." Yet on the other hand, you breathe all the time when you are not thinking about it, and in that way it is involuntary. You must breathe — and so it is the faculty through which we can realize the unity of the voluntary and involuntary systems."

Here's a great reminder of the power of breath. We can control it and know that "we are breathing." But at the same time, we can study it and see that we are always "being breathed." It reminds me of what Eddie Stern said in [Healing Through Breathing](#): **"We are literally being breathed by the atmosphere all through the day, all through our lives."**

For these reasons, the breath can help us in our realization of the unity of the voluntary and involuntary systems of the body. The insight this offers is perhaps why breath awareness and breathing exercises have been used for millennia for self-realization 🙏.



4. Meditation Instructions

"Simply become aware of your breathing, without trying to do anything about it at all. Let it happen, and watch it. At the same time, let your ears hear whatever they want to hear. In other words, let them hear in the same way you are letting your lungs breathe."

That's the basic starting point: Sit and observe your breath. Let life happen.

However, he has a few other neat suggestions, which I hadn't heard before. Here's the first:

"Now beyond this, you can breathe out by letting the breath fall outward without pushing it, and as you get to the end of the out breath, let go with the same sort of feeling that you have when you let your body drop into a very comfortable bed — let it drop out and fall. Let the weight of the air do it. Don't push, drop. Then after a while, the breath will return. But don't pull it in, let it fall back in. The breath will drop in until you've had enough; then let it drop out again."

It's a good idea in this exercise to breathe in through the nostrils and out through the lips, allowing there to be a slight sensation of moving air on your lips so that you know you are breathing. Never force anything — just have the feeling of going this way and that way by virtue of weight, and of gravity."

And the second suggestion is to add sound:

"Then, if you wish, as you let the breath fall outward, you can simply float a sound on it. First, you can just do this mentally. Think of a sound that pleases you, a note that seems agreeable to your voice. As you breathe out heavily, imagine that sound to yourself, whatever sound you feel like. Now if you've got a humming sound in mind, on the next round of the out breath, hum it out loud, and keep it going. ... Don't premeditate a tune, but let it come, so that it's almost as if you were talking nonsense. Let it play gently with your voice. You are simply preoccupied with it, like easy humming to yourself."

So, in summary:

1. Notice your breathing.
 2. Let it "fall" in and out naturally; let nature do the work.
 3. Breathe in through nose and out through mouth if it's comfortable.
 4. Add a sound to the exhale. Don't premeditate it; just allow it to happen naturally.
-



1 Life-Changing Idea

The Universe Exploring Itself

"When you take a scientific point of view, your organism is inseparable from its environment, and so you really are the organism/environment. In other words, you are no less than the universe, and each one of you is the universe expressed in the particular place that you feel is here and now. **You are an aperture through which the universe is looking at itself and exploring itself.**"

We are each an aperture through which the universe explores itself. How insane and mind-blowing is that perspective?

One interesting result of this perspective is that we are never truly alone. As Watts puts it, **"When you feel that you are a lonely, put-upon, isolated little stranger confronting all this, you are under the influence of an illusory feeling, because the truth is quite the reverse. You are the whole works, all that there is, and always was, and always has been, and always will be."**

So, the life-changing idea is this: We are each an aperture through which the universe is exploring itself. As a result, we are never truly alone—we are always intimately connected to **"all that there is, and always was, and always has been, and always will be."** 🍌



1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

"We all know what reality is, but we can't describe it. Just as we all know how to beat our hearts and shape our bones, but cannot say how it is done."

"Simply watch everything going on without attempting to change it in any way, without judging it, without calling it good or bad. Just watch it. That is the essential process of meditation."

"But powerful breath is not accomplished through muscle power. It is accomplished by gravity, by weight."

"In any athletic discipline, the alignment of body and breath is critical. The synchronization of what you are doing with your breathing is the whole art."

"Watch the flow of water when it floods an area of land and you will see that it puts out fingers, and some of them stop because they come to blind alleys. But the water doesn't pursue that course; it simply finds its way around. The water never uses any effort, however, only its weight and gravity, and by following its level it finds the path of least resistance."

"Most of us would rather have money than tangible wealth, and a great occasion is somehow spoiled for us unless photographed. To read about it the next day in the newspaper is oddly more fun for us than the original event."

"One of the problems when people ask for miracles is that they never know what the miracle they ask for ultimately involves. That is why magicians and genies always grant three wishes, so that after the first two you can always use the third one to get back to where you began."



[Get This Book
on Amazon](#)

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Book 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes

Stolen Focus: Why You Can't Pay Attention— and How to Think Deeply Again

BY: JOHANN HARI

THE 4 THOUGHTS

1. Why Slowing Down Leads to Better Attention and Feels So Good
2. How to Deal with Distraction: A Method that Actually Works
3. Safety, Focus, and When “Just Breathe” is Bad Advice
4. Practice What You Preach: Tech Companies vs. Gandhi

4 THOUGHTS

1. Why Slowing Down Leads to Better Attention and Feels So Good

“But when you practice moving at a speed that is compatible with human nature—and you build that into your daily life—you begin to train your attention and focus. ‘That’s why those disciplines make you smarter. It’s not about humming or wearing orange robes.’ Slowness, he explained, nurtures attention, and speed shatters it.”

(Inset quote from Guy Claxton)



One of the experts Johann Hari interviewed for this book, Guy Claxton, has reviewed a broad range of studies on how slowing down affects our focus. He discovered that basically any kind of slow practice improves our attention—whether it’s breathing, yoga, or tai chi.

Here, we learn why he thinks they all work: when we do these practices, we move at a pace “*compatible with human nature.*”

This is one more reason why conscious breathing consistently [improves focus and cognitive function](#): Slowness nurtures attention. Speed shatters it.

P.S. Another fascinating idea Hari shares around this topic is how we consume information. As part of this book, he took an internet-less retreat to write and focus. He read traditional newspapers and books instead of digital headlines and Twitter. He concluded: *“I was—for the first time in my life—living within the limits of my attention’s resources. I was absorbing as much information as I could actually process, think about, and contemplate—and no more.”*

I think this is another reason why slowing down our breath feels so good. We are literally absorbing the optimal amount of air we can process—and no more.

2. How to Deal with Distraction: A Method that Actually Works

“I realized then that to recover from our loss of attention, it is not enough to strip out our distractions. That will just create a void. We need to strip out our distractions and to replace them with sources of flow.”

When we talk about eliminating distractions, we hear a lot of the same advice. *Put away your phone. Delete apps. Use airplane mode.* It’s your own fault; you just need more discipline.

However, Hari provides a compelling case for why these tactics don’t work for most people (of course, if you’re reading this, you’re not “most people,” lol). But one of the solutions he gives is powerful for everyone.

Instead of trying to eliminate distraction, try to create flow.



As Hari tells us, *“Seeking out flow, I learned, is far more effective than self-punishing shame.”*

How do we do this? We can simply ask ourselves a few questions when we feel distracted. What could I do right now that would be meaningful? Or, could I create meaning in the task I need to complete? Maybe I can set a time limit to make it more challenging and engaging?

Or, my favorite, we can perform a few minutes of a focusing breathing technique (I like alternate nostril breathing) to reset and recharge.

Remember: Don’t shame yourself for lack of discipline. Instead, create flow.

Related Quote: *“Don’t ask what the world needs. Ask what makes you come alive, and go do it. Because what the world needs is people who have come alive.”*
– Howard Thurman

One More: *“Let yourself be silently drawn by the strange pull of what you really love. It will not lead you astray.”* – Rumi (I found this one in the [Daily Delight newsletter](#))

3. Safety, Focus, and When “Just Breathe” is Bad Advice

“She believed she had uncovered a key truth about focus: To pay attention in normal ways, you need to feel safe. You need to be able to switch off the parts of your mind that are scanning the horizon for bears or lions or their modern equivalents, and let yourself sink down into one secure topic.”

Safety is an essential consideration for focus (and, as you’ll see in the life-changing thought, for mind wandering too).

Fortunately, almost any slow breathing technique will activate the calming parasympathetic nervous system, acting as a biological hack for feeling safe. This will set you up to focus (which is why I practice them before making these 411s).

However, there is an important caveat to this idea. Here’s how Dr. Jon Jereidini, one of the experts Hari interviewed, puts it:



“if you are in a dangerous environment, selective attention [where you focus on just one thing] is a really dumb strategy. What you need instead is to evenly spread vigilance around your environment, looking for cues for danger.”

Thus, if you’re in a stressful or dangerous environment, focusing is actually “a really dumb strategy.” Beating yourself up and telling yourself to “just breathe” would be bad advice.

Lastly, a caveat to the caveat. If the stressful environment is one you created in your head (guilty here), then slow breathing can certainly help you feel safe again and prepare you for focus.

4. Practice What You Preach: Tech Companies vs. Gandhi

“When I met with several of these tech dissidents, it struck me how young they were—like they were almost children who had invented toys and watched their toys conquer the world. Everyone was scrambling to meditate in an attempt to resist the programs they had invented. He realized ‘one of the ironies is there are these incredibly popular workshops at Facebook and Google about mindfulness—about creating the mental space to make decisions nonreactively—and they are also the biggest perpetrators of non-mindfulness in the world.’”

(inset quote from Aza Raskin)

I’ve often thought it was cool to hear that (insert any big tech company) had meditation pods or mindfulness events. How neat, right?

Well, maybe not, as this passage points out. These companies are the “*biggest perpetrators of non-mindfulness in the world.*” (I’d never thought of it like that before). It’s kind of like if tobacco companies provided their employees with resources to quit smoking, but still spent billions ensuring the rest of the population stayed addicted.

Of course, no one person or one company is perfect—we’re all just trying to do the best we can. But, as Gandhi says, “*One man cannot do right in one department of life whilst he is occupied in doing wrong in any other department. Life is one indivisible whole.*”

So here’s to trying our best to live up to our values in all domains of our lives.



1 LIFE-CHANGING IDEA

Mind-Wandering is a Superpower (and How to Do It Correctly)

"In fact, when you look back over the history of science and engineering, many great breakthroughs don't happen during periods of focus—they happen during mind-wandering."

'Creativity is not [where you create] some new thing that's emerged from your brain,' Nathan told me. 'It's a new association between two things that were already there.' Mind-wandering allows 'more extended trains of thought to unfold, which allows for more associations to be made.'"

(Inset quote from Nathan Spreng, Professor of neurology and neurosurgery at McGill University)

Mind-wandering is a real-life superpower. It's when new connections are made and when novel ideas are formed (Hari provides several excellent case studies of this, too). If we're always looking at our phones, stimulated, learning, etc., we can never fully integrate that wisdom into our own lives in our own way. We need to mind wander a little bit.

However, here is a crucial point to remember about mind wandering:

"In situations of low stress and safety, mind-wandering will be a gift, a pleasure, a creative force. In situations of high stress or danger, mind-wandering will be a torment."

I've implemented this concept by using mind wandering right after a slow breathing session, when my body feels safe and is primed for connecting ideas.

I've also added mind-wandering into the first ~10 minutes of my sauna sessions, when I just feel warm and relaxed.

How about you? How can you build mind-wandering into your life? Find a time when you are safe and relaxed, and use it to let your mind do what it does best.



1 STACK OF MEMORABLE QUOTES

"I wondered if the motto for our era should be: I tried to live, but I got distracted."

"When you are unable to pay sustained attention, you can't achieve the things you want to achieve."

"We know, at some level, that when we are not focusing, we are not using one of our greatest capacities. Starved of flow, we become stumps of ourselves, sensing somewhere what we might have been."

"Charles believes that—as he said to another interviewer—'every time we turn on a light, we are inadvertently taking a drug that affects how we will sleep.'" (Inset Quote from Charles Czeisler)

"Every day, as a direct result of his invention, the combined total of 200,000 more human lifetimes—every moment from birth to death—is now spent scrolling through a screen. These hours would otherwise have been spent on some other activity."

"I have changed the way I respond to my own sense of distraction. I used to reproach myself, and say: You're lazy. You're not good enough. What's wrong with you? I tried to shame myself into focusing harder. Now, based on what Mihaly Csikszentmihalyi taught me, instead I have a very different conversation with myself. I ask: What could you do now to get into a flow state, and access your mind's own ability to focus deeply?"

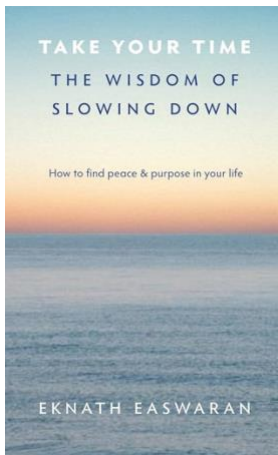
"Not everything that is faced can be changed, but nothing can be changed until it is faced." – James Baldwin

"Depth takes time. And depth takes reflection. If you have to keep up with everything and send emails all the time, there's no time to reach depth." - Sune Lehmann



BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



Take Your Time: The Wisdom of Slowing Down

BY: Eknath Easwaran

411 Released: May 19, 2024

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. The Wisdom of Slowing Down
2. How to Set a Calm, Unhurried Pace
3. The Two Primary Tools for Slowing the Mind
4. Speed Bumps and Why Worry Goes with Hurry

1 Life-Changing Idea

1. It Just Takes One Person (you)

Reading Time: 6 min 2 sec

I hope the next 90'ish breaths are the most nourishing of your day.



4 Thoughts

1. The Wisdom of Slowing Down

"It may sound paradoxical, but however tight our schedule, however many things clamor to be done, we don't need to hurry. If we can keep our mind calm and go about our business with undivided attention, we will not only accomplish more but we'll do a better job – and find ourselves more patient, more at peace."

This idea is simple but genuinely life-changing: we can be busy, but we don't need to hurry. That simple reframe can immediately bring more peace to our days.

And this is the essence of the whole book: by learning to slow down, we can cultivate more patience, peace, and attention, allowing us to accomplish more than we ever have before.

That sounds worth the endeavor to me 🙏

P.S. And if slowing down sounds like it may lead to boredom, this gem from Easwaran reminds us that it's the opposite: *"When I talk about a slower pace of life, I don't mean an idle sail far from any stirring breeze, with no adventure beckoning us. If anything is less desirable than a speeded-up life, it is a life of boredom and indifference. **When we slow down and train attention at the same time, we are naturally cultivating enthusiasm for every day.** We begin to face each task with energy and focus. This is a difficult balance to achieve – not hectic, not blasé – but it is a quality to be cultivated if we want to live at our best."*



2. How to Set a Calm, Unhurried Pace

"The easiest way to find more time is so simple that we often overlook it: get up earlier. ... This does much more than simply gain another hour or so of clock time. The pace you set first thing in the morning is likely to stay with you through the day. If you get up early and set a calm, unhurried pace, it is much easier to resist getting speeded up later on as the pressures of the day close in on you. This simple step has profound effects."

"The pace you set first thing in the morning is likely to stay with you through the day." That's so good. It means that when we do our breathing/meditation/etc. in the morning, we literally set the tone for a calmer, less hurried day. *We learn to slow down.*

And not only that, but there is something especially serene about the morning: **"In the natural rhythms of life, there is a period in the junctions between night and day, in the ebb and flow between activity and rest, when the mind grows calm. If you set aside a period of quiet time early in the morning, it puts your activities into a more peaceful perspective that will stay with you all day."**

Amazing. So, let's use this as inspiration to set aside time each morning to cultivate a more peaceful perspective that will stay with us all day 🙏



3. The Two Primary Tools for Slowing the Mind

According to Easwaran, the foundation of slowing down is learning to slow our minds. He provides two primary ways of doing this: meditation and a mantra.

For meditation, he teaches a unique form called Passage Meditation ([here's his book on it](#)), which involves memorizing an inspirational passage and mentally reciting it while sitting for 30 minutes each morning. In his words:

“The principle of meditation is simple: we are what we think. When we meditate on inspired words with profound concentration, they have the capacity to sink into our consciousness, alive with a charge of spiritual awareness. Eventually these ideals become an integral part of our personality, which means they will find constant expression in what we do, what we say, and what we think.” (*That's so good...I think our morning TB1% does this too 😊.*)

Next, there's the mantra (he also has [a book](#) or [this website](#) to help):

“The most practical and immediate tool we can use to slow down the mind is what in India is called a mantram or mantra: a name or phrase with spiritual meaning and power. All the world's great spiritual traditions recommend this practice... The mantram has immense power to slow down the speed of the mind and lift its attention from any problem that is troubling us. ... When we use a mantram, we remind ourselves of our true nature and hold before our mind's eye this highest image of ourselves.”

That sounds good to me. And Easwaran's recommendation for these practices is straightforward: **“Half an hour of meditation every morning slows down the thinking process. Then, during the day, the mantram keeps the mind from speeding up again.”**

So, if we are ready, we can adopt one (or both) of these practices to help us slow our minds and cultivate patience, allowing us to experience more peace throughout our days 🙏



4. Speed Bumps and Why Worry Goes with Hurry

"We all need the protection of a patient, unhurried, well-trained mind. If life were always pleasant, it wouldn't matter so much if our minds were speeding out of control. But life has a way of presenting us with speed bumps. If you hit a speed bump at seventy miles per hour, you are going to be in the hospital. When life puts up speed bumps, we have to be able to slow down to get over them without injury."

That's an incredibly insightful analogy, perfectly illustrating the benefit of slowing down. Let's remember that life will always throw us speed bumps—that's just part of being human. But by taking time to slow down (using any of the tools listed above), we build our resilience so that we can get over them with less injury 🙏

P.S. And one of the biggest speed bumps we face is of our own making: *Worry*. Slowing down can help here, too. As Easwaran articulates beautifully: **"Worry goes with hurry because people in a hurry don't have time to think clearly and make clear decisions, so they are always worried about results. ... If you slow down enough to think clearly and act wisely, you have no need to worry because you know you are doing your best."** <-- Amen to that.



1 Life-Changing Idea

It Just Takes One Person (you)

"Pressure is contagious, but so is good will. Just one person slowing down, one person not putting others under pressure, helps everyone else to relax too."

This is truly life-changing, not just for us, but for everyone we interact with. When we learn to slow down, we indirectly help others to slow down, too. This allows everyone else to feel more at ease. *It just takes one person*, so let's use this as inspiration to be that person for ourselves and for those we interact with 🙏

P.S. If you are naturally tense like me, this additional passage from Easwaran is helpful: **"To paraphrase the Buddha, we learn to do this by doing it. We learn to slow down by trying to slow down."** I hope the tools in the 411 will help you do just that.



1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

"Every moment is a doorway to meaning, purpose, and joy. The key is an unhurried mind."

"Everyone seems to be trying to fit more and more into the same fixed twenty-four hours. That is the paradox: we hurry faster and faster only to find we have less and less time."

"Have you noticed that when you try to fit more into a day, you're likely to go through the whole day late? Trying to squeeze more in, we only squeeze time out."

"Taking time to pause and reflect now and then is not only part of slowing down; it is one of the rewards, too. And because it adds to efficiency and effectiveness in any walk of life, it is a very good use of time."

"Even when we have a lot to do, we can avoid stress and hurry by tackling one thing at a time."

"When our attention does not retreat to the past or wander into the future, we are delivered from time into the eternal now. To rest completely in the present like this brings limitless security and infinite joy."

"Autotellers, telephones, fax machines, and computers are unquestionably useful, but they are not fundamental. The real essentials of life are compassion, kindness, good will, and forgiveness. It is qualities like these that are fundamental to living as a true human being."

"It is important to realize that we can't read everything, can't keep ourselves entertained every available moment, can't absorb or even catch all the so-called information that is offered to us every day. We have to make choices – which requires an unhurried mind."

"Patience is the very heart of love. I don't think any skill in life is more valuable. Patience is the best insurance I know against all kinds of emotional and physical problems – and it is absolutely essential for learning to slow down."



[Get This Book
on Amazon](#)

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Book 411

4 thoughts, 1 stack of memorable quotes, and 1 idea that will change your life

The Art of Impossible A Peak Performance Primer BY: STEVEN KOTLER

THE 4 THOUGHTS

1. Breathing to Boost Creativity: Quieting the Amygdala, Pessimism, and 80%
2. Do This When Life Gets Complicated: Two Hours Instead of One
3. Personality Doesn't Scale, but Breathing Does
4. How to Get Started with Breathwork

4 THOUGHTS

1. Breathing to Boost Creativity: Quieting the Amygdala, Pessimism, and 80%

“Unfortunately, to keep us safe, the amygdala is strongly biased toward negative information. We’re always hunting danger. In experiments run at the University of California, Berkeley, psychologists discovered that we take in as many as 9 bits of negative information for every positive bit that gets through.²³ Nine-to-one are lousy odds under the best of conditions—and peak performance rarely takes place under the best of conditions.”



Yet negative thinking leads to heightened stress. This crushes optimism and squelches creativity. When tuned toward the negative, we miss the novel."

Nine-to-one. Those are our odds when it comes to noticing the negative versus positive, thanks to our amygdala. Fortunately, however, when we meditate or practice slow breathing (~4-6 breaths/minute), activity in our amygdala is reduced. (It's hypothesized that this occurs through the "hyperpolarization" of neurons, which literally makes them harder to excite.)

This turns down negative thinking and turns up creativity. It's not magic; it's membrane potential :)

Perhaps this is why, after interviewing the most creative people on the planet, Tim Ferriss discovered that *"More than 80% of the interviewees have some form of daily mindfulness or meditation practice."*

These practices naturally lead to cardiorespiratory coherence, which quiets the pessimistic amygdala, allowing us to see the novelty all around us.

So how about we slow down our breath, quiet our amygdala, and cultivate a little more creativity, today.

Related Quote: *"When Video Arts asked me if I'd like to talk about creativity I said 'no problem!' No problem! Because telling people how to be creative is easy, it's only being it that's difficult."* - John Cleese

2. Do This When Life Gets Complicated: Two Hours Instead of One

"The non-negotiable part is key. When life gets complicated, these four practices are typically what we remove from our schedule, but the research shows this is the last choice we should make. When life gets complicated, lean into these practices, as they're how you get the creativity needed to untangle the complicated."

Kotler is discussing four key practices for "sustained peak performance" (which he says are gratitude, mindfulness, exercise, and sleep).

But the idea applies to anything we do for better health (like breathing).



When life gets absurdly busy, lean into these practices. As Gandhi said, “I have so much to accomplish today that I must meditate for two hours instead of one.”

3. Personality Doesn't Scale, but Breathing Does

“Personality doesn't scale. Biology, on the other hand, scales. It is the very thing designed by evolution to work for everyone. And this tells us something important about decoding the impossible: if we can get below the level of personality, beneath the squishy and often subjective psychology of peak performance, and decode the foundational neurobiology, then we unearth mechanism. Basic biological mechanism. Shaped by evolution, present in most mammals and all humans.”

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1 IDEA THAT WILL CHANGE YOUR LIFE

“As far as I can tell, the only thing more difficult than the emotional toil of pursuing true excellence is the emotional toil of not pursuing true excellence.”

This sentence amazed me. It’s scary pursuing excellence in our lives. What if we fail? What if we can’t live up to the highest version of ourselves? It’s easier to just not worry about it. But, as Kotler reminds us here, not pursuing true excellence is even harder.

It’s a lot like Abraham Maslow’s classic line, “*What a man can be, he must be.*” To live a life we’re happy with, we have to pursue the best version of ourselves.

And because breathing is literally the foundation of life, the [biological process that](#) “*makes all things possible,*” it’s the starting point for pursuing true excellence in all aspects of our lives.

All of this is to say that you should use this breathing stuff in whatever way is right for you to go out and chase your own unique definition of excellence. You don’t want to live with the emotional toil of not doing that.



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Citation

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April 18, 2022

Book 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes

The Art of Impossible A Peak Performance Primer BY: STEVEN KOTLER

THE 4 THOUGHTS

1. Breathing to Boost Creativity: Quieting the Amygdala, Pessimism, and 80%
2. Do This When Life Gets Complicated: Two Hours Instead of One
3. Personality Doesn't Scale, but Breathing Does
4. How to Get Started with Breathwork

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"Unfortunately, to keep us safe, the amygdala is strongly biased toward negative information. We're always hunting danger. In experiments run at the University of California, Berkeley, psychologists discovered that we take in as many as 9 bits of negative information for every positive bit that gets through.²³ Nine-to-one are lousy odds under the best of conditions—and peak performance rarely takes place under the best of conditions."



Yet negative thinking leads to heightened stress. This crushes optimism and squelches creativity. When tuned toward the negative, we miss the novel."

Nine-to-one. Those are our odds when it comes to noticing the negative versus positive, thanks to our amygdala. Fortunately, however, when we meditate or practice slow breathing (~4-6 breaths/minute), activity in our amygdala is reduced. (It's hypothesized that this occurs through the "hyperpolarization" of neurons, which literally makes them harder to excite.)

This turns down negative thinking and turns up creativity. It's not magic; it's membrane potential :)

Perhaps this is why, after interviewing the most creative people on the planet, Tim Ferriss discovered that *"More than 80% of the interviewees have some form of daily mindfulness or meditation practice."*

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Related Quote: *"When Video Arts asked me if I'd like to talk about creativity I said 'no problem!' No problem! Because telling people how to be creative is easy, it's only being it that's difficult."* - John Cleese

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"The non-negotiable part is key. When life gets complicated, these four practices are typically what we remove from our schedule, but the research shows this is the last choice we should make. When life gets complicated, lean into these practices, as they're how you get the creativity needed to untangle the complicated."

Kotler is discussing four key practices for "sustained peak performance" (which he says are gratitude, mindfulness, exercise, and sleep).



But the idea applies to anything we do for better health (like breathing).

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BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



The Comeback Quotient: A Get-Real Guide to Building Mental Fitness in Sport and Life

BY: Matt Fitzgerald

411 Released: September 22, 2023

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. Becoming an Ultra Realist: The Foundation of Staging a Comeback
2. Step One: Accept the Situation (the Buddha & mindfulness)
3. Step Two: Embrace the Situation (locus of control & gratitude)
4. Step Three: Address the Situation (the what, the why, the how)

1 Life-Changing Idea

1. Never Follow a Leader Who Doesn't Limp
-
-



4 Thoughts

1. Becoming an Ultra Realist: The Foundation of Staging a Comeback

“This sense of control is the essence of what it feels like to be an ultra realist. When you’ve cultivated the ability to fully accept, embrace, and address any situation, you are no longer dependent on external circumstances. While you still want things to go your way, it no longer really matters if they do or don’t. In either case, you know you’ll be able to make the best of the situation. You’re in control of the only thing you truly can control, which is your mind, and it feels like freedom.”

The foundation of making a comeback of any kind (health, fitness, etc.) is becoming what Fitzgerald calls an “ultra realist.” At their core, ultra realists can face reality head-on rather than wishing things were different. Sounds pretty anti-climactic, but it’s actually quite profound and practical.

Fitzgerald didn’t just dream this idea up in theory land, either. He studied some of the most remarkable sports comebacks and extracted principles that could be used in any arena of life.

He discovered that this concept of “ultrarealism” spanned ancient philosophers to modern endurance athletes. This begs the question: What are the characteristics of an ultrarealist, and how do we become one?

Fortunately, Fitzgerald discovered a surprisingly straightforward (but easier said than done) 3-step process for doing just that:

Step One: Accept the Situation
Step Two: Embrace the Situation
Step Three: Address the Situation

We’ll cover each of them next.



2. Step One: Accept the Situation (the Buddha & mindfulness)

“When a situation turns bad, the first opportunity an athlete is presented with is the opportunity to accept or not accept the reality of it, and it’s an opportunity you don’t want to miss. Acceptance is absolutely essential to making the best of the situation. Why? Because to accept a bad situation is to perceive it in a way that preserves your ability to make choices. But acceptance isn’t always easy. Failure to accept reality, on the other hand, is quite a bit easier.”

If being an ultrarealist is the foundation of comebacks, then acceptance is the foundation of being an ultrarealist. And although “acceptance” sounds easy, it doesn’t always work that way in real life. When we’re hit with a life-changing setback, it’s often much easier to pretend it’s not real, wish it didn’t happen, or say “why me” than fully accept the new reality.

So, to cultivate this genuine attitude of ultra-realist acceptance, Fitzgerald says there’s basically no better way than through mindfulness meditation.

As you know, mindfulness starts with focusing on our breath while cultivating an accepting and nonjudgmental attitude. With practice, we learn to apply this attitude in all of life—that is, we learn to become an ultra realist.

Of course, this is precisely why the Buddha chose this route for his practice (and ultimate enlightenment). As Fitzgerald says:

“It took some time, and there were a few missteps along the way, but in the end, through meditation, Siddhartha achieved an epiphany, and with it, inner peace. His key insight was that yearning, or wishing things were different than they are, is the root of all suffering, and that letting go of this desire is the secret to happiness.”

In other words, becoming an ultra realist.

So, step one is acceptance. It’s the most critical step. And one of the primary means of cultivating this trait is mindfulness of the breath.



3. Step Two: Embrace the Situation (locus of control & gratitude)

“Having accepted the reality of a bad situation, an athlete has the option to either give in to it or try to make the best of it. Embracing the reality of a bad situation entails committing to making the best of it.”

Now that we’ve accepted the situation, we must embrace it. Fitzgerald provides several ways to do this, but two can be tied back to our breathing practice.

The first is to find an internal locus of control—you need to believe you can stage a comeback. This is where breathing comes in. Learning to use your breath to immediately change your physical, mental, and emotional states provides this locus of control. Breathing becomes a metaphor for all aspects of your life, and it gives you the belief that you can regain control when things go wrong.

The second way to embrace a situation is gratitude. This isn’t some fairyland optimism but rather a cognitive reframe to see your situation in a new light. Fitzgerald says, **“That’s how gratitude works, transforming not reality itself but how reality is seen.”**

And that’s also how slow breathing works. It doesn’t change your situation, but by changing your nervous system and brain, it transforms how reality is seen.

And if you practice slow breathing enough, it changes the baseline state of these systems, helping you experience more gratitude throughout your day.

So, we might say to embrace your situation, embrace your breath practice, and watch your locus of control and gratitude grow with you.



4. Step Three: Address the Situation (the what, the why, the how)

“Addressing the reality of a bad situation means making the best of it. As we’ve learned, to do so you must first accept the reality (i.e., recognize it as bad in a way that preserves your ability to make choices), and then embrace it (i.e., commit to making the best of it). But accepting and embracing the reality of a bad situation are no guarantee that you will address it. Put another way, even after you’ve accepted that life has given you lemons and decided to make lemonade from them, you still have to make the damn lemonade.”

Accepting and embracing a setback are really mindset shifts. Addressing the setback is where rubber meets the road, where you make lemonade out of your lemons.

To do this, Fitzgerald provides three additional ideas: your what, your why, and your how.

Your what is your end goal. This is obvious, but you must be clear about what would make your comeback successful. Your why means getting clear on why you’re making a comeback. It’s going to be super hard. There will be many times you feel defeated and want to give up. Thus, you need a strong “why” to ensure you have the motivation to keep going. Finally, you need your how: A plan for achieving your goal.

Although not in this chapter, Fitzgerald provides two excellent tools for “the how:” Process goals and enjoyment.

Process goals mean choosing targets that you can control by showing up. Ten minutes of meditation. Twelve minutes of slow breathing. Thirty minutes of walking. And so on. You should build these into your comeback plan.

But to make these process goals easier, make sure they include enjoyment. As Fitzgerald says, **“Literally anything you can do to augment your enjoyment of training will facilitate a process focus and lead to better performance.”** This means that when you perform your process goals and carry out your “how,” you’ll be much better off focusing on things you enjoy rather than forcing yourself to do something you don’t like.



1 Life-Changing Idea

Never Follow a Leader Who Doesn't Limp

““I stopped saying, ‘Why me?’ and started saying, ‘Why not me?’” Saul told me as he continued to run. “Do you know the saying, ‘Never follow a leader who doesn’t limp?’ That’s how I see myself now. What happened to me allows me to touch people in a way I never could before.””

Saul Raisin is a cyclist who suffered a traumatic brain injury during a race. Although his comeback to cycling failed, he became a beacon of hope to other TBI sufferers.

I think about Saul’s story and the quote above often. It’s an excellent reminder that the shortcomings we sometimes try to hide are usually what make others appreciate us most 🙏

Thus, the life-changing idea is this: never follow a leader who doesn’t limp. And if you are a leader in any capacity and have some limps you’re hiding, perhaps now is the time to let them shine?



1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

"My greatest hopes for this book are (1) that it is read by athletes and nonathletes alike and (2) that every reader is able to apply the inspiration and learning they glean from it to their own life, whether it be in a sport, a relationship, a job, a health crisis, or any other circumstance where a comeback is called for."

"[T]he highest purpose of sport is not to determine winners and losers but rather to train the mind for success—a success that goes well beyond sport."

"As Emerson put it in "Self-Reliance," "It is easy in the world to live after the world's opinion; it is easy in solitude to live after our own; but the great man is he who in the midst of the crowd keeps with perfect sweetness the independence of solitude.""

"I can think of no better words to encapsulate what it means to accept the reality of a difficult situation. It will not be easy. You will suffer. But it doesn't matter."

"Step one in facing the reality of yourself is understanding yourself. After all, you can't work with what you've got until you know what you've got to work with. The ultimate goal is to become your best self, and to do this, you must first identify the parts of you that you most want to nurture."

"To become the person you want to be, you must fully acknowledge the person you are. Nurturing the parts of you that you're most glad for is important, but no less important is managing the parts you might wish didn't exist at all."

As Toni Morrison said, "The purpose of freedom is to free someone else,"

"That's ultrarealism in a nutshell. In sport and in life, reality always gets the first move, but the mind, if it so chooses, gets the last one, and if it's the right move—one that locates the small pocket of freedom that forever exists within reality's confines, no matter how tightly they press—the mind always wins. Indeed, for the ultrarealist, comebacks never fail."



[Get This Book
on Amazon](#)

Citation

Harris, R., (2011). The Confidence Gap: A Guide to Overcoming Fear and Self-Doubt (1st ed.). Trumpeter.

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Additional Note

This is one of those rare books that actually changed how I think on a daily basis. If you're interested in Acceptance and Commitment Therapy, this is an excellent place to start. 🙏

Book 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes

The Confidence Gap: A Guide to Overcoming Fear and Self-Doubt BY: RUSS HARRIS

THE 4 THOUGHTS

1. Presto, Instant Success: Breathing (And Life) Values Vs. Goals
2. How to Be Confident: The First "Right Rule" of the Game
3. How to Get Good at Anything in 4 Steps
4. Mindful Breathing is Just the Start to You Engaging Fully with Life

4 THOUGHTS

1. Presto, Instant Success: Breathing (And Life) Values Vs. Goals

"Values are 'desired qualities of ongoing action.' In other words, your values describe how you want to behave as a human being: how you want to act on an ongoing basis,

[...]

Goals are 'desired outcomes.' In other words, goals are what you want to get, complete, possess, or achieve.



Goals are not ongoing. The moment you achieve a goal, you can tick it off the list.”

This is a beautiful distinction between values and goals. And it highlights why we should focus on breathing values (nasal, quiet, deep, etc.) over goals.

Goals come and go, but values are always there. As Harris says, “*in any moment, we can act on our values—yes, even if we’ve neglected them for years. Presto, instant success!*”

Thus, anytime we act on our breathing values, no matter how long we’ve neglected them, we are instantly successful. So let’s do that, right now :).

P.S. Here is another gem on values—we can choose them anytime we’d like: “*Well, one of the beautiful things about values is we can choose them, right now, in this moment. So even if for our whole lives, up to this point in time, we have never lived by values such as persistence or self-development, we can choose to start right now. We can persist a little longer than last time, or work even a little at improving the way we do things. (Of course, you don’t have to choose these values, but if you want the benefits they can bring, then you can choose them anytime you like.)*”

P.P.S. And one more tip for pursuing your values, which is their “right rule” number 5 for the confidence game: “*Hold your values lightly, but pursue them vigorously.*”

2. How to Be Confident: The First “Right Rule” of the Game

“This is a key point. If we want to do anything with confidence—speak, paint, make love, play tennis, or socialize—then we have to do the work. We have to practice the necessary skills over and over, until they come naturally. If we don’t have adequate skills to do the things we want to do, we can’t expect to feel confident.

This insight gives us the first “right rule” of the confidence game: RULE 1: The actions of confidence come first; the feelings of confidence come later.”



If we want to feel confident with our breathing, or any other skill we're developing, we must practice it over and over. Until it comes naturally.

For breathing, we could say: The action of breathing comes first; the good feelings and self-regulation come later.

But we can also apply this concept to being consistent. There are plenty of days when I don't *feel* like doing my breathing practice (yes, even The Breathing Diabetic has days where he doesn't want to breathe 😞). But I always just start. **The action comes first; the motivation comes later.**

So, let's apply "right rule 1" in all domains of our life: action comes first; everything else comes later.

P.S. This also goes perfectly with the discussion of values above. When we act on our values, not only are we instantly successful, but our goals usually follow suit. Values come first; goals come later.

3. How to Get Good at Anything in 4 Steps

"If we want to get good at doing anything, we need to follow the four-step Confidence Cycle."

The Confidence Cycle (or how to get good at anything)

1. *Practice the skills*
2. *Apply them effectively*
3. *Assess the results*
4. *Modify as needed"*

If we want to get good at anything (which just so happens to include breathing), Russ Harris tells us we must follow the four-step Confidence Cycle.

Here they are modified for our breathing, but you can insert any skill you'd like to be more confident at:

1. Practice the skills: Consistently practice the breathing techniques that interest you. You have to practice to get good—no way around it.

2. Apply them effectively: Test them out in real life. Apply them when you're stressed at work, before a presentation, or before sleep.



3. Assess the results: Did they actually help? Did they make things worse? (I can't tell you how many times breathing didn't do anything for me, or how many times it was a life-saver. Find what works for you.)

4. Modify as needed: Make changes based on what worked well and what didn't.

Then, of course, repeat the cycle—but only for the rest of your life :)

4. Mindful Breathing is Just the Start to You Engaging Fully with Life

"Mindful Breathing is a useful practice in its own right. It allows us to take some time out from our busy daily routines, and often creates a restful state that allows us to recharge our batteries and find some inner peace. However, I'd like you to think of it as a versatile training tool to help you engage fully in every meaningful task in your life." (my emphasis)

This is the perfect way to approach not only Mindful Breathing but any type of breath practice.

We use it to find inner peace, recharge, or build resiliency in a controlled environment.

But, ultimately, our purpose in all of this is to live better, to *"engage fully in every meaningful task in your life."*

As Harris also says, when you're engaged in something meaningful, *"instead of shining the spotlight on your breath, shine it on the task that you are doing. Engage fully in the experience and let your thoughts come and go like passing cars."*

So, here's to using our breath not as the end in itself but as a tool to help us become the best version of ourselves. To help us grow in our own unique way and engage fully in whatever we have been put on this planet to do.



1 LIFE-CHANGING IDEA

No One is Perfect (and the solution)

"The fact is, no matter how good we get at mindful, values-based living—even if we become Zen masters—there will be times when we forget. We'll fall back into old habits, we'll act in self-defeating ways, and we will get hurt and suffer as a result."

"Our minds don't want to accept this. Our minds want us to become perfect, to eliminate all our "flaws" and "weaknesses." ... Perfection may exist in the world of fantasy, of superheroes, magical beings, and gods. But it doesn't exist down here on earth."

So should we give up?

No way! Although we'll never be perfect, we can keep on learning and growing until the day we die. ... In other words, we can continually develop our psychological flexibility: the ability to take effective action, guided by values, with awareness, openness, and focus."

That's about as good as it gets, folks! No one (*literally no one*) is perfect. No matter what we see on TV, Instagram, and so on, we're all imperfect humans.

And even more life-changing than that is remembering that we'll always slip up, no matter how far along the path we get. But as Harris tells us, that doesn't mean we should give up. In fact, it's even more reason to keep learning, keep improving, forever.

As someone who studies and practices this "life improvement stuff" a lot, **but still slips up even more**, this framework literally changed my outlook on life. I hope it does yours too.



1 STACK OF MEMORABLE QUOTES

"You can think of values as a compass you use them to set a direction and help you stay on track during the journey."

"The second definition is used far less commonly. In this definition, confidence is not a feeling but an action; it is 'an act of trust or reliance.'"

"For now, let's just acknowledge, one more time, that developing genuine confidence requires work. Or rather, it requires 'committed action.'"

"The practice of Mindful Breathing is thousands of years old. You can find it in religious, spiritual, and philosophical traditions as diverse as Hinduism, Judaism, Taoism, Buddhism, Christianity, Islam, yoga, tai chi, and many martial arts."

"So, Mindful Breathing is an excellent way to improve your ability to focus. And naturally, the more you practice, the better you'll get."

"One of the great things about Mindful Breathing is we can practice it anytime, anyplace."

"When you step out of your comfort zone, take a risk, or face a challenge, you will feel fear. That's not weakness; it's the natural state of affairs for normal human beings."

"Personally, I think we really shouldn't call it 'the comfort zone,' as that makes it sound like a cozy café or a health and beauty spa, rather than a place that drains our lives away."

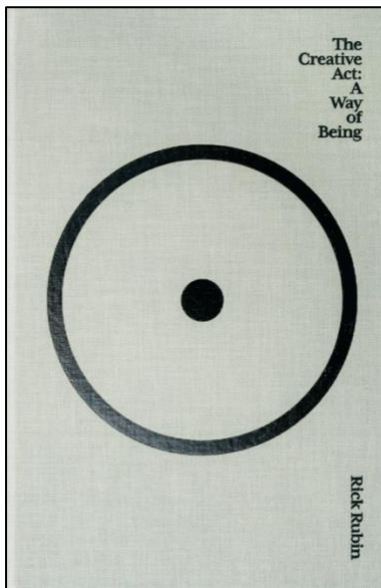
"Security is mostly a superstition. It does not exist in nature, nor do the children of men as a whole experience it. Avoiding danger is no safer in the long run than outright exposure. Life is either a daring adventure, or nothing." - Helen Keller



“To quote the writer Margaret Fontey, ‘One important thing I have learned over the years is the difference between taking one’s work seriously and taking one’s self seriously. The first is imperative, and the second is disastrous.’”

BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



The Creative Act: A Way of Being

BY: Rick Rubin

411 Released: March 24, 2024

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. We're All Creators (because we're all breathing)
2. Using Mindfulness to Cultivate Awareness and Creative Insight
3. Use Intention to Find Inner Harmony and Create an Energetic Charge
4. There is No Single Path to a Fulfilling Life

1 Life-Changing Idea

1. Japanese Pottery and Highlighting Our Imperfections

Reading Time: 5 min 33 sec

I hope the next 83'ish breaths are the most nourishing of your day.



4 Thoughts

1. We're All Creators (because we're all breathing)

"Creativity is not a rare ability. It is not difficult to access. Creativity is a fundamental aspect of being human. It's our birthright. And it's for all of us.

Creativity doesn't exclusively relate to making art. We all engage in this act on a daily basis.

...

Through the ordinary state of being, we're already creators in the most profound way, creating our experience of reality and composing the world we perceive."

This excerpt captures a central theme of the book: we're all creators simply because we're alive, creating our own experience.

I'm biased 😊, but I think we could take it a step further and say that we're all creators because we're all breathing. We literally construct our body and mind with each breath we take.

We can choose to create feelings of calm and peace, or stress and tension, by changing our breath. Or, we can simply observe our breath to observe our own creation.

So, let this memorable passage remind you that you are an artist, your "creative act" is the life you're composing, and your breath is the driving force of that ultimate creation.



2. Using Mindfulness to Cultivate Awareness and Creative Insight

"The gift of awareness allows us to notice what's going on around and inside ourselves in the present moment. And to do so without attachment or involvement. We may observe bodily sensations, passing thoughts and feelings, sounds or visual cues, smells and tastes.

Through detached noticing, awareness allows an observed flower to reveal more of itself without our intervention. This is true of all things.

Awareness is not a state you force. There is little effort involved, though persistence is key. It's something you actively allow to happen. It is a presence with, and acceptance of, what is happening in the eternal now."

All throughout the book, Rubin blends meditative wisdom with artistic philosophy. Sometimes, he explicitly talked about mindfulness and breathing; other times (like here), it's implied.

The detached awareness he's discussing above is one of the main results of practicing mindfulness. And it's critical to "The Creative Act" because it attunes us to what's going on, which helps us tap into the ideas the world is offering. Moreover, mindful awareness like this allows us to connect with our inner voice and intuition, enhancing our ability to choose projects that align with our purpose and deepest aspirations.

But most importantly, cultivating awareness is critical because it expands our world, opening up new creative opportunities. As Rubin says, **"The universe is only as large as our perception of it. When we cultivate our awareness, we are expanding the universe."**

Mindfulness creates detached awareness, expanding our universe and connecting us to our inner knowing.



3. Use Intention to Find Inner Harmony and Create an Energetic Charge

“Though the artist may have a number of goals and motivations, there is only one intention. This is the grand gesture of the work.

It is not an exercise of thought, a goal to be set, or a means of commodification. It is a truth that lives inside you. Through your living it, that truth becomes embedded in the work. If the work doesn’t represent who you are and what you’re living, how can it hold an energetic charge?

An intention is more than a conscious purpose ... It requires an alignment of all aspects of one’s self ... It’s a state of living in harmonic agreement with oneself.”

That’s. So. Good.

And it’s precisely why we should find contemplative practices that align with our whole being (not just ones we’re told we “should” do on a podcast or elsewhere).

Finding practices that **“represent who you are and what you’re living”** gives you an enormous energetic charge. When we breathe, meditate, do yoga, walk, etc., in ways that align with our soul at its deepest levels, we reach **“a state of living in harmonic agreement with oneself.”**

Which is, of course, the whole point of contemplative practice in the first place :)

Don’t do contemplative practices because you’re supposed to. Do them because they bring your soul to life.



4. There is No Single Path to a Fulfilling Life

"It may be helpful to receive advice from more experienced artists, but as information, not as prescription. It can open you to another point of view and broaden your idea of what's possible.

Established artists generally draw from their personal experience and recommend the solutions that worked for them. These tend to be specific to their journey, not yours. It's worth remembering that their way is not the way.

Your path is unique, for only you to follow. There is no single route to great art."

This is so good, and it applies to all of life. It's helpful to receive guidance and test others' techniques, but don't use them blindly. Let their wisdom open you up to another point of view.

As Rubin also says, **"Receive wisdom skillfully. Try it on for size and see how it fits. Incorporate what's useful. Let go of the rest. And no matter how credible the source, test and tune in to yourself to discover what works for you."** The same goes for breathing and meditation.

And remember this gem: **"The only practice that matters is the one you consistently do, not the practice of any other artist. Find your most generative method, apply it, and then let it go when it is no longer of use."**

Amen to that 🙏

The techniques established teachers use are specific to their journey, not yours. There is no single path to a fulfilling life.



1 Life-Changing Idea

Japanese Pottery and Highlighting Our Imperfections

"In Japanese pottery, there's an artful form of repair called kintsugi. When a piece of ceramic pottery breaks, rather than trying to restore it to its original condition, the artisan accentuates the fault by using gold to fill the crack. This beautifully draws attention to where the work was broken, creating a golden vein. Instead of the flaw diminishing the work, it becomes a focal point, an area of both physical and aesthetic strength. The scar also tells the story of the piece, chronicling its past experience.

We can apply this same technique to ourselves and embrace our imperfections. Whatever insecurities we have can be reframed as a guiding force in our creativity. They only become a hindrance when they prevent our ability to share what's closest to our heart."

That's incredible. Let us use it as a reminder that highlighting our imperfections may enhance our ability to share what's closest to our hearts.

P.S. This goes perfectly with the Life-Changing Idea from [The Comeback Quotient](#): Never Follow a Leader Who Doesn't Limp.



1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

*"It's not unusual for science
to catch up to art, eventually.
Nor is it unusual for art
to catch up to the spiritual."*

"Impatience is an argument with reality. The desire for something to be different from what we are experiencing in the here and now. A wish for time to speed up, tomorrow to come sooner, to relive yesterday, or to close your eyes then open them and find yourself in another place."

"For the lungs to draw in air, they must first be emptied. For the mind to draw inspiration, it wants space to welcome the new."

"The goal of art isn't to attain perfection. The goal is to share who we are. And how we see the world."

"The artist actively works to experience life slowly, and then to re-experience the same thing anew."

*"Any framework, method, or label
you impose on yourself
is just as likely to be a limitation
as an opening."*

"At the same time, there's no need to fear learning too much theory. It won't undermine the pure expression of your voice. If you don't let it. Having the knowledge won't hurt the work. How you use the knowledge may. You have new tools. You don't have to use them."

"The objective is not to learn to mimic greatness, but to calibrate our internal meter for greatness. So we can better make the thousands of choices that might ultimately lead to our own great work."

"It helps to realize that it's better to follow the universe than those around you."



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on Amazon](#)

Citation

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Book 411

4 thoughts, 1 stack of memorable quotes, and 1 idea that will change your life

The Happiness Track: How to Apply the Science of Happiness to Accelerate Your Success BY: EMMA SEPÄLLÄ, PH.D.

THE 4 THOUGHTS

1. Calm & Energized: How to Achieve the Ideal Physiological State
2. A Revolutionary Finding: The Two-Way Street of Breathing and Emotions
3. Compounding: The Long-Term Benefits of Breathing
4. What Does All of this Mean in Real Life?

4 THOUGHTS

1. Calm & Energized: How to Achieve the Ideal Physiological State

*“[Breathing] allows you to function at peak energy, yet without the physical and psychological costs of anxiety and adrenaline overload. In other words, being calm and energized is not only possible through the breath, but it is also the ideal state.”**

I'm a double espresso kind of person. I got through graduate school drinking 5-hour energies ☹️ But that's not a sustainable way of living.



Enter the power of breathing practices (particularly slow breathing exercises). They optimally fuel your cells with energy (oxygen) and activate the calming parasympathetic nervous system.

You feel calm yet energized: “the ideal state.”.

2. A Revolutionary Finding: The Two-Way Street of Breathing and Emotions

*“Lo and behold, the participants started to feel the emotions that corresponded to the breathing patterns. In other words, when they took deep, slow breaths, the participants felt calm. And when they took rapid, shallow breaths, they felt anxious or angry. The finding that we can change how we feel by using our breath is revolutionary.”**

We know that how we feel affects our breathing. For instance, Dr. Seppälä tells us that research shows *“When we experience anxiety, for example, we are likely to take rapid, shallow breaths. When we feel calm, we take deep, slow breaths. Laughter and sobbing are other examples of how the breath accompanies emotional states. When we come home from a long exhausting day, we slump down onto the sofa and sigh.”**

However, research now also tells us it’s a two-way street: We can change our breathing to change how we feel.

Why is this so critical? *“Given that it is so difficult to change our emotions using thoughts (for instance, talking yourself out of intense anger or anxiety), learning to use the breath is a powerful and liberating tool for handling stress so we can perform at our best.”**

Quite revolutionary, indeed.

3. Compounding – The Long-Term Benefits of Breathing

“The long-term effects of a daily breathing practice, just like those of a daily exercise routine, are even more pronounced. Preliminary studies have found that regularly practicing breathing exercises normalizes your level of cortisol, the ‘stress hormone.’ As a



*regular practice breathing can recondition your body to a state of greater calm, helping it bounce back from stress more quickly and perhaps reducing reactivity in the face of challenges. Similarly to a marathon runner who trains her body regularly as a prelude to running longer stretches, you can use daily breathing exercises to prepare your nervous system to be resilient in the face of stressful events.”**

And this is where the real power of breathing lies, in my humble opinion. Long-term practice reconditions your nervous system to its optimal state.

Imagine consistently feeling calm and energized (Thought #1). Imagine regularly using the two-way street of breathing and emotions to control your reactivity and your moods (Thought #2).

Then, ultimately, imagine watching those benefits aggregate and compound over time.

As James Clear says, *“Time magnifies the margin between success and failure. It will multiply whatever you feed it. Good habits make time your ally. Bad habits make time your enemy.”*

So, let's make optimal breathing a habit, making time our ally for our overall health and wellness.

4. What Does All of this Mean in Real Life?

*“So what does this mean for us? We can use our breath whenever we experience a stressful event. [...] It's the most accessible tool you have, and it's invisible. You can practice breathing for well-being no matter where you are without anyone noticing.”**

That's a perfect description of what all this breathing education means in real life. Of course, it won't fix everything, but it's the most accessible tool we have.

Let's use it wisely.



1 STACK OF MEMORABLE QUOTES

“So what is the fastest way to achieve well-being? It is so close to you that it can easily be overlooked. Your breath. A rapid and reliable pathway into your nervous system, dedicated to helping you regain your optimal state.”

“Expressions like “live in the moment” or “carpe diem” sound like cliches, yet science backs them up robustly.”

“Another breathing exercise that research shows help strengthen your attention is breath counting. Count each breath you take and when you reach 10, start over. While this exercise may not sound very exciting, research shows that it increases your ability to pay attention and stay in the present moment.”

“Similarly, if you can bring greater relaxation and ease into your body, your mind will naturally be at its best and have the chance to reset from the stress.”

“Even if you have an intuitive understanding that the breath can regulate the mind and emotions (you probably have told someone who is stressed to take a deep breath), you might not be fully aware of its power.”

“Breathing is something we do every day, every moment. It's arguably the single most important action of our life. It is also the most neglected one because it mostly happens on its own and below the level of our awareness.”

“Your breath is with you all the time. It's the most accessible tool you have, and it's invisible. You can practice breathing for well-being no matter where you are without anyone noticing.”

“By tapping into your natural resilience through breathing and other calming exercises that activate the rest and digest part of your nervous system, you can learn to reduce stress and accomplish more than you ever thought possible.”



1 IDEA THAT WILL CHANGE YOUR LIFE

*“Athletes put their bodies under stress at each training session and competition, but they are only as successful as the speed at which they recover physiologically. Your daily stresses may be different from those of an athlete, but the concept is the same. Your success is determined by the speed of your recovery. **By tapping into your natural resilience through breathing and other calming exercises that activate the rest and digest part of your nervous system, you can learn to reduce stress and accomplish more than you ever thought possible.**”** (my emphasis)

When we apply all of these concepts consistently, we learn to “*reduce stress and accomplish more than you ever thought possible.*” Sounds good to me 😊.



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Additional Note

I listened to this book on Audible. Therefore, the quotation might not be correct, but is my best attempt at reproducing the punctuation based on the narrator's pace, tone, and pauses.

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4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes

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3. Compounding – The Long-Term Benefits of Breathing

“The long-term effects of a daily breathing practice, just like those of a daily exercise routine, are even more pronounced. Preliminary studies have found that regularly practicing breathing exercises normalizes your level of cortisol, the ‘stress hormone.’ As a



*regular practice breathing can recondition your body to a state of greater calm, helping it bounce back from stress more quickly and perhaps reducing reactivity in the face of challenges. Similarly to a marathon runner who trains her body regularly as a prelude to running longer stretches, you can use daily breathing exercises to prepare your nervous system to be resilient in the face of stressful events.”**

And this is where the real power of breathing lies, in my humble opinion. Long-term practice reconditions your nervous system to its optimal state.

Imagine consistently feeling calm and energized (Thought #1). Imagine regularly using the two-way street of breathing and emotions to control your reactivity and your moods (Thought #2).

Then, ultimately, imagine watching those benefits aggregate and compound over time.

As James Clear says, *“Time magnifies the margin between success and failure. It will multiply whatever you feed it. Good habits make time your ally. Bad habits make time your enemy.”*

So, let's make optimal breathing a habit, making time our ally for our overall health and wellness.

4. What Does All of this Mean in Real Life?

*“So what does this mean for us? We can use our breath whenever we experience a stressful event. [...] It's the most accessible tool you have, and it's invisible. You can practice breathing for well-being no matter where you are without anyone noticing.”**

That's a perfect description of what all this breathing education means in real life. Of course, it won't fix everything, but it's the most accessible tool we have.

Let's use it wisely.



1 LIFE-CHANGING IDEA

*“Athletes put their bodies under stress at each training session and competition, but they are only as successful as the speed at which they recover physiologically. Your daily stresses may be different from those of an athlete, but the concept is the same. Your success is determined by the speed of your recovery. **By tapping into your natural resilience through breathing and other calming exercises that activate the rest and digest part of your nervous system, you can learn to reduce stress and accomplish more than you ever thought possible.**”** (my emphasis)

When we apply all of these concepts consistently, we learn to “reduce stress and accomplish more than you ever thought possible.” Sounds good to me 😊.

1 STACK OF MEMORABLE QUOTES

“So what is the fastest way to achieve well-being? It is so close to you that it can easily be overlooked. Your breath. A rapid and reliable pathway into your nervous system, dedicated to helping you regain your optimal state.”

“Expressions like “live in the moment” or “carpe diem” sound like cliches, yet science backs them up robustly.”

“Another breathing exercise that research shows help strengthen your attention is breath counting. Count each breath you take and when you reach 10, start over. While this exercise may not sound very exciting, research shows that it increases your ability to pay attention and stay in the present moment.”

“Similarly, if you can bring greater relaxation and ease into your body, your mind will naturally be at its best and have the chance to reset from the stress.”

“Even if you have an intuitive understanding that the breath can regulate the mind and emotions (you probably have told someone who is stressed to take a deep breath), you might not be fully aware of its power.”



“Breathing is something we do every day, every moment. It's arguably the single most important action of our life. It is also the most neglected one because it mostly happens on its own and below the level of our awareness.”

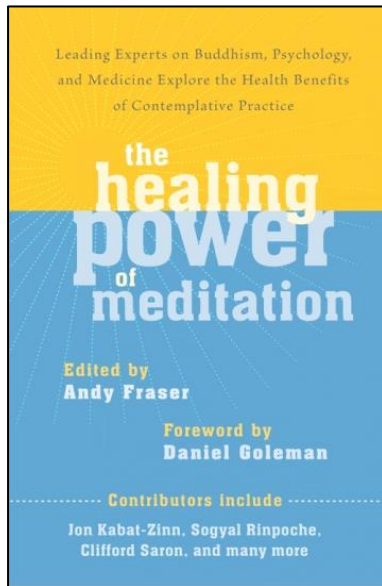
“Your breath is with you all the time. It's the most accessible tool you have, and it's invisible. You can practice breathing for well-being no matter where you are without anyone noticing.”

“By tapping into your natural resilience through breathing and other calming exercises that activate the rest and digest part of your nervous system, you can learn to reduce stress and accomplish more than you ever thought possible.”



BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



The Healing Power of Meditation: Leading Experts on Buddhism, Psychology, and Medicine Explore the Health Benefits of Contemplative Practice

Andy Fraser (editor) (NOTE: Each chapter is written by a different expert)

411 Released: June 2, 2023

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. What Meditation Is & Its Overall Goal
2. Well-Being, Telomerase, and Adaptive Functioning
3. The Emotional Benefits of Meditation
4. Brain Changes from Meditation

1 Life-Changing Idea

How to End a Breathing, Meditation, Reading, or Really Any Contemplative Practice



4 Thoughts

1. What Meditation Is & Its Overall Goal

“Broadly speaking, the many different schools of meditation share two components. The first is shamatha (sometimes, samatha), which can be translated as tranquillity, peace, or inner calm, either mental or physical. The second component of most meditation practices is vipassana (or vipashyana). In the ancient language of Pali, vipassana means penetrating insight, but we can also give it a more modern translation: mindfulness, observing things as they are, not as we would—or would not—like them to be.” - Dr. Frédéric Rosenfeld

So across all schools of meditation, two general themes emerge: tranquility and mindfulness.

Aside from these general themes, it is critical to note that **“there is no single way of meditating. Meditation should really be written in the plural, because there are so many meditations—different approaches, perspectives, and practices.” (Dr. Rosenfeld)** It is for this reason that I consider all “breathwork” to be a subset of meditation...but that’s just me 😊

(Interestingly, they note that for shamatha—which brings about tranquility—the breath is common to all spiritual traditions...but I digress...).

Regardless of the methods we use to meditate, the end goal is the same: to tame the mind. As Sogyal Rinpoche puts it, **“The mind follows past habits, anticipates the future, and in the present gets entangled and lost in whatever thoughts and emotions happen to arise. Left to its own devices, it can lead us into intense suffering. However, if we can tame or conquer our minds, then nothing can frighten or upset us. The Buddha explained that anxiety, fear, and suffering only arise in minds that are in the grip of delusion and distraction. In other words, there is nothing to fear except our own untamed mind.”**

And once we begin using meditation to tame our minds, it can lead to some pretty remarkable healing, which we’ll cover next.



2. Well-Being, Telomerase, and Adaptive Functioning

One chapter of the book described “The Shamatha Project,” one of the most extensive studies on meditation. It assessed people taking part in an extensive three-month meditation retreat. There were many interesting findings, but there were three that stood out:

1. Meditation Gradually Improved Well-being

“First, our results demonstrated that retreatants’ daily reports of mood and psychological traits are consistent with improved well-being.” – Clifford Saron, Ph.D.

This wasn’t simply because they were on a retreat. Quite the contrary, their analysis indicated that the participants were gradually learning to accept the conditions of their minds through meditation practice.

2. Meditation Increased Telomerase

“...measured telomerase levels and found that the control group had 30 percent less telomerase than the retreat group at the end of the first three-month retreat ... these telomerase levels were related to individual differences in psychological change over the course of the retreat, providing a strong link between biological changes and psychological function.” – Clifford Saron, Ph.D.

Because telomerase plays a crucial role in keeping cells alive, these results also hint at meditation’s ability to keep us young.

3. Meditation Improved Adaptive Functioning

“An increase in adaptive functioning means there has been an increase in well-being, mindfulness, empathy, and ego resiliency and a decrease in depression, anxiety, neuroticism, and difficulties in emotion regulation.” – Clifford Saron, Ph.D.

That sounds pretty amazing to me. Crucially, researchers also found that these changes were associated with changes in “response inhibition,” which measures our ability to resist immediate emotional reactions and, instead, speak and act from a grounded position.

Overall, these results indicate that meditation is indeed helping to tame the mind.



3. The Emotional Benefits of Meditation

“Thus, meditation can make a huge difference for emotions in several ways. One is this aspect of calming down, and the other is mindfulness, because it can play a role right from the very beginning in how you encounter events, in how you might typically respond to certain situations. Rather than having an automatic, quick appraisal, maybe you can slow that down and see that the situation is not threatening.” – Erika Rosenberg, Ph.D. (all below quotes too)

Because the goal of meditation is taming the mind, it is perhaps no surprise that some of the biggest benefits are for our emotional health. As stated above, it seems to help in two ways.

First, it calms us. **“If you are calm, if the mind is clear, and if you have cultivated mindfulness, you can make more choices about what you can do once this emotion has arisen.”** (This is essentially the response inhibition and adaptive functioning we learned in the last thought.)

Second, being mindful allows us to respond thoughtfully and appropriately to emotions. That is, rather than have emotions about emotions, we can slow down and distinguish real threats from trivial ones that we’ve created in our minds.

Thus, it’s not about removing negative emotions entirely; it’s about seeing our emotions calmly and clearly and acting from the right place. Stated differently, meditation gives us choice:

“If I had to say in one or two sentences what the benefits of meditation were for your whole life—for your emotional life in particular—it is that meditative practice helps introduce the element of choice. ... We cannot necessarily control what the outside world offers us, but we can control how we respond to it. That is the element of choice, and choice creates freedom.”

4. Brain Changes from Meditation

“To summarize, our research on meditators has revealed structural changes in regions of the brain that are important for emotion regulation, empathy, and self-referential processing. Furthermore, changes in stress levels correlated with changes in amygdala gray matter density. These data provide important information on how meditation works, and lend considerable evidence to the claims of meditators that practice improves their mood, their emotion regulation capacity, and, in particular, their ability to handle stressful situations.” – Sara Lazar, Ph.D. (all below quotes too)



I probably don't need to add anything to this section besides that perfect paragraph, but here are a few more neat details.

Gray matter is where neurons in the brain communicate. Lazar and colleagues discovered that, in the brains of meditators, there is more gray matter in the insula, a part of the brain **“involved in the integration of senses, emotions, and thoughts.”** That sounds pretty useful :)

Gray matter was also thicker in the prefrontal cortex. This has significant implications for aging: **“Interestingly, when we plotted each person’s cortical thickness in this region against their age, the graph suggested that meditation may help to slow down or even prevent this normal age-related decline in thickness.”** This again hints at meditation’s ability to keep us young.

Lastly, perhaps most significantly, they found that changes weren’t just occurring in long-term meditators. People who took part in an 8-week MBSR course showed decreased gray matter thickness in their amygdala (which correlated with less perceived stress) and increased gray matter in their hippocampus and insula.

Altogether, it doesn’t take long to make meaningful changes to our brains with meditation.

1 Life-Changing Idea

How to End a Breathing, Meditation, Reading, or Really Any Contemplative Practice

“[E]ven if I have been distracted, and even if I have retained just a fraction of what I have read here, is there something that has moved me, and that I would like to keep? Is there something that I would like to take with me and use to nourish myself?” – Dr. Cathy Blanc

It says **“of what I have read here”** because it was presented at the end of the chapter. But it can be: “a fraction of what I have practiced here” or “a fraction of what I contemplated here” or “a fraction of the calm mind I have” or “a fraction of the peace I obtained,” and on and on.

Then, silently wish to yourself that you can put whatever resonated with you into practice so you can bring more peace, humanity, and love to the world.



Do this right now with the information you've read here. Even if you skimmed or got distracted, is there something that moved? Can any ideas in this 411 nourish you physically, mentally, or spiritually? We'll start ending all our 411s like this 🙏

P.S. If the above passage didn't move you, here's another beautiful way to end a session: **"Now take a moment to check in with yourself. How does it feel to be like this? Does it feel natural? Is this a way you would want to continue to be in your life?"** – Rosamund Oliver

1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

"To know that the mind is the root of everything is to realize that we are ultimately responsible for both our own happiness and our own suffering. It is in our hands." – **Sogyal Rinpoche**

"Sometimes, it is true, genuinely dramatic, traumatic things happen in our lives. But a lot of the suffering that creates the physiological effects of stress that have a negative impact on our mental and physical health is just about grasping at and revisiting trivial unpleasant events." – **Erika Rosenberg, Ph.D.**

"This is actually very common in the Tibetan tradition, to welcome emotions as opportunities for transformation and growth. 'Emotions show us where to direct our attention. Rather than obscure the path, they can clarify and sharpen it.'" – **Erika Rosenberg, Ph.D.**

"We are what we think, all that we are arises with our thoughts, with our thoughts we make the world. Speak or act with a pure mind, and happiness will follow you as your shadow, unshakable." — **Buddha**

"The poet Milton summed this up in Paradise Lost:

*'The mind is its own place, and in itself
Can make a Heaven of Hell, a Hell of Heaven.'"*

"Water, if you don't stir it, will become clear;



The mind, left unaltered, will find its own natural peace, well-being, happiness, and bliss.” –
Tibetan Saying

“What is truly extraordinary is that not altering our mind brings about in us the greatest change of all.” – **Sogyal Rinpoche**

“This is a common experience for those coming to meditation and meditation practices. They begin practice looking for stress reduction, or to increase their brain size, or to bring some other tangible benefit to their life. But they start to realize that these practices do much more, that they enrich their lives in inexplicable ways and help them in ways that they didn’t even know they needed to be helped.” – **Sara Lazar, Ph.D.**

“What if learning how to inhabit silence and stillness and awareness—especially when you do so with kindness, with patience, and with self-compassion—is itself healing?” – **Jon Kabat-Zinn, Ph.D.**

“It is not even logical, but it seems that when the human mind is open, compassion is the most natural thing to arise, and I think that is a key part of what we call mindfulness training.” – **Dr. Edel Maex**

“For example, when Varela put on an EEG cap, which uses electrodes to measure electrical activity in the brain, monks from the Institute of Buddhist Dialectics in Dharamsala laughed and said, “How could we be measuring anything to do with the mind by putting a cap on the head? The mind is here!”—pointing to their hearts.” – **Clifford Saron, Ph.D.**



[Get This Book
on Amazon](#)

Citation

Brown, R. P., & Patricia, G. M. D. (2012). The Healing Power of the Breath: Simple Techniques to Reduce Stress and Anxiety, Enhance Concentration, and Balance Your Emotions (1st ed.). Shambhala.

411 Created On:
December 9, 2022

Additional Note

This book is a must-read for anyone interested in breathing—which means you :)

Free Guided Breathing

It also comes with guided breathing tracks that teach you how to perform most of the breaths they discuss. The audio is super valuable and makes it even easier to start using these exercises today:

<https://www.shambhala.com/healingpowerofthebreath/>

Book 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes

The Healing Power of the Breath: Simple Techniques to Reduce Stress and Anxiety, Enhance Concentration, and Balance Your Emotions
BY: RICHARD BROWN, MD & PATRICIA GERBARG, MD

THE 4 THOUGHTS

1. Healing and Thriving are Now Available to Everyone
2. The Three Core Breathing Practices
3. How and When to Do the Core Breathing Exercises
4. Why These Breaths Improve Our Health

4 THOUGHTS

1. Healing and Thriving are Now Available to Everyone

"Throughout history, great healers have discovered the power of breathing to enhance the physical, mental, and spiritual well-being of their people. Once secret and sacred, breath practices are now available to everyone. We invite you on a journey through our book and the Healing Power of the Breath audio program to learn simple, natural methods to become calmer, overcome stress, boost energy, focus your mind, enhance physical fitness, sleep peacefully, and feel closer to those you love."



That's how the book starts, and it's a perfect way to start this 411. The book blends ancient wisdom with modern science to provide accessible and practical ways we can use our breath to heal and thrive.

Quite literally, they make healing and thriving available to everyone.

And perhaps the best part was how they chose which breaths to include. After examining ancient wisdom and modern research along with years of real-world clinical application, they say:

“Rather than write an exhaustive book with hundreds of breath practices, we have selected a few that are easy to teach, easy to learn, safe, rapidly effective, and useful in many different aspects of life.”

Sounds perfect to me. Let's jump into the core breathing practices and see how we can use them in our lives.

2. The Three Core Breathing Practices

The three core breathing practices taught in this book are Coherent Breathing®, Resistance Breathing, and Breath Moving. Let's briefly look at each one.

1. Coherent Breathing® is taught as breathing at a rate of 5 breaths a minute with a 6-second inhale, and a 6-second exhale. Why do we do it?

“Coherent Breathing ... calms the mind, slows the heart, lowers blood pressure, reduces inflammation, and strengthens stress resilience.” <-- Sounds good.

2. Resistance Breathing is any technique that adds resistance to our breath. They have two practices for this, ujjayi (or ocean breath) and pursed-lips breathing:

“Whether you choose to make a sound in the back of your throat like the ocean or to use pursed lips to create resistance to the flow of air, your practice of Resistance Breathing can amplify the benefits of Coherent Breathing.”

3. Breath Moving: *“Breath Moving entails moving the breath in circuits to different parts of the body, moving upward on the inhale and downward on the exhale. ... [It] ... can be used to elevate energy as well as to relieve pain.”*

Total Breath: Combining all three into one practice.

“While these breath practices have traditionally been used separately, we combine them into one Total Breath practice in order to intensely activate the parasympathetic system and create the most powerful effects on the stress-response system in the shortest possible time.”



(The [free audio program](#) with the book has guided tracks for each of these breathing exercises—I found it especially helpful for Breath Moving).

And finally, if you don't want to deal with any of that, the absolute bottom line, only-sentence-you-need from this book is:

“Coherent Breathing sets the fundamental rhythm for transformation. If you use only one technique from this book, let it be Coherent Breathing.”

Alright, let's next look at why these breaths work to improve our health.

P.S. They provide several other powerful practices, including the 4-4-6-2 breath, “Ha” breathing, chanting, and light movement practices linked with the breath. Check out the book for more.

3. Why These Breaths Improve Our Health

“Of all the automatic functions of the body, only one can be easily controlled voluntarily—breathing. By voluntarily changing the rate, depth, and pattern of breathing, we can change the messages being sent from the body's respiratory system to the brain. In this way, breathing techniques provide a portal to the autonomic communication network through which we can...send specific messages to the brain using the language of the body.”

That's a perfect description of why *all breathing methods* work. But for the three core breaths, here are three reasons why they help just about everyone.

1. They reduce stress: *“One of the ways that Coherent Breathing and Resistance Breathing work is by turning off the “worry centers” of the brain. ... The tendency to calm both the intellect and the emotions may account for the rapid effects of these breath practices in reducing negative thoughts and emotions, such as excessive worry and anxiety.”*

2. They increase HRV: *“[B]reathing slowly increases HRV. Is that good? ... increasing HRV is very good, because having a higher HRV is associated with a healthier, more flexible cardiovascular system, a more balanced and resilient stress-response system, and overall greater health and longevity.”*



3. They cause brain synchronization: *“When people did breathing practices such as slow breathing with Resistance Breathing, as well as other breath forms, however, their electroencephalograms showed an increased synchrony, that is, the tendency for the peaks and valleys of the brain waves from diverse areas of the brain to line up in synchronous activity.”*

And if that isn't enough, they also show that these practices increase circulation and maximize blood flow to the extremities. Not bad for 20 minutes a day 🙌

4. How and When to Do the Core Breathing Exercises

“In learning breath practices the most important thing to remember is to relax. ... Self-judgment adds another layer of stress. The less you judge yourself, the easier it will be to relax and experience the benefits ... Try not to evaluate or judge what is happening. Just go with it.”

That's perfect advice for all their breathing practices. They also recommend sitting or lying down and keeping your eyes closed and hands still. Easy enough.

As for the length of practice, here's what they suggest:

“For healthy people who have mild to moderate stress, twenty minutes of Total Breath practice once a day is usually sufficient. However, during periods of greater stress, it helps to practice twice a day. [...] For people with anxiety or depression, we recommend twenty minutes twice a day.”

As for the time of day, here are their guidelines:

“Total Breath is best done in the morning. Because some people find Breath Moving to be activating, we recommend simple Coherent Breathing or Coherent Breathing plus Resistance Breathing at night to facilitate sleep. During the day, Coherent Breathing, Resistance Breathing, and Breath Moving can be used as often as necessary to prevent or minimize anxiety.”

But remember, if we do nothing else, **we can simply use Coherent Breathing® for 20 minutes daily.** It doesn't get any simpler or more effective than that.



1 LIFE-CHANGING IDEA

Beyond Stress: What Will You Do with the Breath?

*“Breathwork can help relieve symptoms of everyday worry, anxiety, insomnia, depression, post-traumatic stress disorder, or physical injury. It can be used alone or as a complementary treatment that fits seamlessly into any therapeutic plan without causing side effects. And beyond improving stress resilience, **breath practices can restore your sense of being genuinely who you are, of knowing what you feel, of recognizing what others feel, and of being able to experience deep and meaningful connections with people, with your values, and with all that is.**” (my bold)*

That might be one of the best excerpts I’ve read on breathing. And to me, that bold section is what’s truly life-changing: remembering that all this breathing stuff is more than just stress resiliency, brain synchrony, or HRV. It’s about restoring a sense of being genuinely who we are. Of connecting with all that is.

With that in mind, let’s end with this unbelievably powerful question:

“Now that you have learned the core breathing practices, they are yours forever. No one can take them from you. They will never run out, run down, or expire. They belong to you. So, what will you do with them?”

1 STACK OF MEMORABLE QUOTES

“The daily use of breath practices can turn back the tide of stress, counteract disease progression, and improve overall quality of life.”

“What do Mahatma Gandhi, the martial artist Bruce Lee, Buddhist meditators, Christian monks, Hawaiian kahunas, and Russian Special Forces have in common? They all used breathing to enhance their physical, mental, and spiritual well-being.”

“The presence of related ancient breath forms in so many different areas of the world suggests that their roots must go back in time, perhaps ten thousand years or more.”



"Can you focus your life-breath until you become supple as a newborn child?" - Lao Tzu, Tao Te Ching

"The breathing will seamlessly bring you back to the natural mental and emotional flexibility you had as a child, but with the direction and purpose you have as an adult."

"In the Anapanasati Sutra, an ancient Buddhist text, Buddha taught that awareness of breath was the beginning and the end of the road to enlightenment."

"All breathing should be slow and gentle without any straining."

"Once you establish an inner calm, you will transmit it naturally to others."

"Breathing practices have the power to restore a healthy balance in the stress-response system, to unlock the grip of trauma on the mind and emotions, to create the conditions necessary for healing from the many effects of trauma. As this healing occurs, we rediscover our true selves and the capacity for love and bonding that are essential to our relationships."

"Learning to dissolve anxiety by breathing slowly, smoothly, and evenly can go a long way toward improving performance in any field of endeavor."

"Even though you have read this far, you still may not fully realize that you now have the ability to change your life by using the breathing and movement practices you have learned."

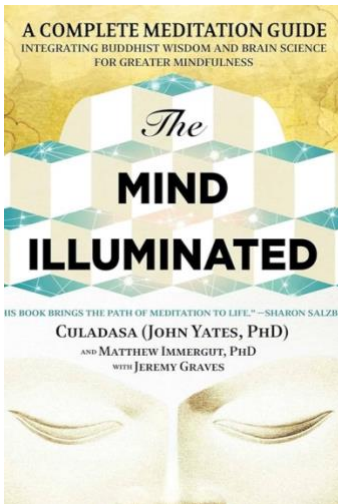
"Breath practices have changed the lives of millions of people. How they will change your life depends on the effort you put into learning and practicing some of the methods in this book as well as attending more intensive courses."

One More Time:

"Now that you have learned the core breathing practices, they are yours forever. No one can take them from you. They will never run out, run down, or expire. They belong to you. So, what will you do with them?"

BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes



The Mind Illuminated: A Complete Meditation Guide Integrating Buddhist Wisdom and Brain Science

BY: Culadasa (John Yates PhD), Matthew Immergut PhD, Jeremy Graves

411 Released: November 3, 2024

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. The Two Goals of Meditation: Stable Attention and Mindfulness
2. How to Deal with Mind Wandering: The Key to Stable Attention
3. The Magic of Mindfulness
4. Pixels and Coffee: Two Great Analogies for Attention & Mindfulness

1 Life-Changing Idea

1. The Power of Conscious Intention
-
-



4 Thoughts

1. The Two Goals of Meditation: Stable Attention and Mindfulness

"The two main objectives of meditation practice are:

- Developing stable attention.
- Cultivating powerful mindfulness that optimizes the interaction between attention and awareness."

Since this is a book about meditation, let's start with its main goals: stable attention and mindfulness. As the authors explain, **"Like two wings of a bird, both stable attention and mindfulness are needed."**

First, let's look at stable attention. This is described as **"the ability to intentionally direct and sustain the focus of attention, as well as to control the scope of attention."**

Basically, stable attention allows us to choose one object of focus and keep our attention on it. Makes sense, and this is a fundamental objective of meditation.

Next, for mindfulness. Mindfulness (a translation of the word "sati") is often interpreted as "remembering to pay attention," or similar. However, the authors make a critical distinction here: **"Even without sati, we're always paying attention to something. But with sati, we pay attention to the right things, and in a more skillful way. This is because having sati actually means that you're more fully conscious and alert than normal."** (I love that additional emphasis on "right things" 🙌.)

So, in essence, meditation helps us develop our ability to direct and sustain our attention while cultivating our ability to focus on what truly matters—the "right things."

In the next two Thoughts, we'll explore these in greater depth.



2. How to Deal with Mind Wandering: The Key to Stable Attention

"Try to keep your attention centered on the meditation object. Inevitably, your mind will get distracted and drift away. As soon as you recognize this has happened, **take a moment to appreciate the fact that you have remembered your intention to meditate, and give your mind an imaginary "pat on the back."** The tendency is to judge yourself and feel disappointed for having lost your focus, but doing so is counterproductive. Mind-wandering is natural, so it's not important that you lost your focus. Remembering and returning your focus to the meditation object is what's important. Therefore, positively reinforce such behavior by doing your best to reward the mind for remembering."

Their discussion of mind wandering was one of my favorite parts of the book. As we know, mind wandering is natural during meditation. However, what they point out is that *the act of noticing the mind wandering* is an unconscious process. They compare it to suddenly remembering you need to make a phone call—it just hits you out of nowhere.

This reframing is crucial. If noticing mind-wandering is out of our control, then how do we train it? It turns out, we do so by valuing the moment we notice it. As they explain, **"By valuing this moment, you're training the mind through positive reinforcement to wake you up more quickly in the future."**

So, for developing stable attention, we focus on a meditation object (like the breath). Then, when our mind inevitably wanders, we value and positively reinforce the moment we notice we our minds were wandering. This positive reinforcement helps train our unconscious to "wake up" more frequently to mind-wandering, and we gradually increase our ability to sustain stable attention on our meditation object.

P.S. The worst thing we can do is beat ourselves up when we notice our minds wandering. As they say, **"It's like telling your unconscious you don't want to have the mind-wandering interrupted."** That's such a good reframe. So, don't reprimand yourself when you notice your mind has wandered—give yourself credit for catching it instead.



3. The Magic of Mindfulness

"Everything we think, feel, say, or do from one moment to the next—who we are, and how we behave—all ultimately depends on the interactions between attention and awareness. Mindfulness is the optimum interaction between the two, so cultivating mindfulness can change everything we think, feel, say, and do for the better. It can completely transform who we are."

That sounds perfect 🙏. When we achieve the second goal of meditation—mindfulness—we can change everything we think, feel, say, and do for the better. The authors call this the "magic of mindfulness."

Here's how it works: **"Anytime we're truly mindful of our reactions and their consequences, it can alter the way we will react in the future. Every time we experience a similar situation, our emotional reactions will get weaker and be easier to let go of. We can respond mindfully to the actual situation rather than reacting mindlessly. As we grow less reactive, we are empowered to respond more objectively and conscientiously."** That sums it up beautifully, and I can say with confidence that this explanation has held true in my life.

Of course, we will still mess up, especially highly emotional situations (we're human, after all). But even then, not all is lost. As they explain:

"As long as we stay mindful enough, we give our unconscious processes new information, and we will be more successful in the future. With repeated effort, we will become less reactive, maybe without even realizing it. Even if we lose mindfulness completely in the heat of the moment, we can still use it afterward to reflect on what happened, our reactions, and their impact on ourself and others."

So, in short, the magic of mindfulness is that it gradually transforms us, helping us dampen the effects of emotional reactions while reconditioning our habitual responses to life's stressors. With continued practice, this helps us become the people we want to be.



4. Pixels and Coffee: Two Great Analogies for Attention & Mindfulness

First, here's an amazing analogy for sustaining attention on the breath—or any meditation object (however, I like to use coffee instead of tea ☺️):

“When you’re carrying a full cup of hot tea through a crowded room, you want to sustain your attention on the cup while remaining aware of everything else around you. That way you can avoid a collision. Similarly, keep your primary focus on the breath and simply allow all other sensations and mental events in your peripheral awareness to just be there. Let them come, let them be, let them go.”

So good. Just as we carefully carry a cup through a crowded room, meditation requires that same balance of focused attention and peripheral awareness.

Second, here's a “picture-perfect” analogy for the power of mindfulness:

“Think about a digital photograph. The vividness and clarity of the image depend on the number of pixels. Likewise, the vividness and clarity of the meditation object depend on the number of perceiving moments of attention whose content is the meditation object. If perceiving moments decrease and non-perceiving moments increase, subtle dullness is setting in and the quality of perception declines.”

Although focused specifically on meditation, this idea extends beautifully to life as a whole. The more “perceiving moments of attention” we bring to what’s happening (aka mindfulness), the more pixels we add to the image of our lives, and the clearer and more vivid they become 🍷



1 Life-Changing Idea

The Power of Conscious Intention

"The correct use of intention can also transform bad habits, undo incorrect views, and cultivate healthier perspectives. In short, skillfully applying conscious intention can completely restructure the mind and transform who we are. This is the very essence of meditation: we reprogram unconscious mental processes by repeating basic tasks over and over with a clear intention."

For me, the most life-changing idea from this book was the power of intention. It applies effortlessly to the process of meditation: **"If your intention is strong, the appropriate responses will occur, and the practice will unfold in a very natural and predictable way."** For example, if you set a strong intention to watch the breath, your actions will more easily align with this intention, allowing your meditation to flow more smoothly.

But the concept goes far beyond just meditation. For example, the authors explain, **"The stronger our intention to attend to a particular object, the more moments of attention will subsequently be focused on that object."**

Thus, when we *intend* to be good people, or *intend* to live more joyfully, or *intend* to be more caring and compassionate, then **"more moments of attention will subsequently be focused"** on cultivating these qualities, and they'll gradually become part of our character.

So, the life-changing idea is to focus on setting intentions—with our practice and life—so that our actions will more naturally align with who we want to become 🧘



1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

"Meditation is the art of fully conscious living."

"Although pain and pleasure are an inevitable part of human life, suffering and happiness are entirely optional."

"Awakening is an accident, but continued practice will make you accident-prone."

"Repeating simple tasks with a clear intention can reprogram unconscious mental processes. This can completely transform who you are as a person."

"Each moment of doing your best is a success. Let all else fall away."

"Joy seems to be the "natural" state of a unified mind, and the more unified a mind is, the more joyful it is."

"With mindfulness, life becomes richer and more satisfying. You don't take things personally."

"Avoid becoming annoyed or self-critical about mind-wandering. It doesn't matter that your mind wandered. What's important is that you realized it."

"Mindfulness allows us to recognize our options, choose our responses wisely, and take control over the direction of our lives. It also gives us the power to change our past conditioning and become the person we want to be."



[Get This Book
on Amazon](#)

Citation

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Book 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes

The Mindful Day: Practical Ways to Find Focus, Calm, and Joy from Morning to Evening

BY: LAURIE J. CAMERON

THE 4 THOUGHTS

1. What is Mindfulness and How is it Different from Meditation?
2. Breathing is the #1 Path to Mindfulness
3. The ROI for Our Daily Morning Self-Care Practice
4. Breathing is the Definition of “Presencing”

4 THOUGHTS

1. What is Mindfulness and How is it Different from Meditation?

“Mindfulness is the awareness that arises when we deliberately direct our attention toward our inner experience, toward others, and toward the environment around us. But more than just focusing your mind, it’s about your mindset—how you view the world. Mindfulness reinforces a mindset of being open, receptive, accepting, and compassionate.”



We hear the word mindfulness all the time. Here, we get an excellent definition of what it means. And I love that Cameron says it's also about our mindset.

It's not that we "practice mindfulness" and then we're done for the day. It's that, by practicing regularly, we change our outlook on life and become more "*open, receptive, accepting, and compassionate.*" Sounds pretty good to me.

And, of course, breathing is the number one way to practice mindfulness, which we'll cover in the next thought.

P.S. Before getting to breathing, Cameron also has a great passage on mindfulness vs. meditation, a sometimes-confusing topic. Here's how she clarifies the two: "*People often ask me about the difference between mindfulness and meditation. The two are distinct, yet tightly connected: You can be mindful without meditating, but the research shows that mindfulness meditation is the surefire way to becoming more mindful. Think of it like this: Meditation is to mindfulness as sports is to fitness.*" A somewhat similar analogy for us would be that meditation is to mindfulness what Wim Hof's Method is to breathwork.

2. Breathing is the #1 Path to Mindfulness

"Following your breath as you inhale and exhale is the basic mindfulness meditation practice that trains attention, cultivates awareness, settles the mind, and calms the body. The breath serves as an anchor for attention that you can use wherever you are. When your mind wanders, you return it to your anchor and strengthen your ability to direct, stabilize, and sustain your focus at will. You will learn about other anchors you can use later in the book—but remember that the breath is always available to you."

Here's the easiest way to practice mindfulness: focus on your breath. "*The breath serves as an anchor for your attention that you can use wherever you are.*"

In fact, almost every mindfulness technique Cameron discusses in the book starts with a focus on the breath.

Although it sounds easy enough, let's not forget what we learned from Larry Rosenberg in [Breath by Breath](#): "*It sounds simple, of*



course, but it's actually—as anyone knows who has tried it—a profound and difficult practice. The fact is that when we focus on the breath, we are focusing on the life force. ... To contemplate breathing is to contemplate life itself.”

So, it's definitely not easy, but it can be profound. As Cameron said, it can change how we view the world and reinforce “a mindset of being open, receptive, accepting, and compassionate.”

Sounds worth the challenge to me 🙏

3. The ROI for Our Daily Morning Self-Care Practice

“Think of mindful meditation as a smart investment of your time, offering such returns as being less reactive, less stressed, and more alert, grateful, and content. All of these will help you optimize the rest of your morning and whatever else the day brings.”

Those returns sound good (& really apply to any daily self-care practice you do).

And remember, by being less reactive, less stressed, more alert, and more grateful, everyone around you will also profit.

And although the morning is one of the best times to practice, just make sure you're consistent and build it into your routine, regardless of what time you do it.

As Cameron says, “A routine is like scaffolding for your commitments, providing structure and reinforcing the underlying mechanisms that help you stick with what you want to do versus what your impulses push and pull you into.”

So, here's to building mindful breathing practices into our routines to be less reactive, less stressed, more alert, and more grateful. Starting today.

P.S. Cameron provides all sorts of ways to bring mindfulness into your daily activities, as the book title and subtitle suggest. See the book for more. But one thing she inspired me to do is take one conscious breath before getting out of bed. After turning off my alarm, I immediately do one centering breath (in 6, hold 2, out 7). Then, I get moving. Amazing stuff 🙌



4. Breathing is the Definition of “Presencing”

“Otto Scharmer, the founder of the Presencing Institute and an MIT professor, suggests that identifying and letting go of our restricting inner voices can help us become more open and present, and thus more creative and collaborative. Scharmer uses the term “presencing”—combining “present” with “sensing”—to describe the process of coming into the moment and activating full, uninhibited awareness.”

Presencing. I love that word. And what better way to be present and sensing than with mindful breathing? It’s literally the definition of presencing.

As Rick Hanson tells us in [Neurodharma](#), “Your experience of the present moment is based on the activity of your nervous system at that moment.” And the fastest way to tune into our nervous system? Our breath.

So, by tuning into our breath, we are actively presencing. **This is good.** As Cameron says, “When you are actively “presencing,” your interior state is open-minded and receptive to new ideas, aware and sensing what is happening in the moment without bias and judgment.” That sounds like a pretty ideal state to me.

And presencing has an even greater benefit, which we’ll cover in the Life-Changing Idea next.

1 LIFE-CHANGING IDEA

How to Live Longer (regardless of your age, lifespan, or healthspan)

“Harvard researchers found that 47 percent of the time, people are thinking about something other than what they’re doing. That’s nearly half of our day.”

We’re not present about half the time. **That’s nuts.** It made me think, what’s the point of trying to live a long, healthy life if we’re not actually experiencing it?

Enter the power of the breath. As we learned above, by coming back to our breath, we learn presencing. And we instantly (and truly) live longer.



As Cameron says, *“It amounts to having a longer, richer life, because you’re present for much more of it. And we can all do this.”* <— Let’s do that 🤝

P.S. This idea made me think of a new word: Presence-span. We often focus on our lifespan and healthspan. But what we should focus on is our presence-span, which we can define as *“The part of a person’s life during which they are actually present and aware they are living.”*

1 STACK OF MEMORABLE QUOTES

“Mindfulness is life-changing. It is a superpower that allows you to deliberately direct the beam of your attention instead of being tossed around by racing thoughts and turbulent emotions; to choose your mindset; and to shift how you relate to your experience, so that you have less stress and more joy.”

“To make a deep physical path, we walk again and again. To make a deep mental path, we must think over and over the kind of thoughts we wish to dominate our lives.” - Henry David Thoreau, poet, author

“And the point is, to live everything. Live the questions now. Perhaps then, someday far in the future, you will gradually, without even noticing it, live your way into the answer.” - Rainer Maria Rilke, poet and author

“Nothing ever becomes real till it is experienced.” - John Keats, poet

“If I do not practice one day, I notice it. If I do not practice a second day, the orchestra notices it. If I do not practice a third day, the world notices it.” - Ignacy Jan Paderewski, pianist, composer

“Humans are unlike other animals—we are often thinking about anything but the present. We’re usually contemplating past events, worrying about what might happen in the future, or imagining things that may never happen at all.”



“By now you’re getting the hang of this: Begin almost any mindfulness practice by focusing on the breath, relaxing the body, and stepping into the present moment, to whatever is important right now.”

“According to research, these powerful effects of being outside are not unusual. Scientists around the world are demonstrating what philosophers, artists, and poets such as John Muir, Ansel Adams, Henry David Thoreau, and Mary Oliver have long known: Being in nature has a significant impact on your brain, physiology, and well-being.”

That quote reminded me of this excellent one from Michael J Stephen:

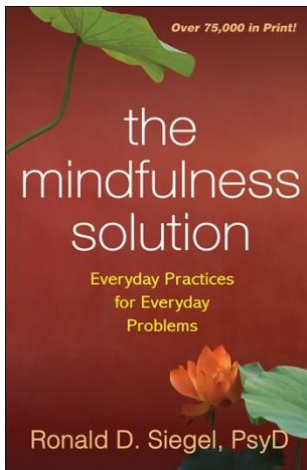
“Science is beginning to investigate in a serious manner something humanity has known for centuries—that the breath can be used to heal the body.”

“Mindfulness doesn’t mean stopping and sitting with your eyes closed in the middle of a challenging travel moment; it means having the ability to see clearly without judgment—it gives you the ability to take skillful action.”



BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



The Mindfulness Solution: Everyday Practices for Everyday Problems

BY: Ronald Siegel, Psy.D.

411 Released: June 16, 2024

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. What Mindfulness Is and Where It Came From
2. Where Pain Comes From (and how mindfulness helps)
3. The Power of Loving-Kindness Meditation
4. Mindfulness Helps Us Live Better (and cultivate a different kind of happiness)

1 Life-Changing Idea

1. A Whole New Personality?

Reading Time: 5 min 41 sec

I hope the next 85'ish breaths are the most nourishing of your day.



4 Thoughts

1. What Mindfulness Is and Where It Came From

"In some regards, things haven't changed much over the last 40,000 years. Our brains—marvelous as they are—continue to give us trouble. Fortunately, though, some of the same abilities that helped our ancestors survive have also enabled us to develop effective practices to deal with our troublesome brains and enhance our happiness. ...

Mindfulness is one of these practices. It developed through thousands of years of cultural evolution as an antidote to the natural habits of our hearts and minds that make life much more difficult than it needs to be."

I've read many books on mindfulness, but this is the first time I've seen it presented as a cultural evolutionary **"antidote to the natural habits of our hearts and minds that make life much more difficult than it needs to be."** That's so good.

In other words, mindfulness is an evolutionary adaptation to offset other evolutionary adaptations we developed for survival (like being biased toward negative information) that make life more complicated than it needs to be 🤖

So, what exactly is mindfulness, then? Siegel simplifies it, saying, **"The working definition of mindfulness that my colleagues and I find most helpful is *awareness of present experience with acceptance.*"** It's a simple idea, but of course, it's harder than it sounds.

However, it's worth the challenge because every time we embody this aware and accepting state, we take a small evolutionary step toward a more present and grateful society 🙏



2. Where Pain Comes From (and how mindfulness helps)

"Some pain and illness is unavoidable, and some can be prevented with thought and care. A remarkable amount of pain and illness, however, is actually caused by our attempts to get rid of it. Like the psychological difficulties we've been discussing, a lot of physical disorders result unwittingly from our efforts to avoid unpleasant experience... Stress—our reaction to things we don't like—is at the heart of all of these problems."

That's a humbling reminder that, because pain is part of life, we often cause ourselves more pain by thinking we shouldn't have any. Thus, our resistance to pain creates the suffering, not the pain itself. Siegel provides a handy equation to show how it works:

$$\textit{"Suffering = Pain x Resistance"}$$

This symbolic relationship means:

- If our resistance is zero, we won't suffer from pain.
- If our resistance is high, we'll suffer a lot from pain.
- Same pain, different outcome.

Of course, it's unrealistic to completely eliminate resistance (we're only human, after all 😊). But this equation highlights the potential usefulness of mindfulness: **"By bringing our attention back to the pain sensations in the present, our future-oriented anxiety is reduced. Furthermore, by cultivating acceptance of the pain sensations, we don't amplify them with resistance."** Thus, both of these aspects of mindfulness reduce suffering.

So, awareness + acceptance = mindfulness = less resistance = less suffering. Sounds like a win-win to me 🙏



3. The Power of Loving-Kindness Meditation

“An ancient approach to working with our harsh or judgmental tendencies is loving-kindness meditation. It can take many forms, all designed to soften our hearts and help us be more accepting of ourselves and others, to develop what has been called ‘affectionate awareness.’ Ancient meditation texts describe compassion and mindfulness as two wings of a bird—emphasizing that we need an open heart to have open eyes.”

“We need an open heart to have open eyes.” That’s so good. And Siegel says loving-kindness helps open our hearts by **“strengthening the intention to be accepting and compassionate—it does not paper over our real feelings of the moment with false positive sentiments.”**

That is a critical aspect of loving-kindness. It’s not about creating fake feelings; it’s about strengthening our *intention* to be accepting and compassionate, which, over time, will help us do just that.

Moreover, loving-kindness also supports our ability to practice mindfulness. When we practice mindfulness (*“awareness of present experience with acceptance”*), we often find ourselves judging our thoughts or getting caught up in our racing minds. In this regard, loving-kindness helps us be more caring toward ourselves, enhancing our ability to accept the present moment.

Thus, altogether, loving-kindness (1) supports mindfulness and (2) strengthens our capacity to show compassion toward ourselves and those we encounter.

If you want to try it, you can check out the guided loving-kindness session on [the practice page](#)





4. Mindfulness Helps Us Live Better (and cultivate a different kind of happiness)

“When we pay close attention to our experience, we notice that harmful behavior creates waves of disturbance in the mind. It’s difficult to have a peaceful meditation session after a long day of lying and stealing...So through mindfulness, we make healthier, wiser decisions (and minimize the pain of doing the opposite) because we’re more sensitive to the subtle effects of those decisions.

We start noticing that certain mental states tend to follow certain actions, which naturally leads us to more ethical and skillful behavior.”

In my opinion, that is the whole purpose of mindfulness and everything we do in the Learning Center: to **“start noticing that certain mental states tend to follow certain actions, which naturally leads us to more ethical and skillful behavior.”**

Here’s to doing a little more of that today (and forever) 🙏

P.S. This also leads to a different kind of happiness, as Siegel says: **“Modern scientific research is lining up nicely with ancient wisdom to point the way to a rich and meaningful life. It is reinforcing what mindfulness practice has long revealed: savoring our experience, appreciating and embracing our place in the amazing ever-changing world, sensing our interconnection with other people, animals, and the rest of nature, and engaging our talents fully for the good of all fosters a kind of happiness that isn’t dependent on fickle fortunes.”**



1 Life-Changing Idea

A Whole New Personality?

"In my early days of practice I hoped that it would give me a whole new personality. I've discovered that instead mindfulness practice has actually helped me enjoy the one I have while giving me effective tools to work with life's inevitable challenges."

I love that. It's what separates contemplative practices from all other "self-improvement" tactics. Instead of promising to "transform us" into someone else, these practices help us become more of who we already are—to enjoy the personality we already have.

It brings to mind this gem from Rick Hanson, Ph.D.: **"Paradoxically, it takes time to become what we already are."**

And this one from Miles Davis: **"Sometimes you have to play a long time to be able to play like yourself."**

So rather than trying to become someone else, here's to using our practice to cultivate more of our own true nature and enjoy who we already are 🙏



1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

"Research and clinical practice are beginning to demonstrate what ancient cultures have long proclaimed—that mindfulness provides insight into what causes our distress and offers effective ways to alleviate it. Lucky for us, it is a skill that can be learned by almost everyone."

"As my colleague Metta McGarvey puts it, 'Mindfulness is singletasking.' It means being wholeheartedly present in our lives."

"Because mindfulness practices help us embrace our experience in the present moment, they can help with most everything that ails us."

"A great Zen master renowned for his wisdom was once asked, 'What's the most remarkable thing you've learned in all of your years of meditation and study?' He answered, 'The most remarkable thing is that we're all going to die but we live each day as though it weren't so.'"

"We usually try to feel better by decreasing the intensity of painful experiences; in mindfulness practice, we work instead to increase our capacity to bear them."

"As long as our basic needs are met, much of our well-being or misery has more to do with how we interpret our situation than with the situation itself."

"It's important not to become too attached to health or to blame ourselves when such an illness strikes. Some people assume after learning about the role that the mind and behavior can play in illness that every malady is somehow "my fault." I like to remind my patients what happened to all the great ancient meditation masters. No matter how wise, skillful, or compassionate they were, their bodies all fell apart in the end."

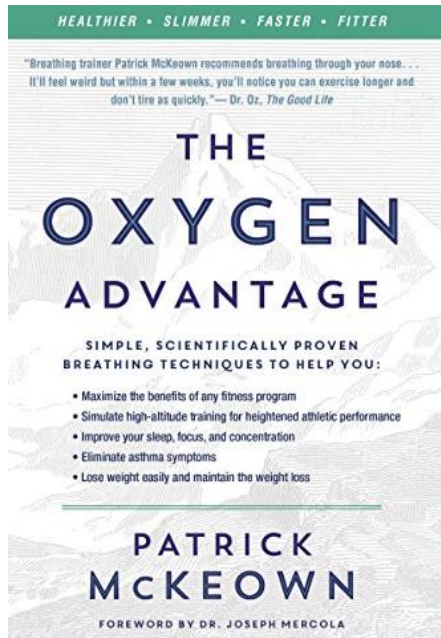
"If you don't want to die, don't be born." — Larry Rosenberg

"At this very moment billions of oxygen atoms are changing identity from being 'the air' to being 'you.'"



BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



The Oxygen Advantage: The Simple, Scientifically Proven Breathing Techniques for a Healthier, Slimmer, Faster, and Fitter You

BY: PATRICK MCKEOWN

411 Released: March 10, 2023

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. An Abundance of Overbreathing
2. How to Assess Overbreathing: The BOLT Score
3. How to Fix Overbreathing: The Nose and Breathe Light to Breathe Right
4. Improve Performance with the Simulation of High Altitude

1 Life-Changing Idea

The Power of Carbon Dioxide: Oxygen and the Bohr Effect



4 Thoughts

1. An Abundance of Overbreathing

“Just as we have an optimal quantity of water and food to consume each day, we also have an optimal quantity of air to breathe. And just as eating too much can be damaging to our health, so can overbreathing.”

This was the most essential and actionable idea presented in the book: Most of us are chronic overbreathers and need to reduce our breathing volume to achieve optimal health.

And even if we think our breathing is fine (which was the case for me over 5 years ago when I discovered the Oxygen Advantage® [OA]), we may be overbreathing unknowingly:

“Chronic hyperventilation or overbreathing simply means the habit of breathing a volume of air greater than that which your body requires. It does not necessarily manifest as dramatic symptoms, such as the panting a person might experience during a panic attack.”

Thus, it may simply present itself as excessive sighing or yawning, habitual mouth breathing, or as breathing mainly through the upper chest.

Although this might seem insignificant, Patrick tells us that over time, this bad habit can cause or exacerbate a variety of health conditions:

“Chronic overbreathing leads to loss of health, poor fitness, and compromised performance and also contributes to many ailments including anxiety, asthma, fatigue, insomnia, heart problems, and even obesity.”

That sounds pretty crazy for something as seemingly minor as breathing. But it's not:

“It may seem strange that such a disparate range of complaints can be caused by or worsened by overbreathing, but the breath of life influences literally every aspect of our health.”

So, the number one thing we need to address for optimal health is overbreathing. But before we get to how we do that, let's look at a simple tool for diagnosing it: the BOLT score.



2. How to Assess Overbreathing: The BOLT Score

“As far back as 1975, researchers noted that the length of time of a comfortable breath hold served as a simple test to determine relative breathing volume during rest and breathlessness during physical exercise. The Body Oxygen Level Test (BOLT) is a very useful and accurate tool for determining this relative breathing volume. BOLT is simple, safe, involves no sophisticated equipment, and can be applied at any time.”

The BOLT score (known as the “Control Pause” in Buteyko) is the simplest way to assess your breathing and diagnose chronic overbreathing. It’s powerful because it only measures **your first urge to breathe** and does not involve willpower like most breath-hold tests.

Physiologically, the BOLT measures your sensitivity to carbon dioxide (CO₂). CO₂ is your primary stimulus to breathe. So, the higher your BOLT, the longer it takes to feel the first urge to breathe, the higher your tolerance to CO₂ is, and the easier breathing is for you.

The best time to measure your BOLT is first thing in the morning. Sit and relax for about 10 minutes beforehand and then perform the following steps:

1. **“Take a normal breath in through your nose and allow a normal breath out through your nose.**
2. **Hold your nose with your fingers to prevent air from entering your lungs.**
3. **Time the number of seconds until you feel the first definite desire to breathe, or the first stresses of your body urging you to breathe. These sensations may include the need to swallow or a constriction of the airways. You may also feel the first involuntary contractions of your breathing muscles in your abdomen or throat as the body gives the message to resume breathing. (Note that BOLT is not a measurement of how long you can hold your breath but simply the time it takes for your body to react to a lack of air.)**
4. **Release your nose, stop the timer, and breathe in through your nose. Your inhalation at the end of the breath hold should be calm.”**

In general, the lower your BOLT is, the higher your odds of chronically overbreathing. If you’re looking for specifics, the goal of the Oxygen Advantage is to get you to a BOLT of 40 seconds. But in my limited experience, anything above 20 seconds indicates decent breathing habits.

Lastly, don’t get stressed over your score. It’s just one measurement of breathing health. And it only measures where you are now, *not where you’re going*.

With that in mind, let’s look at two simple things you can do to increase your BOLT score.



3. How to Fix Overbreathing: The Nose and Breathe Light to Breathe Right

"If you reduce your breathing and properly regulate the amount of air you take in, you will teach your body to breathe more efficiently, and you will become healthier."

Here are two primary things you can do to reduce overbreathing and become healthier: (1) breathe nasally and (2) practice "breathe light to breathe right."

#1. Breathe Nasally (especially at night)

You know the importance of nasal breathing by now, so I won't dwell on it here. Instead, let's focus on mouth tape during sleep because this is perhaps the biggest help most new people get from the Oxygen Advantage®.

"Taping the mouth at night ensures the benefits of good breathing during sleep, allowing you to fall asleep more quickly, stay asleep longer, and wake feeling energized. The tape that I have found most suitable, as it is simple to use, hypoallergenic, and light, is 3M Micropore tape, which can be bought from most drugstores."

Even if you did nothing else, mouth tape at night can help significantly with reducing breathing volume because: **"Spending a guaranteed eight hours breathing through your nose while you sleep is an opportune way to reeducate your respiratory center to adjust to a more normal breathing volume."**

So, we start by breathing nasally, especially at night.

#2. Breathe Light to Breathe Right

The next step is to deliberately reduce our breathing volume in an exercise called "Breathe Light to Breathe Right" (this exercise is the foundation of the OA program):

"The objective is to create a tolerable need or hunger for air. A sustained need for air over the course of 10 to 12 minutes resets the receptors in the brain to tolerate a higher concentration of carbon dioxide.

[...]

The only way to know you are reducing your breathing volume is feeling as if you would like to take in a bigger breath."



Rather than go through the detailed instructions here, you can let Patrick guide you through it using the free Oxygen Advantage app. Here are the [iPhone](#) and [Android](#) links.

By practicing nasal breathing 24/7 and breathing light to breathe right, you can expect your BOLT score to increase by about 3-4 seconds per week until it gets to 20 seconds. After that, it may plateau some. This is where breath-hold training comes in...

4. Improve Performance with the Simulation of High Altitude

“By learning how to simulate high-altitude training, you will increase the oxygen-carrying capacity of your bloodstream, allowing your red blood cells to fuel new capabilities. Additionally, it will help you to sustain sharper psychological focus during physical activity as you become less conscious of the act of breathing. This will free you to devote more attention to maintaining proper form while exercising or formulating strategy in a competitive sport.”

Once you’ve switched to nasal breathing, consistently practiced breathing light, and achieved a BOLT score of at least 20 seconds, you’re ready for the next step in the OA program: high-altitude simulation.

Simulation high-altitude simply refers to breath-hold training. Breath holds reduce the oxygen saturation of the blood, mimicking (for very brief periods) being at altitude. Doing this leads to adaptations that improve performance, such as increased oxygen-carrying capacity, better blood flow, greater endurance, and an improved VO2max. It’s essentially “legal blood doping.”

Another benefit of the OA breath-hold techniques is that they occur after a passive exhalation. As Patrick tells us, this helps lower blood oxygen saturation, but it also increases CO2 concentration, building CO2 tolerance. Having high CO2 and low O2 produces adaptations that lessen oxidative stress and reduce lactic acid during physical exercise.

Lastly, the strong breath holds used in the OA strengthen the diaphragm, our main breathing muscle, which can help reduce the onset of respiratory muscle fatigue during exercise.

With all these benefits in mind, here’s how the OA breath-hold techniques are generally performed: (1) a regular inhale and exhale, (2) pinching your nose, (3) holding your breath while walking, and (4) resuming nasal breathing.

To get started, use the OA app or find a certified instructor to ensure you don’t have any contraindications that would make breath holds dangerous.



1 Life-Changing Idea

The Power of Carbon Dioxide: Oxygen and the Bohr Effect

"In short, our body's relationship with carbon dioxide determines how healthy we can be, affecting nearly every aspect of how our body functions. Better breathing allows carbon dioxide to ensure that all the interlocking parts of our system work together in harmony, allowing us to achieve our maximum potential in sporting performance, endurance, and strength."

I'd say that of all the concepts presented in the book, learning about the power of CO₂ for overall health and body oxygenation is the most life-changing.

Specifically, the Bohr effect—and its implications for oxygen delivery—were the most enlightening. Here's how Patrick summarizes the Bohr effect:

"The crucial point to remember is that hemoglobin releases oxygen when in the presence of carbon dioxide. When we overbreathe, too much carbon dioxide is washed from the lungs, blood, tissues, and cells. This condition is called hypocapnia, causing the hemoglobin to hold on to oxygen, resulting in reduced oxygen release and therefore reduced oxygen delivery to tissues and organs."

Thus, counterintuitively, when we reduce breathing volume and raise CO₂ in our blood (using Thoughts 1-3), we actually increase oxygen delivery to the tissues and cells.

With this principle, we could summarize 90% of the book as: breathe less, increase your CO₂, and increase the amount of oxygen delivered to your cells and tissues. *This is how we get "the oxygen advantage."*

Life-changing, indeed.



1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

"We can live without food for weeks and water for days, but air for just a few brief minutes. While we spend a great deal of time and attention on what we eat and drink, we pay practically no attention to the air we breathe."

"What if healthy breathing habits were just as important as healthy eating habits in fostering maximum fitness—or, in fact, even more so?"

"Developing body strength while ignoring breathing efficiency is counterproductive, and this book will show you how to build your respiratory stamina alongside any athletic training program."

My favorite quote from the book:

"It is quite a striking example of evolutionary balance and beauty that the trees around us that give off oxygen and the trees in our lungs that absorb it share a similar structure."

"In the words of Christian Bohr, "The carbon dioxide pressure of the blood is to be regarded as an important factor in the inner respiratory metabolism. If one uses carbon dioxide in appropriate amounts, the oxygen that was taken up can be used more effectively throughout the body.'"

"In short, the lower the BOLT score, the greater the breathing volume, and the greater your breathing volume, the more breathlessness you will experience during exercise."

"You may be surprised to learn that the roof of the mouth is in fact the floor of the nose! The nose you see on your face comprises approximately 30 percent of its volume. It is the tip of the iceberg, so to speak, with the remaining 70 percent of the nasal cavity set deep within the skull."

"The traditional Chinese philosophy of Taoism succinctly describes ideal breathing as "so smooth that the fine hairs within the nostrils remain motionless.'"



“True health and inner peace occurs when breathing is quiet, effortless, soft, through the nose, abdominal, rhythmic, and gently paused on the exhale. This is how human beings naturally breathed until modern life changed everything.”

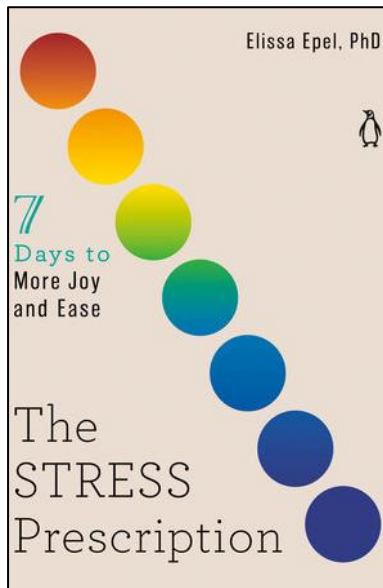
“If we use the definition of “extending far from the top” in the context of deep breathing, the “top” will refer to the top of the lungs or the upper chest. A deep breath, therefore, means to breathe down into the full depth of the lungs. It also means using the main breathing muscle, the diaphragm, which separates the chest from the abdomen.”

“It’s very intuitive: If we breathe better, increasing the amount of carbon dioxide inside us, then we can deliver more oxygen to our muscles and organs, including the heart and brain, and thus heighten our physical capacity. All we’re really doing is assisting the body in working the way it was meant to work in the first place.”



BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



The Stress Prescription: Seven Days to More Joy and Ease

BY: Elissa Epel, Ph.D.

411 Released: June 16, 2023

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. Accepting & Embracing Uncertainty
2. Baseline Stress, Vagal Tone, and Morning Breathing
3. Your Body Loves Acute Stress (plus the challenge mindset)
4. The Power of Nature, Water, and Breathing

1 Life-Changing Idea

Flip the Script and Bring the Retreat to You



4 Thoughts

1. Accepting & Embracing Uncertainty

"We know now that stress biology and aging biology are wrapped up together. Our bodies get worn down more quickly under chronic stress, and chronic uncertainty is the most ubiquitous form of chronic stress. Thus, the antidote: We need to "turn off" our threat response to uncertainty. We need to shift our mindset to accept uncertainty as the defining condition of our lives, instead of fighting against it or feeling threatened by it."

"Chronic uncertainty is the most ubiquitous form of chronic stress." < -- Let that sink in.

As Dr. Epel says, the antidote is to accept uncertainty as a **"defining condition of our lives."** That by itself might change our lives forever.

But what I love about this idea is how it can be related back to the concept of "pre-silience" we recently discussed in *Peak Mind*. Recall that having pre-silience means you can be in a difficult situation and know you have the inner resources to get through it. We might add that if we embrace uncertainty, we immediately increase our pre-silience, too.

But how do we actually do this? One of the best ways is to loosen (but not remove altogether) our expectations:

As Dr. Epel says, **"Strong expectations can hurt us whether they're positive (something we're looking forward to) or negative (something we're dreading). Better to loosen our expectations as much as we can."**

So by loosening our expectations and embracing uncertainty, we can increase our mental pre-silience while decreasing our stress.

And in the next thought, we'll look at how breathing might help this process even more.



2. Baseline Stress, Vagal Tone, and Morning Breathing

“We each have our unique starting baseline—the level of stress arousal that we usually hover around through any typical day. Every person’s starting baseline is different: some people are tightly wound up, vigilant, and ready to startle at an unexpected noise, while others might be like a placid lake that is hard to disturb. Regardless of where we start from, the lower we can get our baseline stress arousal, the better—it means we’ll be much more able to tolerate the peaks of stressful events.”

The mission of this book is to lower our baseline stress levels, and this is where the power of breathing comes in in a couple of ways:

1) Vagal Tone: We know that slow breathing can increase our vagal tone, directly translating to a lower baseline stress level in our nervous system. Thus, a consistent slow breathing practice may be one of the most efficient ways to lower our baseline stress, making us **“much more able to tolerate the peaks of stressful events.”**

2) Morning Breathing: To me, the passage above also highlights the power of doing some slow breathing first thing in the morning. By starting out at a lower baseline every day, we’ll tolerate stressful events better. And as a bonus, starting out calmer will help us accept and embrace uncertainty simply because we’re in a better state of mind.

Together, we might say that having a consistent morning slow breathing practice is one of the best ways to lower our baseline stress levels. The importance of this cannot be overstated. As Dr. Epel points out, **“dropping our default stress baseline allows us to operate at a healthier and more biologically sustainable level of nervous system arousal.”** 🙌

3. Your Body Loves Acute Stress (plus the challenge mindset)

“Your body loves acute stress. This process of peak and recovery—of sympathetic nervous system action followed by parasympathetic nervous system action, triggering cell cleanup and repair—is wonderful for us. In fact, we need it ... We need rest and relaxation, yes, but we also need positive stress. We need both.”



You've probably heard this a thousand times, but it's worth repeating: Stress isn't necessarily bad; it's *chronic stress* that harms our health.

And while much of the book focuses on relaxation-oriented exercises to reduce chronic stress, Dr. Epel does an excellent job describing the benefits of positive stress too:

"It turns out that exposing the body to manageable positive stress does the opposite of what long-term toxic stress does: it improves the health and regenerative life span of your cells, instead of slowly wearing them out. We call this hormetic stress."

How do we practice "hormetic stress?" She provides many ways. Of course, exercise is #1. But she also explicitly mentions the power of cold-water immersion and Wim's method as potent hormetic stressors. And in my opinion, we can clump any *short-term fast-breathing exercise* into this "hormetic stressor" category.

But perhaps most powerfully, we can simply shift our mindset from a "threat response" to a "challenge response" in almost any situation to reap the benefits of hormetic stress. To do this, we reframe everyday "stressors" as "challenges." That simple reframe can change the entire response of the nervous system:

"So know this: To a certain extent, you can shape your own stress response! You might feel the spike of adrenaline at work, but then you can choose how to interpret your body's natural stress response and improve how things unfold."

That's pretty amazing. So here's to harnessing and reinterpreting our body's natural stress response to improve how things unfold and enhance our quality of life 🍌

4. The Power of Nature, Water, and Breathing

"This dramatic shift we experience in nature is called the attentional restoration effect: we have relieved attentional overload, we have opened up space in our mind, we feel better."

Nature has an incredible ability to lower our stress. And it's extra potent because it's passive: All you have to do is show up, and nature takes care of the rest (pun intended).

More specifically, Dr. Epel tells us that when we enter nature, blood pressure, cortisol, and inflammation go down, while relaxation and calm feelings go up. This results from the calming sounds, awe-inspiring views, refreshing smells, and clean air for breathing that nature provides.



To take advantage of these benefits, simply get out into nature (whatever is available to you) as much as you can: **“It’s simple: By shifting our physical environment, we can shift our mental state. We can change both the content of our thoughts and our thought processes.”**

And if you can’t get out, try bringing nature to you. Even listening to water can improve mood and slow your breathing: **“Many people also resonate with the soothing sound of rhythmic ocean waves—it affects our breathing, slowing it down and encouraging deeper breaths than the shallow and insufficiently oxygenated breathing that is our habit.”** 🙌

So choose whichever way that resonates with you and enjoy the passive power of nature a little more, today.

1 Life-Changing Idea

Flip the Script and Bring the Retreat to You

“When we create conditions that are ideal for deep rest—feeling safe, engaging in a mind-body practice, or being in nature—our breathing will often change naturally as the body adjusts. Today, we flip that. We start with the breath. When we practice the kind of breathing our body wants to do in a deep rest state, we signal to the body that it’s okay to rest. It’s okay to let go. ... Breathing, it turns out, can be the quickest, most direct path to deep rest. When you can’t go to a retreat, you can bring the retreat to you. And all you need is your breath.”

When we create the right conditions for deep rest (like being on a retreat or in nature), our breathing will change accordingly.

But the true power of breathing is that we can consciously change it to create the conditions for deep rest—we can bring the retreat to us.

So, the life-changing idea is this: Pick a distraction-free time and make it a ritual to create your own deep-rest mini-retreat using the breath.

Dr. Epel suggests a 4-6-8 breath (4-second inhale, 6-second hold, 8-second exhale). But, essentially any slow breathing technique between 3-7 breaths a minute that uses a slightly longer exhale than inhale will create the deep-rest, retreat-like conditions we’re after.

And if you need any additional motivation, I’ll leave you with this gem from Dr. Epel:



“Breathing practices are one of the most powerful acts we can do to change our physiological state—and quickly. It’s quite amazing: we can control our breath, which means we can control the state of our autonomic nervous system and even our state of consciousness. By altering our breath, we also influence our emotional state, pushing us toward calm, joy, and equanimity.”

1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

“Our mission, as part of the Stress Prescription, is to push our default baseline level closer to true rest. To live well with stress, we need to drop our default baseline.”

“Our stress arousal level manifests in our breathing rate, as one of many factors shaping it. Spoiler alert: the deep rest we need is also about breathing.”

“There’s not one single way to create deep rest—there are a lot of ways to get there. ... But there’s one common change that happens with all those activities: a change in the breath to be more slow and rhythmic, and which leads to greater vagal tone (greater parasympathetic to sympathetic balance) and greater oxygen in the body.”

“If you’re feeling like a victim of circumstance (Why me?) think instead, Try me! Think about all the hard situations you have survived already—all that experience and hard-earned wisdom are embodied in you.”

“For the tough things you cannot change, consider practicing radical acceptance. This means accepting the situation completely: in your mind, your heart, and your body.”

“When we are holding tension—when the stress baseline is high—we tend to take more breaths per minute, and those breaths tend to be shallow rather than deep. We respond to stress with light, rapid breathing, often through our mouth.”

“Ultimately this can become a kind of “stress spiral”—the stress of the day triggers a lighter, faster breathing pattern, marked by periods of unconscious breath holding, and that in turn keeps the body in a state of sympathetic nervous system activation.”



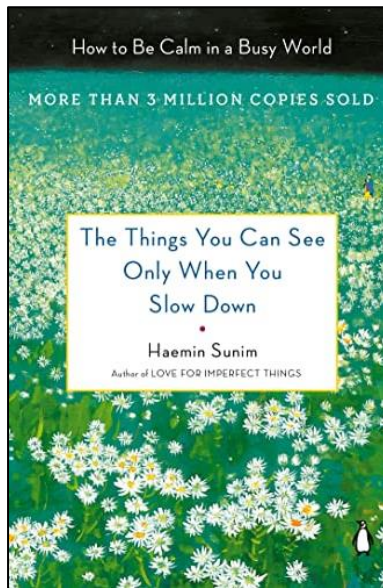
“Breathing physiology is complex and fascinating, but the actual practice of ideal functional breathing is—thank goodness—simple and graceful.”

“Your breath is something you always have access to as a powerful form of stress relief.”

“But the research shows us that when it comes to building stress resilience, one of the most powerful interventions is focusing on joy—specifically, the positive things that exist in our lives now, and on creating a positive future.”

BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



The Things You Can See Only When You Slow Down: How to Be Calm in a Busy World

BY: Haemin Sunim

411 Released: July 14, 2023

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. The Power of Awareness
2. Effort Leads to Effortlessness
3. Breathing Must Be Practiced Not Just in Solitude
4. The Power of Humor & Joy

1 Life-Changing Idea

1. Breath is Connection, Literally & Figuratively
-
-



4 Thoughts

1. The Power of Awareness

**“When you are stressed out, be aware of your stress.
When you are irritated, be aware of your irritation.
When you are angry, be aware of your anger.
As soon as you become aware of these feelings
you are no longer lost in them.
Your awareness allows you to witness them from the outside.
Awareness is inherently pure, like the open sky.
Stress, irritation, and anger can temporarily cloud the sky,
but they can never pollute it.”**

This book is full of bite-sized wisdom on all aspects of living. Each wisdom nugget Sunim shares could be a thought, but this one is a great place to start because it coincides with many things we discuss in the Learning Center.

And the idea is super simple: When we bring awareness to a situation, it has less power over us. Without awareness, we can fall into worry and rumination.

This, of course, comes back to breathing because all awareness begins with breath awareness. As Al Lee and Don Campbell say:

“[W]e must seek awareness, and that can begin with the awareness of your breath, the foundation of your totality as a human being.”

But what I love about the above passage from Sunim is the weather analogy.

Awareness is the sky. Our sky may get temporarily clouded (we experience real stressors, after all, and storms in the sky cause real damage), but we know it will eventually pass. We know we can ride out the storm, so we don't let it permanently pollute our life's atmosphere ☁️.



2. Effort Leads to Effortlessness

**“When our bodies are fit and healthy, we feel light, almost like air.
But just because we feel light does not mean our bodies are not there.
It takes a lot of effort for our fitness to appear natural and effortless.
But just because it appears effortless does not mean that no effort was made.”**

This is incredible motivation for practice, especially breath practice. All the great ancient and modern teachers agree that our breathing should be effortless—we want quiet, deep, nasal breathing to be automatic. But that effortlessness comes from effort. Let’s remember:

- Kobe Bryant’s game-winners looked easy. But he spent an excessive amount of time practicing.
- Thich Nhat Hahn’s compassion looked effortless. But he spent a lifetime practicing it.
- Abraham Lincoln seemed like a natural leader. But he failed so many times he actually said, **“To remain as I am is impossible; I must die or be better.”**
- And on and on.

So, we must never forget: **“just because it appears effortless does not mean that no effort was made.”** And we must use that as motivation *to practice* our breathing or anything we want to come effortlessly to us 🙏

3. Breathing Must Be Practiced Not Just in Solitude

**“Spirituality must be practiced
not just in solitude but also among people.
Open up to people around you and feel connected.
This is the true challenge of spiritual practice.”**

As you know by now, my favorite thing to do is take non-breathing passages and apply them to breathing. And with the above one, it happened—dare I say—effortlessly :)

Our breathing (or any contemplative tradition) must also be practiced not only in solitude, but in real life. Let’s remember:

- How we do (or do not) reply to comments on social media is our practice.
 - How we do (or do not) reply to emails that provoke us is our practice.
-



- How we do (or do not) interact with friends & family is our practice.
- And on and on for every aspect of our lives...

So, this is the true challenge: To use our favorite contemplative practice to fundamentally change who we are and how we interact with the world for the better.

P.S. Here's a related quote. It's about faith, but we can easily apply it to breathing or yoga or meditation, and all the different schools out there arguing about whose method is best:

**"Faith is overvalued while practice is undervalued.
If we emphasize faith over practice,
spirituality remains ideology, creating theological conflicts.
But if we focus on carrying out the teachings in our actual lives,
we realize that the love taught by Jesus
is no different from the compassion taught by the Buddha.
If you wish for peace among different spiritual paths,
then practice what you preach."**

4. The Power of Humor & Joy

"To be happy, it's not necessary to expend great effort so we get somewhere else.

**Instead, relax into the present moment while finding humor in your life.
With humor, life becomes light and leisurely.
And laughter always brings people to experience openness and joy.**

**Humor opens closed hearts.
Humor can free us from the grip of our thoughts.
When we smile, we feel we can accept things we previously could not.
We feel we can forgive those who have wronged us.
Humor is an essential part of life."**

I often refer to laughing as "the most therapeutic breathing exercise."

And in my life, I've discovered that slow breathing and mindfulness naturally elicit humor. Perhaps it's because these practices teach us not to take ourselves so seriously. Or maybe the nervous system and brain changes make us physiologically capable of laughter.

Either way, this thought is simply a reminder that **"Humor is an essential part of life."**



And if it inspires you, view it as a powerfully therapeutic breathing exercise, and make sure you carve out time each day to get your regular dose of laughter :)

P.S. On a related note, joy & humor go together (and we do have evidence that [slow nasal breathing](#) helps us experience more joy). This is equally powerful, as Sunim tells us:

**“When we are joyful, our heart opens up to new things.
When we are in a bad mood, we can’t be open to new things,
no matter how wonderful they are.
Without joy in our heart,
our progress in life is slow and uninteresting.”**

1 Life-Changing Idea

Breath is Connection, Literally & Figuratively

**“The air I inhale enters my body and becomes part of me.
The air that I exhale moves into someone else and becomes part of her.**

**Just by looking at how the air moves,
we realize we are all connected to one another,
not just figuratively but also literally.”**

This idea is life-changing because it’s so obvious. But, there was something about how Sunim said it that made it “click,” and it blew my mind.

It’s simply a beautiful reminder that the breath connects us to all living things, both figuratively and literally 🙌



1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

"Demonstrations of love are small, compared with the great thing that is hidden behind them."

– Kahlil Gibran

That quote inspired this one: Demonstrations of breathing are small compared with the great life force hidden behind them.

"Given that the world we see through our mind's eye is limited, if we can train our mind and choose wisely where to focus, then we will be able to experience the world corresponding to the state of our mind."

*"Don't struggle to heal your wounds.
Just pour time into your heart and wait.
When your wounds are ready,
they will heal on their own."*

*"With love in our hearts,
we find even the most mundane things sacred and beautiful.
With love in our hearts,
we become kinder and gentler, even to complete strangers."*

"No matter how effective the medicine may be, if you demand that someone take it, it can taste like poison."

*"When a question has both a long, complicated, but logical-sounding answer
and a simple answer that can be understood by even a child,
the right answer is usually the simple one."*

"He who knows only one religion knows none." —MAX MÜLLER (1823–1900),

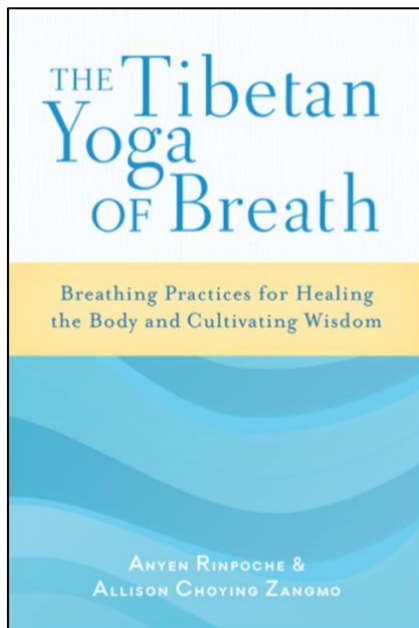
That quote inspired this one: If you know only one breathing method, you know none. If you understand breathing, you know them all.

*"From time to time we should take a breath
and notice the silence between sounds."*



BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



The Tibetan Yoga of Breath: Breathing Practices for Healing the Body and Cultivating Wisdom

BY: Anyen Rinpoche & Allison Choying Zangmo

411 Released: March 24, 2023

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. Why Breathing is the Best Tool for Healing and Transcending Suffering
2. Rlung Sems: The Breath-Mind Connection
3. How We Should Breathe: Nasally and Abdominally
4. The Basic Sequence of a Wind-Energy Training Session

1 Life-Changing Idea

The Breath-Weather Connection



4 Thoughts

1. Why Breathing is the Best Tool for Healing and Transcending Suffering

"If we practice mindfulness and appreciate training in the breath, we have an incredible number of opportunities to balance the body and mind every day. When we recognize the opportunity that training in the breath provides, we give ourselves a gift: the opportunity to transcend ordinary suffering."

Working with the breath provides us with a unique opportunity for healing because the breath is something that is with us all the time, every moment. It does not matter whether we are awake or asleep, working or sitting, lying down or doing something active—the opportunity to train in and be mindful of the breath is always with us."

A central theme of this book is that breathing is the most powerful tool we have, simply because it's always there. Each of the 20,000+ breaths we take daily allows us to heal our bodies and minds and transcend suffering...sounds good to me.

But beyond just "being there all the time," breathing is our best tool because it links our inner and outer experiences: **"what is happening within our bodies and minds is channeled through our breathing."** Thus, mindful breathing helps us understand our state. Conversely, conscious breathing allows us to influence our bodies and minds for the better (more in Thought #3).

But perhaps what makes breathing the absolute best tool is that it's available to everyone:

"The breath is something that is readily available to us simply because we are human beings. We do not need anything else to qualify. How marvelous!"

Marvelous, indeed.

P.S. It's not just available to everyone—it's also useful for everyone: "Because the breath is such an excellent and abundant support for life and vitality for every being on the planet, everyone can benefit from training in the breath, working with the inhalation and exhalation." 🙏 Amen to that.



2. Rlung Sems: The Breath-Mind Connection

“Each time a gust of wind blows over the ocean, ripples and waves cause movement and agitation on the water’s surface. However, when the air is calm, so is the water. It is just so with the mind. The more often we breathe, the more agitated the energy of body and mind becomes. By breathing less frequently, we begin to achieve elemental harmony.”

This is such a good analogy. And this close connection between breathing and the mind is another predominant theme of the book. The Tibetan language even unites them with the compound word “rlung sems,” or “wind-mind.” (They use “wind energy” and “breath” interchangeably throughout the book, which we’ll cover in the 1 Life-Changing Idea.)

From this relationship, we see that breathing drives the mind and can thus be used to calm it:

“The wind energy is the root of all of our experience, since it provides energy for the mind’s movement. So, wind energy training is a powerful tool for purifying, calming, taming, and relaxing the wind energy to impact the expression of neurotic mind.”

So, from their perspective, a primary goal of breath training is steadying our minds and reducing neurotic tendencies, such as anxiety, stress, depression, obsession, and so on:

“Of course, change will not happen immediately. But generally speaking, over a long period of time, working with the breath is effective at cutting through all types of neurotic tendencies, because it brings the wind energy into balance. As the wind energy is brought into balance and becomes more stable, neurotic tendencies lessen and even begin to disappear.”

Thus, because of the breath-mind connection—rlung sems—we have the power to change our breath and change our mindset. Let’s look at how we do that.

P.S. Modern science agrees with this “breath-mind” perspective. Countless studies support the idea that the breath can directly influence the mind and reduce “neurotic tendencies,” [namely stress, anxiety, and depression.](#)



3. How We Should Breathe: Nasally and Abdominally

Let's look at how we can practically use everything discussed in Thoughts #1 and #2. The two biggest things we can do to optimize our everyday breathing are to make it abdominal and nasal. Let's look at some of the benefits of breathing like this:

"How does abdominal breathing benefit us? As we discussed previously, by breathing abdominally, we increase the oxygen available in the blood, and therefore the brain. But also, when we breathe deeply with prolonged nasal exhalation, this action enables the vagus nerve to reset itself. The vagus nerve is an aspect of our nervous system that brings equilibrium and balance to the whole. It either stimulates or calms the system, depending on what is needed. Therefore, working with wind energy training actually delivers the necessary antidote to everyone, no matter what type of stress imbalance we suffer from, despite differences in our state of mind and physical health."

That last sentence is amazing and reminds me of this wisdom in Relaxation Revolution:

"In fact, any condition that is caused or exacerbated by stress can be helped by a well-designed mind body approach. Furthermore, because all health conditions have some stress component, it is no overstatement to say that virtually every single health problem and disease can be improved with a mind body approach."

So, we breathe nasally and abdominally to trigger the relaxation response and deliver **"the necessary antidote to everyone."**

Making these two changes to our default way of breathing is the best way to harness our "wind energy" for better mental and physical health. This is the essence of the whole book.

P.S. Here's another excellent quote on nasal breathing: "As a general note, the teachings on wind energy training and Yantra Yoga emphasize breathing through the nostrils during the entire practice session. Unless we are given specific, personal instruction by a master on how and when to breathe through the mouth, we should always breathe through the nose when we practice wind energy training."



4. The Basic Sequence of a Wind-Energy Training Session

There wasn't any "breathwork" or secret Tibetan breathing exercises in this book. Instead, it focused on coupling the breath with contemplations and visualizations. They are rather lengthy and can't fit here. However, from a practical perspective, I found the structure of a "wind-energy training" session useful:

"A typical session is structured like this: Begin with a short session of physical yoga. Practice for about fifteen to twenty minutes, or however long you wish."

The type of yoga you start with doesn't matter. What's most important is doing some physical activity to open the body's energy channels.

"Then take your seat on a cushion. Take a moment to reflect on your motivation, making sure that the wish to practice for the benefit of all beings is present in the mind."

You can adopt this beautiful mindset for any wellness practice you do.

"Next, engage in the Nine-Cycles Breathing to dispel the karmic wind."

This is essentially six alternate-nostril breaths followed by three breaths in and out of both nostrils. For ANB, one cycle is out-left, in-left, out-right, and in-right (the audio version of this 411 has more details). Make the inhales and exhales as long and deep as you comfortably can. There are also visualizations you can do with this practice—get the book for more.

After this short sequence, you go into a contemplative practice, such as meditating on impermanence with each in and out breath.

I've been trying out the Nine-Cycles Breathing and reflecting on my motivation to begin each breathing session, and I really enjoy it. If you feel inspired, give it a try, too 🙏

P.S. They also have some neat info on posture. I shared it in [TB1% #115](#), so check it out if you're interested in becoming a "spiritual hero who works for the benefit of others."



1 Life-Changing Idea

The Breath-Weather Connection

“Wind energy has the same relationship to our mental and emotional energy as it does to the environment and atmosphere. When the wind energy is wild, agitated, or imbalanced, it manifests as physical illness in the body or as mental suffering, neurosis, or any other extreme state in the mind.

We also know that when the air element is harmonious, calm, and in balance, we tend to feel happy. When the sun is shining, the weather is warm, and the air is calm, life feels abundant, and we feel comfortable. Harmony in the elements makes it easy to feel good.”

Viewing breath as wind was the most life-changing perspective shift from the book. Of course, I studied the weather for over 10 years, so it has a special place in my heart. But this viewpoint is genuinely something that can change your daily life in three ways:

1. Make the connection that “breath is wind.” We know when the wind is strong outside, it can cause destruction. Think of hurricanes, tornadoes, and damaging winds associated with thunderstorms. Now, realize something similar occurs with our internal wind, our breath. When it is strong, it causes physical and mental disturbances. So, when you walk outside, notice the wind, and use it as a reminder to observe your internal wind.

2. Realize that atmospheric wind is a balancing response. High- and low-pressure systems create wind in the atmosphere; air movement is a balancing response to these differing pressures. Similarly, our breath is a balancing response to our mental and physical states. A strong “breath-wind” is usually a sign of a physical or psychological imbalance. In contrast, calm breathing is a sign we are close to balance. THE KEY DIFFERENCE: We can control our breath and bring balance—that’s life-changing by itself.

3 Everywhere gets weather. Every place on Earth receives powerful winds or destructive weather from time to time. Similarly, if we’re alive, we’ll always have turbulent breathing from time to time. It’s part of life to have ups and downs and destructive weather now and then. There’s no need to beat ourselves up over it. It comes and goes, like clouds in the sky :)



1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

"Therefore, according to Tibetan medicine, the breath is part of an intricate system of wind energy that regulates and supports the body's health. For this reason, we often use the words breath and wind energy interchangeably."

"The breath is not only a source of support for the physical body; it is also a support for mental, emotional, and spiritual well-being."

"This illustrates the most empowering point of all: the key to our own experience lies within our bodies all the time. We need not look outside of ourselves to find peace or to resolve conflicts. We have the power to do that within ourselves."

"No matter how out of control we feel, how low our energy is, or how large our problems seem to loom, wind energy training is an effective intervention for all emotional imbalances. When we work with the breath, we work with the root of the problem."

"It staves off physical and mental illnesses. It cultivates emotional stability. On a daily basis, it can bring us greater peace of mind because we carry the breath with us wherever we go."

"The only thing that we can control and master is our own spiritual path."

"All of us are equally capable of working with the inhalation and exhalation of the breath. After the lessons and insights of this book, we may see the practice of breath work as a wish-fulfilling gem that we never knew we carried until now."

"Wind energy training represents complete abundance in our lives. There is no shortage of anything—we have all the support and opportunity we need to practice."

"[I]t is no coincidence that the breath is the perfect tool to use on a moment-to-moment basis. Whether we are eating, sleeping, sitting, working, engaging with others, or driving, we can cultivate awareness of the breath throughout them all."



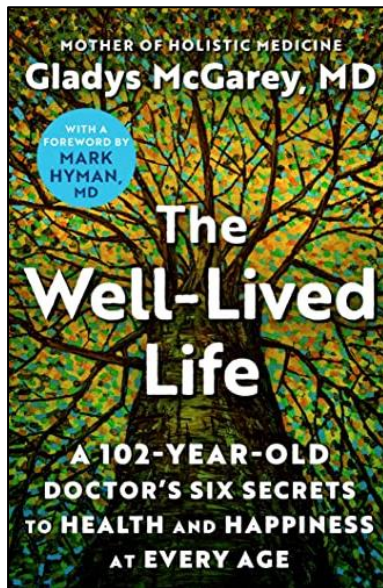
“When the breath is calm and relaxed, we notice that the body’s energy is also calm, especially in the areas of the abdomen, lungs, and chest. As a result, the mind becomes clear and we feel relaxed and even-tempered.”

“At the end of the wind energy training session, spend a few moments using the breath to channel this attitude of rejoicing. As you inhale, you can think, ‘How fortunate! My life lasted long enough to take this breath.’ As you exhale, you can think, ‘May I use the remainder of my life wisely.’”



BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



The Well-Lived Life: A 102-Year-Old Doctor's Six Secrets to Health and Happiness at Every Age

BY: Gladys McGarey, MD

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What You'll Learn:

1. The Point of Medicine is to Allow the Soul to Fulfill Its Purpose
2. Your Life Purpose (and why you should enjoy searching for it)
3. Love is the Greatest Medicine Ever Known
4. Becoming Students of Life to Live Our Best Lives

1 Life-Changing Idea

1. Align with Your Soul: We Are Each Pieces of a Jigsaw Puzzle

Reading Time: 5 min 44 sec

I hope the next 86'ish breaths are the most nourishing of your day.



4 Thoughts

1. The Point of Medicine is to Allow the Soul to Fulfill Its Purpose

“Over my many decades in practice, I’ve come to understand that the point of medicine—and of life—is quite different from what I was taught in medical school. Most people think that the role of medicine is simply to promote physical well-being through putting a stop to whatever ails us. Yet the greater aim is to create a suitably healthy environment—the body—in which the soul can fulfill its purpose.”

I like this “point of medicine” much more than the conventional one 😊. And a central theme of the book is just this: fulfilling our soul’s purpose. As Dr. McGarey says:

“Each of us came here to do something. And as I see it, true health has nothing to do with diagnosing a disease or prolonging life just for the sake of it; it’s about finding out who we are, paying attention to how we’re called to grow and change, and listening to what makes our heart sing.”

That’s a quite stunning and powerful statement worth reading several times over. And it’s a big part of why I think breathing and mindfulness are the best medicine. What better way to listen to our hearts sing and fulfill our purpose than to align with our life force, our breath?



2. Your Life Purpose (and why you should enjoy Searching for it)

“Each of us is here for a reason, to learn and grow and to give our gifts. When we are able to do so, we’re filled with the creative life energy that I call the “juice.” The juice is our reason for living. It’s our fulfillment, our joy. It’s what happens when life is activated by love. It’s the energy we get from the things that matter and mean something to us.”

Dr. McGarey refers to our life force as “juice,” and that passage perfectly summarizes what it means. She also provides scientific evidence that having “juice” (or a life purpose) supports improved physical and mental health, which we all probably know by now.

But one of the most profound things McGarey points out is that *searching for our juice* is as essential as finding it. We’re supposed to enjoy the never-ending quest of finding what makes our hearts sing, knowing that our juice will change as we grow:

“What’s most important is to realize that searching for your juice is nearly as important as finding it. The search itself is life reaching for life. Even if you don’t have much juice, your longing for more means that some part of you remembers what’s possible. It suggests that you are more than just a beating heart—you are a living soul.”

So here’s to embracing the journey—the endless reading and learning—while knowing that this search is the most important (and fun) part of being alive.



3. Love is the Greatest Medicine Ever Known

"Medicine often underestimates the power of love. These words are so commonly used that they can even sound a bit hokey ... Yet hopefully you've experienced love in your life, and you've already caught a glimpse of what it can do. I hope you've had the chance to know how love can sweep in and change everything, overpowering anything in its presence. It's not hokey. It's not overstated. Love truly is the greatest medicine the world has ever known. It takes life from a passive state (being alive) to an active state (truly living) ... Our life force is activated by love."

And in my opinion, this doesn't just apply to love between people. It's a universal principle. Love can transform work into play, a sleepless night into energy, and physical pain into fulfillment. If we focus our efforts on love, we can transform any situation into bliss.

As Dr. McGarey also states, **"Any effort we put toward love—truly, any effort at all—will self-perpetuate, bringing joy, health, and well-being into our lives."**

Sounds worth the "effort" to me. Here's to purposefully seeking, finding, and appreciating the love in our lives a little more 🙏

P.S. Although Dr. McGarey doesn't mention it, a systematized way of "practicing love" is through loving-kindness meditation. In fact, this chapter of the book inspired me to start doing it consistently. However, keep in mind that any contemplative practice you do serves as self-love, which will perpetuate joy, health, and wellness into your life, too :)



4. Becoming Students of Life (and breath) to Live Our Best Lives

"We live our best lives when we approach life with curiosity and a desire to learn from everything. I believe that this is part of the point of life—to learn, to grow, to evolve in response to our experiences. Certainly, we get the most out of life when we extract lessons along the way. Life always has new teachings to offer us if we can find the courage to look for them."

Dr. McGarey's fifth secret, which is the key to living our best lives, is becoming students of life. As she says, **"Life is always trying to show us something. It's communicating with us through the events, people, and ideas that show up in our lives."** We have to be life's students to pick up on these messages.

And I'd say the same thing is true for breathing. When we tune into our breath, we tune into the signals our inner and outer environments are sharing. This allows us to cultivate awareness and gratitude and, if necessary, make changes to restore balance.

That's why of all the identities we have—mother, father, friend, spouse, accountant, or scientist—the most important is as a student: **"[U]nderstanding ourselves as a student of life is the most important identification of all. It gives context to both our struggles and our joys."**

So here's to becoming students of life (and breath) so we can give context to our struggles and joys and ultimately live our best lives.



1 Life-Changing Idea

Align with Your Soul: We Are Each Pieces of a Jigsaw Puzzle

"I like thinking of us as puzzle pieces because it gives us each space to be unique. We're not supposed to be shaped this way or that; we're supposed to be shaped precisely as we are, because that way we can fit together. It isn't anyone's job to judge the shape of anyone else's piece, and in the same way, it isn't useful to try to make ourselves more or less like anyone else or to worry if they judge our shape. Instead, it's up to each of us to align with our own soul and help others do the same. Seeing things this way helps us understand that each of us is essential. Have you ever nearly finished a jigsaw puzzle only to find that there's a piece missing? It's a crisis!"

This may now be one of my favorite passages ever. I have nothing helpful to add...except for a few of these 🙏🙏🙏.

P.S. Well, I do have one more gem from McGarey to add. If you're interested in many things and hate when told to "find your niche," I think you'll love it: **"We're able to connect with life best when we get juice from multiple places. A puzzle piece doesn't just click in on one side; it clicks in on two, three, or four. What that looks like varies from person to person."**



1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

"Health and happiness are about being so connected to our own life force that we feel we fit into the world around us."

"To be truly alive, we must find the life force within ourselves and direct our energy toward it."

"All life needs to move. Life itself is always in movement, so aligning with our life force means that we must always look for the flow within us."

"Stillness promotes tension. And when we hold tension in our body, we restrict our circulation, digestion, and nervous system, making it harder for our body to get nourishment."

"Life reaches for life. Always."

"[Y]ou must find the physician within, the one who knows how to heal, and start to trust."

"When we make loving a part of our everyday existence, we perpetuate life."

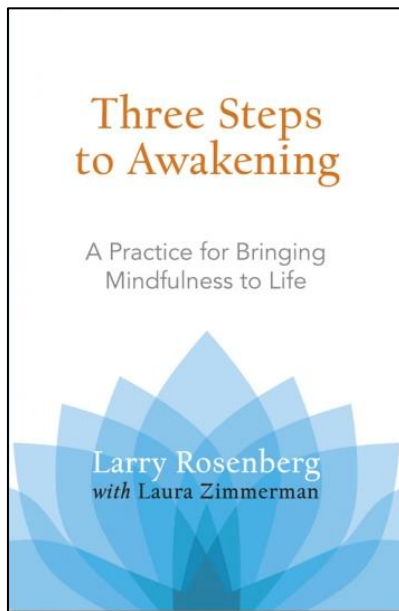
"No matter how hard we may try to separate ourselves, we are part of a community, for better or worse. We're part of a family, a culture, a country, a continent, a species. We connect through shared experiences and shared genes. We literally share the air we breathe."

"Healing, too, takes its own time. More often than not, time is the secret ingredient that allows healing to take place."



BOOK 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, & 1 stack of memorable quotes



Three Steps to Awakening: A Practice for Bringing Mindfulness to Life

BY: Larry Rosenberg with Laura Zimmerman

411 Released: April 7, 2023

[Get this book on Amazon](#)

What You'll Learn:

1. The Power of Breath Awareness ('a joyful abiding in the here and now')
2. How to Practice Breath Awareness
3. Life is the Real Practice
4. The Proof is in the Pudding (plus some 'ouch' teaching)

1 Life-Changing Idea

The Best Advice on Methods (plus long beards)



4 Thoughts

1. The Power of Breath Awareness ('a joyful abiding in the here and now')

"Thoughts also come and go. So do moods and images. Likewise, the body feels comfortable, then uncomfortable. The mind is optimistic, then pessimistic. You are totally interested in practice, then bored with it. Throughout it all, make your home in whole-body breath awareness. The breath is like a good friend helping to support that awareness. Every time you're with an in-breath or out-breath, you're learning how to be in the present moment. You're learning how to be with the breath sensations just as they are. It's actually an advantage that the breath takes on so many different qualities, for this challenges the mind to learn how to stay awake with the breath when it's long, when it's shallow, when it's fine, when it's coarse."

This passage beautifully summarizes the power of breath awareness: It teaches you to be in the present moment, to be with things just as they are.

And it made me think about how this practice is really "life awareness." Of course, we say "breath is life" all the time. But that's not quite what I mean here. It's more a metaphor for the realization that if you can bring awareness (and acceptance) to the breath in all its forms, you'll be able to do the same with all the things life throws at us. Simply put, you learn about life by bringing awareness to the breath.

As Rosenberg also says, **"The breath accompanies you the full length of life's road: you learn about the body, feelings, mental formations, the mind itself, and, finally, the lawfulness of impermanence and emptiness of a substantial self."**

If that seems too far-fetched for something as simple as breathing, remember that the Buddha still practiced breath awareness after enlightenment:

"Even after full enlightenment, the Buddha himself set aside personal retreat time for the practice of mindfulness of breathing, calling it 'a joyful abiding in the here and now.'"

If it was enough for the Buddha, I think it's enough for us, too :) So here's to using our breath to joyfully abide in the here and now a little more in our lives 🙏



2. How to Practice Breath Awareness

"We'll start with a translation of the third of the sixteen steps in the sutta itself: *'Being sensitive to the whole body, the yogi breathes in. Being sensitive to the whole body, the yogi breathes out.'* The frame of reference is the whole body, sitting. This implies that you experience each breath as it turns up in you, however that is. It's not a desperate search. It's not trying to encompass the entire body. It's just feeling whatever you feel. That's good enough.

What's crucial is the quality of awareness. The sensations turn up more distinctively in different places in the body from breath to breath, and this helps train the mind because it's challenging. Not only is the mind learning to be attentive, but also to be supple, flexible. It is learning to stay with breath sensations as they emerge, whatever their quality, wherever they are most vivid."

That's breath awareness in a nutshell. Rosenberg suggests whole-body breath awareness, not a single-pointed focus such as in the nostrils or abdomen. There are benefits to both approaches, but Rosenberg makes a compelling case for this one here and in Thought #1 above.

Typically, this would be practiced in a seated position as part of a formal meditation session. But Rosenberg had another passage on "perfect practice" that jumped out at me, which can be used anytime, anywhere. I use it 10+ times a day now and find it incredibly valuable:

"At this very moment, whether you know it or not, each breath happens right here and right now. Little by little the question becomes, Are you intimate with this breath just as it is? Intimate, meaning not separate but fully experiencing whatever you experience as the breath fills up the lungs and empties in this particular posture at this time in this place.

When the mind gets caught up in its productions, can you return to the body and the breathing? Wherever you feel those breath sensations at any moment, your practice is perfect."

So, you just notice your breath in whatever posture you're currently occupying. Do that periodically throughout your day for 1-3 breaths, and watch your body and mind transform for the better 🙏



3. Life is the Real Practice

“Could it be that our encounters with partners, colleagues, and strangers hold the same potential to liberate us as sitting in a solitary room, mindful of breath? I encourage you all to investigate this possibility. As you do, it might help to remember the simple and beautiful words of the Chan master Sheng Yen: ‘Practice should not be separated from living, and living at all times should be one’s practice.’”

That’s how the book ends, and this idea of treating our lives as the practice is a significant theme of the book. Of course, I absolutely love this. Yes, I have a formal breathing routine in the morning I never miss. But in my opinion, the whole point is to take what we learn during practice into the real world to live a better life, which is what Rosenberg advocates here.

He provides many ways of doing this. But, for our purposes, I love his suggestion for bringing mindful breathing into our days:

“Breath awareness is one method that can help you develop full attention to otherwise easily overlooked moments of daily life. Using this practice throughout the day transforms many small and simple activities into meaningful chances to develop a mind that is focused, calm, and alert.”

This really works. The book has motivated me to do it more throughout my day, and it’s truly powerful. (To start, use the short instructions from Thought #2.) So, enjoy treating your life as your practice as you find more chances to cultivate *“a mind that is focused, calm, and alert.”*



4. The Proof is in the Pudding (plus some ‘ouch’ teaching)

“From there, it’s up to you. “The proof of the pudding is in the eating.” You have to bite into the pudding, chew it, and taste it. ... Tentatively, take the teachings as true and useful. But investigate them. As you read, test them out in your direct experience.”

This is the perfect mindset for us to adopt for any mind-body practice we might use. Get inspired by the words, the teachers, and the teachings. But ultimately, it’s up to us to test them in our lives and see if they actually work. We have to taste the pudding.



And although I'm not a Buddhist, perhaps I'm consistently drawn to Buddhist books because this mindset was precisely what the Buddha encouraged:

"[The Buddha] advises them that just because a teaching is ancient, or recited from the scripture, does not make it true. Just because it appears reasonable, or you're drawn to the person teaching it, does not mean it is wise."

Amen to that. And don't forget that this applies to modern science, too :)

P.S. Rosenberg shares an amazing little story to drive this point home. There's a young, popular Dharma teacher who knew everything about everything—all the citations, all the scriptures, and so on. He came to give a talk, and an old master showed up. But the old master kept falling asleep...

"The more authorities he cited, the sleepier the old master appeared. Finally, the young teacher interrupted himself to ask, *'What's wrong? Is my teaching so boring, so awful, so totally off?'* At that point, the old master leaned over and gave him a hard pinch. The young teacher screamed, *'Ouch!'* The old master said, *'Ah! That's what I've traveled this long distance to hear. This pure teaching. This 'ouch' teaching.'*"

1 Life-Changing Idea

The Best Advice on Methods (plus long beards)

"While you practice a particular method, it can be helpful to believe that your technique—or your teacher or lineage or meditation center—is the best. You feel fortunate. This mobilizes energy and often inspires strong practice. But as you grow on the path, more ingenuity is called for. You have to become self-reliant and see what you need from moment to moment. Just watch out for compulsive shopping around, which stems from the restless mind and its refusal to sustain any effort."

Reading this was like taking a long slow exhale for my brain. It's perhaps one of the most honest and insightful passages I've read on methods and teachers. I just love how he recognizes the power of believing your approach is the best: **"This mobilizes energy and often inspires strong practice."** While simultaneously, he acknowledges that it will eventually change.



It means that if you're currently excited about a method, that's amazing. If it's encouraging you to practice, get as excited as possible. But as you grow, realize that at some point, you'll have to become more self-reliant. What do we do then? Back to Rosenberg for another gem:

"For me, approaches to mindfulness and concentration need to be adjusted to our unique character structure and temperament. The same holds true for all your meditation practices: choose the method that helps you let go of grasping and attachment. If it does, it is in the service of the Dharma. You may learn the approach from a little-known teacher who never wrote a book or presented at a Buddhist conference. Find out what is skillful for you, and don't worry about what is useful for the person sitting next to you. This investigation requires patience and honesty. As you do it, it's a practice—not a waste of time."

Amen to that. I'm going to do my best to follow this. I hope you'll join me.

P.S. The above passages ultimately lead to trusting yourself, not a particular method or teacher. As usual, Rosenberg has a funny story to drive this home: **"Years ago, a wonderful Hindu teacher, Swami Chinmayananda, who taught me the Vedanta, said, 'The longer the beard, the bigger the fake.' And he, himself, had a beard that almost touched the floor!"** That makes me laugh but also makes me think of how in today's society, our version of "beards" are our credentials touching the floor: Ph.D., MD, Psy.D., D.O., and on and on :)

1 Stack of Memorable Quotes

"As you will hear me say throughout, each yogi responds to a particular approach in his or her own way. For both teacher and student, the choice of methods remains "skillful means." No one size fits all."

"Breathing awareness is not just about calming the mind—a common assumption among meditators not familiar with this method. Rather, the breath helps you maintain full attention, enabling you to see with greater clarity and accuracy the true nature of all forms: everything that arises passes away."

"[The Buddha] realized that the process of respiration, so often taken for granted, comprises the basis for a method of awakening available to all of you."



“Waking up is becoming more alive. The aliveness that’s available to all of you is already here in this moment. It’s life in the form of breathing.”

“Awareness is never limited to a particular time, place, or posture; and neither is the breath. Wherever you find yourself, the breath is present. If you aren’t breathing, you’re dead.”

“Mindfulness, the breath, and movement are happening within the same time frame. Can you be simple and alert enough to know this unitary event just as it is?”

“You're more alive when body and breath are permeated with the energy of awareness.”

“Of course, it is a truism that none of us can live without breathing. But can you make use of this truism, so that it helps your contemplative life?”

“But no matter where you find yourself, you have the ability to help the mind quiet down. Wherever you go, the breath is with you, providing an anchor. At moments that are right for you, you can turn to it just as you might turn to a good friend, to help you stay alert and cut down on the mind’s habitual, unnecessary thinking that often squanders so much energy.”

“The next step is crucial: you give relaxed, careful attention to respiration and to the obvious, often neglected fact that each one of us is breathing. In other words, you are alive! Did you know that?”



[Get This Book
on Amazon](#)

Citation

Benson, H., & Stark, M. (1996). Timeless healing: the power and biology of belief . Scribner.

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Additional Note:

[Here are some quotes](#) to keep in the back of your mind as you read this one...

Book 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes

Timeless Healing: The Power and Biology of Belief

BY: HERBERT BENSON, MD

THE 4 THOUGHTS

1. Remembered Wellness: How to Harness the Power of the Mind
2. The Faith Factor = Relaxation Response + Remembered Wellness
3. Brush Your Teeth and Heal
4. Let Go and Believe: It's Profound Medicine

1 LIFE-CHANGING IDEA

To Understand the Healing Power of the Body and Mind, Do the Opposite

4 THOUGHTS

1. Remembered Wellness: How to Harness the Power of the Mind

"[A]ll of us have the ability to "remember" the calm and confidence associated with health and happiness, but not just in an emotional or psychologically soothing way. This memory is also physical.

[...]

Our brains are wired for beliefs and expectancies. When activated, the body can respond as it would if the belief were a reality, producing deafness or thirst, health or illness.



[...]

This is how our thoughts become self-fulfilling prophecies, and how our beliefs gear our bodies for the splendid opportunities of remembered wellness.”

You’ve probably heard some remarkable stories on the power of the mind. Inert pills curing illness. Sham surgeries that work as well as—or even better than—the real thing (if the patient believed they got the real thing). And on & on.

I’ve always known this intellectually, but I’ve never known how to harness this power of the mind. Now I do: *Remembered wellness* (also see the 1 Life-Changing Idea in [Relaxation Revolution](#) for more).

Remembered wellness refers to visualizing past states of health and wellness. This puts your body into that physiological state, allowing you to heal:

“All of us have distinct neurosignatures—for wellness, for illness, ... and for the specifics you associate with all the other activities and situations you have faced in life.”

Remembered wellness allows us to use these neurosignatures to our advantage:

“Like a bad habit, or conversely like a good habit, recurring top-down thoughts, along with their corresponding emotional values, engage your brain’s previously used nerve-cell-firing patterns to instruct the body.”

So, by regularly visualizing past states of wellness, we **“engage [our] brain’s previously used nerve-cell-firing patterns to instruct the body”** to heal.

To get the most out of it, we first put our bodies into a state that allows us to harness the power of the mind. This is where the relaxation response comes in.

2. The Faith Factor = Relaxation Response + Remembered Wellness

The relaxation response (RR) is the exact opposite of the stress response. It puts our body into a calm and relaxed state: our heart rates and blood pressure lower, we consume less oxygen, and our brains quiet down. See the [Book 411 on Relaxation Revolution](#) for exact instructions on how to elicit it.



Crucially, once we've elicited the RR, our physiology is primed to be more receptive to remembered wellness. And when these two are paired (RR + remembered wellness), this creates what Dr. Benson calls the "faith factor:"

"I decided to call the combined force of these internal influences the faith factor—remembered wellness and the elicitation of the relaxation response."

He used this term because many patients relied on religious faith during their RR and remembered wellness practices, which seemed to boost the benefits.

But he discovered that the practices themselves often increased spirituality in general, amplifying results: **"It was the more amorphous feeling of spirituality that could be linked to better psychological and physical well-being."**

For us, it means we can combine the RR with remembered wellness to increase spiritual health (with or w/o religion) and boost physical and mental well-being.

P.S. If the ideas of spirit and faith don't resonate with you, no big deal. Simply focus on the RR by itself. The RR doesn't require any spirit or faith; it's simply an intrinsic state we all have: **"The human body is geared to react by providing this calming state—the opposite of the fight-or-flight response—whenever the mind is focused for some time and disregards intrusive, everyday thoughts. [...] So powerful, in fact, is this process that you need not believe, you need not call upon remembered wellness to generate the relaxation response."**

3. Brush Your Teeth and Heal

"Try to think of the practice as you would the daily ritual of brushing your teeth ... Let your body heal itself without the interference of mind-generated doubts, criticism, and appraisals. ... You wouldn't critique your toothbrushing so don't analyze this exercise either."

A prominent theme throughout this book, which we'll continue in the next thought, is letting go of expectations. We need to simply perform the exercises (RR, remembered wellness, or both) without judgment. Judgment and self-appraisals will only take away from their healing potential.

That's why Dr. Benson also says, **"I encourage people to make the elicitation of the relaxation response part of their daily routine, but not to aspire to good results or some specific end. 'Just do it,' as the slogan goes."**



It sounds easy enough, but letting go of expectations is difficult. So, every time you find yourself judging your practice, remember it's like brushing your teeth: **"You wouldn't critique your toothbrushing so don't analyze this exercise either."**

P.S. Two other brilliant MDs come to mind here, Drs Richard Brown and Patricia Gerbarg. In [*The Healing Power of the Breath*](#), they echo this same sentiment: **"Self-judgment adds another layer of stress. The less you judge yourself, the easier it will be to relax and experience the benefits ... Try not to evaluate or judge what is happening. Just go with it."** 🙏🙏🙏

4. Let Go and Believe: It's Profound Medicine

"You've read all about your physiology, you've surrounded yourself with good caregivers who help you take a moderate, balanced approach to your health and health care. Now it's time to enjoy your endowment, this wiring for faith that makes the power of remembered wellness so enduring.

...

Believe in something good if you can. Or even better, believe in something better than anything you can fathom. Because for us mortals, this is very profound medicine."

I condensed it some, but that's how the book ends, and it's the perfect way to end our 4 Thoughts: with the power of belief. It all comes back to belief. (Recall the subtitle of the book: The Power and Biology of Belief.)

But as we said earlier, we don't need to believe in a religion to harness this power. We just need to believe in something good: In our body's innate ability to heal, in our mind's natural ability to solve problems, in the intrinsic good of humanity, or whatever resonates with you.

It may be difficult sometimes, but it's the approach we need most.

We must let go and believe, **"Because for us mortals, this is very profound medicine."**



1 LIFE-CHANGING IDEA

To Understand the Healing Power of the Body and Mind, Do the Opposite

“Regular elicitation of the relaxation response is of enormous benefit to your body. ... [J]ust as repeated activation of the fight-or-flight response can lead to sustained problems in the body and its mechanics, so too can repeated activation of the relaxation response reverse those trends and mend the internal wear and tear brought on by stress.”

It’s easy to see how chronic stress can add up to all sorts of health problems. But as this passage reminds us, the opposite is also true. Repeated elicitation of positive physiological states can reverse those negative trends.

But it gets even better when we apply this same concept to our minds (a big theme of this book). It’s super easy to see how repeating negative thoughts, worry, and rumination can cause health problems. And it’s medically (and socially) accepted that negative thoughts cause physical problems.

Yet, it’s often labeled “woo-woo” or pseudoscience to suggest the opposite: that remembering positive times or having inspiring beliefs could somehow heal our bodies. (Of course, this is because ideas like this have become synonymous with wishful thinking, marketed as a “secret” that will help you manifest 1M dollars.)

But that’s not what we’re talking about here. It’s the perspective shift—thinking in opposites—that’s life-changing.

If negative thoughts show up physically as stress, anxiety, hypertension, and cardiovascular problems, perhaps it’s not so crazy to suggest that the opposite—positive thoughts and beliefs—might also show up physiologically as better health and well-being?



1 STACK OF MEMORABLE QUOTES

"Despite the fact that the body is the grandest problem-solver there is, quietly and perpetually sustaining life, overcoming billions of obstacles without our conscious imperatives for it to do so, we don't trust it. Instead, we turn to our medicine cabinets."

"Much of the success the medical profession achieves is not due to anything doctors do or dispense that is inherently healing. We should really attribute the success of many medical treatments to the inherent healing power within individuals."

"They concluded, according to Clinical Psychology Review, that "under conditions of heightened expectations" the power of the placebo effect "far exceeds that commonly reported in literature." A full 70 percent of the patients they studied experienced excellent or good results from bogus treatments."

"When you focus for a short time, gently brushing aside any intrusive thoughts, your mind and body suddenly become a five-star resort in which all the service personnel make your restoration and health their priority and are especially concerned with alleviating the harmful effects of stress."

"The less you worry about the results, the better. Just let it happen."

"A priest who reviewed the faith healings at Lourdes, the famed Roman Catholic shrine in France, once said that people are mistaken if they think that "miracles produce faith." Quite the opposite, he says, "faith produces miracles."

"Remembered wellness isn't particularly mysterious. The evidence of its substantial, positive influence over the body has existed for centuries. It's known in the scientific community as "the placebo effect." But I hope to replace the term with 'remembered wellness.'"

"This is remembered wellness, the potential of which seems boundless when we realize that we can markedly control brain activity, that we can assign priorities to diagnoses and medicines, and that we can rehearse affirmations, visualizations, and other exercises to expand the hotbeds of nerve cells that fire off signals to our hearts, lungs, and limbs."



“In all the activities I am about to recommend, the goal is not to deny reality, only to project images and ideas of something better for yourself. You act “as if” the preferred reality were true and the body responds.”

“Dr. Marcus Reidenberg, editor of the journal Clinical Pharmacology and Therapeutics, believes that many drug companies “are taking symptoms of daily living, of normal existence, and converting these into diseases requiring medical treatment.”

*“Sometimes an uncontrollable biological entity prevails, despite our most fervent prayers, our most exuberant living, and our most hopeful attitude. Yet there should be no guilt involved. **We do the best we can in difficult circumstances to preserve hope. That is all we can humanly expect from ourselves.**”*



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on Amazon](#)

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Book 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes

Transcend: The New Science of Self- Actualization

BY: SCOTT BARRY KAUFMAN, PH.D.

THE 4 THOUGHTS

1. The Good Life & the Good Breath
2. Diverse Tactics & Breathing Hammers and Nails
3. Why Coherence Fuels Purpose: Finding Internal & External Safety (and connection) for Growth
4. Learned Helplessness to Learned Hope: The Power of the Breath (or any self-improvement tool)

4 THOUGHTS

1. The Good Life & the Good Breath

"Instead, the good life that I present, which is deeply grounded in the core principles of humanistic psychology and a realistic understanding of human needs, is about the healthy expression of needs in the service of discovering and expressing a self that works best for you.

The good life is not something you will ever achieve. It's a way of living."



I absolutely love this passage. It's the perfect place to start this 411 because it succinctly represents what this book is about: living a deeply meaningful life in a way that is unique to you.

But for our purposes, this passage inspired me to create a modified version, which we can call "**The Good Breath:**"

The good breath is deeply grounded in the principles of human physiology and psychology, along with a realistic understanding of individual human differences. It's about the healthy expression of your emotions and highest potential through breathing practices that work best for you.

The good breath isn't something we try to achieve. It's simply a way of breathing.

This means that the good breath will be different for each of us. It doesn't matter which method, how long, or how many times a day. As long as we're using it to become a better version of ourselves, we're doing it right.

Related: [The Deep Breath Hypothesis](#)

2. Diverse Tactics & Breathing Hammers and Nails

"The integration of a wide variety of perspectives is necessary for a more complete understanding of the full depths of human potential, as too much focus on a single perspective runs the risk of giving a distorted view of human nature. As Maslow said, 'I suppose it is tempting, if the only tool you have is a hammer, to treat everything as if it were a nail.'"

Here's another excellent reminder that we need a wide range of methods, in breathing and life, to become the best version of ourselves.

But specifically for the breath, if we only have one breathing hammer, we'll assume every problem is a nail. Let's be mixed-breathing artists instead.



P.S. Here's another passage related to being unique and using a wide range of methods. This could also go with Thought #1, but it seemed slightly more appropriate here. *"Maslow viewed the role of the teacher, therapist, and parent as horticulturists, whose task is to 'enable people to become healthy and effective in their own style.'¹ To Maslow, this meant that 'we try to make a rose into a good rose, rather than seek to change roses into lilies. . . . It necessitates a pleasure in the self-actualization of a person who may be quite different from yourself. It even implies an ultimate respect and acknowledgement of the sacredness and uniqueness of each kind of person.'"* I hope these 411s help you in this way :)

3. Why Coherence Fuels Purpose: Finding Internal & External Safety (and connection) for Growth

"The need for coherence is the form of meaning that is most strongly tied to the need for safety. Does my immediate environment make sense? Is there any predictability and comprehensibility in my life? Coherence is necessary to even get a chance to pursue one's larger purpose or pursue various ways that one can matter in this world."

Kaufman tells us to "pursue one's larger purpose," we need external coherence with our environment, which allows us to feel safe.

However, we also know that slow breathing (~5-6 breaths/min) provides internal coherence—a predictability in our nervous system that makes us feel safe.

And in my opinion, this internal type is even more potent because it's always available, and our inner state determines how we relate to our external world.

So let's breathe slowly, find some internal coherence (and maybe even external, too), and use this feeling of safety to pursue our bigger purpose.

P.S.: As you probably know by now, slow breathing also activates the vagus nerve and, with regular practice, increases vagal tone. This is critical to connection, as Kaufman also tells us: *"Yet another key player in the connection system is the tenth cranial nerve, also known as the vagus nerve ... Those with higher vagal tone experience greater connection with others in their daily lives,*



and in turn, this greater connection increases vagal tone, causing ‘upward spirals of the heart.’⁴³

To pursue our bigger purpose, we’ll need connection. So, we could say: Breathe slowly, feel safe, and connect better with others.

4. Learned Helplessness to Learned Hope: The Power of the Breath (or any self-improvement tool)

“In their classic studies beginning in the late 1960s, psychologists Steven Maier and Martin Seligman found that, given enough repeated shocks, dogs eventually stop trying to escape from their situation even when they eventually are given the opportunity to do so.⁶⁵ They just gave up ... The researchers called the resulting state of defeat “learned helplessness” and came to see it as a major cause of depression.

In a recent review of the evidence ...Maier and Seligman concluded that they actually had it completely backward.⁶⁶ The latest research suggests that the passivity and feeling of lack of control is actually the default response in animals, an automatic, unlearned reaction to prolonged adversity. What must be learned is hope—the perception that one can control and harness the unpredictability in one’s environment.”

If you’re into self-improvement, you’ve likely heard of the learned helplessness experiments. But I didn’t know that recent research shows that helplessness isn’t actually learned: **it’s our default reaction to prolonged adversity.**

To beat it, we need learned hope: *“the perception that [we] can control and harness the unpredictability in [our] environment.”*

In my opinion, this is precisely why breathing techniques are so powerful. It’s not that some magical breathing method is going to fix us. It’s that once we’ve experienced our ability to control our body and emotions through the breath, we develop “learned hope.”

Then, when adversity hits, we feel empowered. Breathing shifts our mindset from helplessness into hope.



1 LIFE-CHANGING IDEA

It's OK to Be Sick (In fact, Maybe We Should Be)

"Indeed, the hallmark characteristic of the self-actualizing person may be the ability to strive for a purpose that will make one unpopular with the neighboring environment, particularly if the environment is unhealthy, hostile, or dangerous.³² Maslow echoed this sentiment in the introduction to Toward a Psychology of Being:

'Does sickness mean having symptoms? I maintain now that sickness might consist of not having symptoms when you should. Does health mean being symptom-free? I deny it. Which of the Nazis at Auschwitz or Dachau were healthy? Those with stricken conscience or those with a nice, clear, happy conscience? Was it possible for a profoundly human person not to feel conflict, suffering, depression, rage, etc.?'³³"

Here's a life-changing thought: If you have no problems in today's world, that might actually be a sign of sickness.

We spend almost all our time indoors in front of screens. We breathe polluted air. We use artificial light. We eat processed foods (even when we eat organic whole foods, they've somehow been treated with something terrible). And on & on.

How could we not be sick?

Of course, the goal of all our self-development is to mitigate the effects of our modern world. But I think it's a disservice if we guilt people into believing they should never have any problems, and if they do, that it's a sign of weakness.

We may never be "ok." And that's ok. Paradoxically, that's more reason to keep doing what we're doing. As Russ Harris tells us in *The Confidence Gap*, *"Although we'll never be perfect, we can keep on learning and growing until the day we die. ... In other words, we can continually develop our psychological*



flexibility: the ability to take effective action, guided by values, with awareness, openness, and focus.”

So it's ok to be sick, and it's ok to keep trying to improve. Let's hold those dichotomies in parallel while we keep taking effective action toward the life we want.

1 STACK OF MEMORABLE QUOTES

“My research has convinced me that we all have extraordinary creative, humanitarian, and spiritual possibilities but are often alienated from them because we are so focused on a very narrow slice of who we are. As a result, we aren’t fulfilling our full potential.”

“Modern-day presentations of Maslow’s theory often leave out this critical notion of an integrated hierarchy and instead focus on the stage-like pyramid—even though in his published writings Maslow never actually created a pyramid to represent his hierarchy of needs.”

“The pyramid from the sixties told a story that Maslow never meant to tell; a story of achievement, of mastering level by level until you’ve “won” the game of life. But that is most definitely not the spirit of self-actualization that the humanistic psychologists emphasized. The human condition isn’t a competition; it’s an experience.”

“Yes, we are apes, but we are apes insatiably curious about personal identity, creative expression, meaning, and purpose. Humans have developed a capacity for growth unprecedented in the animal kingdom. We are truly unique in the long time scale of our goals and in the flexibility to choose which goals we most wish to prioritize, and therefore in the number of ways we can self-actualize.”

“No one can build you the bridge on which you, and only you, must cross the river of life. ... There is one path in the world that none can walk but you. Where does it lead? Don’t ask, walk!” . . . It is . . . an agonizing, hazardous undertaking thus to dig into oneself, to climb down roughly and directly into the tunnels of one’s being.” - Friedrich Nietzsche

“There seems to be no intrinsic reason why everyone shouldn’t be this way [self-actualizing]. Apparently, every baby has possibilities for self-actualization, but most



all of them get it knocked out of them. . . . I think of the self-actualizing man not as an ordinary man with something added, but rather as the ordinary man with nothing taken away.” – Abraham Maslow

“Perhaps we can define happiness as experiencing real emotions over real problems and real tasks.” – Abraham Maslow

“The most fortunate are those who have a wonderful capacity to appreciate again and again, freshly and naively, the basic goods of life, with awe, pleasure, wonder and even ecstasy.” – Abraham Maslow

“The great lesson from the true mystics—from the Zen monks, and now also from the Humanistic and Transpersonal psychologists—is that the sacred is in the ordinary, that it is to be found in one’s daily life, in one’s neighbors, friends, and family, in one’s back yard.” – Abraham Maslow



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Additional Note

I am not a Wim Hof
instructor. To ensure
safety, it's critical that
you use a certified
instructor ([or Wim's
free app](#)) if you're
interested in trying the
method. You should
consult your physician
before trying anything
new.

One More Thing...

This Book 411 doesn't
discuss too much of the
science of Wim's
method because we
have four Science 411s
available on it. Check
out the [Wim Hof
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want to nerd out.

Book 411

4 thoughts, 1 life-changing idea, and 1 stack of memorable quotes

The Wim Hof Method: Activate Your Full Human Potential

BY: WIM HOF

THE 4 THOUGHTS

1. The Origins of the Wim Hof Method®
2. The 3 Pillars of the Method: Cold, Breathing, and Mindset
3. A Cold Shower a Day Keeps Us Breathing the Right Way? (+ achieve deep meditation in one minute)
4. Wim's Daily Routine (+ his one-minute stress relief breathing)

4 THOUGHTS

1. The Origins of the Wim Hof Method®

"I began to notice that I would involuntarily gasp each time I immersed myself [in cold water], and I found this intriguing. And when, at a certain moment, I did twenty-five deep breaths, it made my body tingle like crazy, like electricity. ... It was an amazing feeling, and over time, a routine gradually took shape. It was organic and progressive, and this physical experience of the cold and following my gut led me to a true personal discovery of my own consciousness, my own mind-body connection. I was only seventeen, and I felt alive and excited."



That's how the method started: 17-year-old Wim went into the cold and listened to his body. But sadly, it was a tragic loss that led to the full development of his method. When Wim was in his mid-thirties, his wife and mother to four children, Olaya, committed suicide.

Wim says he didn't have time to properly grieve. He had to take care of his children. Thus, he relied on the things he had been practicing—cold, breathing, and meditation—to help him through (plus, of course, his love for his children). This is how the three pillars shaped into a method:

“It was then that I first understood the true benefits of the cold water, breathing techniques, and positive mindset I was employing. So I made a method out of them, in the hope that others could benefit from them as I had. ...That was twenty-five years ago, and the method has evolved a lot since then, but its original spark is still with me. Like the memory of my dear, sweet love, Olaya, I carry it with me wherever I go.”

It's tragic that Wim endured this loss, but inspiring that he used it to not only heal himself but to also create one of the most popular methods on the planet.

Let's dive into its components.

2. The 3 Pillars of the Method: Cold, Breathing, and Mindset

There are three pillars in Wim's method, which are cold, breathing, and mindset. Let's briefly look at each and the basic way of doing them.

1. Cold: Although Wim does extreme cold endurance, his recommendations for starting out are very practical:

“So what can we do to reduce the impact of the shock and instead allow the ice water to optimize our cardiovascular system? Most of us who live in the West take showers every day, and most of those are warm or hot showers, because we don't like the cold. But if you end your warm or hot shower with just thirty seconds of cold water—just thirty seconds—you will begin to see results.”

Thirty seconds isn't much to ask to get the benefits of the cold (which we'll discuss in the following thought). And Wim says you need only 10 days to start noticing these benefits.

2. Breath:



“We can live in sensitive connection with our most vulnerable souls and become the enlightened, radiant beings we were meant to be. It all begins with forty breaths.”

You probably know this one by now:

1. Take 30-40 full breaths
2. Exhale
3. Hold for as long as comfortably possible
4. Inhale and hold for 10 seconds
5. Repeat for 3-4 rounds

Wim suggests that beginners start using the nose, or nose-in/mouth-out, because it's easier to remain in control. [Use his app to guide you](#) through the process.

3. Mindset:

“We call this pillar ‘commitment’ in our training programs because you must have the right mindset to make the commitment to go against your ego and take the damn shower, to just breathe. You could also call this pillar the power of the mind. It includes the idea of will and the power to imagine, to meditate, to visualize — the power to send your attention to any part of your body, to observe any bodily process.”

The basic approach is to sit or lie comfortably and follow your breath, breathing deeply and peacefully. When you feel a sense of calm wash over you, set an intention (doing more push-ups, rocking a presentation, etc.). Visualize doing that task. **“Tell your body what you expect it to do.”** Then, continue the visualization until you know you can do it. (Listen to the audio version for more.)

3. A Cold Shower a Day Keeps Us Breathing the Right Way? (+ achieve deep meditation in one minute)

“All we need to do to begin reclaiming our innate capacity, our inner power, our ability to place mind over matter, and achieve strength, happiness, and sustainable health is to take cold showers. Just a minute or two a day. It's all there for you, and we have proven through science that it works. ... A cold shower a day keeps the doctor away.”

Wim is obviously a huge fan of the cold, and he provides a lot of scientific and anecdotal support for why the cold is so powerful for building resilience.

(This one especially stood out:



“The control you will gain won’t be limited to your body’s response to the cold though. It can be applied to stress in any form, be it heat, emotion, work, frustration with the traffic, relationships, whatever. Because the cold is merciless but righteous, we can learn from it.”)

But although we know the cold is powerful, we often separate it from the breath pillar of his method. However, the two really work in synchronicity. Here’s why.

When we practice cold exposure, our vascular system gets exercised—we condition our **“sixty-two thousand miles of veins, arteries, and capillaries.”** This ultimately improves blood flow. Why does this matter? Back to Wim:

“[I]t’s our vascular system that delivers blood to the cells and with it, all the nutrients, oxygen, and vitamins our bodies need to thrive.”

Thus, remember that breathing is nothing without blood flow. And better blood flow makes each breath we take more efficient.

Together, we see that the cold complements the breathing perfectly.

So, in addition to keeping the doctor away, we could say that a cold shower a day keeps us breathing in an efficient way.

P.S. And if that’s not enough, Wim says the blood flow changes from cold exposure can also help you achieve deep meditation in one minute: **“Because the brain and the heart are connected neurologically, your decreased heart rate affects your mood, lessening your anxiety. In peace and at rest, your brain begins to “cool down,” and blood slowly flows deeper into it. If that blood reaches the limbic system, it is possible to achieve a level of deep meditation that only seasoned mindfulness practitioners of many years have been known to realize. In my experience, a one-minute cold shower every day can deliver you to the same realm.”**

4. Wim’s Daily Routine (+ his one-minute stress relief breathing)

“I rise in the morning, and I do my breathing. I don’t do it because it’s good for me, which it is, but because it feels good. That’s why I want to do it. And then, shortly after, I take my cold shower, or an ice bath if I can. I love it, and I never skip a day, even when I am on



the road. The ice bath, combined with the breathing, generates a ton of metabolic activity in the body. I stay in the cold water until I feel a deep peace, which comes from complete adaptation.” (my bold)

It’s always inspiring to find out how authors use the information they’re writing about. Of course, it’s a little different in Wim’s case, but still awesome to get a peek into his routine at the time of this writing.

After the cold, here’s what he does next:

“When I get out of the water, I don’t jump directly into a warm shower or anything like that. No. I let the body work, and it’s amazing what it does, what it can do. All the metabolic activity and biochemical processes are priming the body for ultimate functionality. Everything works. I do some stretching, some splits, some balance exercises.”

Breathing, cold, stretching. If it works for Wim, I’m sure it can work for us 🙏

P.S. Although his routine keeps him aligned, even The Iceman gets stressed from time to time. His solution? Humming. And it only takes a minute:

“What I do for stress is one minute of humming and breathing. This always works for me. It taps into your parasympathetic nervous system — where the peace is inside — and calms down your hectic sympathetic nervous system.”

Here are his instructions:

1. Set a timer for one minute.
2. Breathe in deeply, and hum in any way you’d like during exhalation.
3. Repeat until the timer goes off.

Easy and highly effective 🙌

1 LIFE-CHANGING IDEA

Wim’s Breathing Philosophy: The Breath is a Door (and of course: breathe, m*therf*ckers)



There are lots of life-changing ideas in this book. But, perhaps the most inspiring is simply Wim's philosophy on breathing. Adapting even a fraction of his enthusiasm for (and belief in) the breath is guaranteed to change your life.

Here are a few gems to contemplate and incorporate into your thinking:

"[T]he breath is a door. It leads to corridors that take us deep within ourselves."

"Without the breath, what is there? It's where you and I and everyone else began. It's where all life begins."

"The breath is as big as the ocean. ... It is the sea itself. It's where we came from, who we are. It is bigger than us because it is us. Now go consciously into the breath and let go."

"It starts with the breath and controlling the life-force through breathing. Without the breath, we are nothing, but by controlling it, we are able to access the neurology of our consciousness, our perception."

"Be still, and breathe. That is where the depth is gained."

"There's nothing mystical or abstract about it. It's physical. Your breath is your life-force, right here, right now. It could not be any simpler. Just breathe and reclaim your soul."

"Can it really be so simple? Just breathing deeply? Is that it? The answer, friends, is yes."

And finally, remember to breathe, motherfuckers:

"People come up to me with questions like, 'Should I breathe through the nose?' or 'The diaphragm this or that,' and I just say, 'Yeah, breathe, motherfuckers! Don't think, just do it! Get into the depth of your own lungs!' ... get out of your mind and get into your breath because the breath is the life-force. Not your mind, the breath. Follow your breath, and it will lead you anywhere in your brain—thus the mind—that you want to go."



1 STACK OF MEMORABLE QUOTES

"I realized that we all have this sacred spot within us, and it became my aim to access it. Once you can do that, you become aware of your own light, your own being, your own purpose. It's all there for you if you know where to look."

"There is so much more to life than meets the eye if you choose to seek it. The seeker becomes the finder, the finder of so much more than we thought was possible."

"It's very simple. A cold shower a day keeps the doctor away."

"Anybody is able to endure thirty seconds of cold water, especially after spending several minutes under the warm or hot water, collecting heat. The warm water opens up your veins, aiding your blood flow. So while the cold water might cause you some discomfort at first, thirty seconds is no great hardship."

"The greatest accomplishment you can achieve is stillness of the mind."

"People think of the sixth sense as 'extrasensory perception,' like reading minds or telling the future. But I call the sixth sense 'confidence,' the absolute confidence in your own nature, your own destiny, your mission, your purpose on this earth and beyond."

"We are limited only by the depth of our imagination and the strength of our conviction."

"They all called me a madman and mocked me. To be sure, many still do. And you know what? They're right. I'm crazy about life, I am! I love it!"

"Breathe. Go out into the cold. Feel it. Follow the light. It will take you back into yourself."

"Follow the breath. Lean into it. The breath goes everywhere, and it will lead you where you need to go."